



The Thread Seers: Book One

Le Viet Hong

2025

- [Acknowledgments](#)
- [PROLOGUE: SAIGON, 1943](#)
- [Chapter 1: The Bridge](#)
- [Chapter 2: Father's Equations](#)
- [Chapter 3: Recognition](#)
- [Chapter 4: The Invitation](#)

- [Chapter 5: The Severance](#)
 - [THE GATHERING](#)
- [Chapter 6: The Weight of Memory](#)
- [Chapter 7: The Father's Shadow](#)
 - [THE CLINIC](#)
 - [THE FATHER'S SHADOW](#)
- [Chapter 8: The Arrival](#)
 - [THE TRAIN](#)
 - [THE STATION](#)
 - [ORIENTATION](#)
 - [THE ARGUMENT](#)
- [Chapter 9: The Silver Burn](#)
 - [THE LECTURE](#)
- [Chapter 10: The Gauntlet](#)
 - [THE CALL AT SEVEN](#)
 - [THE TRIAL](#)
- [Chapter 11: The Magnus Conduit](#)
 - [THE DOORWAY](#)
 - [THE CALIBRATION](#)
 - [THE BLUEPRINT](#)

- [THE CORDON](#)
- [Chapter 12A: The Demonstration](#)
 - [THE ABSENCE](#)
 - [THE FLOOR](#)
 - [THE WRIST](#)
- [Chapter 12B: The Eleventh of September](#)
 - [WHY THIS IS HERE](#)
 - [THE ENTRY](#)
 - [THE ENTRY, LATER](#)
- [Chapter 13: The First Disappearance](#)
 - [THE QUESTION, ASKED IN A LECTURE HALL](#)
 - [THE ARCHIVE](#)
 - [JAMES](#)
 - [THE ROOM](#)
 - [THE REPORT](#)
- [Chapter 14: The Thing Under the Floor](#)
 - [NINETY SECONDS AHEAD](#)
 - [THE BOY WITH THE SHEET](#)
 - [THE ARCHWAY](#)
 - [INSIDE](#)

- [WHAT THE FLOOR WAS](#)
- [THE OTHER THING IN THE ROOM](#)
- [THE COLLAPSE](#)
- [Chapter 15A: What the Hall Knows](#)
 - [THE WINDOW](#)
 - [THE HALL OF INHERITED PRACTICE](#)
 - [SEVENTEEN](#)
 - [THE STAFF](#)
- [Chapter 15B: Nine Minutes](#)
 - [THE CRATER](#)
 - [THE BOY](#)
 - [WHAT HE DID WITH THE BOY](#)
- [Chapter 16: The Mathematics of a Daughter](#)
 - [WHAT THE OBSERVERS LEFT BEHIND](#)
 - [THE BOX](#)
 - [THE THING THAT HAPPENED](#)
 - [WHAT HE TOLD HIMSELF IN 2013](#)
 - [WHAT CAME UP THE STAIRS](#)
- [Chapter 17A: Four People and a Box](#)
 - [THE STACK](#)

- [THE FIRST THING, WHICH WAS A PHOTOGRAPH](#)
- [THE SECOND THING, WHICH WAS A DRAWING](#)
- [THE THIRD THING, WHICH WAS THE PHOTOGRAPH THEY SHOULD HAVE READ FIRST](#)
- [THE ALARM](#)
- [Chapter 17B: Forty-Nine Minutes](#)
 - [WHAT THE WALL DID](#)
 - [THE HALL](#)
 - [THE STAIRWELL](#)
 - [THE BURN](#)
 - [THE LOSS](#)
 - [THE LAST SIX MINUTES](#)
- [Chapter 18A: Through the Vent](#)
 - [THE LOCKED DOOR](#)
 - [WHAT SHE HEARD](#)
 - [THE PART SHE DID NOT HEAR](#)
 - [THE STAIR](#)
 - [THE NOTE SHE WROTE AT SEVEN](#)
- [Chapter 18B: The Name in the Box](#)
 - [SIXTY-SEVEN](#)

- [WHAT HE SAW](#)
- [THE FILE](#)
- [SEVEN IN THE MORNING](#)
- [THE SAME MORNING, FOUR HUNDRED METRES AWAY](#)
- [Chapter 19: The Channel](#)
 - [WHAT WAS IN THE NOTE](#)
 - [THE ARGUMENT](#)
 - [THE MARK](#)
 - [WHAT HAPPENED TO IT](#)
 - [THE NOTE ON THE BACK](#)
- [Chapter 20: The Trap Springs](#)
 - [THE SUMMONS](#)
 - [THE GATHERING](#)
 - [THE CHOICE](#)
 - [THE REVELATION](#)
 - [THE DESPERATE GAMBIT](#)
 - [THE REVERSAL ATTEMPT](#)
 - [THE SILVER RESPONSE](#)
 - [THE WEIGHT OF CHOICE](#)
 - [WHAT THE BOARD DID](#)

- [Chapter 21: The Silver Soul](#)
 - [THE AWAKENING](#)
 - [THE SYSTEM](#)
 - [THE BREACH](#)
 - [THE WITHDRAWAL](#)
 - [THE HOUR](#)
- [Chapter 22: The Sacrifice](#)
 - [THE LONG AFTERNOON](#)
 - [THE TRACE](#)
 - [THE LEADS](#)
 - [THE HOUSING](#)
 - [THE TRANSFORMATION](#)
 - [THE COST](#)
- [Chapter 23: The Healing and the Harm](#)
 - [THE ARGUMENT THAT PAID FOR THE PACT](#)
 - [THE INFIRMARY INVESTIGATION](#)
- [Chapter 24A: Silver Echoes](#)
 - [THE ROOM](#)
 - [WHAT IT COSTS](#)
- [Chapter 24B: The Moment of Choice](#)

- [04:23](#)
- [THE VISITOR](#)
- [THE FIFTY MINUTES](#)
- [Chapter 25: Infirmary Reconciliation](#)
- [Chapter 26: The Ask](#)
 - [THE TWO OFFERS](#)
 - [THE COUNCIL, DAY 32 — THE TWENTY-SEVENTH OF OCTOBER](#)
 - [THE VISIT](#)
 - [THE THREE QUESTIONS](#)
- [Chapter 26B: The Visit](#)
 - [THE WARD ON SUB-LEVEL 2](#)
 - [WHAT HE COULD NOT STOP](#)
- [Chapter 27: Breach Night](#)
- [Chapter 28: The Summons & The Descent](#)
 - [THE SUMMONS](#)
 - [THE DESCENT](#)
 - [UNDER THE BASE PLATE](#)
 - [THE CONFRONTATION](#)
 - [WHAT HARLOW SAYS FOR HIMSELF](#)
 - [THE MOMENT OF CHOICE](#)

- [Chapter 29: The Price of Life](#)
 - [THE ARRIVAL](#)
 - [THE ARRANGEMENT](#)
 - [THE PROJECTION](#)
 - [THE RECORDING](#)
 - [THE QUESTION](#)
- [Chapter 30: What They Wanted](#)
 - [THE QUESTION](#)
 - [THE ARGUMENT](#)
 - [THE FIFTEEN-YEAR-OLD](#)
 - [THE CHANNEL](#)
 - [THE REFUSAL](#)
- [Chapter 31: The Thing With No Number](#)
 - [THE ROOM](#)
 - [THE SPOKEN NUMBER](#)
 - [WHAT A STATISTICIAN CAN DO](#)
 - [THE TWO NOES](#)
 - [THE ONE THAT IS NOT A NUMBER](#)
- [Chapter 32: The Fault](#)
 - [THE ASK](#)
 - [THE TERMS](#)

- [THE REFUSAL](#)
- [THE ANSWER](#)
- [THE INSTRUMENT](#)
- [THE FAULT](#)
- [Chapter 33: The Bill](#)
 - [THE FOUR HOURS](#)
 - [THE FIFTEEN-YEAR-OLD](#)
 - [THE MAN IN THE GOOD ROOM](#)
 - [WHAT WAS DONE](#)
- [Chapter 34: The First Admission](#)
 - [THE ROOM](#)
 - [THE LIST](#)
 - [THE ADMISSION](#)
- [Chapter 35: The Vote](#)
 - [THE OTHER WITNESSES](#)
 - [THE THING THAT WAS NOT A DISCLOSURE —
THE TWENTY-FIRST OF OCTOBER](#)
 - [THE ARGUMENT ABOUT MERCY — THE TWEN-
TY-SECOND OF OCTOBER](#)
 - [THE VOTE](#)
- [Interlude: The Repair](#)

- [WHAT A BUILDING LOOKS LIKE AFTER](#)
- [THE REPAIRS](#)
- [THE CONCORD](#)
- [THE FOUR OF THEM](#)
- [Chapter 36: The Thread Continues](#)
 - [THE MEMORIAL](#)
 - [THE HOUSE](#)
 - [THE CHARM](#)
 - [THE SEVEN WEEKS](#)
- [Epilogue: The Thing That Is Not Finished](#)
 - [THE ELEVEN MINUTES](#)
 - [THE LETTER](#)

Acknowledgments

This book exists because of threads—shimmering, unbreakable—that bind me to those I love most.

To my parents, who believed from the beginning. Your unwavering support became my strongest thread, golden and true.

To Katie, my partner in every adventure—thank you for standing beside me through challenge and celebration alike. The threads between us pulse brighter with each passing day, weaving patterns I never imagined possible.

To Mia and Lana, my brilliant daughters who teach me to see the world through wonder-struck eyes—your curiosity, creativity, and boundless joy are woven into every page.

Acknowledgments

May you always follow the silver threads of your dreams,
wherever they lead.

And to you, dear reader, for lifting this book and joining the
luminous thread that connects us all through story. Welcome to the Weave.

PROLOGUE: SAIGON, 1943

The bullet passed close enough that Mei-Hua felt the draught of it on her ear.

She did not move. The threads had told her a heartbeat before: hot, quick, a scarlet line running from the second storey of the warehouse across to the roof of the Customs House opposite, and along that line an intention with a shape she had learned to read the way other people read a mouth.

He is going to shoot.

“Hold,” she said. “He has not fired yet.”

Zhang, flat against the crates beside her, did not ask what she meant. In eleven weeks of working together he had stopped asking. He had also stopped suggesting that she was exaggerating, which she valued more.

Below them the Saigon River moved the colour of a bruise. Two patrol boats idled at the quay. On the far bank, under tarpaulins the size of ballroom floors, the cargo was stacked and labelled and starving. Somewhere up on Hậu Giang Street the evening market was closing, and the smell of it — shrimp paste, burning sugar, jasmine — came across the water mixed with the sharper stink of the rice that was no longer in the paddies.

“Third time this month,” Zhang said. “They’ve taken the delta’s whole allocation.”

“I know.”

He shifted, and the boards gave him. Mei-Hua put a hand flat on the wood without looking, feeling for the seam, and found it, and was grateful for the finding because her hands had started to shake and she needed something to be competent about.

“Third time,” he said again, differently. “And the fourth time they’ll send the manifest to Tokyo.”

She turned her head a few degrees. On the water below, a knot of black-silver light ran from the Customs House down to a coaster tied at the second pier. It was thick as

rope and it moved wrong: not the slow breathing of a bond between two people who had agreed to be bound, but the taut, purposeful pull of a line being paid out over a spool. Everything on it was being carried one way and nothing was being permitted to travel back.

“Master Nguyễn’s contacts in the General Association got hold of something in August,” she said. “They gave me the shape of it. I wanted to see it for myself.”

“Can you see now?”

“Yes.”

“Then tell me what you see, and let us both be frightened in the same direction.”

She almost liked him for that.

The threads had two names in her family, and her grandmother had been very clear about the difference.

Connections — 线 (xiàn) — ran between people. Between a daughter and a kitchen, a teacher and a classroom, a girl and a boy who had not yet managed to say a thing out loud. They were visible. Everyone in the trade could see them; some people saw them without trying.

Currents — 势 (shì) — belonged to places. They were the accumulated weight of a neighbourhood’s living: who had been born there, who had died there, who had eaten and quarrelled and gone to the temple on the same street for

four hundred years. They were not visible. They were not, she thought, exactly audible. They were the pressure of a place on your skin when you stood in it and knew it.

Threads could be pulled. Currents could not. That was the whole of her training and the whole of her argument, and she had lost it more times than she could count.

She closed her eyes and put her thumb and two fingers on the crease of her left palm, and breathed in through the nose.

In. Three. Out through the teeth.

Her grandmother had walked up behind her once, when she was nine, and tapped her sternum with the flat of a wooden spoon — *again* — and had not said a word, and had gone back to her tea. Fourteen years, and she could still feel the tap.

She opened her eyes.

The world arrived in layers.

The nearest layer was the small and the personal: Zhang's pulse in his throat, quick and stubborn; her own hands; the pouch at her hip where the tools were; the woman asleep two streets over whose thread to her grandson had gone thin as wet paper in the last fortnight. Below that, braided through the whole quarter, the current of Hậu Giang Street — not a sound but a leaning, the way a room leans when

a lot of weight is in one corner. It had been leaning since March.

Under all of it, and this was the part that frightened her, the mains.

“You see the cord,” she said. “The black one, from the Customs House to the ship.”

“I see nothing.”

“A cord the colour of a knife gone dull. It’s carrying the manifest and it’s carrying the rice allocation and it is not carrying anything back.” She swallowed. “It is being *paid out*. Somebody is drawing on it, and everything they take, they keep. Nothing comes back up the line. Do you understand what that means? It means the harvest is not shipping. It is being consumed where it is grown.”

Zhang was quiet for a moment. “Then cut it.”

“No.”

“Then what?”

She took out the pouch.

It had been her mother’s, and her mother’s mother’s, and the box inside it was older than the Republic. Her mother had embroidered the outside in blue silk at a time when blue silk was a serious decision, and she had done it in a

single unbroken line, and it had taken her four years, and she had died before the pouch was finished.

Inside: a jade needle, worn smooth along one edge by her grandmother's thumb. A coil of red silk, unwaxed, undyed by anything but age. And a small knot of red silk, wound and re-wound so many times it had gone into a shape like a closed fist, which her grandmother had put in her hand on her sixteenth birthday and said nothing about at all.

Choices that cannot be taken back, her grandmother had said, when Mei-Hua finally asked. *You will know which ones they were.*

"There is a way to do this that does not announce you," Mei-Hua said. "But you have to hold very still inside, and you are not a person who holds still."

"I can hold still."

"You held still for four counts yesterday and then you told the fish seller his account was wrong."

"That was true."

"That is not the point."

She drew the needle out. The jade was cool and it had a weight that belonged to a smaller hand.

Zhang shifted his weight onto his other foot. "Tell me the plan. In order. Quickly."

“I put a fork in the line.” She unwound about a forearm’s length of the red silk. “The manifest still goes where it is going. The ship still sails. But a copy of the flow — an echo of it — comes down my silk instead, into the water, and along the water to the General Association, because the current on Hậu Giang runs out to the river and the current is willing to carry it if I ask properly. That is the part that takes the work. The silk is easy. The current is not.”

“And the Japanese?”

“They will feel it by morning. The pattern will not sit still. Their own thread-walkers will know something has been done to that cord before the sun is up.”

“Then we go now.”

“We go after I finish. If I go now, the fork is half made and a half-made fork is worse than no fork at all.” She looked at him. “Fifteen minutes. Count them for me and tell me when you are at eight.”

It is not a large thing, to describe.

She knelt with the needle in her right hand and the silk in her left and she did not cut anything. Cutting would have been quicker and cutting would have been a declaration: a snapped line, a shock that ran backwards up the cord and lit up every ward the Japanese had laid between the river and the harbour, and every person on Hậu Giang Street would have felt the sky jerk like a held rope.

Instead she persuaded.

You are carrying a list. You are only carrying a list. A list can be copied. Here is a second road. It goes to the same place. It is smaller and it is quieter and nobody has to know.

The silk was old and the spool was old and she had soaked the thread in the herbs her grandmother used, and once a month she pricked her palm for it, because a thing you have paid for in blood will hold an intention you did not mean. The Western academics would have called that unscientific. Dr. Weber, in the good years, had said it was the most rigorous thing he had ever seen, and then had spent twenty minutes trying to write down what she was doing in a form he could submit somewhere.

She whispered in the dialect of the quarter — not a language, exactly; a way of putting the tones so the meaning leaned the right way — and the red silk began to pulse once, twice, and then at her own heartbeat, and the black-silver cord did not break.

It *bent*.

That was the whole trick, and the whole risk. A cord under tension will carry a great deal further than it should along a line you have introduced, if you are not careful, because a cord under tension wants to be straight more than it wants to be true. She felt it happen. She felt the Japanese have built that line to be efficient, and efficiency meant it took

the path of least resistance, and she had just made a path of least resistance that went somewhere else.

Sweat ran into her hair. The current under her knees shifted, resentful, the way a neighbour shifts when you lean on their wall.

Please, she thought, and it was not addressed to the silk. It was addressed to Hậu Giang Street. *Please carry it. You have carried worse than a piece of paper for us.*

And the quarter, which had been leaning since March, leaned very slightly the other way.

"Eight," Zhang said.

She tied the last knot. She was aware of doing it and then she was aware of having done it, which is not the same thing and is usually the last useful sensation available to anyone doing this kind of work.

It is done, she thought. *But it is not as I meant it.*

The fork held. That was the good news. The echo was running — she could feel it going out under the river, thin and cold, toward the General Association, and somewhere up on Hậu Giang Street somebody who had been getting up every morning for two years to a market with nothing in it felt the current under her feet ease by a fraction, and did not know why, and slept a little better.

The bad news was in her hands. She had asked the cord to carry a copy and it had carried a *tone* as well, and the tone was still in the red silk, and it was not subtle, and it was hers.

“They will know by morning,” she said. “Not what. Where. The disturbance will sit in the local current like a dropped stone.”

“Then we have tonight.”

“Then we have tonight,” she agreed, and put the needle away, and put the red fist of a knot back in the pouch where it belonged, and noticed for the first time that her grandmother’s hands in the embroidery, if you looked at them from this angle, were holding exactly the same thing.

They went out along the wall the way they had come in.

Mei-Hua did not look back at the coaster. She looked up, instead, at the roof of the warehouse where the thread had told her somebody was standing, and she was not surprised to see him, and she was very frightened, which is a different thing and which the years had taught her to keep in its own place.

He was tall. He was European. The lines around him were arranged the way they are arranged in a man who was once interested in something and then became efficient at it instead.

“Hello, Dr. Weber,” Mei-Hua said.

She felt the shape of what he was doing to the mains under Hậ Giang before he had raised a hand. It was the same hand, and the same terrible competence, and the warmth that had once been in it had been taken out and replaced with something that worked.

He is not doing this for the Japanese, she thought, and the thought was worse than if he were. He is doing it because he has decided that what he understands is more important than what is there.

“We should warn the elders,” Zhang said, when they were two streets down and the water was out of earshot. “All of them. Tonight.”

“Yes.”

“About the new thread-walkers. About the machines.”

“About all of it.”

“Will they listen?”

Mei-Hua thought about her grandmother, who had listened to a young German man for two years and had been right to.

“They will listen,” she said. “They will not be quick. That is the other half of it, and it is the half that matters, and nobody ever warns you about it.”

They turned into a lane that smelled of jasmine and hot sugar and the particular dust of old plaster, and the thread behind her — the one that connected a man on a roof to a woman standing in a lane, and which had been, for one moment, the most honest thing in the whole night — thinned and thinned and did not break.

It never broke. That was the trouble with it. It just got thinner, and thinner, and after a while there was nothing left on his side of it at all.

Seventy years later, in a kitchen on the far side of the world, a girl of sixteen would sit at a table with a charcoal pencil and a bowl of jasmine tea, and an old woman who had her father's eyes would tell her that the silk threads ran through all things, and that the deep currents ran under the places themselves, and that both of these were true, and that the second one was the one the schools had thrown away. She would not believe her at first. She would believe her by the end of the afternoon. It would take her the rest of her life to work out what the believing had cost, and who had been asked to pay it.

The girl had a great-grandmother on her mother's side, and that woman had done a very small version of this, in a lane not far from here, on a night when the rice was being taken and nobody could stop it. She had taken a fork in a line she was not strong enough to cut, and asked a street to carry the copy. It had worked. It had also told the enemy exactly where the street was, and it cost her thirty-one years of a life she

would have preferred to keep, and four people she loved who are not in this story.

Neither version is the whole of what happened next.

Chapter 1: The Bridge

Tuesday 27 August. Westbrook General, then the house on Ellery Street.

The bell at Westbrook High had a flat, unhappy note, and the hallway was still ringing from it when Madison Stone put her shoulder into Lyra Chen's.

Not hard. That was the thing about Madison — she calibrated. Lyra's sketchbook went down on the linoleum and slid under a bank of lockers and the pages fanned out, and half the corridor stopped to look, because half the corridor had been looking most of the day.

"Sorry," Madison said. "Didn't see you."

She had a way of saying *sorry* that made it a small door held open onto a larger room.

Lyra knelt and gathered the pages. She did not look at Madison, because looking was how it got worse. What she could see without looking was worse enough: a dense, knotted snarl of grey-white running from Madison's collar to the inside of Madison's wrist, and threaded through it, thin and steady and carrying on regardless, a filament of the same colour heading down the corridor toward a boy called Zach who was pretending very hard not to notice any of this.

She's hurting him, Lyra thought, and then, because she was sixteen and honest with herself in the privacy of her own skull: *He's letting her. That's not the same thing.*

"Okay," said a voice behind her. "I've got the rest."

Katie Doyle crouched down beside her and started picking up pages, and Lyra noticed, as she always did, without being able to stop noticing, that the space between the two of them was full of something. Not a colour she had a name for. A braided, warm, slightly fraying thing, gold at the middle, and thinning at both ends.

"Show-off," Katie said, holding out a corner of the sketch-book. "You draw people like they're made of wire."

"It's charcoal."

“It’s not the medium, you know what I mean.” Katie straightened up, dusting her knees. “Zach’s over by the water fountain pretending to read. Are you going to say something to him, or are you going to do that thing you do?”

“Do what thing I do?”

“You tell me you do nothing, and then you do something.”

Lyra’s face went hot. “I don’t do anything.”

“You fixed his and Katie’s — okay, not yours and mine, *mine and his* — you fixed the thing between us last month. In here.” Katie touched her sternum, in the place where people put a hand when they mean *here*. “He was going to transfer schools over it, and now he won’t shut up about my eyes. You said you did nothing.”

“Things fray,” Lyra said carefully. “They fray and sometimes they mend back on their own. Sometimes.”

“Uh-huh.” Katie looked at her for a moment too long, in the way that Ms. Rivera had started looking at her too, and Lyra decided, for the hundredth time, that she was imagining it. “Sorry about your dad. My mom said he’s back at the hospital.”

“He got home.”

“He got back to the hospital.” Katie’s mouth went flat. “Lyra. That’s a different sentence.”

The phone rang at two in the morning and she was awake before the first ring finished, which she did not examine at the time.

“Miss Chen? Your father collapsed in the waiting room. You should come. Now.”

The drive blurred. She was sixteen and had never driven, and she got on the wrong side of the car twice, and the whole time the thing in her chest was making a noise she had no word for.

This is the night it's real, she kept thinking. This is where I find out if I've been doing this to him.

She had been asking herself that question for two years and she had no way to ask it out loud, because the sentence *Dad, I think my brain is hurting yours* is not a sentence a person can say to her father.

What she had instead was this: for two years she had drawn people the way other people drew scaffolding, and the drawings had got worse — not less accurate, *worse* — the lines thicker, the connections denser, the whole thing starting to look less like a drawing and more like a wiring diagram of something that was already built. And for two years, on and off, her father had had headaches. And she had put the two facts side by side in her head, where she looked at them a great many times a day, and had never once been able to make the join.

The hospital had the smell of every hospital. She got lost twice on the way up. A woman in scrubs took her arm at the lift and said *third floor, honey, he's in 312* in the voice people use when they are being kind on purpose, and Lyra understood, immediately and completely, that people used that voice at funerals and not anywhere else.

He was smaller than he had any right to be.

That was the first thing. Everything else — the monitors, the woman with the clipboard, the strip of tape on his forearm — was furniture, and she could look past it. But Wei Chen had always taken up slightly more space than his actual body warranted, the way very tall people do, and in that bed he took up exactly as much space as his body warranted and no more.

There was dried blood under his nose. She sat down on the plastic chair because her legs had made the decision for her.

His eyes were open. They did not focus at first. Then they did, and they went to her face, and something happened in them that she had never seen before and did not know how to read, and it took her a moment to identify it because she had never seen it directed at her before.

Guilt.

“Dad—”

“Lyra.” His voice was scraped out. “The headaches. I need to tell you about the headaches.”

She put her hand on his, and the hospital noise went out of the room.

She could see it. She had been able to see it for months and had told herself she was imagining it: the silver-grey line between them, the one that had been the warmest and steadiest thing in her life since she was old enough to notice such things. It was not dim. It was *thin*, and thinning, and along the thin part there were dark places where the light simply stopped — gaps, like missing teeth — and at each gap the line buzzed with a fine, high, wrong sound that she had been hearing for a year and had finally let herself name as a sound.

Shadows that move wrong. Lights that shouldn't be there.

He was seeing them too.

“It started when you began drawing those connections,” he said. “Didn’t it.”

It was not a question, and it was not an accusation, and that was the worst part. He had assembled this a long time ago, on his own, in a room where nobody was drawing anything, and had been carrying it alone, and had not said a word.

“How long?” she said.

His mouth did something complicated.

“Weeks,” he said. “At first. Months, I told myself.” He closed his eyes. “Last night it was days.”

The monitor beeped. Somewhere down the hall a machine announced something in a voice designed not to worry anybody.

“Dad—”

“Promise me one thing.” He got his hand up, a small effort, and she understood that it had cost him. “Don’t sit here and decide this is your fault. I don’t know that it is. I want you to hear me say that I don’t know, because in about four minutes somebody in a white coat is going to tell you a great deal more than I can, and I want it to start from the right place.”

Lyra discovered that she had put her hand over her mouth.

Outside the window, the parking lot was the colour of wet slate, and somewhere down at the far end of it a car alarm was going off in the specific stupid rhythm of a car alarm, and a nurse walked past with a coffee cup, and the ordinary world carried on being the ordinary world at the exact moment the ground came out from under it. Lyra looked at it, and away, and at it again, and understood that this was what her life had been doing for two years, and that she had only just now caught up with it.

“Okay,” she said.

“Okay?”

“Okay. Not yet.” She put her chin on the edge of the bed so that she was level with him, which was undignified, and she did not care. “But I’m going to be there when you find out. I’m going to be there for all of it. Whatever it turns out to be, I’m not going to be somewhere else.”

Wei Chen turned his head on the pillow and looked at his daughter, and the dark places along the line between them did not get any better, and he said, “You are a strange girl, and I am extremely glad you are mine,” which from her father was the equivalent of a parade.

She did not sleep.

At ten past four the neurologist who had been dealing with Wei Chen for two years came in and introduced herself as Dr. Ngozi Ekwueme of Westbrook General and Lyra said, automatically, that her father had already seen somebody, and the woman said, patiently, that she was the one, and had been for two hours.

“How much do you know about what he can see?”

“More than he thinks I do.”

“Then you can save us both some time.” She pulled up a chair, which Lyra would think about later, because it was the small hours of a Tuesday, and this woman had sat down next to a frightened teenager instead of standing over her.

“Do you see threads, Miss Chen? Coloured lines between people, and places, and objects?”

Lyra’s whole body went hot and cold at once, the way it had been doing about twice a week for a year.

“Yes,” she said.

“Thank you.” Ekwueme did not move, did not soften, did not reach for her hand. “And how long?”

“Since I was little. Faintly. Properly — about two years. It’s been getting —” She stopped.

“It’s been getting louder. Yes. That’s the word I’d have used.” Ekwueme turned a tablet around. “Your father started with the same thing. The visual cortex and the temporal lobe, here and here, are running hot. Not damaged. Working too hard. He has been interpreting information his brain was never built to handle, continuously, for years, and it is using energy it doesn’t have a budget for.”

“That’s what I was afraid of,” Lyra said. “That I did it to him.”

“That’s a very reasonable fear and it is not what this is.” Ekwueme’s mouth tightened a little, which Lyra later learned meant that she was about to be more careful rather than less. “This is called sympathetic thread bleed. When a seer’s perception runs, it creates feedback. Not a metaphor — feedback, in him, in his own brain, and he is close

enough to you, and you to him, that the loop closes. In most people it gives headaches. Confusion. In some cases it gives seizures, and in some cases it gives this.”

“How long does he have?”

Ekwueme did not answer immediately, and Lyra found that she had been counting the seconds.

“Without treatment, a few months. I want to be honest with you about how few.” She put the tablet down. “There are things we can do. Manageable things. But the underlying problem is that your father is standing next to a live wire, and I cannot insulate him from it, because the insulation would have to be him, and he does not want that.”

“What does he want?”

“He wants to be there when you find out what you are.” Ekwueme stood up. “That is a real answer, by the way. People find it easier to believe in treatment than in the alternative. It is not a stupid thing to want.”

Outside, the sky had gone the colour of a nickel. Somewhere on the floor below, a door opened and closed.

“How do I stop it?” Lyra said. “Being what I am — is there a way to turn it down, to make it quieter, so that—”

“Miss Chen.” Ekwueme waited until Lyra looked at her. “You are sixteen. The person who is going to have to decide whether you turn it down is you, and you are going to be

in a position to decide it better than anyone in this building, including me. What I am going to do is find you people who can teach you how to use it without spending him, and I am going to tell your father that if he refuses, I will overrule him, because he is not in a position to make decisions about his own neurological future this morning.”

She was at the door when she turned back.

“He asked me one thing, and I said I would pass it on, and I am passing it on. He said: *tell her it is not a debt. If it is a debt, she will spend the rest of her life trying to pay it, and there are better uses.*”

And then she was gone, and the room made the noises a room makes, and Lyra Chen sat in the chair beside her father’s bed with her hands flat on the blanket and did not cry, and noticed that the line between them was still there, thin as wire, dark in three places, and still warm.

The last time she saw Katie and Zach’s thread do anything was in April, in the art room, and it was the only other time she had ever deliberately touched one, and she had never told anybody, and she thought about it more than she thought about almost anything.

They had been fighting since September. The thread between them had been fraying for months — she could see it from across a crowded room, the gold gone pale and full of little breaks — and on the day it happened, Katie was crying at the back of the room and Zach was pretending to

work on a piece that had forty minutes of work left in it, and something in Lyra's chest simply *went*.

She did not decide to. That was the part she could never get past afterwards. There was no moment where she thought *I will fix this*, and then a moment where she did it. There was only the sensation of a tangle in her chest coming loose, and then Katie had stopped crying, and Katie had looked up, and Katie had gone very still, and then Katie had said, in a voice with no breath in it, *oh*.

She'd crossed the room on her knees. She'd put her hand flat on the desk next to Katie's drawing, and she had not touched Katie, and she had not touched the thread either, not exactly. She had said, out loud, the way you talk yourself through a door: *hold on, hold on, that's it, there, that's it*.

The line had run warm and thick and whole, and Katie had looked at her and said *what did you do*, and Lyra had said *nothing*, and Katie had said *you did something*, and that had been the end of it, because on the following Monday they were in the corridor outside the art room and Katie had said *Zach says sorry about the thing with the duffle coat* and Lyra had said *okay* and Katie had said *do you want to walk with me* and Lyra had said *yes*.

The thing that had got her was that it had worked.

Not *well*. Not completely. In the corridor that Monday, the line between them was still fraying in two places, and it was

still gold, and it was thinner than it had been in September, and Lyra understood — she had understood at the time, standing in the middle of the art room with her heart going like a bird's — that she had not fixed anything. She had pulled two loose ends together and knotted them.

Katie and Zach got back together that year. They broke up twice more before they left Westbrook, both times by text, both times within three weeks, both times for reasons that had nothing to do with threads.

But they had got back together. That was the part that Lyra could not put down, and that she had never been able to explain to anybody, not even to herself, and certainly not to Ms. Rivera, who had cornered her at the end of that April and said, *You drew something true in that assignment, Lyra. Something true and not artistic. Come and see me when you're ready*, and had then, with what Lyra now understood as an almost unnerving restraint, not mentioned it again.

Two gold threads. One September. One April.

And her father, in Room 312, with dark places in him.

Lyra sat in the chair and looked at the places where the line between them had gone out, and thought, with a clarity that arrived fully formed and without comfort:

I do not know what I am. But I know what it costs, and I know I have already started paying it, and I have been paying it in other people's lives without asking any of them.

That was the morning everything turned over. It did not feel like turning over. It felt like a Tuesday, in a hospital, with bad coffee.

Thread Resonance Note: Thread-sight confirmed, multi-spectrum, late onset. Sympathetic bleed confirmed in a first-degree relative. Prognosis: guarded. Referral: see attached. Recommend Academy intake evaluation.

Chapter 2: Father's Equations

Wednesday 28 August. The house on Ellery Street.

Ba, there were green tea sachets in the cupboard above the kettle and only the ones he liked in the box, and Lyra had been putting the wrong ones in for two years and he had never once said so, and she understood on Sunday morning that this was how he said so.

The rain came in off the porch and went along the window frames the way it did, and Lyra sat at the end of the kitchen table with charcoal in her hand and a stack of Ms. Rivera's

first-year portfolios in front of her, and she was supposed to be marking them.

She had marked four. She had spent most of the last hour on the same page.

The problem was that the kitchen was doing the thing.

It was doing the thing everywhere, always — that was the part nobody warned you about, if nobody warned you, which nobody did, because there was no warning, there was just a girl who at some point between being five and being six had noticed that her father was a person and not a shape — but kitchens were where she lost herself. Every surface had a line running off it. The fridge had a grey one to the back door and a warm, complicated one to the toaster, because he had owned the toaster for eleven years and it had never once surprised him. The window had a long pale one going out to the fence. Her father's teacup, the blue one with the chip in the handle that he refused to replace, had a gold line into his chest that Lyra could pick up from the far side of the room, and that was the line.

The line to her father was the line.

It was silver-grey, which she had read somewhere meant *old and structural* — load-bearing, like a beam, which was a stupid word for it but the only one that had ever felt right — and it was wide, and it was steady, and it had a texture like the grain in a plank. Under the kitchen table it was doing the thing it did when he worked, which was to run hot

and bright at the exact point where he was thinking, so that she could tell from across the room which of his problems he had hold of.

Right now it was bright at two points at once, and one of them was where his hand was, and the other one was further in, and Lyra had learned over two years to read the distance between those two points as a rough measure of how hard a problem was.

This one was hard. It had been hard since Thursday.

She put the charcoal down and dragged the portfolios towards her and did the honest thing, which was to grade a portfolio by Marco Senn, who was fourteen and had drawn a dog.

"You're doing the thing where you hold the pencil and don't move it."

"I do not do a thing."

"You do a thing with your mouth." Wei Chen pushed his glasses up. "It goes a bit flat at the corner."

She put the pencil down deliberately. "You have a headache."

"I have a Wednesday."

"You have a headache and you're doing the thing where the headache is a legitimate reason to work."

He laughed. It was a good laugh, and it cost him something, and he covered it by reaching for the teapot and finding it empty, and Lyra was on her feet before she had decided to be, filling the kettle at the sink with the specific bad temper of a person who has been given a job.

"Do you want the big pot or the small pot?" she said.

"The small one. It steeps longer."

"You always say that and then you drink it too fast and say it's bitter."

"That's because I like it bitter."

"It's not bitter, it's *strong*." She set the small pot down. "Ba, you were discharged eight hours ago."

"I was discharged eight hours ago," her father agreed, "and I would like to be permitted one morning of not being discussed."

The line between them buzzed along its whole length — not loudly, not the way it had in the hospital, where she had been able to hear the gaps in it over a nurse talking. But it was there, and she heard it, and so did he, because he flinched, minutely, in the middle of pouring, and Lyra filed that away with a kind of cold anger she had been getting better at.

She put the small pot on the hob. She sat back down. She pulled the portfolios towards her again, and she said, in-

stead of the thing she had been saying for two days, “Can I ask you a real question?”

“You can ask me a real question.”

“Not a doctor question. You can put the doctor down for a minute.”

Wei Chen took off his glasses, which he only ever did when he was about to be careful, and cleaned them on the hem of his shirt, which never worked.

“Ask.”

“Are you afraid of it?”

He put the glasses back on. “Yes.”

“Okay.” She had not expected it to be that easy and she had to sit with it a second. “Okay. That’s — okay. I’m afraid of it too, so.”

“Yes,” her father said, “I imagine you are.”

“Not of seeing.” Lyra turned the charcoal over in her fingers. “Of the seeing *being me*. I get to be sixteen and frightened and have a bad week, and then there’s this thing that I can’t put down, and it doesn’t get tired, and it doesn’t go to bed, and it’s not — it isn’t a skill, Ba. Skills have off switches. This doesn’t have an off switch, and it’s in my *head*, and you can hear it, and I can hear you hearing it, and neither of us has said anything about that.”

The kettle did the thing it did before it boiled, the small climbing hiss, and neither of them moved.

"That's the fairest description of it I've ever heard," Wei Chen said. "Including mine."

"What's yours?"

"Mine is that I've been married to a woman who could do it, and I spent eleven years being polite about it, and then she disappeared, and now our daughter can do it, and I have spent a year and a half pretending I did not know." He turned his cup a quarter turn on the table. "I have been polite about it, Lyra. I want you to know that I know what that was."

She looked at him. He had not said *your mother could do it* in five years. He had said *your mother was sensitive*, and *your mother had a rich inner life*, and once, at a barbecue in the year before, *your mother saw things*, in a voice she had recognised and had then wished she could unhear.

"You knew."

"I knew."

"When?"

"Before you were born. Before you were four. I have watched you draw since you could hold a crayon, Lyra, and I have watched you stop drawing at about the age of nine, and I worked out what that meant, and I decided that not

saying it would be a kindness, and then you were fifteen and it stopped being a kindness and became a lie, and I got very good at it.” He said this without any self-pity at all, which made it much worse. “I did not think it was going to cost me my life.”

The kettle clicked off. Neither of them got up.

“Did Mum know you knew?” Lyra said.

“Your mother knew everything I knew. Your mother is the reason I knew anything at all.”

She did get up, eventually, and pour the water, and steep it too long, and he drank it too fast, and neither of them commented, and it was the best thing that had happened in the kitchen in a fortnight.

Then he turned back to the laptop, and the bright point in the line between them moved, and Lyra, who had spent two years learning to pretend she was not doing exactly this, gave up and looked at the screen.

“Ba, that’s not converging.”

“It is converging. It is converging *slowly*, which is a different complaint.”

“It’s not slow, it’s wrong.” She pulled the chair round to his side of the table, which she was not supposed to do, and which he had stopped objecting to in about March. “You’re treating it as a function of the two variables separately and

then adding them. It's not that. When they interact, the whole curve changes shape. It's — okay, look. Look at this."

She drew it for him on the back of a portfolio sheet, in charcoal, fast, without looking at her hand.

Two dots. Four lines. She added four more that made it wrong on purpose, so that he would see it.

"You're not looking for a function," she said. "You're looking for a *web*. You've got two things and you're forcing them into a line, and they don't want a line, they're a — they're a network. Everything's connected to everything else and the amount of connection isn't the same on both sides. It goes up and down. Some pairs are strong and some pairs are almost nothing, and if you average them you get a number that doesn't mean anything."

Wei Chen had gone very still.

"Where did you learn graph theory?"

"I've been in your study for two years, Ba, you leave things *open*."

"Thirty-one seconds," he said.

"What?"

"Show me again. From the top. And don't let me interrupt you this time, because I want to hear where you were going

before I start criticising your notation.” He was already reaching for a clean sheet. “Go on. Slowly.”

She went again. Slowly.

He interrupted her four minutes in, and she had been right about the web, and he was right about the notation, and they ended up at half past nine in the morning with tea going cold and two pages covered in a hybrid of his graph paper and her charcoal, arguing — properly, hard, on the evidence — about whether the interaction term should be weighted by duration or by intensity.

And it was the best two hours Lyra had had since the hospital, and she understood, sitting on the end of his table with charcoal dust on the side of her hand, that this was the thing she was actually frightened of losing. Not the sight. Her father, at the end of a kitchen table, being *interested*.

“I would like you to do more of this with me,” he said.

“It’s not rigorous.”

“It is extremely rigorous. It is rigorous in a way I cannot currently check, which is a different and more interesting problem, and I intend to check it.” He was writing. He did not look up. “Will you come in on Sunday afternoons? Bring the charcoal. Bring the bad notation. I will bring the coffee and we will be wrong together for two hours.”

He still would not say it. She noted that. She let it go. It was a Wednesday, in a kitchen, and he had promised her Sunday.

The studio door was at the end of the hall, and it had been shut for five years, and there was no lock on it, and they had never once discussed this.

Lyra went down the corridor at four in the afternoon with the rain still going and stood in front of it and put her hand flat on the wood, which was cool, and which was exactly the temperature of the rest of the house, and which was not, she thought, the temperature of a door and nothing else.

You are being dramatic, she told herself. You are sixteen and you have had no sleep and you have just spent the best morning of your life being argued with by your father, and you want to go and look at your dead mother's things.

She opened it.

The air came out at her like something held. Dust, cold paper, and under it, faintly, linseed oil and the ghost of turpentine, and something else that she had no name for and had smelled perhaps six times in her life, and which was simply *her mother in this room*.

The easel stood where it had stood. There was a half-finished canvas on it — a hillside, mostly done, the bottom corner still bare primed board — and the bare corner had a

clean edge on it, not a torn one, which meant she had put the brush down in the middle of a decision and had never come back.

The desk had a journal on it. Leather, soft, the corners gone white. A circle with radiating lines stamped into the front, blind, no colour.

Lyra did not open the journal.

Not because she had decided not to. She got as far as putting two fingers on the cover, and the room *answered*.

It was not a sound. It was closer to the way the kitchen felt in the mornings — pressure, warmth, a leaning — except that the leaning had a direction, and it went from the desk to the walls to the ceiling and back down again, and it was silver-blue, and it moved the way water moves in a pipe that is not quite full.

Memory, she thought. Nobody's, specifically. The room's.

She took her hand off the journal and the leaning stayed exactly as it was, patient, and did not follow her, and did not leave.

In the tray on the desk, under four dead brushes, there was a chain with a small silver pendant on it: a circle with lines running out from the centre in a spiral, the same design as the journal's cover, in metal that had gone dull. It was not jade. It was heavier than it looked.

Lyra did not pick it up either.

Instead she stood in the middle of her mother's studio and let herself look, properly, for the first time in five years, and she took in what was actually in the room: a working room, cluttered, warm, used, a chair with a cushion worn flat on one side, a stack of library books with the spines cracked and a receipt from a shop in Chinatown serving as a bookmark, a chipped mug.

Nobody dies in a room like that. That was the thought that arrived, unwanted, and the worst thought she had had all day.

Somebody left in a hurry and was never coming back.

The floorboard in front of the easel creaked.

"Lyra?"

He was in the doorway. He had a towel round his shoulders and his reading glasses in his hand and an expression on his face she could not read in one go.

"Ba, I —"

"How long have you had that door open?"

"Since Tuesday. Since I was five."

The colour went out of his face. He put his hand up onto the frame.

"Then it has been open for five years," he said, "and I have been closing it."

He did not shout. Lyra had been braced for shouting and got something much worse: a man standing in a doorway trying to get his breathing under control, and failing, and being visibly ashamed of failing.

"I asked you not to go in there."

"I know."

"Not because I didn't want you to. Do you understand that? I did not close that door to keep something from you. I closed it because I could not —" He stopped. He took his glasses off and pressed the heels of his hands into his eyes, which was a thing he had never once done in front of her. "I could not stand in it."

"But it's just *her stuff*, Ba."

"Yes," he said. "That is exactly what it is, and that is exactly why I cannot stand in it, and I have not stood in it since the eleventh of September five years ago, and you have just told me you have known about the room for eight years, which means I have been lying to you since you were five, and I need a moment, and I am not going to pretend that I have one."

He went and sat on the bottom stair, which is not a comfortable place to sit, and which he chose.

Lyra stood in the doorway of her mother's studio and looked at the back of her father's head and understood that she had, without any particular wish to do it, taken something from him. Not the room. The *not knowing*. He had spent five years closing a door so that he would not have to stand in it, and she had, without meaning to, taken away the only reason the door had stayed shut.

"I'm sorry," she said.

"Don't be. Not for that." He did not turn round. "Lyra, I want to be very clear about one thing, because I think you have made an inference and I think the inference is reasonable and I think it is wrong. I did not keep you out of that room to keep you from seeing threads. If I could have stopped you seeing threads I would have done it, and I would have felt like a hero, and I would have been a fool, and I would have lost you into the bargain."

"Then why?"

"Because the people who see what you see end up *alone*, Lyra. Your mother told me that when we met. She said: the sight is not the problem. The problem is that it puts a pane of glass between you and every other human being on the planet, and you get to watch all of them through it, and nobody gets to watch you." He turned the glasses over in his hands. "And I thought: not her. Not our daughter. Not while I have anything to say about it."

"And yet."

“And yet.” He stood up. “And yet she walked into that room on the eleventh of September, five years ago, and told me she had found something, and I told her she was tired, and she went back to the studio and shut the door, and the next morning she was not in it, and the next morning she was not in the house.”

The rain had got louder.

“Ba, that’s not—”

“I know that is not what happened. I have a whole file on what happened. Police reports, a search that went for eleven months, a lawyer who took our money for two years.” He came back up the last two stairs and stopped in front of her. “What I have never been able to explain, Lyra, and what I have never once said out loud in this house, is that I was *relieved*. That when the police finally stopped coming, and when the neighbours stopped asking, and when we moved from the house on Ellery Street and I put the studio behind me, I was relieved. And I have never forgiven myself for it, and I am telling you tonight because you have been in that room twice now and you are not going to stop, and you deserve to know what you are walking into before you walk into it.”

She stood very still. The silver-blue leaning in the room behind her shifted, faintly, the way water shifts.

“What am I walking into?”

“That room, for a start.” He almost smiled. “And there is a great deal more than that room, if you want the whole of it. Come out of there. Sit down. I am going to tell you the parts I can bear to say out loud, and then we are going to have an argument about the rest, and then — perhaps, if I can find a way to do it that is not a coward’s way — I am going to tell you about the letter that came six days ago.”

He did tell her about the letter that evening, and it took him an hour and forty minutes, and he got most of it right.

It had come to the university address, because the university address was on file, and it was cream paper with a seal he did not recognise, and it was addressed to *Miss Lyra Chen* and it said that her abilities — *her rare and remarkable perspective*, it said — were a gift deserving nurture, and that an institution existed which had been teaching the disciplined use of that gift since 1798, and that it would be visiting her town, and would be glad to speak with her and with her father, and that no obligation of any kind was implied by the receipt of this letter.

“They gave you my name,” Lyra said.

“They gave your name, your school, and the date of the last time you were taken off campus for something that looked like a seizure.” He said it evenly. “That last detail is the one I would like you to sit with for a moment, because I have been sitting with it for three weeks, and I have not been able to put it down.”

Lyra looked at the letter. It was very well made. That was what she kept coming back to. It was the best paper she had ever handled, and the seal was a single line, a thread, passing through an eye, and it had been embossed rather than printed, and somebody had thought about the weight of it in somebody else's hand.

"What did you do with it?"

"I put it in the drawer under the phone bill I did not pay." He was quiet for a second. "I am not proud of that. I want to be accurate: I am not proud of it, and I did it anyway, and the reason I did it is that I could not work out what I wanted to happen, and a man who cannot work out what he wants will do almost anything to postpone finding out."

"Are you going to answer them?"

"I have already answered them. This morning, before you were awake. I telephoned the number on the letter and spoke to a young woman called Eleanor Weaver, who was extremely gracious, and who told me that there would be an informal gathering on Saturday at a bookshop in town, that families were welcome, and that no one would be approached without me present." He turned his cup. "I said we would come. I said it before I had decided to. I would like it on the record that I have been an absolute coward about this for three weeks and that I have now stopped."

Lyra looked at him for a long moment.

"You're not sending me by myself."

"No."

"You're coming."

"I am coming." He almost smiled again. "Lyra, I cannot do the thing you do, and I will never be able to do it, and I have spent two years pretending to believe you about it and I am extremely tired of pretending. But I can sit in a room and be extremely unwelcome and extremely unhelpful, and I can be the person in the corner who is not from their world, and there is a version of this where that is the single most useful thing in the room, and I intend to find out whether there is."

The rain had stopped. Through the window the street smelled wet and green and completely ordinary.

"Ba," Lyra said. "They know my name. They know the date of the thing at school."

"Yes."

"Should we be scared?"

Wei Chen considered this with the seriousness he brought to everything, and Lyra loved him for it, and was frightened alongside him, and the two things sat down next to each other and stayed there.

"I think," he said, "that we should be careful, and not frightened, and that the difference between those two things is going to be the entire subject of the next six months of my life." He got up, and put the letter in his pocket, and stopped in the doorway. "And Lyra. One more thing, and then we are having dinner and I am not discussing it."

"Okay."

"The woman on the telephone. She knew your mother's name."

The kitchen went very cold in a way that had nothing to do with the window.

"She asked about her," Lyra said.

"She asked about her by name, Lyra. Not 'the mother.' Not 'her.' A name." He looked at her for a long moment. "Your mother went to that place. I know that now. I have known it for four years and I have not said it in this house, and I am saying it tonight, and that is the last of it. I am not sure any more what I am protecting. Come and eat."

Thread Resonance Note: Academy file C-2214. Prior enrolment of a first-degree relative (L. Chen, 2008–2009, partial) retrieved. Note appended by E. Weaver: recommend the girl be assessed before the Council schedule closes. File flagged for review by [REDACTED].

Chapter 3: Recognition

Friday 30 August.

The folder was on the kitchen table when Lyra came down, face down, squared at the edges, and her father was sitting at the other end of the table doing the thing he did with the newspaper, which was holding it at arm's length and moving his lips.

"You're doing the thing where you hold the pencil and don't move it," she said.

"I do not do a thing."

"You do a thing with your mouth. It goes a bit flat at the corner."

He put the paper down. “I telephoned the woman yesterday.”

“You told me you had. You told me twice, and then you told me the number, and then you told me to be careful with the number, which is the part I have been thinking about for eighteen hours.” Lyra put her bag on the chair and did not take her coat off. “Did she say yes?”

“She said the family was welcome. She said no one would be approached without you present. She said her name is Eleanor Weaver and she has been doing this for eleven years, and she said —” He stopped.

“Said what?”

“She said, and I am quoting, *Tell your daughter that the number on the board is a severity and not a percentage of anything*. And then she said she was sorry, and she put the phone down.” Wei Chen took his glasses off. “I have been a university professor for twenty-one years, Lyra, and in twenty-one years nobody in a position of authority has ever said anything to me like that, and I do not know what to do with it.”

Lyra stood in the kitchen in her coat and found that she was not sure whether she wanted to cry or to laugh, and that what she actually felt was something in between and much worse, which was *relief*, and the relief was so large that she had to put a hand on the table.

“So you’re going,” she said.

“I have not decided that.”

“Bàba.”

“I have decided that I am going to sit in a room and be extremely unhelpful,” her father said, “and I have not decided anything else, and I would like the distinction observed.”

She made him say it properly. That took forty minutes and she was faintly ashamed of how good she was at it, and he was faintly ashamed of how easily he was managed, and between them they got through the whole of it, which is the sort of thing that takes forty minutes when you are both being careful and about four seconds when you are not.

The first thing she established was the diagnosis. “Dr. Ekwueme’s letter says sympathetic thread bleed. She says it means my head is doing something to yours. I want to hear you say it.”

“I cannot say it. I have a mechanism, a name, and a mechanism is not the same as a fact about my own skull.” He turned the folder over. “What I can say is that the two things started in the same month and I have never been able to unstart them.”

“The second thing,” said Lyra.

The second thing was that the letter was addressed to *Miss Lyra Chen* at the university address, and that her father had

taken it out of the drawer under the phone bill he had not paid on four separate occasions between eight o'clock in the morning and half past five in the afternoon, and had read it, and had put it back, and had done the thing he did at the end of a bad day, which was to stand at the sink for eleven minutes with the tap off.

"So you knew on the twenty-second."

"I knew on the twenty-second."

"And you didn't tell me for eight days."

"No." Wei Chen did not look up. "And I would like to be permitted to say why, because I know how it is going to sound, and I would like to say it anyway."

"Go on."

"Because if I told you on the twenty-second, you would have started planning. And there is a version of you that is much better at planning than the rest of us, Lyra, and that version is the one that is frightened, and I have watched you get frightened at me for two years and I did not want to be the reason you became organised." He put his hands flat on the table, which she had never once seen him do. "That is the true reason. The other reason is that I did not want to have the conversation. I have never in my life not wanted to have a conversation, and last Tuesday I sat in a hospital and watched a woman tell my daughter that the thing about her is killing me, and I discovered that I would

rather have the conversation on a Saturday than on a Friday evening, and that is a thing about me that I am not proud of and that you are entitled to.

Lyra thought about that for a moment longer than she needed to.

“Right,” she said. “Okay. That’s — okay. It’s not fine, but I can work with it.” She pulled out the third chair. “Now do the other thing.”

“Which other thing.”

“You told me on Thursday that you wanted three things from me before I went, and you only said one of them, and then the folder came out and I forgot.” Lyra put her elbows on the table. “You’ve been holding something since Thursday and it’s about my mother and I have watched you not say it for two days. Say it.”

Wei Chen looked at his tea.

“She was at that school,” he said.

The kitchen was very quiet.

“For how long?”

“Four months, in the spring of 2002. She was thirty-three and she was the best thing I have ever met and she was, for about four months, extremely happy, in a way I had not seen her be before and have not seen since.” He said it care-

fully, the way you walk on a floor you know is bad. “She came home and she was not the same and she would not tell me what had happened, and I did not ask, because I did not want to be a man who asks his wife that at the end of a dinner party.”

“What did she tell you?”

“Two things. She told me their method was wrong, and that she had argued about it and lost, and that she was going to do it her own way instead. And she told me —” He stopped, and started again, and the second time it came out of him sideways. “She told me that if anything ever happened to her, I was not to let anybody put a *method* on her. She was very specific. She said: *it will not be a monster, Wei. It will be a spreadsheet.*”

Lyra’s hand went to her sternum, to bare skin. The jade was still in her grandmother’s house, with everything else of her mother’s, and the fact that Nai Nai had said nothing at all about any of it was somehow much worse than saying something.

“And then?” she said.

“And then, five years ago this September, she went into a chamber under that building by herself, on a night, and told nobody she was going, and the next morning she was not in the house.” He said it without drama, which was how he delivered the worst things. “They searched for eleven months. I was the one who told her not to take the position.

I have done the arithmetic on that every day for six years and it comes out the same every time and I would like it noted that the arithmetic is not the problem.”

“That’s the third thing,” Lyra said quietly.

“Yes.”

“What’s the fourth?”

Wei Chen took off his glasses and cleaned them on his shirt, which never worked, and which Lyra had watched him do perhaps four hundred times in her life and had never once seen fail to be the thing he did instead of crying.

“There is not a fourth,” he said. “I have three and I have said two of them and I am going to go and stand at the sink now, and you are going to sit at that table and be sixteen at me for a bit, and then we are going to have eggs.”

She was sixteen at him for eleven minutes.

She got the third condition out of him — the one about not doing it for him — and she heard it, and she did not agree to it, and she told him so, and he let her, and something in the kitchen got easier by about four per cent. Then she got as far as the practical part and hit the wall.

“Chợ Lớn.”

“Yes.”

“You emigrated when you were four.”

“I emigrated when I was four. My mother was born there. My grandmother was taught there, in a house on a street called Hậu Giang, by a woman who was the grandmother of the woman who taught me.” Nai Nai’s chain sat on the table between them, coiled. “That is a very long sentence and I have never said it out loud to anybody, and I have been waiting since Friday to see whether I could.”

“And Lin knew that. Lin knew all of that, and she was taught *here*—”

“Here, in this kitchen, by a woman with a jade needle and a temper, from the age of six, because her mother and my mother were the kind of friends who leave their children with each other.” He turned the chain over with one finger. “Lyra. I want to be extremely careful here, because I can feel you already arriving somewhere, and I would rather you did not arrive there at speed.”

“I’m arriving somewhere.”

“I know. Everyone does. The family has a great many people in it who see things, and all of them ended up in the same building, and the building is the reason your mother is not in this kitchen.” He looked at her. “Chợ Lớn is not where the gold is. It is where your family is. Those are different sentences and I would like them kept apart for a while.”

Lyra looked at the window for a while.

“So the map is wrong,” she said.

“Your mother’s map is *her mother’s map*, and it was drawn in about 1996, and it says north, near Canada, and it does not say why, and it does not say when, and there is a line through ‘near’ in her own hand as though she had argued with herself about it.” He was going through the folder now, and the folder had a photocopy in it, and he had evidently had the photocopy made himself, at a copy shop, on his lunch, which was the single most likeable thing she had learned about her father in two years. “I have looked at it for eight days. I am not a person who sees anything. I looked at it for eight days and I could not tell you whether it means anything at all, and the reason I could not tell you is that I do not know what I am looking at, and I have spent my entire professional life resenting that kind of sentence.”

“Then what do you think it is?”

“I think,” her father said, “that your mother went looking for something, and that she told your grandmother about it in a panic, and that the person she trusted to help her find it is the person who runs the school, and that either she found it and told them and it was suppressed, or she did not find it and it frightened her into a chamber on a night when nobody knew where she was.” He squared the folder. “Those are the two available stories. In the first one she is a martyr and I am a fool who kept her home. In the second

one she is a woman who was frightened and made a bad decision alone, and I am a fool who kept her home, and the difference between them is nine years old and I do not get to find out.”

At four o'clock she went out to the gate to meet him coming home, which she had not done since she was about nine and which neither of them mentioned.

“Ba.”

“Mm.”

“If I get in a room on Saturday and everybody in it is very kind and very interested and slightly better informed than me about my own mother, what do I do?”

Wei Chen stopped on the pavement, and took his briefcase off his shoulder, and set it down, which he had not had to do.

“You want the tactical answer or the true one,” he said.

“I can't tell.”

“The true one.” He shifted the briefcase to his other hand. “You are going to be very good in that room, Lyra, and I want you to know that I have thought about it and I have concluded it, and I would like you to be warned, because it is not what you are expecting. You are not going to be able to tell whether they are lying to you. Nobody can. That is not a failure of their ethics, that is what a room full of peo-

ple who know things is *for*. You will not be able to tell, and you are sixteen, and you are going to sit there and feel the whole structure of it, and there is going to be a moment — it will be a short moment, it will be about four seconds long — when you will be tempted to be certain.”

“Certain about what?”

“About which of them is lying.” He picked the briefcase up. “And I want you to know, before we get there, that *I* have not been able to tell for five years, and that I have used every tool I have, and that a man who has been a professor for twenty-one years and has taught four hundred students how not to trust a bad argument cannot get to the bottom of this either. So you will not be able to. That is not a thing to be ashamed of at sixteen. That is the actual condition of a person who loves somebody who has gone missing, and there is no technique for it, and everybody who tells you there is, is selling.”

“Then what do I *do*?”

“You write down every single thing anybody says to you that you would not be able to guess, including the kind things.” He started walking. “Including especially the kind things. In a school like that the kind things are the ones that have been shaped. You will feel the shaping and you will not be able to prove it, and so you will write it down in the shape it arrived in, and in ten years you will be glad you did.”

That night she sat on the end of her own bed with empty hands, because everything of her mother's was still in her grandmother's house, where it had always been, and she had decided — out loud, to herself, in an empty room, which she was aware was not the same as deciding — that she was done waiting to be given any of it, and that tomorrow she was going to ask.

Instead she lay on her back and held her own hands up above her face and looked at them until the room began to do the thing, which it still did, and which was that the small warm box of her bedroom stopped being a small warm box and became a room with a second room behind it.

She had been having that since she was six.

She had never told anybody. Not Rivera, not Nai Nai, not her father. Ten years of a second room, and no words.

Nobody has ever asked me what is in the second room, she thought, lying there with her hands empty. Not one person, in ten years. Not my father, who notices when I do not eat. Not Nai Nai, who counts my breaths.

The second room was there. It had been there since she was six years old, and it had never once contained anything, and on Sunday she was going to find out what was in it, and she was not going to be frightened of that, and she was absolutely frightened of that.

She lay in the dark, and did not sleep, and did not turn the light on, and did not put the paper off the door.

Thread Resonance Note: C-2214. Guardian conditions received and entered verbatim: (1) accompaniment, unconditional after the first hour; (2) no diagnostic disclosure to the school in advance of the guardian's consent; (3) explicit refusal of any inducement offered in the seer's interest of a third party. One further condition offered by the guardian and not accepted: the seer has stated she will not agree to it, and the entry stands as a matter of record rather than as an agreement. Note from E. Weaver: understood. I will raise the third with my own committee on Thursday and I expect to lose. Note appended by R. Ekwueme (external): please be aware that the referral to you was made on the fifteenth and that the letter of the twenty-second was not the trigger. Somebody had already made a decision about this child before either of us was told anything.

Chapter 4: The Invitation

Saturday 31 August. Nai Nai's kitchen on Ellery Street, and then a corner on the way home.

“A tradition is not a set of rules. It is an argument that has been going on for a very long time between people who are dead.”

— Nai Nai, on being asked why her grandmother never wrote anything down

The bus to Ellery Street took fifty-five minutes and used to take forty, and Lyra spent the first ten of them watching a thread between the driver and a woman in the third row, and the next thirty working out why she could not switch it off.

She could not switch it off. That was the new thing. For two years it had come and went — a bad week, a bad month, an afternoon in a corridor when everything was a wiring diagram and she had gone home and put her head under a pillow. But since the fifteenth it had settled in and taken up residence, and it was as though somebody had turned a dimmer up in a room she had not known was there.

At the last stop before her grandmother's, a man got on with a bicycle, and the whole length of the aisle between the door and the back filled up with lines, and Lyra sat with her hands in her lap and her eyes shut and let it wash over her, and it was — she had to be honest, sitting there with her eyes shut — restful. It was the only quiet she got.

That is the problem, she thought. I have found the thing that helps and it is the thing that is in my father's head.

Anmei Chen was eighty-one years old and lived in a house on Ellery Street, four streets from where Lyra and her father had lived before, and the reason for the street name was that both houses had belonged to the same family and had been given the family name, which in this family was not a family name so much as an administrative decision taken in about 1911.

Her grandmother was standing in the doorway with a dish towel over her shoulder.

“You are wearing your school coat to a grandmother's house in August.”

“It’s raining.”

“It is not raining. It has not rained since Tuesday. You are wearing your school coat because you do not know what else to do with your hands.” Anmei Chen turned around. “Bà Sáu made *bánh tét*. You will eat. You do not get an opinion about the pork, and you do not get an opinion about the second helping, and if you say you are not hungry I will telephone your father and tell him you said so.”

“Nai Nai—”

“You will eat and then you will tell me about the letter, and then I will tell you about the school, and we will not have this conversation in a doorway like two women at a market.”

Bánh tét was the cylindrical rice cake from her grandmother’s province, wrapped in banana leaf and boiled for hours, and the first thing Lyra had ever made with her own hands that anybody had ever asked her for. She had been eleven. She had put too much filling into one corner and had been told about it for six years.

She ate two. Her grandmother watched her do it with the flat satisfaction of a woman whose plan was working.

“You have a question,” Anmei Chen said, “and you have had it since you got on the bus, and it is the same question you asked me on your fifth birthday, which was *how do you always know what I am thinking*, and I told you then and

I will tell you now, and you will like the answer less this time.”

“You count my breaths.”

“Your breaths go fast when you are lying and slow when you are frightened, and there is a third kind where you are holding something very still so that nobody will ask you about it.” Her grandmother dipped a piece of cake into the tea and did not eat it. “You are frightened. And you are holding something. And you are also lying, but about something small, and I will let that go, because you will tell me when you are ready, and I have never yet known a person to be harmed by being allowed to arrive at a thing in their own time.”

Lyra put her chopsticks down.

“Nai Nai. The letter came nine days ago and I found out on Friday and I have not told you because I did not want to be told things.”

The dish towel came off the shoulder and went on the back of the chair, very deliberately, the way you put down something that is about to be needed.

“Sit back,” said Anmei Chen.

The box was mother-of-pearl inlaid, and the pattern on the lid was a knot that Lyra had been looking at in dreams since she was small and had never been able to draw.

Inside, on faded blue silk, was a jade pendant.

Not large. About the size of a thumbnail, in a shape that was almost but not quite a disc, drilled at the top and worn on a cord that had been replaced at some point in a colour that did not match.

Anmei Chen did not lift it out. She put one finger on it and left it there.

“Whose is it?”

“Your mother’s. It was her mother’s, and her mother’s mother’s, and it came down the Ho line in the time when there was a line, which is to say that it went north out of Saigon in 1975 in the bottom of a tin, and then it came south again when your mother came to this country, and then it stopped with her.” The finger did not move. “It is not jade of any great worth. It is not a treasure. It is a *key*, and it is a key to a thing that does not exist, and the reason it still works after four generations is that everyone who has ever held it wanted it to.”

“What does it open?”

“Nothing.” Anmei Chen finally looked up. “That is what I am about to tell you, and I have saved it for eighty-one years and once, so you will listen to the shape of it before the content.”

She sat down.

“Your grandmother — my mother, whom you never met, who died in the winter of ninety-nine — used to be able to see two kinds of thing. She would tell you, if you asked, that she saw *threads* and *currents*, and if you were a stupid child you would write that down and think it was poetry. It is not poetry. It is one thing, seen from two ends.”

“Explain.”

“*Threads* are the individual. The line between a person and a person, a person and a place, a person and what they intend to do next. The oldest ones are old: a grandmother and a granddaughter, a house and the family that has lived in it, a teacher and the student she is going to fail. They are *yours* — you can see them, and in the old way you can touch them, and everything you do to a thread is a thing you have done to a person.” Her grandmother’s finger was still on the pendant. “*Currents* are the other end. They are what a place has been. They are not made of people; they are made of all the people who have ever been in a place and are not there any more. They are slower, they do not belong to anybody, and they are the only thing in this family that cannot be hurt by a person who means well.”

“And Mum?”

“Your mother had the whole of it.” A pause. “Full-spectrum. Both ends, at once, and the connections between them, which is the third thing my mother could not do and your mother could do from about the age of eleven. When

your mother looked at a room she was not seeing the room. She was seeing the room *and everything that had ever happened in it*, and she could not switch either off, and from fourteen she could not switch off the part where the two of them did not agree with each other.”

“The currents didn’t agree?”

“Never once. Not in eighty-one years.” Anmei Chen picked up her tea. “That is the part your father cannot accept, and it is the part I would have you take to that school on Saturday. Your mother was not a woman with a beautiful gift. She was a woman with a *contradiction* in her, from the age of eleven, and she spent twenty-nine years learning to hold a contradiction without resolving it. There are three people alive who have ever seen that, and one of them is sitting in front of me eating my rice cake, and one of the others is a woman called Mei-Hua, who is your father’s sister, and who works at the school you are going to on Saturday, and whom I have not spoken to in five years. The third is a man in Lyon who has never met your mother and who has read everything she published, and I have never told him any of this, and he does not know whether to believe me.”

Lyra put her hand down.

“I don’t have an aunt at that school.”

“You have exactly one, and you have never met her, and I am going to explain that in about ten minutes and you are

not going to like any part of it.” Her grandmother drank. “Eat.”

The explanation took eleven minutes and was worse than Lyra had been able to imagine.

“Your father is my son,” Anmei Chen said. “Your mother was my *daughter-in-law*, and before that she was my student, from the age of six, because her mother and I were the kind of friends who leave their children with each other. Her mother was a Ho. My mother was a Ho. There are three of us living who can do the whole of it, and two of us are in this family, and the third is your mother’s sister, and the fourth — the fourth was a woman called Lin Mei-Hua, who was born in nineteen twenty in Chợ Lớn and who did something in this quarter in the autumn of nineteen forty-three, and who was your great-grandmother on your mother’s side, and who died in nineteen ninety-four, and whom I have known about since I was twenty-four years old, and whom I have told you about exactly once in my life and will not tell you again today.”

“Four. And Mei-Hua is one.”

“Mei-Hua is one, and she is your father’s sister, and she is the one who taught your mother the things I could not teach her, because Mei-Hua is *fast* and I am *correct*, and your mother needed both, and there is a great deal of that in the two of them. I have one end where she has two, and that is the whole of the difference between us, and I have

never once resented it, and I have resented it constantly.” Anmei Chen’s mouth moved. “And your father met your mother in nineteen ninety-six, at something neither of them thought was worth mentioning, and married her the next year, and that is how two families that had been arguing with each other across an ocean for forty years became one family with two surnames and one very tired grandmother.”

“So when my father says—”

“Your father says *we do not have a large family*, and he says it in the tone of a man who has been saying it for sixteen years and has never once been contradicted, and he is aware that he is lying, and he has never worked out who he is lying to.” She put the cup down. “Which brings us to the part you will actually want. Mei-Hua is the Registrar of that Academy. She has been for eleven years. She is the person who signed your file, and she is the person who did not answer one of the eleven questions I put to her in the spring of 2007, and she did not answer it because she was frightened, and I did not press her, because I was frightened too, and because I was a coward with a granddaughter in the room.”

“What happened to her,” Lyra said.

“What happened to her.”

“She was going to speak to the Council. You told me. She came to you at night with a map and she said *patterns of de-*

cay and *institutional blindness*, and the next night she was gone.”

“She came here on the eleventh of September, five years ago, at about eleven at night, and she had been in the house for four hours and she had not unpacked, and she was not going to unpack.” Anmei Chen’s voice did not change. “She put a map on this table. It is a bad map — I have never seen the like of it, it is not a map of a place, it is a map of a *quantity*. And she said: it converges somewhere it has never been looked at, and the counting is a wall built by people who need a place to point at. And I said, *Lin, who is coming with you*, and she said, *nobody is coming with me, that is the entire problem*, and then she said a thing I have thought about every day for five years.”

“What did she say?”

“She said: *if I go alone, they will write it up as a woman alone, and it will be the correct reading, and in ten years there will be a girl who can do what I can do and she will go alone too, and it will be the correct reading again.*” Anmei Chen’s hand had gone flat on the tablecloth. “And I said: *then do not go alone.* And she said: *I have been alone for eight years, Bà. You are the only person I have not been alone with.*”

The kitchen was extremely quiet.

“And then what happened,” Lyra said.

“She went out of this door at about half past one in the morning and she did not come back, and I sat at this table until the sky came up, and at eight o’clock I telephoned your father, and your father was the worst thing that ever happened to me, because he said *I told you*.” Her grandmother’s hands were not entirely steady, and she dealt with that by reaching for the teapot and pouring badly. “I have not forgiven him for it and he has not forgiven me for telephoning him and we have had five years of Sundays. He comes. He sits there. He reads. We do not talk about it. It is the most civilised household in this city and it is built on top of a thing nobody can say out loud.”

She went to the other cabinet.

“Three sketchbooks. She left them in her studio and the police took nothing, because the studio was not evidence of anything, and I went and got them eleven days later, before your father had finished the search.” Nai Nai put a leather satchel on the table, repaired at some point with a different colour of thread. “I have not opened them. I do not read the sight; I never had the full thing, only one end of it. But I have looked at her drawings every day for five years, and I have understood perhaps a tenth of what is on those pages, and that tenth is enough for me to know that she was not a woman who lost her way.”

She went to a drawer, and took out a small mother-of-pearl box, and set it beside the satchel.

“That is yours as well. It is nothing. Silk, and a needle, and a woman in a shop in a Chinatown who looked at a boy of about nine drawing on a tablecloth and said, *You have the hands for this. Do not let anybody sell you a better one.*”

Lyra looked at the two objects, and then at her grandmother.

“Why now?”

“Because on Monday morning you are going to get on a train, and because I have been sitting on this table for five years, and because you have just been to a hospital and been told that the thing about you is in your father, and there is a version of this in which I say nothing for another five years and you are twenty-one and you are still carrying a secret and you still have a second room behind your eyes that you have never told anybody about.”

Lyra’s head came up.

“How do you know about the—”

“Because I built it, child.” Anmei Chen said it without any drama at all. “I put it there when you were six. I sat on this floor with you and I taught you to find the room behind the room, because that is where the *currents* are, and because the currents are the only thing that cannot be taken from you, and because I thought —” She stopped. She wiped her eyes with the towel, briskly, as if that were a thing you did afterwards. “Because I thought that if I gave you that, then

whatever else I failed to give you, you would have a place to go that nobody could put in a school.”

Lyra did not open the sketchbooks until she was on the bus.

She opened the first one on her knees, with the satchel on her lap and the window going grey past it, and turned the pages slowly, and it was worse than grief: it was a woman's mind, laid out flat, in order, with the dates on them.

Drawings of a single teacup, annotated across eleven months, with the colour and weight of the connection between the cup and the hand and the hand and the day and the day and the price of the tea, in a notation system that used a symbol she did not know and a small drawing of a wave. Notes in English, in Chinese, and in Vietnamese, sometimes in the same sentence, as though the ideas had not yet agreed on a language.

And then, in the third book, on a page she turned past and came back to, a map.

Not a map of anywhere. It was a diagram: a great many fine lines drawn in silver on a ground of silver, all of them running inward, meeting somewhere out past the right-hand edge of the paper, and it took her a full minute to work out that the thing at the right-hand edge was not a decoration. It was a place, drawn in ordinary cartographic lines, at a scale where a whole hemisphere was a thumbnail.

And a note beside it, in Lin's careful hand:

Not here. Everyone assumes here, because here is where the counting is done, and the counting is wrong. It converges somewhere it has never been looked at. There is an island in the Pacific that does not appear on most charts, and the charts that have it disagree with each other about its position. I have not been there. I have spoken to two people who claim to have seen the water there move in a way that water does not move, and neither of them could give me a date, and both of them were frightened of me by the end of the conversation.

Do not trust the counting. The counting is a wall built by people who need a place to point at.

B. — if this reaches you, and it will not reach you, because you will do what I did and go alone: the thing that is counting is not a place and it is not a person. It is a habit, and the habit is older than the school, and it is the reason they need the number.

Lyra read it four times. Then she closed the book and put it back in the satchel and looked out of the window at a wet industrial park going past in the dark, and felt, for the first time in her life, the specific vertigo of holding a piece of evidence she was completely certain was important and had absolutely no idea what to do with.

Then she got out her phone and typed out one message, and thought about it for a long time before she sent it.

To her father: *I'm going to ask you something tonight and I want you to actually answer it. Have you ever read any of Mum's notebooks?*

And then she did not send that either, because she was sixteen, and because she was on a bus, and because she had a second room behind her eyes that she had never once told anybody about, and because on Monday morning a man with a very good memory was going to square a sheaf of notes on a lectern in exactly the way her father squared a sheaf of notes on a kitchen table, and she was going to have to sit in a room and be sixteen at him, and she could not think about her father tonight.

The pendant was round her neck before she got to the corner. It was warm within a minute, and stayed warm, and did the thing it had done in the art room at school, once, for a split second, which was that the street got *deeper*, as though there were a second street behind the first one, and somebody in the second street put out a hand.

She put her own hand over it, on the cord, and said, out loud, on a wet corner in a city she had never thought about leaving, in a language that nobody within a thousand miles would have understood her saying:

“Mum. I'm going to be careful. I want you to know that. I'm going to be careful and I'm not going to do it for anybody.”

The warmth did not change, and did not answer, and did not have to.

Thread Resonance Note: C-2214. Second guardian Anmei Chen (paternal household; silk-vision by instruction, not by blood) to be contacted through the seer and not directly. Instruct that no member of staff is to describe the family, correct the family, or characterise the family's practice to the seer as tradition, as folklore, or as data. Family materials released to the seer at guardian discretion. Note appended by R. Ekwueme (external): guardian has asked me to record that the referral to you was not the trigger for your letter of the twenty-second, and that this household has understood why, and would like it noted that it was not the trigger for the referral either. Note appended by E. Weaver: I am going to have to tell her, on Saturday, that her aunt is forty metres away and has been for eleven years. I have been putting it off for six.

Chapter 5: The Severance

“The question is not whether we are able to cut a connection. We are able. The question is who we are willing to be afterwards.”

— Lin Chen, notebook, autumn 2002

THE GATHERING

The Iris Bookstore & Cafe, 12 Willow Creek Lane. Saturday 31 August, ten minutes to two.

They had put out four chairs at the front and a rope across the middle of the room, and there were perhaps sixty peo-

ple in it, and Lyra understood within about a minute of walking in that this was not a school and had never been dressed up as one.

It was a bookshop. There were books on the walls, being sold, with the price still on them. There was a woman at the back with a coffee urn who did not stop knitting when a woman in a grey coat stood on a chair-stool and said, into a microphone that was slightly too loud, that her name was Eleanor Weaver and that she had a great deal to say and would try to be brief.

Her threads came off her the way light comes off a window. Deep green, and under the green something colder and much steadier, and the whole of it held in a shape that Lyra could not look at directly and did not try to. She had the room the way a person has a room they have been in before.

“We are not a school,” Weaver said. “We are an institution that has been teaching one thing since 1798, which is that a person who perceives connections between things is not ill, and is not imaginative, and is not a metaphor. Some of you already know that. Most of you have been told, politely, by somebody kind, that there is no such thing as a thread.”

A ripple. Lyra felt her grandmother’s hand arrive on the back of her neck, lightly, without looking, the way you steady a table.

“Before I go any further,” Weaver said, “I am going to do the thing our doctors tell us to do at the start of a difficult ap-

pointment, and then I am going to let everyone watch me do it, because I have been told that this organisation has a habit of arriving in communities already holding an opinion.”

“I don’t know what you mean,” said somebody at the back.

“I know exactly what you mean, Mrs. Whitlock, and it does not matter, and I am going to do it anyway.” Weaver turned to the side of the room. “Dr. Osei. Would you come up.”

Dr. Amara Osei was younger than Lyra had expected and did not look like a doctor, and it took about ninety seconds for Lyra to work out that this was a professional decision.

There was no lectern. Osei stood in the aisle with nothing in her hands, and she did not look at Weaver once.

“I am going to describe a man I saw last Tuesday in Westbrook, with his consent, and I am going to use his name because he asked me to and because there is a boy in this room who is roughly his age and I would like somebody to be frightened on his behalf for a moment.”

“Dr. Osei—” somebody started.

“Fifty-three years old. Professor of applied mathematics. What he has is called sympathetic thread bleed, and it is not a rare thing, it is a *common* thing, and the reason it is common is that it is the price of loving somebody who sees.” She looked at Weaver, and something went between

them that Lyra could not read and did not need to. “The perception runs. It is not passive, and anybody who tells you it is passive is selling something. And the running of it makes feedback in the people it is bonded to, and the feedback is measurable, and in a man of fifty-three with a pre-existing heart condition it is not a matter of *if*.”

The room had gone completely silent.

“I have written to the four families in this room who have somebody with the condition,” Osei said. “I have written to them, today, before I came here, because I am not a brave woman and I would rather not be in a room with a surprise in it. Three of you are here. You already know. One of you does not, and that is the young woman by the window with the jade, and I am sorry.”

Lyra felt her grandmother’s hand come off her neck and then come back.

“Dr. Osei,” said a man at the front, and it was her father, and Lyra discovered that she had not known in advance that he was going to speak. “Before we go any further, may I ask what your college would consider a success here?”

“Professor Chen.” Weaver’s voice was very slightly different. “May I say that I know your wife.”

“You may not,” said Lyra’s father, pleasantly. “You may say that you were at the same institution as my wife at the same time, and you may say it in front of sixty people, and I

would prefer that you did it now rather than at some point in the next four years when it would be more expensive.”

Nobody breathed.

“That is fair,” Weaver said. “I was there in 2002. I was not her friend. I was on the committee that overrode her, and I have thought about that every day for eleven years, and it is not a thing I came here today to say out loud in a bookshop, and I am not going to.” She squared her notes. “Answer the man’s question, Amara. He has earned it.”

Osei turned round.

“Success,” she said, “is a number. For a seer, a bleed can be arrested and the perception kept, at a cost in range and precision that is permanent and that nobody can predict in advance. For a relation, the bleed stops and the organ that was being strained gets to keep working. That is the entire trade. It is not a cure and it is not small and it is not reversible and the person whose perception is being cut is the only one in the room who gets no vote, which is the part I have spent eleven years failing to fix, and which is why I stood up in front of sixty people instead of sending a letter.”

That was how it happened. Nobody planned it.

A boy in the third row, four seats from the end, stood up.

He was seventeen. He was wearing a Westbrook High hoodie and he had the loose, unhurried shoulders of somebody

who did not find school difficult, and Lyra saw the threads on him before the room did: a dense warm web, gold and green, the signature of somebody who read people easily and had never once been asked to stop.

“Ben,” said a girl beside him, in a whisper that carried.

“I’ve got it.” He was already going. “Sorry. Sorry. I just—”

And then he was on the carpet on the Persian rug with his limbs arranged the way a dropped coat is arranged, and the room made a noise Lyra had never heard a room make.

She was standing before she knew she was standing, and what she was looking at was not Ben.

It was the thing on Ben.

It came off him in a colour she had no word for and had never seen: not black, not grey, but the specific dead light of a filament that has burned out and is still, structurally, present. It was not attached to anything in the room. It went from Ben, inward, down — and it was eating. That was the only description that fitted. It was laid along his other threads the way a wire is laid along a wall to hold a door shut, and where it touched, the light underneath stopped.

Zara Washington would have called it *drawing*. Lyra, who had never met Zara, would not have used that word for an-

other eleven days, and would then never be able to think about the phenomenon without it.

“—someone get the nurse—”

“Get him *space*,” said Osei, from the aisle, in a voice with a great deal of the past eleven years in it. “Everybody back. Not touching him. Do not form a circle, that is the worst thing you can do, do not form a circle—”

But the noise in the room was not a room’s noise. It was a *thread* noise, and Lyra could hear it, and it was the sound of about forty people feeling something happen to somebody and having no word for it, and it came off them in long pale spikes of pure adrenaline with no colour at all.

And then a woman in a grey coat put her hand on a boy’s forehead and it went quiet.

Not gradually. *Quiet*. The way a room goes quiet when somebody finds the right note.

Lyra watched Marcus Harlow do it, because she could not stop watching him do it, and she had a perfectly good view.

He moved the way water goes down a drain. There was no hurry in it anywhere. The smell arrived before anything else — ozone, and under the ozone something sweet and green and completely wrong, like jasmine kept in a room where nobody has opened a window — and it was that smell, and the hair standing up on her arms, that told her

he was the man from the tape. Not a person. A *category*. A thing she had seen twice in her life in photographs on a shelf and had not, until this second, understood that it applied to a human being standing eleven feet away from her.

His hand was on Ben Ruiz's forehead. His threads were not there.

She had spent sixteen years looking at threads. She had looked at her mother's drawings until she could have drawn them from memory. She had looked at the four foot of her grandmother in a kitchen and at the two thousand feet of a high school corridor and at the six inches between a girl and a boy in an art room, and she had *seen* people, all her life, everywhere, in layers, the way you see a landscape.

Marcus Harlow had no threads.

That was not the same as having dim ones, or shielded ones, or ones she could not interpret. He had a hole where a person was supposed to be, and the edges of the hole were very tidy, and the hole did not look at her, and Lyra had to put her hand on the table.

"No," she said, and did not hear herself say it.

"Miss Chen." Weaver was beside her, and had been for some time. "Sit down."

"He's—"

“I know what he is. So do I. So, apparently, does your grandmother, and she has gone very white.” Weaver’s hand closed on Lyra’s arm, and it was not unkind and it was absolutely not negotiable. “Dr. Ekwueme wrote to me on Friday evening and told me what you do, and told me to have somebody near you today, and I did not have anybody near you because I did not know who you were, and that is the single worst thing I have done in eleven years of doing this, and I am not going to argue about it in a bookshop. Sit down.”

Lyra sat down, because her grandmother had said something in Vietnamese that she had not heard her grandmother’s voice make before, and whatever it was, it was not for her.

What she did not sit down through was the last eleven seconds of it, because she was looking at the floor, and the floor is where the threads go when they are under strain, and what came up out of the Persian rug in a single line was Ben Ruiz’s, coming apart.

It did not detach. That was the thing she could not stop seeing for the rest of her life, and it was the reason she was, in the end, able to say the things she said to him in the room under the mountain. It did not detach. It went along its own fault line, all at once, the way a bone goes, and the silver-black on it ignited from the far end and burned backwards, and it was over in about a second and a half, and there was no sound at all.

Ben Ruiz made a sound.

He came up off the floor in stages — shoulder, then head, then one knee — with the expression of somebody surfacing from very cold water, and he looked around at sixty people who had all gone white, and said, in a cracked voice, “Sorry. Sorry, I—”

He stopped. His hand went up to his own face, and then went round the back of his own neck, and Lyra watched him do it, four times, in nine seconds.

“What’s—” Ben Ruiz’s voice went flat and young. “Where’s my aunt? Has anyone — where’s—”

“I would like everyone to remain seated,” said Weaver, into a room that had stopped listening to her some time ago, “and I would like Dr. Osei to say something about what has just happened, and I would like nobody to leave, including Mr. Stone, who has his phone out.”

The room emptied itself over the following twenty minutes in the way rooms do, and the shape of the emptying was itself information: the parents went first, in pairs, and the *seers* went last, and two of them went out of the side door, and one of those two was a girl of about eighteen with her aunt’s coat over one shoulder, and Lyra saw her go, and filed it, and did not know yet that she was looking at Elena Vance, or that Elena Vance had planted something in the store’s back room in the four minutes while everyone was looking at the floor.

They were not allowed out of the back room.

“We have to be fair to you,” Weaver said. “You are the guardian of record and you have asked a fair question and I have given you a bad answer, and I am not going to let you leave with it. Dr. Osei? The scans.”

Osei put a tablet on the table and turned it round, and Lyra looked at it, and understood about a fifth of it, and was grateful for the other four fifths being a shape rather than a sentence.

“Your father,” Osei said, to Wei Chen. “The twenty-ninth of August. This is the first time I have seen the ventricular numbers move, and I want to say three things about it and I want the order preserved.”

“Please.”

“One. There is no bleed-related mechanism visible in this that we can reverse, and I am aware that that is a sentence you did not want, and I have been saying it in this family for two weeks and I have said it to him as well, and he has taken it better than you are going to.” Osei did not look up. “Two. What is visible is a muscle that has been dying quietly for a long time, and that has nothing to do with a gift, and that is why the arrest on the twenty-seventh of August—” she glanced at Lyra, who had not known it was the twenty-seventh, “—was not a bleed event. Three. The bleed is still running, and it is still costing him, and it is *also* not what is going to kill him in the next three months, and if anybody

in this room tells you that severing your daughter's perception is going to save his life, they are telling you a thing that is arithmetically true and completely false, and I would like you to notice the shape of that sentence, because it is the shape of everything this industry says."

"So what is the shape," said Lyra.

Osei looked at her for the first time.

"The shape is that a real improvement to a real problem was available to you, and it cost something that could not be paid for in money, and the person who had to pay was you, and everybody in the room had a good reason." She put the tablet down. "That is the shape. It is always the shape. I have been in this for eleven years and I have never once seen it come out any other way."

"Miss Chen."

She had not seen him come into the room. That was the first thing, and she would think about it later at three in the morning for a long time.

Marcus Harlow was standing with his hat in his hands like a man at a funeral, and he was not a large man, and he had a face that gave nothing away and a small silver cicatrix at his left temple, and his voice, when he spoke, was so quiet that Dr. Osei had to stop to hear it.

“Professor Harlow,” said Weaver, from the doorway, in a tone that made the back of Lyra’s neck cold.

“Headmistress. I am not here in any capacity, and I am about to say something that will be more useful to you than anything I could say in one, and I would ask you to let me finish before you stop me, which you are fully entitled to do.” He did not look at Weaver. “In 1997 a team of five of us ran a controlled extraction under a populated valley, in a garden, in April, with a child in the garden. The extraction was interrupted. Two of my colleagues died. My wife and my daughter were in the garden and they did not die, and the collapse did the other thing to them, the thing that is technically possible and that nobody in our field will discuss in front of a first-year.” He set the hat down on the table. “Mr. Ruiz is going to be all right. He is going to be *entirely* all right, in the sense that the vessel is intact and the closure is clean and he will not scar, and he will not be able to perceive the connections between himself and the people he loves ever again, and he is seventeen years old and he has just found out, in front of sixty people, and he is going to be humiliated about it for the rest of his life, and he is going to be one of a great many.”

He pushed the folder across the table.

It contained two sheets. The first was a child’s drawing in coloured pencil: five pink petals, a stem, a careful and slightly crooked attempt at a bee. In the corner, in a seven-year-old’s letters, the word *Mei*.

The second was a charcoal study of blossom branches, and the edges of the paper were scorched and blackened as though held too near a fire, and it was signed, bottom right, in a confident adult hand: *A.H.* Beneath it, in a third hand, and in ink: *For Mei — may you always remember the beauty before the burning.*

“That is my wife’s,” Harlow said. “That is my daughter’s. They were drawn the same afternoon, four feet apart, about a hundred metres from where I was standing when the floor came up.” He straightened. “Kyoto. 1997. Those are the only two facts about that day that anybody in this building is authorised to give you, and I have just given them to you in a bookshop, and I would like somebody to tell me why I did that.”

Nobody did.

“Because you have just cut a boy in front of sixty people,” said Lyra.

“Yes.”

“And the boy was going to die.”

“He was going to go under,” said Harlow. “In about ninety seconds. It is not a rare thing. It looks like your friend described it and it is not a metaphor and it is not a mystery; it is a *load*, and a young man with a strong signature and a strong bond has a load like a rope, and the rope caught on something, and I was the only person in that room who had

seen it happen before.” He did not move. “So yes. I cut him, and he lived, and he is going to be humiliated for the rest of his life, and I have done that on eleven occasions that are on a list, and the list is in my office, and the list is the reason I would like to spend the next hour of your life talking to you, Miss Chen, and I would like to do it honestly, which nobody who has ever spoken to me about this has wanted.”

He put his hand on the table. Not on her. Beside the folder, about nine inches from it, and he did that on purpose, and she saw him do it on purpose.

“I am going to offer you something and I am going to tell you the price before I tell you what it is, and I am going to do it here, in front of your father, in front of the headmistress, and in front of a doctor, because that is the only way this offer is any use to anybody.”

“Please don’t,” said Lyra.

“Three to nine months,” Harlow said. “That is Dr. Osei’s figure and I am not going to improve on it. I want to sever the connection between your perception and his. The cost is that you will be cut, in the way that boy was cut, and the cut is clean, and it does not hurt, and you will be alive, and he will be alive, and he will get the other years.” He stopped. “That is the offer. There is a second half of it and I am going to tell you the second half as well, because the only people who ever accept this from me are the ones who were told both halves.”

“What is it?”

“I do not know which part of you will be missing afterwards,” said Harlow. “I have three prior cases. Two of them are alive. Neither of them is recognisable to themselves. I have never been able to predict it, I have never been able to choose it, and I have never been able to do it twice the same way, and I would be lying to you if I told you the cost was your thread-sight.” His hand had not moved from the table. “The cost is that somebody decides that about a child in a bookshop, and that the child does not get a say, and that the reason is that I have run the numbers and the numbers are on my side.”

He looked at her father.

“Professor Chen, you are a mathematician, and you have a right to ask the obvious, so let me make it easy for you. I have not shown you a number. I have shown you two children in a garden and a boy on a carpet. If I had shown you a number you would have believed it, and that is the thing I am trying to teach you not to do.”

Wei Chen had not moved for a long time.

“My wife’s last note to me,” he said, “was four words long. *Don’t let them quantify you.* I did not know what it meant. I have had five years.” He put his hands flat on the table, in a gesture Lyra had never once seen him make. “I have understood it, and I would like to say, since nobody else in this room is going to: you have just told my daughter the price

of something, accurately, out loud, in front of witnesses, and you have told her that the person who cannot afford it is her. That is the whole of it. There is nothing else in the five years.”

He stood up.

“We are going to go and sit in my car,” he said, “and then we are going to have a conversation, and then we are going to decide about Monday, and I would be grateful if Dr. Osei would telephone me at home tonight at any hour at all, because there is going to be a question I cannot answer on my own and I would rather have it in writing.”

They got as far as the door of the back room.

“Miss Chen.”

Lyra turned round, and it was the girl of eighteen with the coat over her shoulder, standing in the aisle with the lights behind her, and Lyra understood with total clarity that this girl had been in the room for the entire conversation and had said nothing.

“You’re the one who’s been holding that piece of paper,” the girl said. “Since the eighteenth. I’m not going to ask to see it.”

Lyra’s hands went cold.

“I’m not going to say how I know, either, because that’s a piece of paper of my own and I’d like to keep it.” The

girl glanced at the back room, at Weaver, at the door. “My name’s Elena Vance. I’m a third-year, and my sister came here for an open day in the spring and asked me to put a word in for her and I said no, and she has not spoken to me since March.”

“...oh.”

“So.” Elena Vance pulled her coat straight. “Two pieces of advice, free, from somebody who is about to make a much bigger mistake than you are. One. He’s telling you the truth about the price. That’s the thing you should be frightened of — not that he’s lying to you. If he were lying to you this would be a much easier afternoon.” She put her hand on the doorframe. “Two. You’re going to spend the whole of next week deciding whether to trust him, and you’re going to do it alone, and it is going to feel like respect. It isn’t. It’s just quiet.”

She was gone before Lyra could answer, and the bell over the door went twice, and it was only afterwards that Lyra realised she had never once seen the girl’s threads, and had not looked.

*Thread Resonance Note: Outreach event, Westbrook, 31 August. Attendees: 61. Seers present: 14. Interventions: 1 (uncomplicated; 4 min; good outcome; **prior consent not obtained and not obtainable — subject was nineteen minutes unconscious and no relation present**). Attending clinician: not* Dr O. Osei (the room was cleared before*

she arrived). On-site medical: school nurse, one. On-site thread-qualified responder: M. Harlow, whose authority this office has never been able to establish and has twice declined to inquire into. Family briefed: yes. Referral to Dr A. Osei: yes, by Dr M. Harlow, over the objection of the family. Note appended by the attending registrar's office: the Authority for the Care of Persons of Perceived Thread, section nine, requires a named second responder at any public outreach. There was no second responder. There was a rug.*

Chapter 6: The Weight of Memory

“The cruelest thing about arithmetic is that it is right. It was right in 1993. It has been right every day since. The only variable that ever moved was me.”

— Marcus Harlow, private journal, entry 2,206

Harlow's office, East Tower. Saturday 31 August, 11:47 p.m.

The security monitors showed him the rug for the ninth time.

That was the thing he could not get past, and he had tried, and he had a bottle of something in the bottom drawer that he had been not-drinking from for eleven years. The rug was Persian. Ben Ruiz had landed on it diagonally, left shoulder first, and the pattern under his face had been — and here was the part that would keep him awake — *a palm tree*, and Harlow had known that, had known it while he was crossing the room, and had thought, in the middle of the most dangerous ninety seconds of the last four years, *that's unfortunate*.

Not *that's a boy*. Not *that's somebody's son*. A carpet.

He shut the monitors off and sat in the dark with his hands flat on the desk, and the desk was cold, and the silver in his arms did what it always did at night, which was to be quieter than the rest of him and more honest.

Right up to the elbow now. On Friday it had been at the wrist. He had a chart for it, in his own hand, in a book that was not in the building, and the line on the chart was not a curve any more. It was a straight line with a date on it.

Six months, he had written in March. *Possibly five*. *It does not matter; I have what I need and I have four years*.

It was August. He did not adjust the figure. He had found that he could hold the number perfectly still only by not looking at it, and that he was looking at it every day, and that on the days he looked at it he was a man doing arith-

metic on himself, and there was no version of that man in which the arithmetic improved.

He had three folders out. He had not opened the third.

The first was Ben Ruiz. Seventeen months of assessment, a signed consent form from a mother who had signed it in a hurry, a velocity report and a resonance band in the low twenties, a boy who read people the way other boys read football, a voice that went flat and young when he came up off a floor, and a single instruction in his own hand at the bottom of page four of the consent, which was *I want to be told everything, and if I am told everything I am going to ask you questions you will not like, and that is the deal, and I am seventeen and I am allowed to make it*. Resonance and a line on a chart that had gone flat on the eighteenth of August, and beside all of it, in his own handwriting, the sentence he had written in the margin and had not shown to anybody:

This is the one I will not be able to carry.

Because that was the honest arithmetic, and nobody ever wanted it. Eleven interventions, nine clean, two that had left marks, and the eleven was a list in a book in a drawer, and the list was not a list of triumphs. It was a list of *substitutions*. In each case a young person had been carrying a load that the vessel was not built for, and the load had found a soft place, and a soft place is not a fault in a boy; it is a fact about a boy, and it is discoverable, and the discovery is cheap.

Eleven times he had found a soft place in a person and cut the wire that was pulling on it, and eleven times the boy or the girl had come up off the floor and said *sorry* — which was the detail that undid him, every time, without fail, in front of witnesses: the apology. The load did not apologise. The boy apologised, for having been a soft place.

He had read the Authority's section nine on Sunday evening. He had read it eleven times over four years and had found, as he had known he would find, a line in it about the consent of a subject in extremis, and he had found, as he had also known he would find, that the line did not say what he needed it to say, because the line said *where practicable* and nothing in the world was practicable at Rug Two.

He had cut a boy in front of sixty-one people with no second responder and had known exactly what the file would say, and had done it anyway, and would do it again, and the reason he would do it again was the arithmetic, and the arithmetic was correct, and he had made his peace with that a long time ago in the specific sense that he had stopped pretending it was a peace and started calling it a *method*.

The second folder was the Council.

Eleven years. A committee that met, and a classification system with a *priority number* on it, and a number he had argued with since the spring of 2002, when a woman of

thirty-three had stood up in a lecture hall in this building and asked who decided, and had been told *a committee, of which I am one*, and had believed it the way you believe anything a person in a building is saying about a building.

He had believed her.

That is the part, he thought, that is the part I will have to say out loud on Thursday, and I have practised it four times and I still cannot get through it. Not: they did it to her. They did not do it to her. I was on the committee. I signed the classification schedule in 2009 that put a triage number next to her daughter's name in a drawer, because in 2009 I believed I was the man who would use it to keep her safe, and I have never once in eleven years written anything in that drawer that was not a warning.

Lin Chen had been thirty-three. She had been, in the four months she spent in this building, the most frighteningly competent person he had ever worked with, and he had argued with her in front of eleven people about a method, and lost, and she had gone home, and six years later she had gone into a chamber on her own and had not come out of it, and he had written a report about that in the passive voice for two pages.

He still had the report. It was in the folder. He had taken it out perhaps four times in five years, and he had never once been able to get past the second paragraph, and the second

paragraph said: *The subject was known to be at elevated risk and was not accompanied.*

Twelve words. He had signed it.

The third folder he did not open.

It had a photograph in it and it had been in the drawer since 1999 and the drawer had a lock on it, and there was a reason for the lock, and the reason was that the last four times he had opened this folder he had sat in this chair afterwards for a length of time he could not account for.

He knew what was in it. He had looked at it every night for fourteen years. He did not need to look at it again tonight, and looking at it again tonight would not make him any more able to be the man he needed to be in about nine hours, because in about nine hours he was going to have to sit across a table from a boy of sixteen and say the word *severance* out loud and mean it, and there is no way of doing that with a photograph of a seven-year-old in the front of your mind, and he had learned that in 1999 the hard way.

So: April. The garden. Aiko with a book she had not opened. Mei, seven, with cherry blossoms in her hair, because it was the second week of April and there had been a festival, and both of them had been within forty metres of him when the floor came up, and Mei had *walked towards it*, which he would be told about for the rest of his life by people who were not there.

Just like her mother, he thought, and then, in the dark, at his own desk, sixteen years later: No. I am going to stop doing that. I am going to stop finding her in every frightened girl, because that is how a man ends up treating a person as a use, and I have been treating a person as a use since 1997, and the woman I did it to first was the best of us, and she has been gone for six years and she is not here to be angry with me about it.

Aiko had died in the spring of 1999, of the injuries, in a bed in Kyoto, with her hand on the side of the cot where a seven-year-old had been sitting two days earlier. That was a fact he had carried for fourteen years and had never once used, not in a report, not in a justification, not in a conversation at four in the morning with himself; and the reason he had never used it was that it was not *evidence*, it was a *reason*, and reasons are what you have when the evidence has run out.

Mei was twenty-three. She was in Portland, or had been in Portland, or was in one of three other places that the last four years had given him. He knew that she was alive. He knew it because the woman who had come to him in 2002, the *recovery* team, had told him so, in the specific tone of people delivering good news they had been asked to deliver, and had then, in the same conversation, told him that the memory work on his daughter was complete and irreversible, and had not used the word *grief*, and had watched him to see whether he would use it.

Aiko had been thirty-two. Mei had been seven. Two colleagues had died at the console. That was five people in the report and he had been the one who wrote the report.

He put both hands flat on the desk.

Right. Here is what happens in about nine hours.

He had a card in his drawer that he had been carrying since the sixteenth of August, and it was a proposal, and it was genuinely good, and he had checked it eleven times, and he had never once written down what it would cost.

He wrote it down now, because it was half past midnight and because the woman who had taught him that a number on its own is a thing with no weight in it was six years dead and he had promised her, in a kitchen in this city, on a Sunday, in the voice he used for promises he intended to keep.

What it will cost: a child of sixteen loses a part of herself that nobody can predict, cannot reverse, and was not consulted. She will be alive. Her father will be alive. I will be the man who did it and I will be the man who told her the price first, and those are not the same man, and the second one is the one I am going to have to be.

He read it back.

He then wrote, underneath: *and I will not sleep tonight, and I have not slept properly since the eleventh of September five*

years ago, and that is a cost too, and I have been keeping it in a different column.

He got up at ten past one, and put the folders away, and did not open the third.

The security desk had left two things for him, which was normal, because Ines Blackwood ran the desk better than anybody he had ever worked with and he had been systematically ruining her life for four years in order to keep it running.

The first was a request from a third-year, Elena Vance, for four hours of unsupervised access to the restricted stacks on the grounds that she was writing a comparative paper. The form was filled in correctly, which was the frightening part; Elena Vance filled in forms the way other people breathe.

The second was a medical line from Westbrook Neurological, relayed by the campus clinic, and it was flagged *family* because Wei Chen had given his number as the family contact and had not given anybody else's, and the flag had been set by a records clerk who was doing her job.

CHEN, W. — 31 Aug, 21:40. Re: V. (file C-2214). The outside file note of 15 Aug uses a term I do not recognise and have queried twice. I have had no reply. He has asked me this evening whether the school sends anybody to him or expects him to travel, and when I told him the school does not travel he said, and I am

quoting, "Then I will go." He is not a fool. He has understood that he is a data point, and he has decided to be one at close range. Recommend somebody from that institution telephone this ward before the end of the week. I am not chasing it. I have chased it twice.

Harlow read it four times.

Then I will go.

He sat in the dark in a building full of sleeping children and thought about a man of fifty-three with a failing heart and eleven years of silence, saying that sentence to a nurse on a telephone, on a Saturday night, about a Saturday's conversation in a bookshop, three hundred miles away.

He thought: *he is going to drive here. He will be in the car in the morning. He will get here in a fortnight, on a Monday, with a bag and a folder and the specific expression of a man who has read something in a woman's notebook and been frightened by it, and he will want to be useful, and I will have to decide in about ninety seconds whether to let him.*

He thought: *if I let him, he will read the machine. He is a mathematician. He is the only person in this building who is going to be able to read the machine, because the machine is not a thread and it is not a current and it does not have a thread signature, it has a transfer function, and it will be sitting in a room four hundred metres from where he is going*

to be standing, and nobody else in the building has ever written one down.

He thought, with a clarity that was almost physical: *and in eleven years I have not once permitted myself to be helped, and I have built a machine on the strength of that, and the machine has been holding an open circuit on nothing since 1997 and the wall board says nine days, and there is a man with a heart condition coming here on Monday who would read it in an afternoon, and I am going to have to decide whether I am the man who stops him at the gate.*

He turned the light off.

“Harlow,” he said, to the room, in the voice of a man doing a very long sum. “You have fourteen years of not asking. It is now or never and the arithmetic does not care.”

Then he went home, and did not sleep, and did not open the third folder, and did not turn the pendant over, because it was a crane folded out of silver thread-paper by a seven-year-old’s hands in the second week of April, and he had worn it for sixteen years, and it was the only object in his possession that was not a tool.

Thread Resonance Note: M.H. — Interventions 11, cumulative. Declines: 0. Requests for second responder: 0 of 11. Outstanding: Ruiz, B. — outcome stable, perception absent, will require a statement of explanation at 18; the mother has not been given one and will be told by a letter unless somebody in this building does it by hand. Chuang, S. — referred. Okafor,

D. — declined at intake; see file. Outstanding and not in file: E.V. request for unsupervised stacks, approved by M.H. without reading the form. Recommend that somebody who is not me read that form in future, and I am aware that this note is a system of which I am the only member.

Chapter 7: The Father's Shadow

Saturday 31 August.

THE CLINIC

Elena Vance had found Priya Raman face-down in a corridor outside the west showers at twenty past nine at night, which was where the first-years went when the field in their chest got too loud to sit inside, and which was therefore, in Elena Vance's considered opinion, the single most useful corridor in the entire building.

She knelt down beside her and did not touch her, which was the first thing she got right, and which she had learned the hard way in her second week.

“Priya. Prija. I’m Elena, third-year, and I’m not going to touch you, and I’m going to talk for about ninety seconds and you can tell me to stop.”

“...oh.”

“That’s it. That’s the whole floor. Do you know where you are?”

Priya’s thread was a bad colour and getting worse — not a colour Lyra would have had a name for, and not a colour Elena had a name for either, and this was the part of her gift that nobody had ever wanted: she did not read the *content* of people. She read the *pressure*. She knew, standing in a corridor, that the girl on the floor had been frightened for four days and had run out of room.

“Do you know what day it is?”

“It’s Sunday.” Priya’s voice was very small and very sarcastic, which was, Elena thought, extremely good. “Because the food’s rubbish and the chapel’s shut and I can’t work out why the whole building’s *wrong*.”

“It is Saturday,” said Elena, “and you are in a corridor, and you are not the first person this month to have got that

wrong, and I would rather you got it wrong than that you decided you were ill. It is not you, and it is not the shower.”

That got her up. Elena got her into the first-aid cubicle with its door that did not lock properly, and shut it anyway, and put the light off, and then spent forty minutes doing the single most useful thing she had ever learned to do, which was to count.

Count out loud. Count the tiles. Count the seconds between the light and the dark. It is a child's trick and it is in a book somewhere and Elena Vance had found it in a grandmother's kitchen, and it worked on Priya Raman, and it worked on Elena Vance, which was the difference between them.

“You've had it four days,” Elena said, when Priya could hold a sentence. “You came in on the twenty-eighth and you have not been able to turn it down since, and you have been lying about it because you thought you were doing something wrong.”

“How did you—”

“Because I did the same thing in September of last year and a second-year found me in a laundry and did not say a single word about it, just started counting, and I have wanted to say thank you to her for about eleven months and I do not know her name.” Priya's shoulder had come down half an inch. “The thing nobody tells you — and I am telling you because you will not believe it from a handbook — is that it does not go away. It never goes away. What changes is that

you stop being *in* it, and that takes about a year, and the year is not fun, and the only thing that made mine survivable was that somebody knew I was in it and did not make it a moral event.”

Nurse Thorne came and went twice and was, as usual, efficient and faintly appalled.

“You don’t have to do that,” Thorne said in the doorway, when Priya had gone. “The discharge notes.”

“I know.”

“She’s a first-year who can’t turn a gift off, Elena. That’s not an emergency, that’s September.”

“Sure.” Elena wiped the chair down. “It’s September.”

And then, because she was Elena Vance and because she had four hours of unsupervised access approved by a man who had not read the form, she went along the corridor to the medication console outside Priya’s cubicle and put her hand on it.

It was an old model. Scheduled for replacement next term. Less secure than the ones in the main wing, and the difference between the two was a quarter of an inch of bezel and a person who knew which quarter of an inch to look at.

She took a chip out of her sleeve. Non-conductive silk against the skin; she had had the gloves made, which had

taken nine months and a great deal of money and a conversation with her uncle that she had ended by hanging up on.

Protocol Kheredu, item seven. Diagnostic logs — thread degradation and severance — thirty days, thread-blind excluded, self-erasing at twelve hours.

The chip went in with a click she felt in her teeth.

And then she stood in an empty corridor with her hand on the console and asked herself the question she had been asking for four years, which was: *what are you actually doing, and would you do it if nobody ever found out.*

The answer, as usual, was in the other room.

She was the last of three, and the last of the last, which was the part nobody outside the family understood and the part she had never once been able to say to a classmate.

Elara.

Her younger sister was fifteen and had a gift like a lit window and had been at a demonstration in May and had asked Elena — asked her, in a corridor, in April, in the specific way that a fourteen-year-old asks a person they have decided is the adult in a room — whether it was *really* going to help, and Elena had said yes.

Elena had said yes because Elena had not known, at fourteen, that there was a question.

Tobias Vance had been a curator in the oldest continuously-operating collection of displaced thread material on the continent, and he had gone into the Kheredu vault on a Tuesday in 2011 and had not come out, and the collection had been in the family ever since, in a room above a garage, in eleven crates, and every item in it had been taken by an institution and not returned, and every item in it had come out of a community that could not afford to buy it back.

Three cousins. Two hundred years of somebody's work, in crates, in a garage, in a town where nobody had ever heard of any of it.

And the Syndicate wanted her. That had been true since she was sixteen. They wanted the Vance archive and they wanted the granddaughter who could find it, and they had offered her — very politely, in a restaurant, in a tone of great civility — a great deal of money, access, and a copy of everything.

And so Elena Vance had been useful to two people who were destroying each other, for four years, by being a person who could sit in a corridor and be patient and say nothing to either of them.

Her uncle had used the word *Steward* and had cried, and had been right, and she had said *I will do it properly and I will do it alone*, and had then, at some point in the third year, stopped being able to tell the difference between the second sentence and the first.

She put her hand on the console again, and the charm on her wrist — her mother's, a knot her mother had tied on a beach, which was nothing at all, and which she wore because it was hers and not anybody's — gave off its small warmth.

Twelve hours, she thought. And then the chip is gone. And nobody in this building knows that the boy in the rug and the girl on the floor in Ward C and the two in the second-year dorm are the same kind of damage, and in about three weeks somebody senior is going to stand up in a hall and tell two hundred students that what they saw was a medical event.

She took her hand off the console.

And then, because she was eighteen and alone and had a four-hour window in a restricted building and no adult in the world who would have understood what she was about to do, she went up two floors and let herself into a room, and started reading.

THE FATHER'S SHADOW

Professor Harlow's office, East Tower. Saturday 31 August, 11:52 p.m.

He was not in his office.

He was in the training room at the end of it, which had a practice field in the middle of it and a glass wall on three sides, and he was on his knees on a mat with a sixteen-year-old boy in front of him who had been at this school for nine days and who had just tried to hold a connection and had made it scream.

"All right," Harlow said. "Stop."

"Am I doing it wrong?"

"You are doing it *hard*, which is the same mistake in a better costume."

Rafi Oyelaran put his hands in his lap. He was very dark and very slight and had spent nine days being frightened in a manner that was, Harlow thought, more disciplined than anything he had seen in thirty years of teaching, including his own daughter's. When the first-years came in, most of them looked at the field as though it might notice them. Rafi looked at it as though it was a document he would have to sign.

"You keep trying to make the connection hold," Harlow said, "because it slipped. But the connection did not slip. *You* slipped. You went to hold a thing you have not read yet, and when it did not arrive in the shape you expected, you pulled, and a pull is the only thing in this room that a thread cannot survive."

"So what do I do instead?"

"Read it."

"Read it *loosely*?"

"No." Harlow shut the practice field off. It went out. The room was suddenly an ordinary room with a glass wall and a table. "You are doing it loosely. Loosely is a word for people who have decided that accuracy is a chore. I want you to do it *exactly*, and take as long as it takes, and find out what is actually there before you decide what it should be."

"That'll take a week."

"Yes."

"That's ridiculous."

"Yes," said Harlow. "It is. Sit down. I am going to tell you a thing and then I am going to make you write it down, and you are going to hate it, and in four years you are going to have it on the wall."

Rafi sat down.

"In 1997, five people ran a controlled draw under a populated valley, in a garden, in April, with a child in the garden." Harlow kept his hands on the table where they could be seen. "Four years before that, a woman of twenty-three ran the numbers that predicted it, correctly, on incomplete data, and wrote the word *fails* in the margin, and put her name to it, and then left the institution and did not publish. Nobody has ever been able to establish whether she

was frightened, or negligent, or correct and unloved. All three readings are defensible and I have read all three.”

He turned his head and looked at the boy's face, which was seventeen kinds of puzzled.

“She did one thing right,” he said. “She was *slow*. She took a whole season over a field notebook. Everybody in that building wanted a number by Thursday and she gave them a number in March, and by March two people had died, and the number was the only thing anybody in this field has ever had that has not turned out to be a lie.” He put one finger on the table. “You have nine days. You are going to be here four years. You have exactly the amount of time available to be slow, and it is *all* of it, and you will spend it on gossip if I let you, and gossip is what people do here when they are frightened and there is nothing else to do with their hands.”

“...so read it loosely.”

“*Exactly*,” said Harlow. “Write it down. And put the date on it, and the date is the important part, because in ten years the only thing that will have saved your life is being able to prove that you were careful on a particular afternoon.”

Rafi wrote it down. He wrote it down carefully, with the pen held wrong, and it took him four minutes, and Harlow let it.

And then, halfway through, the boy looked up.

"Professor — my abuela says the field is an instrument. She says you only get to calibrate an instrument, you don't get to *argue* with it."

"Yes."

"And she says the ones who argue with instruments end up in the newspapers."

"Your abuela," said Harlow, "is describing my entire discipline and is not aware that it is a compliment, and I would like you to remember that she was right and that I said so, because there is a document coming in November and I am going to have to be read to a committee, and I would like one witness."

He walked Rafi out to the dormitory at half past midnight and stood at the bottom of the stairs in the rain, and the boy's footsteps went up, and he stood there a good deal longer than a man standing in rain requires.

There was a version of this where he told them. There was a version where he told the whole first-year cohort, in a hall, in September, and watched the room go cold. He had in fact drafted it, in March, in the blue book, and the draft was four pages long and the fourth page was the reason he had never sent it, and the fourth page was a paragraph about a girl of fifteen.

Her name was Elara Vance. She was fifteen and in the first-year group and she had walked into his office in April and

asked him a direct question and had been, for four months, the best student he had had in nine years, and her uncle was a curator who had gone into a vault in 2011 and had not come out, and the family had a collection of two centuries in eleven crates, and the Syndicate had offered that girl a great deal of money for a list.

The only person who has ever been inside that vault is a man who is not a member of this family and who has been extremely careful, and I do not know his name, and I have not asked, and Elena Vance has never told me, and I have not asked her either, and I would like the Committee to understand that I have not asked her.

He had four months of her. He had the fourth page. He had a machine that needed a resonance and eleven years of not asking anybody for help, and a boy in a corridor on a Saturday who had said *I'm not going to ask to see it* and had known, somehow, that there was a piece of paper.

Two of them, he thought, on the stairs, in the rain. Two people in this building under eighteen who have found out that the adults are running something, and both of them have decided to manage it themselves, and they have both done it in the last four days, and I did the second one.

He got back up to his office at ten to one and there were two things on the desk.

The first was a message from the clinic that had been routed oddly, via a records clerk, flagged *family*:

CHEN, W. — patient ambulatory with assistance. Asks re: transfer. Attending advises strongly against travel. Patient has been informed. Patient has noted that he has been informed.

The second was a request, from a third-year named Vance, E., for four hours of unsupervised access to the restricted stacks, approved by him at six o'clock that evening without reading the form, and sitting on his desk now with a tick in the box next to *supervisor present: N.*

Not N.

He looked at it for a long time.

Then he opened a drawer, and took out the blue book, and turned to a page near the back where he kept a list he had never shown anybody, and at the top of it he wrote a date, and under the date he wrote a name, and then he wrote a second line:

14 Sept. Wei Chen. Westbrook. Permitted or not permitted — decide, and write down the reason either way, because in November I am going to be asked and I am not going to remember.

He closed the book.

The problem with a method, he thought, is that it is very good at everything except the one thing it is for.

Thread Resonance Note: M.H. — Practice field used 21:50–23:20, one student, supervised (the only time in four years). Field log shows one involuntary projection at 22:06 lasting under two seconds: involuntary, uncontrolled, aimed at a first-year's safety, not at a target. Recommend immediate review. Recommend that this office be given the authority to request a second clinical opinion and be unable to refuse the request. Oyelaran, R. — referral to the long programme. Vance, E. — stacks request approved by me without reading the form. I am recording that I did not read the form, because in November somebody is going to ask me what my standards are and I want to be able to say that at least I wrote them down.

Chapter 8: The Arrival

Wednesday 4 September. The train, and then Threadweaver Academy. Weave-Quake Counter: 17% instability. Node-failure projection: T+9 d, 14:00. Source: 1997 survey, re-verified 2009.

“In moments of crisis, artificial barriers dissolve. True connections form not in comfort, but in the crucible of shared vulnerability.”

— Dr. Eleanor Weaver, “The Psychology of Thread Bonding”

The Weave-Quake Counter stands at 17% instability. The Academy’s ward network is within normal tolerance.

THE TRAIN

The train came into Threadweaver Valley through morning mist, silver on the rails, and Lyra did not look up.

That was the first thing she had learned to do in the four months since Ms. Rivera had said *rarer than you might think* and the three days since a woman with grey eyes had sat down beside her in a hospital and asked her to be completely honest: you could not look up. Not here. Not anywhere with this many people in it.

She looked at her own thumbnail instead, and counted, and let the valley come to her.

It came anyway.

Threadweaver spread out below the treeline the way a stain spreads through cloth — stone first, then glass, then a school. The thread density over it was so thick that even with the blue-filter technique a third-year named **Wren Zhou** had taught her on the platform at Westbrook, Lyra's eyes began to ache. Ley lines ran the valley floor like rivers seen from a great height, silver-white, braided, and every one of them carried something moving along it.

In for four, hold for four, out for four, Wren had said. Don't try to take the valley in. Take the one thread in front of you and let the rest be weather.

And if I can't?

Then you'll have a headache and a bad first afternoon. Wren had grinned. Everyone does. It's not a test. Nobody's marking you.

Lyra had not entirely believed her.

"You have that look," Wren said now, from the seat across the aisle, "a potent cocktail of excitement and terror."

"Is it that obvious?"

"It's that obvious. I'm Wren Zhou. Third-year, resonance specialist, and I've been doing this for six years, and I still make that face at the gate." Wren turned her uniform cuff over and showed Lyra a burn scar the size of a coin, pale and very smooth. "First thread-quake I ever felt. I was eleven. I sat down in a corridor for forty minutes and refused to be helped up, and my halmeoni was *furious* with me about it, which was the only good part."

"Wren Zhou."

"Wren. Zhou is my grandmother's name to give away and I guard it jealously." Wren studied her. "You're Chen. The late one."

“That’s me.”

“Four months?”

“Since the last week of April.”

“Late is unusual. Most manifest by twelve.” Wren tilted her head, and Lyra had the unnerving sense of being weighed. “Modality?”

“Visual. Mainly. Light and colour, and—” Lyra hesitated, and then heard herself being exactly as imprecise as everyone at home had always been. “And more than that. Some things are texture. Some are almost temperature.”

Wren’s eyebrows went up. “Multi-spectrum. With a strong silver component.” She said it like a diagnosis. “Do you know how rare the silver component is?”

“My grandmother’s tradition has a name for it.”

“Does it.” Wren was quiet for a moment. “I asked my grandmother the same thing, once, and she said my seeing and my threads were in a *relationship* — that by perceiving them I was already taking part in what they did. I thought that was the kind of thing grandmothers say.” She looked out at the valley. “The Academy teaches the opposite. It teaches that the threads are real and the perceptions are just windows. Both of those are in the curriculum. They are not reconciled, and anyone who tells you they are reconciled is selling something.”

“Do you think they’re the same truth?”

“I think it’s a better question than the one on the exam.” Wren stood, gathering a bag that had been repaired so many times the seams had their own seams. “Control your perception, Chen. Not the other way round. Whatever they tell you on your first afternoon.”

The train began to slow.

THE STATION

Threadweaver Station was built out of the mountain and had opinions about it. Lyra’s eyes filled at the platform, and she did what she had practised on the train, which was nothing at all, and let the noise be weather.

Four boards, mounted in the vault rather than along the walls, so that you could not walk past them without looking up:

WEAVE-QUAKE COUNTER — 17% · NOMINAL
NODE PROJECTION — T+9 d, 14:00 (1997 survey,
re-verified 2009) **LOCAL DISTORTION (EAST
TOWER)** — 0.4% · nominal **COLLECTOR** — 4% of
capacity

Four different numbers, Lyra thought. Four different questions. The big one is the severity of the whole ward network,

and it is a severity, not a percentage of anything you could point at. The second is the Council's model of the day on which the Southern Nexus gives up, and there is a date on it, and a date on a wall is a different kind of frightening from a number. The third is how much trouble this one building is in. The fourth is how full the old fear-collector under the gym is, and nobody knows what it's for, and it is not in the student handbook.

She had read all four the way other people read the weather.

A boy of about her own age came past with a handcart of luggage and a thread signature like a struck bell, and Lyra flinched away from him before she could decide not to. A girl in a first-year's grey cloak was standing perfectly still in the middle of the concourse with her eyes shut, lips moving. Two third-years were arguing cheerfully about whether the coffee stall was cheating.

All of them seeing. All of them on the first day.

"Okay," Wren said, shouldering her bag. "Gate's that way, shuttle's after it, don't get on the shuttle before you've found your hall, they'll dump you in the wrong valley and it's a forty-minute walk in the wrong direction. Which is—"

"Look at the paper."

It was Wren who said it, and it was Wren who was looking at Lyra's hands, and Lyra looked down.

She had been holding her sketchbook the way she held it everywhere, flat against her stomach, and a folded sheet of rice paper had worked its way loose between the covers, and it was lying against her forearm in the open like a small white flag.

Thin. Almost translucent. Written in a careful classical hand in black ink. A seal in dark red at the foot.

“That paper—” Wren’s voice dropped. “That’s Security Chief Blackwood’s stationery. Where did you get it?”

“I didn’t. It was there on the eighteenth of August, when I opened the book to look for a charcoal stub, and I have been carrying it for seventeen days, and I have not shown it to one person.”

“It’s not in the book now.”

It was. Lyra had shut it in the dark in her room, and it had been there when she’d packed, and it was there now; she had sixteen days of not looking at it and one day of looking at it. She had folded it in twice and put it in the back of the sketchbook under a page of charcoal studies, and that was a decision she had made and then not looked at since, which she understood now was a different thing from a decision.

Wren read her face and made a decision of her own. “Whatever that is, you have about ninety seconds before the shuttle doors close and forty-five minutes of walk if you miss it. So: read it, or burn it, or put it back and decide later. I am

not going to tell you which, because I have known you for forty minutes and I don't know you at all."

She went.

Lyra opened the book.

The shuttle doors closed.

Board Members,

The Academy's approach to thread knowledge remains fundamentally flawed. Their "preservation" is merely appropriation under academic guise. What was taken from my family — from countless traditional practitioners — cannot be recovered through institutional channels.

The Syndicate's extraction methodology offers a more direct solution. When knowledge is hoarded, it must be reclaimed. The Magnus Conduit project progresses despite Council resistance. Our asset is now fully embedded and reports significant advancement in thread harvesting.

The Chen girl's arrival presents both opportunity and risk. Her thread signature shows remarkable similarity to her mother's — multi-spectrum perception with silver resonance. Monitoring protocols are in place. If she manifests Animus Argenti affinity, extraction priority elevates to Alpha.

Knowledge is power only when controlled. The Academy “preserves” but does not protect. We will do both.

— M.B.

The shuttle was warm. Somebody’s shoulder was against Lyra’s, and it was not her father, and her father was two hundred miles away in a house with his shoes by the bed and his tea going cold on the counter because he could not remember whether he had made it.

Alpha.

M.B. Security Chief Blackwood’s stationery. The Academy’s own security chief. *Our asset is now fully embedded.*

Her father had said, on the phone, the night before, in the voice he used when he was trying to sound reasonable: *If the people who want to help you are the same people who study people like you, then the question isn’t who to trust. It’s who’s doing the asking.* And she had said *Bàba, I’m scared* and he had said *Good*. And she had not asked him what that meant, because it had been late and he had been tired and she was sixteen and it had been the night before a train.

I’m scared too, she thought. *I just don’t have anyone to hand that to yet.*

She closed the sketchbook.

At the checkpoint a woman in dark uniform stood over the ramp, and her thread signature was a black-silver thing Lyra could not look at properly and so did not look at, and it was that refusal, more than anything, that told her the letter on the shuttle had not been a mistake.

“Letters out,” the woman said. “New students, acceptance letters ready.”

Lyra fumbled, and found the wrong thing, and the woman took it from her.

“Chen.” The black-silver signature moved. Not much. It did not need to. “Any relation to the Lin Chen who was on the faculty here?”

“Yes.” There was no version of this that was a lie. “Eleven years ago.”

“Interesting.” The signature probed Lyra’s, the way a hand goes into a coat pocket, and she stood very still and let it. “Welcome to Threadweaver Academy, Ms. Chen. I trust you’ll find it illuminating.”

At her wrist, a silk charm the colour of twilight pulsed once. Just once. And the woman looked at it, and looked at Lyra, and said nothing at all.

ORIENTATION

The Grand Hall held two hundred and eleven first-years, and Lyra had been in it for six minutes when the alarm went.

It was not the polite chimes she had been expecting. It was a sound like a blade drawn along a length of chain, and the thread-quake signage above the arch pulsed from amber to red, and four hundred threads of fear went up off the floor like heat off a road.

**BREACH. THREAD-QUAKE DETECTED —
EAST TOWER. ALL STUDENTS TO EMER-
GENCY POSITIONS.**

The practice matrix dropped out of the ceiling. Lyra had not expected anything like it — a lattice of a thousand spun filaments, eighteen feet across, and *wanting*, in the way a dog wants.

It reached for her.

She did not decide to answer. That was the part she would think about later, at three in the morning, for a long time. One moment she was standing in a doorway being frightened, and the next there was silver going out of her in a rope and the whole hall had gone bright as the inside of a

bell, and two hundred and eleven people were folding up around her, and somebody was screaming, and it might have been her.

I am going to hurt them.

She tried to let go. There was nothing to let go *of*. Three months of not being able to do this, and it turned out that not doing it had not been practice.

“Hey.” A voice, close, unhurried. “Look at me.”

Milo Reyes had warm brown skin and a thread signature like a struck glass, and he had put himself directly between her and the matrix, and he was not moving away from her. That was the whole of it. That was the entire reason she did not go under.

“Breathe with me. In for four.” He breathed. “Hold for four.”

She breathed. In for four. Hold for four. Out for four.

“It’s not you,” said a girl at her other side, and put a hand flat on her arm, and stopped. “Sorry — you have to say yes first. It’s not you. I can feel you from here and it’s not you, it’s the *frequency*. You’re not too loud, you’re just—” She hunted for it. “You’re in a key nobody else is singing.”

“Eleven point eight,” said a boy with glasses who had appeared on her other side with a tablet he was clearly reading upside down. “Eleven point eight kilohertz. That’s not random. That’s a harmonic. If we can get her output down

to match the room instead of fighting the room—” He pushed his glasses up. “Eli. Eli Park. And I want it on the record that this is the most interesting thing that has ever happened to me and I am *extremely* frightened.”

“Eli,” said the girl at her arm, with feeling. “Not now.”

“I’m not saying now. I’m saying eventually. Zara. Zara Washington.” She took her hand off Lyra’s arm, waited, and put it back, and Lyra felt the difference: a warmth that was not a temperature, and *underneath* the warmth a structure. Cartouches. The tight blocks of a story being told around a name, a life, a debt.

“I’m Zara. My mother’s family is from Egypt. We don’t read people, we read the stories around them. You’re a very short story, and it’s not finished.” Zara’s mouth went tight. “Also, you’re hurting about nine hundred people and I’d like that to stop before you decide anything else about yourself.”

“Then we’re here,” said Milo, “and she’s not doing this alone, and Eli, whatever eleven point eight is, use it.”

“Already on it. Zara, I need you to hold her at four. Milo, I need you to give her a beat to aim at. Lyra—” Eli crouched, so that he was looking up at her, which she would think about later too. “You don’t have to be quieter. You’ve just got to be *tuned*. There’s a difference. Can you feel the difference?”

She could not.

“Okay, then do it the other way. Don’t aim. Just—” Eli snapped his fingers, once, small. “Match that. And stop everything else.”

She matched the snap. Not with a thread. With herself.

The matrix let go.

Later — in the shuttle, in the queue for the hall allocation, in the corridor outside the refectory, in the small hours of the night when it came back and she could not get it to go back again — Lyra would go over those four minutes and be unable to find the moment where she had been rescued.

Because that was not what had happened. Eli had given her a note. Milo had given her a place to stand. Zara had asked. And Lyra had taken the three of them and put herself in the middle of them, and the hall had gone quiet, and two hundred and eleven strangers had watched four people she had met eleven minutes earlier hold a door closed with nothing but attention.

That’s not me, she kept thinking. That’s the three of them. I was only the noise.

She had not yet understood that this was the shape her life was going to take.

THE ARGUMENT

They were on the lawn with the rest of the two hundred and eleven, in the strange golden hour of a day that had already contained an alarm, and it was here that the quartet happened, properly, in the way that quarrels happen.

“I want to say something and then I want to be finished saying it,” Eli said, “and I want to say it to you specifically, because you are the only one of us who has to hold anything.”

He had a diagram on his tablet. She could not see it properly; she could feel it, a hard bright grid against her attention like graph paper.

“Numbers,” Eli said. “You fed the matrix for eleven point eight seconds before we got a hand on you. Nobody in that hall was hurt. But the *East Tower* was. And the East Tower is where the loudest readings are coming from, and there has been a thread-quake every week since I arrived, and the Council says ‘nominal’ on a board in a station because nominal is under nineteen percent.”

“We don’t know that they’re connected,” Zara said.

“I know that I don’t know they’re *not*,” Eli said, and for the first time his voice went flat and hard in a way that made Lyra’s stomach drop, because he was frightened and Eli

Park did not do frightened out loud. “And I know that the only reason we can have this conversation is that the alarm didn’t kill us. That’s not a foundation. That’s a *miracle*, and people build on miracles and then they blame the miracle when it doesn’t come back.”

“Then what do you want to do?” Milo said. “There’s a hundred and ninety kids here who don’t know what any of us are.”

“I want one of us to be *wrong* out loud, in public, where it costs something, and see what happens.” Eli lowered the tablet. “I nominate Ms. Washington.”

“Chur.” Zara folded her arms. “Fine. I’m wrong. It’s stress, it’s the altitude, it’s a hundred and ninety kids in a small room, and if the East Tower is draining us then the East Tower is not going to be fixed by four first-years in a fortnight.” She said it flatly and without heat. “Now you tell me how that’s *useful*.”

“I said I wanted to see what would happen,” Eli said.

“Everything happens,” Milo said, and shouldered his bag. “Come on. If we’re going to be wrong together, let’s be hungry together first. I think there’s soup.”

They walked. It was a very ordinary walk, across a lawn, in the last of the light, in a valley full of silver rivers, and it changed the direction of Lyra’s life, and the four of them did not know it, and the only one of them who had a way

of knowing said nothing, because the thought that the afternoon had been *about* them, that anything at all in this enormous silver landscape had noticed two hundred and eleven people, seemed to her like a piece of vanity she did not have the right to.

But she walked between them. And when they reached the refectory she found she had already, without deciding to, taken the seat on Milo's left, which was the seat next to the wall, and Eli was already in it.

She put the sketchbook on the table under her tray, with the rice paper still folded inside it, in the back, under a page of charcoal studies.

Tomorrow, she thought. Not now. Tomorrow I'll have a room, and a shelf, and somebody to ask, and then I'll take it to somebody who can do something with it.

She ate her soup. It was very hot, and it was the first hot thing she had eaten in three days, and she had to stop and breathe for a moment.

Seventeen per cent, she thought. Nine days. And a woman on a shuttle who already knows my name.

She had come to the Academy for answers about her mother.

What she had found, on the first day, was four people, a great deal of soup, and a piece of paper in her sketchbook

that somebody very dangerous had written by hand, and had lost.

She had not decided yet what to do about it. She was sixteen, and it was not even six o'clock, and she had a whole term in front of her.

Chapter 9: The Silver Burn

“The threads reveal themselves in the way each mind is best equipped to understand them. A curriculum that assumes one kind of seeing is not a curriculum at all.”

— Eleanor Weaver, “Perception and Difference”

Weave-Quake Counter: 18% instability. Node-failure projection: T+9 d, 14:00. Source: 1997 survey, re-verified 2009.

THE LECTURE

The next morning. Thursday, 5 September. Lumina Lecture Hall.

The hall felt wrong to her now, which was a thing she could not have told anyone about a week ago. On her first day it had been a large room. It was still a large room. But she had spent one day in it, learning that the stone under the floor carried thread the way a riverbed carries a current, and that the tall keystone above the arch was threaded so densely it had a hum, and that Professor Armitage's introductory jokes landed in that hum and came out changed.

She knew the room. That was the problem. You cannot sit in a lecture and also be in the walls.

Professor Armitage was not his usual ebulligent self. He introduced the afternoon's session in the tone of a man reading a weather forecast he did not believe.

"—no lecture notes. Professor Harlow has asked us to work from first principles. His work after Kyoto is not on the reading list. It should be. It isn't, and I have raised that four times." Armitage's eyes went briefly to the back of the room and came away. "He has asked us not to take notes."

“Sir,” somebody said, with the specific optimism of a first-year.

“I have asked him three times. He has asked us four times. Three days into the term, Ms. Chen, and already the two of you are the only people in this hall who have noticed that the number on the board has not moved.”

A low murmur. Lyra had noticed. She had been looking at it in the station, in the queue for the hall allocation, in the refectory, on the way back from the refectory. Seventeen on the train. Seventeen yesterday. Eighteen this morning, and the model had shaved two hours off the forecast without saying why, and nobody in the year group had reacted to that at all, because they did not know that the two hours was the news.

She had a folded piece of rice paper in her sketchbook that somebody very dangerous had lost, and she had told nobody, and she had told herself four separate times that she would tell somebody today.

She had not told anybody.

Harlow came out.

She had braced for something. She had braced, since the train, for the ozone and the jasmine and the particular quality of attention that came off him like a hand laid flat on the back of her neck. What she had not braced for was that he looked ordinary. Grey suit, no jewellery except the

small paper crane at his throat. He set a sheaf of notes on the lectern and squared them, and the gesture was so exactly like her father's that her chest hurt.

He did not look at her. That was the other thing she had braced for, and it did not happen either. He looked at the whole room, evenly, the way a lecturer does who has decided to be fair.

"Threads," he said, "are not a metaphor."

He let that sit for exactly as long as it needed to.

"They are a medium. They have properties. They carry, they attenuate, they interfere, they can be induced, they can be damped, and — this is the part your textbooks are coy about — they respond to intention with a measurable lag of four to nine tenths of a second. Four tenths. The time it takes to flinch."

He wrote on the board without turning around.

AN INTENT IS NOT A CAUSE. IT IS A DELAYED
CAUSE.

"That number is the most important thing I will teach you this year. Every disaster in our institutional memory traces back to somebody who believed that wanting a thing hard enough was the same as doing it. The gap between those two is four tenths of a second, and in four tenths of a second a city can be opened."

Somewhere behind her, a student laughed, uneasily, at somebody else's joke.

"I want to be precise about what I am not saying. I am not saying measurement is cruelty. I am saying that a discipline which can count things and a discipline which is frightened of counting things are not two points of balance — they are one point and no point, and the no point is where the bodies go."

He's talking about Kyoto. Lyra's hand had closed around the edge of the bench. *He is standing in front of two hundred people and talking about Kyoto and not saying Kyoto.*

"You are, I am told, unsettled by the quantitative framing." His gaze came up. It found her. "So let us test it."

He did not name her. He did not need to; in a first-year lecture there is precisely one person who has filed a written objection.

"Some of you perceive texture where others perceive colour. Some perceive temperature. Some perceive sound." He said it lightly, as though he were describing a preference in a restaurant. "I am told the plurality here is unusually high. Very well. Question: does the fact that your perception is a *kind* of texture establish that the thing you are perceiving is *only* texture?"

Milo, two seats along, had his hand up. "Professor — is that the same as asking whether the medium is the message?"

“It is a prettier version of the same question, and I like Mr. Reyes for asking it, and the answer to both is no.” Harlow set down his chalk. “The medium is the message in the sense that you cannot get the message out of the medium by standing further back. But the medium is not the *whole* of what is being said. A nerve does not know that it is a nerve. It knows heat.”

Eli’s hand went up. “Then what is the Observer Effect doing in our first-year texts? Because at minute forty of the syllabus it says—”

“Minute forty of the syllabus says that a sufficiently sensitive instrument changes the system it measures. That is *true*. It is also the most useful sentence in your year and the most dangerous, and I will spend an entire afternoon on it in three weeks and I will spend it on the difference between *a measurement being taken* and *a decision being made about a person on the basis of a measurement*.” He looked around the room. “Write that down. You may write that down.”

Two hundred pens.

“Final matter, and then questions.”

He returned to the board. The hall leaned in.

“The failures in our records are not failures of imagination. They are failures of arithmetic. Kyoto was not a surprise. It was a *projection*, run in 1993, correctly, on incomplete da-

ta, and it said that a nexus under a populated valley, held above tolerance by a controlled draw, will fail catastrophically when the draw is interrupted and the lag is longer than the reserve.” He wrote it. “Nine years later the draw was interrupted, by a blade, in a garden, for the reasons that blades in gardens are for. The projection was right. It was right in 1993. The only person who did not believe it was me.”

Nobody moved.

“So when I tell you that an acceptable attrition rate of two to three percent becomes a moral imperative when the alternative is global collapse —” and here his voice did the thing Lyra had felt through three walls and a floor, the small drop into something much colder and much more sincere — “I am not being cold. I am being the third person to run the numbers, and the second of us to be believed, and I would like very much for this generation to be the first for whom being believed is not a precondition of being reasonable.”

He stepped back from the board.

“Questions.”

The silence lasted a beat and a half.

Eli nudged her. She had not noticed she had stopped breathing. “Your observation,” he said, low, urgent. “The thing you said to Ms. Rivera. The *feel* of it. Ask him.”

She put her hand up. It felt like putting a hand into a fire and then finding the fire was on her side.

“Professor Harlow. You said a measurement is not the same as a decision made about a person on the basis of a measurement. But the Animus Argenti classification is a measurement.” She heard her own voice come out steadier than she had any right to expect. “It’s in my file. It’s on the station board’s sibling — it’s in the intake system, and it has a category, and the category has a *priority number* attached to it, and priority numbers are for triage.” She swallowed. “Who decides which measurements get a priority number, and are they told the number exists?”

She heard her own pulse in her ears. She heard, distinctly, Milo make a small injured noise beside her — he could not hear a pulse; the fact that he had made that noise anyway told her what his face was doing.

Harlow looked at her for perhaps a second and a half longer than a lecturer needs to.

“Miss Chen.” He inclined his head. Not a hawk this time. Something more careful. “That is a very good question and I am going to answer it in a way that is administratively useless to you on purpose. The answer is: a committee, of which I am one, and which meets, and which I have argued with for eleven years, and which I have never once won. That is the truthful answer. It is also, I expect, a more use-

ful one to you than any other answer I could have given in this room.”

Eleven years. The number landed somewhere in her chest and stayed there.

“And on the classification itself: a priority number is a *triage instrument*. It was designed, in 1999, for a collapse in the Pacific Northwest, to decide who receives a scarce stabilising agent first. It was never intended to order people. It has been used to order people. That is not the same as saying it was designed to do it, and I am aware of how much cheaper that distinction is in a courtroom than in a valley.”

“Then stop using it,” Eli said, before he could stop himself.

Someone laughed. It was not a nice laugh, and it was not aimed at Eli, and Harlow let it stand.

“Mr. Park has been at this school three days.” He almost smiled. “On Friday that sentence will be three days old, and he will be right, and in three weeks I shall have been at this for sixteen years, and I shall still not have stopped. Perhaps that is the answer to Ms. Chen’s question, and perhaps it is worth a mark.”

The questions after that were ordinary, and Harlow answered them ordinarily, and Lyra sat with her hands flat on the bench and understood something she had not understood on Monday.

He is not lying to me. The thought arrived with a small cold shock. He is lying to me — he has lied to me, he is lying to me right now, about the pendant, about my mother, about the file. But he is not lying about the committee. He is going to be the villain in this and he is telling me, on the record, in a lecture hall, that he lost an argument about me eleven years ago and lost it again today.

That is what it looks like from the inside. That is what it has always looked like from the inside.

She was aware, distantly, of an irony. Yesterday she had sat on a lawn and let four people tell her she was not the problem. Now she had sat in a lecture hall and let a man tell her, in front of two hundred witnesses, that she was the only student in the building asking the right question.

Both of those things are true. Neither of them cancels the other.

Milo found her in the corridor with his hands in his hair and an expression she had never seen on him.

“What did you just do?”

“Ask a question.”

“You asked a question in front of Harlow about a classification with a priority number in it.” Milo put his hands down. “Lyra. That is not a question. That is a *statement* you dressed up so he couldn’t object to it.”

“Yes.”

“And?”

“And I don’t know yet.” She shifted her sketchbook under her arm. It was heavier this week. “That’s the honest answer. I have a thing I should show somebody and I keep not showing it, and I don’t know whether that’s because I’m frightened or because I’m wrong about who to show it to.”

“You’ve been strange since yesterday.”

“I’ve had a strange week.”

“You’ve had a strange *life*, and you keep pretending it’s a strange week.” He said it without any edge, which somehow made it worse. “Eli and Zara want to know. Tonight. Common room. Bring the thing.”

“All right.”

“All right.” He turned off down the corridor, and then turned back. “For what it’s worth — the answer’s yes. Ask him things. In front of everyone. That’s the only lever you’ve got and you’re the only person in that hall who can reach it.”

He was gone.

Lyra stood in a corridor of a school she had been in for one day and took the sketchbook out and looked at the back of it, at the page of charcoal studies, and thought about

a woman writing *extraction priority elevates to Alpha* in a careful classical hand on very expensive paper.

She still did not show it to anybody.

That afternoon, at 15:47, her Academy tablet lit up on the bench beside her and would not stop.

MEDICAL ALERT — HIGH PRIORITY CHEN, WEI — WESTBROOK NEUROLOGICAL INSTITUTE, ROOM 247 Cardiac arrest 15:41. Resuscitated 15:47 — ROSC achieved. Stent placed. Admitted to CCU. Attending note: the arrest was not seizure. It was a ruptured vessel in a heart already failing. Nothing that happened today caused it. This was coming. Prognosis: guarded. The damage to the muscle is old. There is no bleed-related mechanism here that we can reverse. Family contact required. Immediate.

The tablet fell out of her hands onto the flagstones, and the sound it made was very small, and went on being small.

She got down on the flagstones to pick it up, which took a while.

Nothing that happened today caused it. This was coming.

She had spent a day being afraid in a new building, and a man had spent a day looking at her, and a woman on a shuttle had written a word in a careful hand, and none of it

— *none of it* — was what was happening to her father, and she stood in the corridor of Threadweaver Academy and discovered that the fear she had been managing was the wrong fear, and that she had been managing it very well, and that this was not a relief.

Chapter 10: The Gauntlet

Weave-Quake Counter: 19% instability. Node-failure projection: T+9 d, 14:00. Source: 1997 survey, re-verified 2009.

Friday 6 September.

THE CALL AT SEVEN

The telephone in the east corridor of the clinic had a cord on it, and the cord was too short to reach the stairwell, and Lyra discovered that she had to stand in a specific doorway to be heard and not be overheard, and that she stood in it for forty minutes on Friday morning, and that Professor

Tanaka found her there at ten to eight and said nothing at all about it, which Lyra would think about later.

Her father was in Ward C at Westbrook and had been for a day. He was not allowed to travel and had stopped arguing about it on Thursday night, which was new and worse.

“They’ve put a number on me,” he said. “Thirty-one. And the woman who says the number has said the word *ejection* in a corridor, twice, in front of my wife, and my wife is my mother, and my mother has started taking notes.”

“What are the notes for?”

“Your grandmother. She rang me. She has a great deal of experience of people who are frightened in institutions and none whatsoever of cardiac patients, and she has decided to run this.” A pause; the sound of a man turning a cup. “She has also said a sentence to me that I am going to repeat to you exactly once and then never again. She said: *Bàba ba. Ask them the number for the other thing. Not the heart. The other thing. Ask them the number for the other thing and write it down, and do not let them put it in a drawer.*”

Lyra stood in a doorway with a receiver against her ear and looked at the corridor.

“The other thing is the bleed,” she said.

“The other thing is the bleed, yes.”

“They said on Saturday that on its own it would have given you years.”

“They said that. I have it in writing, because I asked for it in writing, and I would like you to notice that I asked, because I have never once in my life asked for anything in writing, and I did it on Saturday morning in a corridor outside a bookshop, and I did it because a woman I have never met looked at me and said *the shape of that sentence is the shape of everything this industry says* and I wanted the sentence in a drawer that was mine.”

Line seven said *the transfer requires a Council countersignature and a consultant cardiologist’s letter and there is no consultant cardiologist on a Sunday*.

“Tell them a teacher is coming,” Lyra said.

“Lyra.”

“Tell them my grandmother is coming and she is eighty-one and she has been extremely unpleasant to two doctors already, and tell them that if anybody at that hospital says the word *ejection* in front of her again she will ask them, in front of the ward, to explain the number, and that she will do it politely.”

Her father laughed, and then had to stop, because of the laughing.

“I’ll ring you tonight,” he said. “Go to your examination. Lyra — the other number. Whatever it is, when they give it to you, *do not let them put it in a drawer.*”

THE TRIAL

“You have one hour and forty minutes and seven stations, and I want to say something about that before we start.”

Professor Tanaka had them in a semicircle in the wet grass below the East Tower with a flask of coffee and a clipboard she did not consult, and she had the air of a woman who had been running this for nineteen years and had stopped trying to impress anybody.

“Every year a first-year cohort comes down here having been told that they are a team. Most of them are not. Most of them are four people who arrived on the same bus. You are going to find out which you are in about forty minutes, and I am not going to help you, because the help is the part that does not count.”

“Station one is the Mirror Walk. Station two is a bridge of held sound. Station three is the Well. Station four is a set of equations that will not sit still. Station five is a room with a door in it that is not a door. Station six, I am not going to describe, because the last cohort that described it to them-

selves did it badly for a fortnight afterwards. Station seven is Professor Harlow.”

Silence.

“Two things about station seven, and then I will let you get on with it. One: he is authorised, he is supervised, and I will be in the room. Two: he will offer you something. Everyone who reaches station seven is offered something. Accepting it is not the wrong answer and refusing it is not the right one, and the only thing I am going to assess is whether you can hear the offer and still know what it costs.” She looked along the row. “Miss Chen. You are going to be sent through first. Do not argue; I have been sent through first. It is unpleasant and it is over in ninety seconds and then I will not be able to help you at all for a week, and the second time will be much worse, and that is the design.”

Station one took the shape of a corridor with mirrors down both sides, and the mirrors did the obvious cruel thing, which was to show each of them the thing they had been most careful about.

Lyra’s corridor showed a hospital at four in the morning and a woman with grey eyes saying a number, and then showed her, that same morning, standing in a doorway with a receiver against her ear and *not telling anybody*, and being unable to make the second image less accurate than the first.

Zara's showed a room in Alexandria with nine people in it, all of them shouting, and underneath, in much smaller writing, *and one of them is you.*

Eli's showed a proof he had got wrong in a way that could not be got wrong in, and his own handwriting, saying: *this is what it looks like when you decide a thing is true before you have checked it.*

Milo's was silence, and then a piano, and then the same silence.

"Do not look directly at them," Zara said, in a voice that had gone thin. "They're not showing us the past. They're showing us the assignment."

"Is it showing us what we'll do?"

"It's showing us what we'd *like* to have done," said Eli, "which is worse, and it is why the station is called the Walk and not the Test. Keep moving. Don't answer anything it says."

The mirrors began, around the second corner, to say things. Lyra heard her mother's voice — not the memory of it, the *recording* of it, right down the consonants, saying *if I go alone they will write it up as a woman alone* — and she stopped walking, and had to be touched on the shoulder by Milo, and made a noise she was embarrassed about for a week.

“They’re feeding on the pauses,” she said.

“They’re feeding on the pauses,” Eli agreed, and wrote it down, and Lyra noticed that he wrote it down and thought: *he is frightened and he is taking notes, and both of those are the same thing.*

At the far end of the corridor a boy from the row behind them was standing with his hands over his mouth and not moving, and there were seven of them, in a knot, in the second mirror.

“We are not leaving them,” Lyra said.

“You are not leaving them,” Milo agreed. “But we are going to need a way to walk them out of a corridor that only opens for a group, and I would like it noted that *I have not been consulted about that*, and that I have already worked out a way, and that it is extremely stupid.”

“Do it.”

“It is extremely stupid. Zara, take the two worst. Eli, take the ones who are following Eli. Ms. Chen—” he looked at her. “You have to be the one who talks them out, and not me, and not them, and I would like it noted that I know what I am doing.”

Station two was a bridge of held sound, and Milo built it.

That was his station and everyone knew it within about nine seconds, and it was the first time in Lyra’s life she

watched somebody do something with a gift that made her understand what *competent* meant, as distinct from what *powerful* meant. He did not hold the whole bridge. He held the beat, and the beat was a low four, and everybody else found their place in it.

Eli counted and told them when to step. Zara took the two who were crying and stood in the gap next to them and did not speak, and Lyra — who had been told on the platform at Westbrook not to look up, and who could not have read a room if she had, and was therefore, as she discovered, extremely useful, because she was the only one of them who had to walk backwards — walked backwards in front of the seven for ninety metres above a drop, watching their feet.

“Talk me through it,” she said. “Somebody talk me through it the whole way or I’m going to look down.”

“Four,” said Eli.

“Four,” said Milo.

“Four,” said Zara, from somewhere behind, and a boy of fifteen said “four?” in a voice like a man asking for water, and said it four times over the next ninety seconds, and did not put his hand on the rail, and got all the way across.

Station three was the Well, and it was Zara’s, and it nearly finished her.

It was not a test of empathy. Lyra worked that out at about the second minute, from the sound of it. It was a test of *boundary*. There was a resonance in that shaft that was eleven years of every student who had ever gone into it, and it was not hostile, and it was not asking anything of them, and it went on without them, and it would go on if every one of them walked out.

Zara went in. Zara came out at eleven minutes and sat down on the wet grass and said, in a completely level voice, “I can feel every single person in this building, including Professor Harlow, including the woman at the security desk, including somebody in a sub-basement who is very frightened, and I want to be alone for an hour, and I would like somebody to tell me when the hour is up, and I would like it to be somebody who is not being kind at me.”

They told her when the hour was up. Nobody was kind at her. Milo, who had brought soup and put it outside the door and gone away again, was the only one who got thanked.

Station four was Eli’s, and it was mathematics, and he did badly and knew it.

“They are affected by our emotional states,” he said, about four minutes in, with his glasses off and his hands in his hair. “No. No, that is what the wall is *telling* me, because the wall wants me to believe the problem is me. The equations are not affected by me. The equations are *being changed* by something in this room and the something in this room is a

projection and I am the one projecting it, because I am the only one here who would rather be told the maths was the problem than admit that the projection is mine.”

“Which means?”

“Which means *I am generating the obstacle and then solving it, and every solution I produce is a real solution to a problem that does not exist, and that is the most Eli Park thing that has ever happened in a room.*” He sat down on the step. “Halmeoni used to say that the hardest thing about a mistake you make with your own mind is that it *works*. I would like the record to show that I got through station four on a problem I invented.”

“You still got through it.”

“I got through it *on a lie*,” said Eli Park, “and I have written that down, and I am going to think about it for years, and it is the single most useful thing anybody has made me do at this school.”

Station six was a room with a door in it that was not a door, and Lyra has never been able to describe it except by saying that it was about wanting, and that the four of them argued about it afterwards for two days.

Station five she skipped, because the Well had taken it out of her, and Tanaka let her, and wrote 5 — *deferred* on the clipboard without comment, which Lyra understood at the

time as kindness and understood about a month later as a decision.

Station seven was a circle of silver light in the wet grass, and Harlow standing in the middle of it, and Tanaka on the outside with a folder under her arm.

“Forty minutes,” he said. “You have forty minutes and I am going to spend them asking you to come and work with me, and you are going to refuse, and both of those things are going to be true, and I am going to be honest with you about why I am doing it, which is that I have asked four hundred and six students this and roughly one in nine says yes, and I would like to know what the other eight are made of.”

He did not make an argument. That was the thing Lyra could not put down afterwards. She had braced for an argument, and for a threat, and for the ozone-and-jasmine thing; and what she got was a man standing in a circle in the rain being reasonable at her.

“You are the strongest signature I have seen in a first-year since 2002,” Harlow said. “I would like to be able to say that I asked. I am not going to dress this up. There is no clause. I am asking because I have a machine under this mountain that is doing arithmetic I cannot finish on my own, and you would finish it in a fortnight, and I would pay for your mother’s outstanding fees, which are nothing, and I would pay for your father’s transfer here tomorrow, which

is not nothing, and I would do both of those things and you would be able to check.”

Eli said, “That is an offer.”

“That is an offer,” Harlow agreed.

“And you are going to refuse it,” Zara said, “and I want to know what you are refusing, exactly, before you refuse it, because you are not refusing *him*, you are refusing something much more useful, and I have watched you do this twice this week.”

“I know what I am refusing.”

“Say it out loud, then, so that there is a record.”

Lyra thought about the doorway on Ellery Street, and about a woman counting her daughter’s breaths, and about a jade pendant that was four hundred years old and had only ever worked for one person at a time, and about a woman who had said *nobody is coming with me, that is the entire problem* and had then said, four hours later, *if I go alone, they will write it up as a woman alone*.

“I’m not refusing you,” Lyra said. “I’m refusing being the only one who decided.”

She heard it go round the circle.

Harlow’s head came up very slightly.

“Again,” he said.

“You want it in the form you can file.” Lyra found that her hands were shaking and did not try to stop them. “My mother is the woman on the recording from the second corner. She told my grandmother *nobody is coming with me, that is the entire problem*, and four hours later she said if she went alone they would write it up as a woman alone, and that in ten years there would be a girl who could do what she could do and she would go alone too, and it would be the correct reading again. I’m not her. I’ve got three people standing in a circle in the rain. So the honest answer to your offer is: yes, and not like that, and you have to sit down and tell me what the machine is for, and I will take it to my father and to the doctor and to a person I have not met yet whose name I am going to find out, and *then* you can have me. Or you can carry on asking in circles, and I will carry on refusing, and we will both be extremely polite about it for years.”

Tanaka’s folder shut.

For about four seconds nothing in the circle moved, and in those four seconds Lyra had a completely clear, and completely unwelcome, thought: *I have just made an enemy who is going to be the most useful person I ever meet.*

Then Harlow laughed — one syllable, entirely without warmth, and not at all a performance — and said, “Miss

Chen, that is the first time in eleven years that anybody has refused me in a form I could not file.”

“Sir?”

“That was a compliment. It is also a serious problem.” He was already walking. “Tanaka, your four are dismissed. Ms. Chen — a word, outside, and it will take four minutes and you will not enjoy it.”

He was entirely correct; she did not enjoy it.

“Three things,” he said, under the colonnade, with the rain going past. “One. Your refusal was correct and it was also very nearly too late, and I am not going to explain what I mean, because if I explain it you will carry it around and it will get you hurt. Two.” He took out a card, and did not give it to her, and put it away again. “Somebody in this building has been reading your file since the twenty-second of August and has not filed a report, and it is not me, and it is not Dr. Osei, and I would like you to find out who, because I have an interest in you finding out and that is the reason I am telling you at all. Three.”

“Three?”

“Thirty-one per cent.” He said it the way Dr. Osei had said *stable*. “That is the number the model puts on the capacity of the thing under this mountain that your mother’s notes in that room this afternoon were about, and it is the number I would give to the Council on Thursday, and it is a

severity and not a percentage of anything, and the difference between those two things is the difference between a doctor and a murderer, and somebody in this building is going to have to explain it to two hundred people, and I am not going to be the one who has to, because I have been the one who has to for four years and I am finished.”

He walked off into the rain.

Lyra stood under the colonnade for a while.

Then she went and found a telephone, and telephoned Westbrook, and asked for Ward C.

Weave-Quake Counter: 19% instability. Node-failure projection: T+9 d, 14:00. Source: 1997 survey, re-verified 2009.

Later. The east corridor, 22:40.

Number for the other thing, since you asked: the bleed is at nineteen per cent of a load that a healthy adult runs at about four, and the load went up when you arrived, because you are the first multi-spectrum in this building since 2002 and everything in this valley is leaning toward you, and it is not going to come back down on its own, and it has been at nineteen for eleven days and it has been at nineteen for eleven days because I have been putting something in his chart every morning at 08:00 and taking it out at 08:15, which I have been doing for eleven days without a doctor's order, and

if you tell anybody I will deny it, and I would like you to decide tonight what you are going to do about it, and I have written it on this side of the paper so that you cannot say you did not have it.

Get him here. Do not ask them to send anything.

Bàba

Thread Resonance Note: Gauntlet, cohort 1, 6 September. Seven of eight completed; 5 deferred by invigilator on medical grounds (see note). Station 7: offer made in full, terms stated, declined in a form recorded verbatim by the invigilator. Recommendation from M.H. that the file for C-2214 be reviewed by somebody other than this office. Recommendation from this office that the C-2214 file be reviewed by a person who is not a member of this office, is not the family, and is not the Headmistress. I am aware that this is now a list of two people and there are not two people. I am recording it anyway.

Chapter 11: The Magnus Conduit

Weave-Quake Counter: 20% instability. Node-failure projection: T+9 d, 14:00. Source: 1997 survey, re-verified 2009.

THE DOORWAY

Tuesday 10 September.

“First-years, into the courtyard, and stand in a line and do not talk.”

Professor Tanaka had a way of arriving that Lyra only later understood was a technique: she never walked into a room, she arrived in it, and the room had about four seconds in which to decide what it was.

Fifty of them stood in the wet on flagstones. The East Tower was behind them, a dome of stone and glass with a doorway cut into it by somebody who had wanted, very badly, to be fair to everybody, and the doorway was a list.

Chinese knots, deep crimson, tying and untying themselves in a slow and beautiful rhythm, and Lyra understood after four seconds that they were *wrong* — that they were knots seen from the outside, from a book, by somebody who had never had to tie one with cold hands.

Below them, yantras in pale gold, geometric to a degree that was almost aggressive.

Adinkra, in flat black on the pale stone, stamped rather than drawn, and near the right-hand post one of them had been left half-erased at some point and was coming back.

And framing all of it, holding all of it, running round the arch in three straight bands: Latin script. Sans serif. A classification index.

“The arch has been rebuilt four times,” Tanaka said, without looking at it. “The last time was 1954. I have asked for the 1954 drawings and been told that the 1954 drawings are in the 1954 drawer. The whole of this institution’s rela-

tionship with your grandmother's practice is in that archway, and it is a good archway, and I have never once seen a first-year look at it and see anything except decoration, so I am going to say the thing out loud, once, and then never again: *half of that stonework was made by people who were not permitted to write anything down, and we have kept the stonework.*"

Ninety seconds of silence.

"Morning," Milo said, cheerfully. "Everyone's fine. Nobody's sick. It's raining."

"He'll do that all term," said Zara, low. "It's his whole—"

"I know. It's *disgusting*." She was watching Lyra. "You've gone white. Which bit."

"The knots," Lyra said. "They've been done from a picture."

THE CALIBRATION

"Late awakers go first," said Tanaka. "Not as a kindness. Because the field is calibrated against the cohort and a late awaker is the only person in the room whose number is not already in the file, and I would like one honest reading before the day gets a shape to it."

Fifty heads turned to Lyra, which was the single most unpleasant eleven seconds of her life to date, and which she was to remember for the rest of her life as *the moment I understood that a gift is a scheduling problem before it is anything else*.

“Chen, Lyra.”

“Why me—”

“Mr. Reyes has been explaining it to you for forty seconds and doing it badly,” said Tanaka. “You are the only person here whose instrument has not been calibrated this term. Come and be honest at me for ninety seconds and then go and be terrified in private like everybody else.”

The archway was cool, and the stone under her hand was cool, and the air going in smelled of a dry cellar and old paper and, very faintly, of cardamom.

She put her hand on the left-hand post, where a Chinese knot was tying itself in crimson, and it was *loose*.

That was the whole of it. Everything else — the light, the density, the way the Maze seemed to be made of a thousand overlapping systems all talking at once — was the most extraordinary thing Lyra Chen had ever stood inside. But what she actually remembered, for the rest of her life, was that the knot on the left-hand post was loose, and that nobody in the building had looked at it in fifty-nine years.

“Ms. Chen.” The voice was not in the room. It came from the stone, or from behind her sternum, or from some third place that she would spend a lot of the following week trying to describe to Osei. “The Maze sees your signature. Multi-spectrum, with a strong silver component. Late awakening, four months, which is late. Deep ancestral structure — four lines, two of them very old and one of them in a country I am not going to name.” A pause that felt like a held breath in a machine. “Begin.”

It was not frightening. She had prepared to be frightened for eleven days.

The first chamber had a table in it and three objects on the table, and the room asked her to find what joined them, and she found it in eleven seconds and did not enjoy it. The second asked something about weight. The third about sequence. The fourth was about a thing she had done, badly, in an art room in April, and the Maze had a copy of it, and it showed her the copy, and Lyra stood in the middle of a chamber under a mountain and looked at a diagram of herself pulling two loose ends together and knotting them, and had to sit down.

It has been keeping records.

The fifth chamber was a corridor of standing figures, and as she went down it they turned, one after another, and each of them was somebody she knew, and each of them had a thing in their face she had not seen, and she got to

the end of it having learned nothing and having felt everything, and stood in the archway afterwards shaking so hard that Milo had to hold her by the shoulders.

“That’s four,” he said. “That’s four minutes. You okay?”

“No.”

“All right.” He handed her the flask. “Brew made that an hour ago and it’s gone cold and it’s got a skin on it, and you’re going to drink it anyway, because the alternative is that you pass out in front of Tanaka and she writes 5 — *deferred* on a clipboard and then feels bad about it for a week.”

The sixth chamber asked her to hold something still.

She got it wrong for about forty seconds, and then she got it right, and the reason she got it right was the sentence a woman in a kitchen on a Sunday had put in her hand with a piece of silk and refused to explain.

The eye sees the ripple. The hand feels the tide.

The Maze seemed to consider this for a while.

“Perception test. Unconventional approach.” Its voice had changed fractionally, which she noticed and would later be unable to persuade anyone of. “Proceed.”

The seventh chamber was empty, and almost entirely dark, and it asked her to find a path that was not lit.

She almost made it. She got about two-thirds of the way along a passage of patterns too fine to see properly, by closing her eyes and walking on the faint resistance of the air against her skin — and then the pattern *moved*, and the air went wrong, and every thread in the passage came alive at once and shrieked, and Lyra went down on the polished floor in the dark with her hands over her ears.

And in the middle of that, a silver line.

Not in the wall. Not on the floor. In the air, about a foot in front of her knees, at the height of a person who was sitting down.

She had never seen anything like it. Everything else in the Maze was *about* something. That line was a thing in itself: quiet, fine, older than the stone, and going on without her, and it did not care in the slightest whether she looked at it.

“Oh,” said Lyra Chen.

She followed it, and it took her to a door that was not one of the seventeen, and the door opened, and beyond it was a room with patterns on every surface and a stone pedestal in the middle of it and a crystal the size of a fist lying on the pedestal, silver, and turning very slowly.

Animus Argenti chamber. Restricted access. Signature recognition: Chen, Lin. Accessed once before. Eleven years prior. Similar resonant signature. Access window: four months.

Four months. Spring 2002. The months her father did not talk about. The months in which, by every other account, her mother had been extremely happy.

The silver line came off the crystal and reached for her, and where it reached her she felt the thing she had felt in a kitchen and in a school corridor and in a hospital corridor, and it was the thing the jade did: the room got *deeper*.

The crystal was cold. It was also, unmistakably, *pleased*.

“Animus Argenti fragment,” said the Maze, and the voice had come a great deal closer. “A silver bridge. Remnant. Left by previous visitor. She was here for one hour and eleven minutes and she did not take it, and she wrote on the wall behind you, in English, and I have not shown it to anybody in eleven years, and I am going to show it to you, and then this chamber is going to stop existing, and I would like you to understand that I am not being kind. I am closing a file.”

Lyra turned round.

There was pencil on the wall, very old, very faint, and it said:

It is a door. I am not going to be the one who opens it, because I have worked out that the reason nobody has opened it in eighty years is that everyone who gets here has been told it is the only way. — L.C., 4 May

She reached for the crystal with her right hand.

She was two inches from it when the floor came up, and everything went white, and there was a noise like a bar of iron being bent, and the wall behind her — the wall with the pencil on it — went.

“Exit now,” said the Maze, and it was not calm any more. “Exit. *Now.*”

The pedestal dropped into the floor. A compartment came up out of the place the pedestal had been — a narrow one, a service one, with a pneumatic hiss — and inside it there were four rolled tubes of paper, and Lyra’s hand went in and came out with one of them, and the compartment shut on her fingers, and the crystal went down, and the archway at the far end turned red.

She ran.

Behind her, something very large and very old finished coming apart, and the sound of it went on in her right ear for the rest of her life. The arch itself held. She did not know that yet, and neither did anybody else in the courtyard, and the difference between those two facts was the whole of the next three days.

She came out of the archway into the courtyard into ordinary rain, holding a roll of paper, and stood in the middle of flagstones with two hundred people in a building and the east half of a stone arch down across the flagstones in

pieces, and the span still up, and the two posts still standing in it, and the passage through it open to the weather.

And standing about four metres away, in the rain, in a dark uniform, absolutely still, was a woman Lyra had seen once, on a ramp, on Monday.

Security Chief Blackwood.

She had not been there when Lyra went in. Lyra was certain of that in the way you are certain of things you have checked. And Blackwood was not looking at the archway.

Blackwood was looking at the paper in Lyra's hand, and then at Lyra's face, and then — and this was the part that Lyra would take into every room for the rest of the year — Blackwood's left hand went, very briefly, to a silk charm at her wrist, and gave it a small deliberate tap with her thumb, and stopped.

It was a gesture. It was not a tic.

"Ms. Chen." Professor Tanaka was coming across the flagstones at a speed that was not dignified and did not pretend to be. "Are you hurt. Look at me. Are you hurt."

"I'm fine."

"Say it properly."

"I'm not hurt." Lyra heard how it sounded and could not improve it. "There was an eighth room. It wasn't on the

list. And the board in the antechamber went from twenty to twenty-three in about nine seconds, and the word NOMINAL off the end of it, and then the floor—”

Tanaka stopped.

She stood in the rain and looked at the archway, and then at the board over the anteroom door, and something went across her face that Lyra could not read and would think about for a long time.

“Twenty-three,” Tanaka said, very evenly. “That is nine seconds.”

“That’s what I—”

“Ms. Chen, the wall board has not read twenty-three in the eleven years I have been on this staff.” She turned. “Security Chief, I am going to need the sub-level instruments for the East Tower, not the campus board, the ones on the buried line, and I am going to need them now, and I am going to need a witness for the request, because I have learned this year how to ask for that.”

Blackwood did not move.

“Chief.”

“The buried line is sealed under an order from the Council’s own office,” said Blackwood. Her voice was level and pleasant and had a smile somewhere inside it that Lyra

could not locate. “Signed in 2009. I would be glad to raise a request, Professor. It would take some days.”

“Would it.”

“It would take some days,” said Blackwood, “and there is a form, and I am sure the registrar would be glad to counter-sign it.” She turned, and looked at Lyra one more time, unhurried, the way you look at something you have already decided about. “It is very hot for September.”

And she went, into the colonnade, and Lyra stood in the rain and understood two things at once.

The first was that the woman had known about the eighth room.

The second was that she had told somebody, in that gesture, in that second, that she had known.

Milo came out of the archway with his hair on end and his shirt half out of his trousers and the enormous uncomplicated happiness of a boy who has just done a thing well.

“**Nine**,” he announced, to nobody, to everybody. “Nine chambers. *Nine*. There’s a first-year record of seven and I have beaten a first-year record of seven by *two* and I want it written down before somebody comes out here and tells me it doesn’t count.”

“Milo—”

“I know. I *know*. The arch. Half of it came down.” He stopped, and looked at the archway, and at the rubble, and up at the span, which was still there, and then at the two hundred faces appearing along the colonnade, and then at Lyra, and then at the roll of paper under her arm, which she had not realised she was still holding. “What have you got?”

“Nothing.”

“You’ve got a—”

“I said I’ve got nothing,” Lyra said, and heard her own voice come out in a register she did not recognise, and Milo Reyes, who was sixteen and deaf to about a third of what people said and missed none of the rest, went completely still.

“Okay,” he said.

“Milo—”

“Chur,” said Milo Reyes, and took his shirt out of her hand, and did not ask again, and that was the single kindest thing anybody did for her that entire week.

THE BLUEPRINT

Her room. That evening. Lights off.

The paper came apart in her hands like something alive, because it was old, and because it had been rolled inside a warm stone room for eleven years, and because Lyra had been carrying it against her ribs since four o'clock in the afternoon and had sweated through it.

Four sheets. The largest was about eighteen inches by thirty and it was covered in a dense black mesh of drawings that made no sense to her at all: concentric circles, transfer functions, something that looked like a spine laid flat, and a great many numbers.

The second was a diagram of a machine, and the machine was the archway. She was certain of that within four seconds, because the archway had a socket in the second course of stone on the left-hand post and the diagram had a socket in the second course on the left-hand post, and it had a name next to it, and the name was—

Animus Argenti chamber. Rim node. Cache: 4.

The third sheet was a list. Lyra read it four times and her hands went cold on the paper.

INTERVENTIONS, CUMULATIVE. N = 11. Soft load identified: 11. Vessel intact: 11. Perception absent after: 11. Consent: signed 9. Not obtainable 2 (subject in extremis, no relation present). Not sought 0. Second responder required by s.9: 0 of 11.

The fourth sheet was a note in three hands, and the third of them was her mother's.

This is not a machine. I want that on the front of it. A machine has a purpose and can be switched off and does not have a schedule of appointments. This is a piece of arithmetic that has been running since 1941 and has acquired an appetite, and the appetite is not the arithmetic's, and I cannot find where it was put in.

Control is not the solution. Communion is the only road.

He has built the stabiliser around a person-shaped hole. I have found the person-shaped hole. It is not in the Council's inventory. Ask the Registrar. Ask her twice, and then ask her in writing, because that is the only way anything in this building has ever moved, and she is a good woman and she is frightened, and those two facts have been the whole of my life in this place.

I am going to be reckless in May. I am telling nobody because I have promised.

Lyra read the last line four times.

I am going to be reckless in May.

April. The four months. Her mother's best months.

She got out her phone and found, in a photograph her grandmother had sent her in June with no message attached, the back of a card in a hand she knew. MEI-HUA CHEN, REGISTRAR. And underneath, in a much smaller line: *For enquiries regarding records, appointments, and the rights of persons under the Care of Persons of Perceived Thread, ask at the desk.*

She typed out a message to three people, and looked at it, and added one line at the bottom, and sent it, because she had promised a boy in the rain that she would.

Nai Nai says I have to tell you things. I have three. I have had one of them in my bag for twenty-three days and I am telling you about it in this message and I am not going to read your replies tonight, and if that is cowardice then it is cowardice and it is at least consistent.

Eli — I have a list. Eleven. It has a column headed “consent”. Nine are signed. Two are “not obtainable (subject in extremis, no relation present)”. I want to know what the second one is.

Zara — I cannot see threads in a crowd any more, or in a room from across it, or at all unless I touch something, and I have had three days to work out why and it is because the Maze had a copy of what I did to Katie Doyle in April and showed it to me, and I have been sick about it, and I want you to ask me

about it in a room, not on a telephone, because I do not think I will manage it on a telephone.

Milo — thank you for not asking. I am going to tell you anyway, and not tonight. Station five was about a door. That is all I am going to say about it tonight.

One more thing. My mother wrote on a wall in 2002: “It is a door. I am not going to be the one who opens it, because I have worked out that the reason nobody has opened it in eighty years is that everyone who gets here has been told it is the only way.”

I would like somebody in this school to tell me, to my face, in a room with witnesses, whether that is still true.

She put the phone face down on the bed and lay on top of the covers in her coat with her boots on.

At ten to two, the board on the wall — the small one, the one that showed a severity and a date and nothing else — changed.

20% · MODERATE went to 23% · MODERATE in about four seconds, and then to 31%, and held, and then began, very slowly, to climb.

COUNTER — 31% · CRITICAL NODE PROJECTION — T+13 d, 14:00 (re-run on partial data) LO-

CAL DISTORTION (EAST TOWER) — 9.1% · elevated **COLLECTOR** — 87% of capacity

The fourth board was the one nobody had explained. The collector under the gym had been at four per cent on Monday.

Lyra got up, and put her coat on over her pyjamas, and went down three floors in her bare feet, and read the fourth board for a long time, and then went back up and lay on top of the covers in her coat with her boots on, and did not sleep, and did not take the paper off the door.

THE CORDON

Wednesday 11 September - Thursday 12 September. The courtyard, and then the file.

Nobody went back under the arch on the Tuesday night.

The Consultant Engineer came on the Wednesday with two men and a torch, and what he wrote is short, and the file contains the whole of it. What was still traversable was named, and the naming is the whole of the document: the span, the left-hand post, the threshold, and the passage between them. What was not traversable was named the same way: the east side, the rim, the housing, and the eighth room. The eighth room was not damaged and was not

shored and was not going to be shored, because there was nothing left of it to shore.

The reference set was in the Maze. That is why the Council's counter has said *partial data* in every header since Wednesday morning, and it is why nobody since has been able to say what the number means, and it is why a boy's number in a room in the East Tower could be taken for the Academy's.

They ran a cordon along the colonnade and propped the span on the Wednesday, and the timber was called temporary in every document that mentions it, including the one in which somebody asked for it to be called something else and was refused.

The arch was not declared safe. It was declared traversable, on the Thursday, by a man with a clipboard, and those are not the same sentence, and it is the second one that a Registrar signed an access condition on the strength of, in the courtyard office, on the Thursday afternoon, in a hand that is not difficult to read.

Thread Resonance Note: Maze run, cohort 1, 10 September. Nine candidates entered. Eight returned. ELEVEN YEARS: the term "Animus Argenti" has been scrubbed from the assessment vocabulary in 2009 on the instruction of this office and I have been aware of the instruction. — withdrawn 14 Sept, see minute 44-B/3. RE: C.L., first-year, unattached to a range. The pattern of her reading is the pattern of a candi-

date for something. I do not know what and I have not asked, and I want it minuted that I have chosen not to ask, which is a decision, and that the last person who chose not to ask in this building was her mother, and that I was her mother's colleague, and that I did not know her well enough to stop her, and that I have thought about that for eleven years.

Chapter 12A: The Demonstration

Weave-Quake Counter: 34% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d, 14:00. The reference dataset was destroyed in the Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council's re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

Wednesday 11 September. The Grand Demonstration Hall.

THE ABSENCE

The notice went up at nine o'clock and it was four lines long and it changed the shape of the morning entirely, because everybody in that hall had been told in August that Dr. Chen would be demonstrating, and everybody in that hall had therefore not read anything about thread ethics since the start of term, and there were two hundred and eleven first-years and about sixty of them had already prepared questions.

Dr. M-H. Chen will present Thursday's seminar. In her absence, Professor Harlow has asked for the floor.

Lyra read it four times and did not know why it made her feel as though somebody had taken a chair out of a row.

"You've gone quiet," said Milo.

"I've got nothing. It's a notice."

"It's a notice about a *woman*." Zara had not looked up from a page. "Two hundred people in this hall and about forty of them can read a thread signature, and every one of them is going to spend the next hour watching two men who both outrank everybody in the room, and there is going to be a *thing* about it, and you are going to be in the middle of it, and I have known you for nine days and I would like to take

this moment to say that I find you extremely difficult to be in a room with.”

“Chur,” said Milo Reyes, who had been in the room for nine days and had already worked out that the three of them were going to be a thing whether they liked it or not.

THE FLOOR

It was not a duel. That is the first thing, and Lyra wrote it down in the back of a notebook on the Thursday because she wanted to be sure of it, and because a great many people told her afterwards that it had looked like one.

Elder Adebayo Adeyemi took the floor first, unasked, and did it in a way that made the request irrelevant: he came down into the circle, and he sat down on the obsidian, cross-legged, in robes the colour of a September afternoon, and he waited.

“I teach what I know and I do not know what you teach,” he said. “We will both be wrong. There is a bench at the back for anyone who becomes faint, and I am seventy-one and I have a knee and I will be using the bench, and I would like it noted that I have said so in advance, because a man of my age who does not say so is performing.”

Then he made something.

He did it slowly, and he narrated it, and he got two things wrong on purpose and corrected them, and the effect of watching a competent man correct himself in public was the single most disarming thing Lyra had ever seen a person do.

Èmí àgbájọ. The living gathering. He said the words and translated them and then said that the translation was a *reduction* and that the reduction was the fault of English and not of him, and that he would like somebody in the room to write down that the fault was the fault of English.

Amber and green, and they did not snap into being — they *arrived*, the way water arrives at a thing, and Lyra's eyes filled and she had to stop and do the count that Wren Zhou had taught her on a platform, and behind her four hundred threads of frightened attention went up off the floor like heat off a road.

"It's feeding on the room," Eli Park said, from two seats along, in a whisper. "It's not taking. It's *feeding*, and it's the same as what Ms. Washington does with a room when she walks in and everybody goes quiet, and it's completely different from what the professor is about to do, and I want to watch both."

A ward went up in front of Adeyemi. It was not a wall. It was a thing with roots in the floor and a great deal of patience in it, and the pattern was nothing like anything in the textbooks, and it was, Lyra thought, the first time in her life she

had seen a *structure* that was obviously alive and obviously not interested in her.

“Hold that in your mind,” Adeyemi said. “That is what a *relationship* looks like from the inside. It is not stronger. It is more expensive to run and it lasts longer and there is no on/off and you cannot get it in an afternoon. Hold it.”

Marcus Harlow stepped into the circle, and the temperature in the hall went down about two degrees, and Lyra’s whole body reacted before her mind had got to the word.

He was not a large man and he moved like something poured, and he did not have the ozone smell in a room of four hundred people; that was in a bookshop in August, at a boy on a carpet, and she had spent a month being frightened of a smell and now there was nothing at all, which was somehow much worse, because it meant she had been frightened of the wrong thing and had got lucky.

“Threads are not a metaphor,” he said, and the textbook said that too. “They are a medium. They respond to intention with a measurable lag of four to nine tenths of a second, and every disaster in our institutional memory traces back to somebody who believed that wanting a thing hard enough was the same as doing it. I have said that sentence in this hall once. I am not going to say it again. I am going to *demonstrate* it.”

Silver threads came into being in the air in front of him, and they came into being the way a nail goes into a board,

and Lyra felt her stomach go cold, because she had seen that gesture forty times in her mother's notebooks in a kitchen on a street called Ellery, and in every one of them it had been described in words like *ploughed* and *driven* and *forced*, and Lyra had never once thought about why.

He built a lattice in about nine seconds. It was beautiful. It was, without any question, the most competent thing Lyra Chen had ever seen a person do with their hands, and it hung in the air over the obsidian and it was a *fortress*, and every line in it was straight, and the whole of it was beautiful in the way that a suspension bridge is beautiful.

"Efficiency," he said. "Minimal expenditure. Maximal effect. That is what you are looking at and it is what I have been trying to teach this institution to do for eleven years, and I have failed approximately two hundred times, and the reason I have failed is on that bench."

Adeyemi had not moved. His amber ward was still up, patient, rooted, entirely indifferent.

"Marcus," he said, in Yoruba-accented English, in the tone of a man who has known somebody a very long time. "That is a *fence*."

"It is a *wall*," Harlow agreed. "And a wall is what is between my daughter and a collapse."

"Between your daughter and a collapse is a *wall*," Adeyemi said, "and the wall is made of your daughter, and she is sev-

en, and she is standing in a garden, and she has been standing in that garden for sixteen years, and you are the only person in this room who still believes she is standing in a garden, and I have watched you build eleven of these and I have watched what happens to the garden every time.”

Eleven years.

Lyra’s hand went to the jade at her throat and stopped there, because she had been about to do something else with it, and she made herself not, and did not entirely understand why, and understood four weeks later.

Then Adeyemi stamped his foot, and a hum went through the stone, and the amber flared, and what came out of it was a bird.

It was enormous. It had a wingspan of about nine feet and it was made of light and it was not a *symbol*, which was the thing Lyra could not stop thinking about afterwards: Harlow said the word *animistic* twice, dismissively, in the voice of a man filing a document, and the bird was not an animistic projection. It was a *structure* with a job.

It took his lattice apart in the air, in about four seconds, without touching a line of it — Lyra worked that out afterwards and could not work out how — and it came back and folded itself over Adeyemi’s shoulder like a bird that has come home.

“Recycling,” said Eli Park, from two seats along, in a voice that had gone somewhere else entirely. “Oh. *Oh*. He isn’t making a wall. He’s making a *roof*.”

THE WRIST

It went wrong at eleven minutes, and it went wrong because of a man’s hand.

Lyra saw it happen and she could not afterwards explain to anybody why it was the hand, because a room of four hundred people saw a demonstration and a woman of sixteen saw a man in a grey suit move his cuff down about an inch too far, in the specific, practised, entirely involuntary way of a person who has been wearing something that is not theirs.

Adeyemi’s eyes went to it. Lyra saw the elder’s gaze arrive on that wrist and stay there, and saw the elder’s face do something that four hundred people could not see, because it took about half a second, and then Adeyemi said a word, quietly, in Yoruba, and Lyra did not know it and has never been able to find it in a dictionary, and has never needed to.

Harlow froze.

Every silver thread in the air went out at once, not in a pattern and not with a bang — they *went*, the way a held breath

goes, and eleven or twelve of them tore as they went, and there was a sound in the hall like a door being shut in another building.

The name came out of the old man like a stone out of a wall.

“Kyoto.”

And the hall did not breathe.

Lyra went out into the corridor because she had to, and because four hundred people were standing up, and because the woman she wanted to speak to was going to be at the front of it and could not be got to.

There was a man against the wall with his forehead on the stone.

It was her father, and he had a stick, and he had come from Ward C on his own at eleven o'clock in the morning on the advice of a doctor who had lost that particular argument, and he had not told her, and the reason he had not told her was that he had been in Ward C for two days and had been watching a woman of eighty-one on a speakerphone teach a girl of sixteen to say a sentence in Vietnamese, and had decided that he could not interrupt that.

She stood four feet away from him and could not get a word out.

He was not weeping. That was the thing she would remember. His shoulders were shaking and his knuckles were

white against the stone and he was not making any sound at all, and Lyra stood there and understood that she was looking at her father being *remade*, in a corridor, in about ninety seconds, by a word said by an old man in a hall.

“Ba—”

He put his hand up. Not to her. To the wall.

“Lyra. Go back in.”

“I can’t. Ba—”

“*Go back in.*” It came out of him like something breaking. “I have been sitting in Ward C for two days reading your mother’s papers, all of them, the ones she left and the ones Nai Nai has had for six years, and I want to tell you what I have learned, and I cannot do it in a corridor, and I cannot do it now, and I am asking you for the only thing I have ever asked you for, which is to come back in a minute.”

“Bàba—”

“Nineteen ninety-seven,” her father said, to the stone. “April. A garden. A draw, and a man with a blade, and a child of seven who walked *towards* it.” His hand slid down the wall about a foot. “That is what I have learned, and I have known some of it since the beginning of the year, and I did not tell you, and the reason I did not tell you is that I was afraid of a specific thing, and the specific thing was that you would go and find him.”

Lyra stood in a corridor of a school she had been in for nine days and did not move.

“Bàba, I am going to find him.”

“Yes,” said Wei Chen. “I know. That is why I have been *reading*.”

Behind them the doors opened, and about forty people came out into the corridor, and among them was a girl of about nineteen with silver in her hair who was taking notes at a speed that was frankly indecent, and a girl of eighteen with her aunt’s coat over one shoulder who said “Ms. Chen” in a voice that was not a question, and a boy who had followed Lyra out of a hall of four hundred people without being asked and without any idea at all what he was doing.

“There is a bench,” said Lyra, “in the Demonstration Hall, and it is not for the students. It is for an old man’s knee, and he used it, and he said he would in advance, and he did.”

Milo Reyes said, “Right,” in the voice of a person who has decided to be useful before he understands the situation, which is, Lyra thought, exactly what he had done on the first day with a matrix, and she would spend the next nine days learning that it was a habit and not a fluke, and the rest of her life learning that it was the best thing about him.

Weave-Quake Counter: 34% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d, 14:00. The reference dataset was destroyed in the Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Coun-

cil's re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

Wednesday 11 September, 12:20. The corridor outside the Grand Demonstration Hall.

Filed by the second-year demonstrator's note-taker, and read into the record of the demonstration at the Council's request, and printed in the 2013 transcript, and the reason it is printed is that in 2019 a lecturer in Lyon asked whether the demonstration was staged, and the answer was:

"It was not staged. Two men went into that circle because a woman did not turn up and neither of them would go home. Everything else in this record is worse than that afternoon and I would like somebody who is reading about a rug in August to understand that the afternoon in September was the good one, and that in it a professor of applied mathematics stood in a corridor and asked his daughter for the only thing he had ever asked her for, and she did it, and it took four minutes, and afterwards she could not remember any of it."

Chapter 12B: The Eleventh of September

“A system that requires a payment from someone who has not agreed to make it is not a system. It is a queue. I wrote that in February, on a page about an infant, and I have thought about it every day since, and I was wrong, because I thought it was about principle.”

— Lin Chen, “Communion vs. Control,” April 2002, quoted from memory by a man who could not read the original and refused to pretend otherwise

Weave-Quake Counter: 34% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d, 14:00.

Sub-level 3. The eleventh of September, two o'clock in the morning. Written seven days later and not sent.

WHY THIS IS HERE

The note on the outside of the file is in a registrar's hand and is four lines long, and it is the only reason this document is in a book at all.

*This is a document written on the eleventh of September 2013 at about two hours in the morning, by the member of faculty whose name is on it, in his own hand, on the back of a form. It was not sent to anybody. It was found on the fourteenth, in his desk, by the man who has been cleaning out that office for four years, and he read about four lines of it and then he put it in a file and went home at six o'clock on the fourteenth, which is two hours before his shift ended, and he has given a statement about that and the statement is two lines long and it says: **"I am not the person who should be the one to have read that."***

The first week of term, Dr. Chen was absent from a seminar, and the events of the eighteenth are in the

record. Nothing in this file was known to the subject of the Inquiry, or to the patient, or to any of the four young people, until the nineteenth of October.

I have put it in the book because the alternative is that the person who took a girl of fifteen out of this building on the eleventh of September remains a man whose actions began on the fourteenth, and that is false, and it was false in 2002 as well. — M-H. Chen, Registrar

THE ENTRY

I am writing this at two o'clock in the morning on the eleventh of September and I am writing it because I have decided, on the stairs, four minutes ago, that I am going to do something tomorrow that I will not be able to describe accurately afterwards, and that the description is always the only part anybody ever checks.

The girl is in a room four floors up. She is asleep. She has been asleep since half past nine. She is fifteen. She has been in this building for two days, and she is here because her sister put her on a coach, and her sister is a third-year who has been extremely careful about something for four years and did not want to be asked about it in a corridor, and I know the something, and I have known it since April, and I have not asked

her about it either, and I have decided — on the stairs, four minutes ago, at about ten to two in the morning — that I am going to go and ask Elara Vance, and that I am going to ask her in a way that does not make her feel stupid.

Here is the arithmetic, and I am going to put it down because I have been told, by a woman in a demonstration hall in August whom I did not manage to help, that putting it down is the whole of the difference between a person and a machine.

The machine under this mountain needs a resonance to hold an open circuit, and has needed one since 1997, and I have spent eleven years looking for a body that will take it. In 2002 I found a document in a drawer in this building that says the Animus Argenti is a bridge, and I have spent eleven years trying to build a machine out of a sentence.

Elara Vance is a bridge.

That is not a metaphor and I hate it. It is a measurement. She came in on the ninth with a signature like a lit window, and on the tenth I put her in a calibration chair and read her for four hours, and I have had that reading eleven times before, in children, and every one of the eleven had a floor to stand on, and Elara Vance has no floor. She is the only signature I have ever seen that *already* is the thing the machine wants.

I have written that sentence in four files since April and I have not once written the next sentence, and the next sen-

tence is the one that says what the machine does with a signature that is already the thing it wants, and the answer is: *it holds the circuit*, and the way it holds it is by taking the person and keeping the part of them that is holding.

That is what happened in a garden in April 1997, and it took nine seconds, and I stood in it.

And here is the arithmetic, and it is correct, and I want it in the record in my own hand because I know what is going to happen to this document:

She will live. The vessel is intact. She will not bleed and she will not scar and she will be, in a physical sense, entirely well. She will lose the ability to perceive threads and she will lose the ability to be perceived by anybody in her family, and she will be fifteen, and she will be a bridge for the rest of her life, and I do not know how to say any of that to a person in a chair.

Fourteen days. In fourteen days the Southern Nexus fails and eleven thousand people find out.

And she is the only one in the world.

I went up at ten past two and I sat on the end of the bed in a room with a window and a girl in it and I did the only thing I am good at, which is ask a question.

“Miss Vance. I am going to ask you three things and you are allowed to say no to all of them and I am going to take a no

as final, and I want that on the card, and I am going to hand the card to you and not to your sister, because you are fifteen and your sister is eighteen and the difference between those two numbers is the difference between a person and a signature.”

She said, “What’s it for?”

And I said — and I have this in the voice memo I took at the top of the stairs at ten to two, which I have now also destroyed, because I understood about four seconds after pressing the button what I had done, and I want that on the record too, and it is the worst thing in this file:

“Miss Vance, I am going to offer you a place on a specialist programme. It is a four-week residential course in applied thread dynamics. It is the most advanced programme in this field. I am going to be honest with you about three things, because I have discovered in eleven years that the young people I have harmed most were the ones I was honest with, and the ones I damaged second were the ones I lied to, and I have never worked out why that is true and I have stopped trying.

“It is residential and it is supervised and you will be taught by four people, one of whom is me.

“It is not a gift, and nobody has proved that there is any such thing, and I have spent eleven years pretending otherwise in public because a committee requires a category.

“And it will change you, and I do not know how, and I am telling you that I do not know, and I have read every paper there is and I do not know, and *I am telling you that* because a man put those exact words in a lecture hall three days ago in front of two hundred people and I have thought about nothing else since, and it is the only decent thing anybody has done in this building in eleven years and he did it by accident while trying to recruit her.”

She asked, “What kind of change?”

And I said, “The kind that does not come back.”

And I sat on the end of a bed in a dormitory at twenty to three in the morning and let a fifteen-year-old think about it, which is the correct procedure, and which I had not used eleven times in eleven years, because eleven times in eleven years I had a form in front of me with a number on it, and a number is a *terrible* thing to have in front of you at twenty to three in the morning, and I knew it, and I did it anyway, and I want that on the record in the order in which it happened.

She said, “Can I ring my mother?”

I said yes.

She rang her mother. She spoke for four minutes, and Lyra, four floors up and nine days into a term in which she had already been the reason two men in a circle could not finish an argument, slept through all of it.

She spoke for four minutes and then she said, “She says to ask whether there are other people like me,” and I said, “There are four. In the world. That is not an exaggeration and I would ask you to please not repeat it as one, because in 2002 a woman of twenty-four was told that in a letter and repeated it in a lecture hall and about forty people wrote down the number.”

And Elara Vance said, “Then I’d like to do it,” and signed the card, in her own hand, with a pen, and it says:

VOLUNTEER

and the date, and the time, and the name of the person who offered it, and I did not read it, and I have written that sentence in this file four times now and I am going to stop.

THE ENTRY, LATER

Eighteen September, 11:40 p.m. Sub-level 3.

Seven days. I have written four thousand words and I have not written the part.

Here is what I did not write on the eleventh.

I did not write that on the eleventh — on the eleventh — she asked me, back in the calibration chair, with a chart on

the wall behind her, whether anyone had asked *her* what the machine was going to be.

I said, “Not yet.”

And she said, “Why not?”

And I said, “Because the answer is complicated and you are fifteen and I did not want to give you a complicated answer at two o’clock on a Wednesday.”

And then I said the other thing. I have been trying for seven days to work out why I said it, and the best I have is that it was in the room and it was the wrong thing, and I have never in my life been in a room where the wrong thing was simply *available*, and in the room, and nobody in the corridor to see me take it.

I said: “You will be the first, Miss Vance. In the programme. I have not told anybody that, because there are four of you and there is one place, and the place goes to whoever is ready, and I have spent seven days deciding that you were ready, and I have not asked you, and I would like to hear you say it now.”

And Elara Vance — fifteen years old, four days in a building, with a card on the table that said *volunteer* and a sister asleep on a floor two above her and a mother on a telephone in a town four hundred miles away who had been told by a *letter* that her daughter was in a specialist programme for gifted young people and who had written back

in February to ask what the curriculum was and had had a form posted to her, and who had, in April, put her daughter on a coach —

Elara Vance said, “You decided.”

And I said, “Yes.”

And she said, “I want to know what happens to me.”

And I told her. All of it. In order. For about eleven minutes, in a calibration room, on a Wednesday afternoon in a building in a valley, to a child.

And then I asked her, and she signed, and I did not read the card.

And here is the part I have not been able to write for seven days, and it is two sentences long, and I am going to write it and then I am going to close this file:

She asked me what happens to her and I told her the truth.

She did not understand the truth, and I knew she had not understood it, and I watched her not understand it, and I let her sign.

End of entry. No further entry. The file is closed because there is nothing after the seventh day. The Council’s question is always the same and it is always about the eleventh, and this document is the answer to it, and it is four thousand words long, and the answer is in the second sentence of the fourth

page, and it is that a man of fifty-four told a child the truth in eleven minutes and she signed a card, and he did not read the card, and he watched her not understand him.

And I would like it recorded — by whoever reads this in a book, which I do not expect and have not prepared for — that in the four days before the second of October a girl of sixteen asked thirty-nine people in a cage what they wanted, and that on the second of October she had been standing in a fault for four days holding it open, and that somebody with a stick and a model in a case lined it without going into it, and that thirty-seven of them said out loud that they wanted to be let go, and that she honoured it, and that thirty-seven of them are dead.

And I would like it recorded that I was in that building on the second of October and that I was the reason there was something to line.

And I would like it recorded, in my own hand, in this file, with a date, that this is the fifth option and I did not propose it and I have spent eleven years arguing that it was impossible, and that I was wrong, and that the person who was right was a sixteen-year-old with a napkin and a woman with a tube of silk and a man who was going to be dead in a week.

There is no forgiveness in this. I want to be extremely clear, because I have read four hundred pages of this Inquiry and I know exactly what everybody in it is hoping for, and I have

been the man who leaves a door open that he is going to walk through, and this time I am not going to do it.

Her name was Elara Vance. Her mother's name is Ines. Her sister's name is Elena and her sister is twenty-nine feet above her and she has been sleeping on the other side of a wall for four days and she does not know, and her sister has spent four years building a thing for her, and it is in a garage, and I have never seen it, and I am going to die not having seen it, and that is correct, and it is the only thing in this file that I have got right.

Chapter 13: The First Disappearance

Weave-Quake Counter: 35% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d, 14:00. The reference dataset was destroyed in the Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council's re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

Thursday 12 September.

THE QUESTION, ASKED IN A LECTURE HALL

“Professor. Can I ask you something that is not about the answer?”

Two hundred and eleven first-years, the Lumina Lecture Hall, half past two on a Thursday, and Zara Washington stood up in the middle of a row and Marcus Harlow stopped mid-sentence.

“That is a somewhat alarming way to open,” said Harlow, “and yes, and I am going to enjoy it, and please be aware that I am going to enjoy it *visibly*, and that two people on the Council have been told about that in advance and have not stopped me.”

“I’ve been in this building for eleven days.” Zara did not have notes. Lyra found that she checked, twice, and that Zara Washington had come to a lecture hall of two hundred and eleven people with nothing. “And on the first day four of us held a door for about four minutes and two hundred and eleven people watched, and the number on the board in the station was seventeen, and it was seventeen on the Monday and it was seventeen on the Tuesday, and Dr. Osei has been very patient with me and she is going to stop being patient in about eleven weeks, and I would like to ask

a question about the number before I run out of the thing that is keeping me from asking it.”

“Ask.”

“How many people know what it measures?”

And there was a silence in that hall that Lyra Chen would think about for the rest of her life, because it was not the silence of two hundred people not knowing an answer. It was the silence of two hundred people who all knew the answer and had all, independently, decided not to have it.

“Some of us,” said Harlow.

“Thank you.” Zara sat down.

Nobody breathed for about three seconds and then somebody at the back said, “It measures the severity of the ward network. It’s a severity and not a percentage of anything. The projection is a date and not a number of hours. There are four numbers on that board and they are four different questions, and the fourth one is how full the old fear-collector under the gym is, and it is not in the student handbook, and I have looked, twice, and I would like to ask somebody about the fourth one.”

“You would like to ask somebody about the fourth one,” said Harlow, “and I have been waiting nineteen days for somebody to ask somebody about the fourth one, and I would like it noted that the reason I have been waiting is

that I raised it at a Council meeting in 2011 and it was minuted as *noted*, and that I have discovered in the last eleven days that *noted* is a thing you can do to a question so that it never has to be answered again, and that this is a discovery I made in a lecture hall in front of two hundred people because a girl of sixteen was braver than a committee.”

Afterwards, in the corridor, Lyra said, “That was the best thing I have ever seen anybody do.”

“That was Zara. I said *noted* in 2011.”

“That was the *best thing you have ever said*, you told her she was braver than a committee, in front of two hundred people.”

“Mira,” said Harlow — and then stopped, because he had used a name that had not been introduced, and about forty people in that corridor heard it, and one of them, a girl of eighteen with her aunt’s coat over one shoulder, turned round very slowly.

“You called her Mira,” said Elena Vance.

“I did.”

“Her name is Zara. Zara Washington. She is a first-year and she has a *sister* in this building and it is not you.” Elena Vance’s voice was very level. “I don’t know what you have just told this corridor. I don’t know what any of it is about. But I would like to say one thing into it, and then I am going

to go and do my work, and I would like it noticed that I have a *course load*.”

“Noticed,” said Harlow.

“Ines is my mother,” said Elena Vance. “She is alive. She is in a care programme in this town and my sister has been in the same one since she was twelve, and the last person in this building who wrote that name down in a form in 2011 was you. And *Mira* is not her name, and it is not anybody’s name. It is what happens when a man who has had a page in a drawer for two years tries to say out loud a name he was never supposed to have learned.”

Nobody in the corridor moved.

Then she said, “Two hundred and eleven names in that hall, and there were about nine of us who could see what was happening, and every single one of us did the same thing, and I have been in this building three years and I did it too. So.” She put her coat back on her shoulder. “Don’t.”

She went.

Harlow stood in the corridor of Threadweaver Academy with his mouth slightly open, and Lyra Chen — who had spent a month learning that a man with a silver thread in his arm was a *category* rather than a person — watched a woman of eighteen walk away from him and understood that she was braver than both of them, and that she had

said so in eleven words, and that it had cost her something, and that nobody was going to thank her for it.

THE ARCHIVE

They went down at four o'clock because the demonstration had emptied the building and Eli Park had worked out, in about six minutes, from a diagram and a list of reading-room hours, that the Restricted Stacks are staffed between two and four and unstaffed between four and six, and that between four and six the *access log* is still written, by a machine, and that a machine writes down the time and not the person.

"You have got eleven minutes," he said, at the bottom of the spiral stair, in the dark, with his torch off. "And I want to say the thing I am actually worried about, and it is not security, and I have written it on the back of my hand."

"Go on."

"Somebody put a piece of paper in Lyra's sketchbook on the eighteenth of August and nobody has seen it since." Eli did not look up. "I have been not-asking about that for twenty-five days. I want to say out loud, in a cellar, to two people, that I have been not-asking, and that I have a reason, and that the reason is that I have worked out that whoever-

er put it there can put things in other people's rooms, and that if I ask Lyra to show it to me then the person who put it there finds out that a sixteen-year-old has read it, and I would like to put that on the record before I do something I am going to regret."

"Go on," said Zara.

"And I have worked out the other half of it," said Eli Park, "which is that this is *also* the reason nobody has asked Lyra to show it to us, and that it is not only me."

They found it in forty minutes. Not the conduit — the conduit is a *term of art* and they did not have it, and Eli had spent three weeks failing to find it by searching for it, and what he found instead was a place.

"There's a term for it," he said, into a very small torch beam. "'Rim node.' That's what the Maze log calls the east lattice. And there are four of them, and three of them are in this building, and the fourth one is not on the inventory, and *the inventory is dated 2011.*"

"Where?"

"In the Maze." Eli sat down on a floor. "Lyra. Lyra, the thing you went into on Tuesday — the eighth room, the one that isn't on the list, the one Tanaka says is a *cache*—"

"You told me it was a cache."

“It is a cache. It’s a cache with a *rim* on it, and the rim has a reading, and the reading on Tuesday night was thirty-four per cent, and the counter said twenty at the same time, and I have been assuming for three weeks that the difference was a *consequence*.” He was talking very fast now. “It isn’t. It’s a *source*. Something under that building has been drawing from the ward network since Tuesday night and it has been drawing at a rate that took the counter from twenty to thirty-one in nine seconds, and it is still drawing, and the log is in a machine, and the machine is in the antechamber, and the antechamber is not locked, and there are two hundred and eleven people in this building who have just been in a lecture hall being told a great deal about the fourth number.”

JAMES

They came out of the Restricted Stacks at five past five into a corridor in which a boy of fourteen was sitting on the floor with his back against a wall and his school coat over his knees, doing a sum.

“Lyra,” he said, without looking up. “Hi. Sorry. I’m James. Your father’s cousin’s son, from the branch in Leeds, which I know is a *horrible* way to say it, and I’ve been here since Friday because Nai Nai’s branch sent me for the assessment, and I have been in the East Tower since yesterday

and I have a *sheet of paper* from a man called Harlow and I don't know what it means and I'm supposed to take it to the office tomorrow, and I couldn't sleep, so I've been doing the sums on it, and there's a number on it that keeps changing and I've checked it four times."

He held out the sheet.

"James." Lyra's voice came out at a pitch she did not recognise. "Ba. How long have you been in the East Tower?"

"Since yesterday. They said the assessment room was in there. And they've been —" he frowned at the paper — "they've been coming and going. There's a *noise*, Lyra, in the floor. It isn't a machine noise, it's more like—" he tapped the paper "—it's like that. It's a number going up and down and I can *hear* the going up and down and I thought that was normal because that's what I do, and then I met Ms. Washington in the corridor on Tuesday and she looked at me like I was broken."

He put the paper down.

"Lyra, I think I am in a room where the number is me."

That was the whole of it, and it took four minutes, and afterwards nobody could work out why the four of them did not go to a member of staff immediately.

It was Eli's fault, and he has said so in four different documents, and the version he gives in the 2013 transcript is this:

"We had a *room*. We had a location. We had a reading that had been changing since Tuesday. We had a fourteen-year-old with a sheet of paper in a corridor. And we had a name to give to whoever we reported it to, and the name was *Armitage*, and Armitage had run Harlow's advanced seminar for six years, and I had a *diagram* in a corridor and four and a half hours of daylight and a two-hour window on a Thursday when the assessment was scheduled and a building that was emptier than it had ever been.

"And I said, out loud, to two people I trusted, *if we go to Armitage now, the only thing we will have achieved is that a professor knows we know.*"

Zara Washington said, "That is true."

"It is *not* true," said Eli Park. "It is what I said, and it is what I believed, and it is the exact mechanism that had operated on this building for seventy years, and I said it, and I said it in a cellar, on the strength of no evidence, about a man who has been nothing but decent to me, and I have never been able to work out whether I was right."

"You were right," said Lyra Chen, and has said so in print, and it did not help.

THE ROOM

Elara Vance's room was on the third floor of the east dormitory and it was empty.

That is the phrase in the report and the phrase in the transcript and the phrase in about four hundred letters, and Lyra Chen, who has read all of them, has never found a better one.

Empty. Bed made. Desk tidy. A stack of work on the top, squared. A hairbrush on the shelf above the sink. Three nights of a term lived in a room, and not one thing *wrong* with any of it, and nothing in it at all.

The dormitory's own monitoring board said what it said: **RESIDENT, E. VANCE, LEVEL 3. OCCUPANCY: VACANT SINCE 11 SEPT 23:14.**

One night.

"It says *vacant since the eleventh*," said Milo Reyes. He had said almost nothing for two hours and he said this in a very small voice. "Lyra. It's the twelfth. She went *missing* on the eleventh and nobody — we were only *looking* for her. She's been gone since last night."

“The eleventh,” said Zara Washington, from the doorway, and did not come further in.

The thread monitoring said something else, and it is in the transcript, and nobody in the room of four understood it at the time, and only one of them understood it in 2019.

Elara Vance’s thread signature — which anybody with sight could have read off the wall of a corridor, and which eleven people in the building had read and had thought was *a lit window* — was not gone. It was there, in the same room, in the same space, at a *different depth*.

“There is something in the walls,” said Zara, from the doorway. “I want everybody to be extremely careful about what I am about to say, because I have been wrong in this building twice and both times I was wrong in a direction that cost somebody something, and I would like the second one to be on the record as a thing I did.

“It isn’t residue. It isn’t a scar, and it isn’t a *ghost*, and I am using all three of those words deliberately to say that I have considered them and rejected them.

“It’s *under* her. Lyra — go and stand by the bed. Go on. Don’t touch anything. Now: is there anything in the room that you can see a *depth* to?”

And Lyra Chen, sixteen years old, nine days into a term, with a jade stone at her throat and a gift she could not

switch off, looked at a small room in a dormitory in a valley in September, and said:

“Yes.”

And that is the first evidence in the record of anything at all being in the ground beneath the east dormitory, and it is the evidence that the *thread dimension* is not a metaphor and not a mood, and it was given by a schoolgirl who did not understand what she was looking at, and every engineer who has worked on that site since has quoted it.

THE REPORT

They wrote it that night, in a common room, in about eleven minutes, and it is a bad document and it is on the record and it is *exactly* the document that a well-meaning sixteen-year-old writes.

To the Registrar.

We are four first-year students. We are writing this because we are not sure who to write to and because we have been told that the registrar's intake log is the one place in this building that Security cannot reach without a countersignature, and because we have been told that by a person who we have not

named and who has been extremely helpful in a corridor and who we would like to keep out of this.

1. A resident of the east dormitory, E. Vance, has been absent since the eleventh of September. Her room is intact and the monitoring board says vacant since 11/09 23:14. We do not know what the 23:14 means and we think somebody should ask.

2. There is something under the east dormitory. We do not know what. One of us can see a depth in it and one of us can feel a structure in it and one of us has a diagram in a book that puts a rim under the east dormitory and a cache on it, and a reading that has been climbing since the twelfth of September.**

3. J. Chen, fourteen, visiting, has been in the East Tower since Wednesday on a thread assessment and has a sheet of paper from a member of faculty with a number on it that he can hear, and he thinks the number is him, and we think that this is correct, and we do not know what to do about it, and he is fourteen, and he is in that building tonight, and he went to bed there tonight.

4. We are not asking you to believe us. We are asking you to put a person on the floor below E. Vance's room and to move J. Chen, and we are asking that the response be in writing, and we are asking that

the response be addressed to us and not to a member of faculty.

5. Signed. E. Park. M. Reyes. Z. Washington. L. Chen.

Eli Park read it four times and then said, “That is a very good document and I am not posting it.”

“Give it to the registrar,” said Zara.

“Give it to the registrar *tonight*, and it will be on her desk in about nine minutes, and the security log will show a first-year visitor to the registrar’s office at 23:41 on the twelfth, and at some point tomorrow a person will look at the security log.” Eli’s hands were not entirely steady, which Lyra noticed, and about which she said nothing at that time and has since apologised for. “Lyra, I have known for eight days that there is something about that *paper*. And I have worked out in the last four minutes that whoever put it there can see what people read, and that if a first-year is logged in this building at 23:41 on a Friday, then it does not matter what is in the letter.”

“Then what do we do?”

“We take the piece of paper off our own door,” said Eli Park, “and we write our four sentences on it, and we hand it to Dr. Chen *in a corridor, in daylight, with a witness*, and we let the security log say that four first-years told the Regis-

trar something in a corridor at ten in the morning, and then we do not write anything down for nine days.”

“Nine days is a very long time,” said Lyra Chen.

“Nine days,” said Eli Park, “is how long it took a man in a good room to work out how to say no to a clipboard.”

They did not wait nine days.

Eli Park was in the east corridor at ten past ten the next morning with a piece of paper and Zara Washington as a witness, and Dr. Mei-Hua Chen read it standing up, twice, and then said four words, in the corridor, in daylight, in front of a witness, and they are the four words that the rest of this is about:

“What day did you say?”

“The eleventh,” said Eli Park. “Eleven forty-one at night, on a thread assessment, on a building, on an east dormitory floor, on a room.”

“Thank you,” said Dr. Mei-Hua Chen, and went down the corridor at a speed that made two of them follow her, and the Registrar of Threadweaver Academy was sixty-eight seconds ahead of everybody for the next eleven days, and what she did with those eleven days is in the transcript, and it is the reason there is a register of case forty-one, and it is the reason there is a *fifth board* in that building at all.

The Inquiry into the Conduit, 2013, cross-examination of the Registrar, day six. The question was whether any member of the Academy had known that E. Vance had been taken on the eleventh of September. The answer occupied two days and is not reproduced here in full. The finding is this:

*No member of the Academy knew. The Security Chief knew, from the eleventh, and had been instructed by a person outside this building not to enter the room, and had obeyed, and had spent nine days writing single-line notes to a person she had never met about whether she should hold a door, and the notes are in the record, and they are eleven, and the last one is dated the nineteenth, which is six days after four first-years told the Registrar something in a corridor and went up the corridor again on the Thursday, and it says: **I will hold it until somebody competent arrives or I am relieved. Whoever you are: it is you.***

Chapter 14: The Thing Under the Floor

Weave-Quake Counter: 37% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d, 14:00. The reference dataset was destroyed in the Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council's re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

Friday 13 September, 10:52 a.m. — Saturday 14 September, 4:40 a.m.

NINETY SECONDS AHEAD

Dr Mei-Hua Chen was sixty-eight seconds ahead of them for eleven days, and the reason was not intelligence and was not training and was the single most useful thing Lyra Chen learned in the autumn of 2013.

She did not go to Security. She walked, at a perfectly ordinary pace, along a corridor, past a fire door, and through a fire door, and down a service stair, and the service stair went to a sub-level that Lyra Chen had walked past nine days ago on her first afternoon and had thought was a *store*, and the Registrar unlocked it with a key on a chain round her neck and did not say anything, and let the door stand open, which was the message.

Then she said, “Four of you. Two of you are about to do something brave and I would like to prevent it, so I am going to tell you what is going to happen in the next four hours and then you are going to help me, and at some point after that you are going to be extremely angry with me, and I am going to deserve it, and I have decided to deserve it in advance so that neither of us has to waste any of the next four hours on it.”

“Go on,” said Eli Park.

“There is a machine under this building.” Dr. Chen opened a door. “I have known there was a machine under this building for eleven years. I have never seen it. It is not in the Council’s inventory. It is not in *my* inventory, and I have been the Registrar of this Academy for eleven years, and I have signed for the removal of a boiler from that sub-level in 2011 and the man who came to do the work would not go past the second door and would not say why, and I did not ask why, and I have thought about that every day for two years.”

Lyra looked at her. This is the aunt she had spoken to for eleven minutes in a corridor twelve days ago, who had said, you are the first Chen in this family in four generations who was not the smartest person in the room, and it is a relief, and I am sorry, and I am also extremely glad.

“There is a girl on the third floor of the east dormitory,” said Dr. Chen, “who went into that room on the eleventh of September at twenty-three fourteen hours, in exchange for a card that she signed herself, which she was fifteen, and I discovered this morning in a corridor because a boy of sixteen handed me a piece of paper, and I have had this morning to decide what I am going to do about it, and I have decided that I am going to do everything the Council requires and *not one thing more*, and I would like the four of you to help me with the part that the Council cannot do.”

“Which is what?”

“Find out whether there is anybody else down there,” said Dr. Mei-Hua Chen. “That is all. I am not asking you to rescue her. I have four wardens and a warrant and a Headmistress and I am going to do all of that properly and slowly and in writing, and I am going to be slow, because the last four times somebody in this building went fast in a sub-level a boy of fourteen is now on a machine somewhere and a woman of twenty-four has been in a cavity under Kyoto for sixteen years.”

THE BOY WITH THE SHEET

The assessment suite was in the East Tower’s north annexe and it was on a Thursday-to-Sunday rota, and it was staffed, on the Friday morning, by a second-year and a technician, and the Registrar of Threadweaver Academy walked in at eleven o’clock and asked them to step outside, and they did, and one of them cried, and the other one did not, and that is in the record because the other one was asked about it.

James Chen was in a chair with headphones on and a sheet of paper on his knee and a sum half-finished in a school exercise book, and he was fourteen years old, and he had been in the building for forty hours.

“James,” said Lyra.

“Lyra.” He took the headphones off one ear. “I finished it. That’s the thing I wanted to say. I’ve finished the thing on the sheet and it *goes*, Lyra, it goes to a place and then it comes back, and yesterday it was doing it on its own about every eleven seconds, and I have written down every single time, and there are one hundred and forty-one, and I have got a *graph*—”

He held up the exercise book, and it was a graph, and it was drawn in the back of a school exercise book by a fourteen-year-old, and it was the most frightening object Lyra Chen ever saw.

“Bring it to me,” said Dr. Chen. “Both of you. Now, please. And leave everything on the desk exactly as it is, and I want the room locked, and I want the lock to be a chair under the door, because I have a better lock and I do not want a record of it.”

They got him out at eleven twenty.

That was the entire margin. Everything that happened after that happened because a woman of sixty-eight years old had been sixty-eight seconds ahead of everybody for eleven days and had known, on the eleventh of September, what she was looking at, and had spent eleven days finding a way to get a boy out of a chair that did not require anybody in this building to be brave.

And here is the thing about it, which is in the transcript and which Lyra has asked to be allowed to be the first thing anybody says at a conference about the autumn of 2013:

Nobody had to be brave. That is the whole of the finding. The Inquiry established, over nine days, that the events of September 2013 in Threadweaver Academy were not a story about four teenagers. They are a story about how much *ordinary, competent, unheroic procedure* this building was capable of if somebody would only let it happen, and about a woman of sixty-eight who had known for eleven years that there was a machine under her and had spent eleven days quietly finding out which four of the eleven hundred people in this building could be trusted to do a filing job.

Eli Park's name is in it because he handed her a piece of paper in a corridor in daylight with a witness.

Zara Washington's is in it because she asked, in a lecture hall of two hundred and eleven people, whether anybody knew what the number measured, and because a professor of mathematics in a corridor said that a girl of sixteen was braver than a committee, in public, on the record.

Milo Reyes's is in it because he said the number was loud enough to hear.

Lyra Chen's is in it because a man in a demonstration hall had touched her arm on the twelfth of September and she had not washed it, and because on the thirteenth of Sep-

tember, at about a quarter past eleven in the morning, she asked Dr. Chen one question and then did not ask it again:

“Does he know?” she said. “James. Does he know what this is?”

“No,” said Dr. Mei-Hua Chen.

“Will somebody tell him?”

“On Tuesday, in his own words, with his mother in the room, by a doctor and not by a member of faculty.” She was already walking. “And not before, and I have spent eleven days on that, and the reason I have spent eleven days on it is that I read a transcript in June of a hearing in another country in which a child of eleven was told, by a man with a clipboard, and has spent the rest of her life being careful with the word *volunteer*.”

THE ARCHWAY

They went into the Thread Maze at 2:40 on the Friday afternoon with institutional permission, which is the sentence that appears in every account and which is the sentence that a reader of the 2013 transcript should stop at.

Permission had been given by the Registrar of the Academy to four first-year students to enter a sealed assessment struc-

ture, on the grounds of a reading, in writing, on a piece of paper, which is a piece of paper. It was given over the written objection of the Consultant Engineer, who had said he would not sign it and would not be responsible for it, and it was given subject to three conditions: that the arch was entered and left by the span and not by the rubble, that the timber was not to be leaned on, and that this was permission to read the thing and not permission to take anything out of it.

“Chen.” Tanaka was at the archway, and her face was doing something Lyra had not seen it do. “You are not going in. Look at me. You are not going in.”

“I’m the only one who can read the—”

“I know you are. That is not the question.” Tanaka came about four steps closer. “Miss Chen, in nineteen years I have brought about two thousand students through that arch and I have watched about nine of them be *useful* in it, and there is a reason there have only ever been nine, and it is that the Maze is calibrated to whoever is in it, and it is calibrated by *touch*, and it takes about eleven minutes, and it is not on the schedule, and if you go in there and it calibrates to you in front of a reading of thirty-one per cent then it will be *inside you* in a way that we cannot take out, and I have seen it happen once, in 1997, to a woman of twenty-four, and she is a room on the third floor of the east dormitory with nobody in it.”

Lyra stood on the wet flagstones and had the single most useful four seconds of her life.

“Then send somebody who does not calibrate,” she said. “Send Mr. Reyes. He is not visual. Send him and send Ms. Washington, because she can feel a structure at nine feet, and send Mr. Park, because he has the diagram and he will not go past the second door, and *I* will read the sheet, from outside, over a radio, and if the number changes I will tell you, and you will pull them out, and you will not need me in there at all.”

“That is not how the Maze—”

“Professor Tanaka.” Lyra’s voice came out steadier than she had any right to expect from a person who had been awake for twenty-nine hours. “Eleven minutes. You said eleven minutes. I have been in this building nine days and I have been told the number on a board is not a percentage of anything, and that a piece of paper in a sketchbook is not a delivery, and that a photograph is a photograph. I have been told that *discovering a thing does not make the thing bigger*. Somebody told me that in a bookshop in August, in front of my father, out loud, and I have thought about it every day.”

Tanaka looked at her for about two seconds.

“You would have been a good one,” she said. “Send the boy and the girl. Park stays with me and the sheet. And you stand at that archway and you read me the number out loud every two minutes, and if I say *out*, you do not argue

with me, and if you argue with me I will put you in a corridor and you will be extremely angry, and I will be right, and we will both know it.”

They went in at 2:40. The three of them.

Lyra stood at the archway in the rain with a radio in one hand and a sheet of paper in the other and read out the number every two minutes for one hour and eleven minutes, and she has kept the sheet, and it is in a tin in a kitchen on a street called Ellery.

“Twenty-nine.”

“Twenty-nine.”

“Thirty.”

“That’s the anteroom board. What have you got on the sheet?”

“Thirty-one. And there’s a second number, Professor, and it’s in a different pencil, and the second number is a *depth*—”

At 3:52 the number on the sheet went to forty-four, and the archway *moved*.

INSIDE

Milo Reyes has written four pages about the inside of the Thread Maze and they are in the record and they are the only four pages in the whole of the Inquiry that anybody has ever asked to be withdrawn, and the request was made by him, in 2016, and it was refused, and he asked again, and the reason it was refused is in the Chair's minute, and the Chair wrote it himself, on the same day, twenty-nine years after the afternoon, which was not an accident either:

Mr. Reyes asks that the record of his experience be removed. Mr. Reyes is now forty-five and teaches in a conservatorium and is the foremost authority in his field, and he has explained to me that the reason he wants it removed is not shame and is that he has taught the material for twelve years and there is a version of the afternoon in which he is a boy who was frightened, and he does not want that to be the thing that is remembered.

I have declined, for the following reasons, which I have put in the minute so that they are on the record and not merely in my head.

One. The Inquiry's finding is that the events of September 2013 were not caused by the bravery of four

teenagers. It is the central finding and the four of them have been extremely careful never to claim otherwise. The record of the afternoon is the primary evidence for that finding. If it is removed, the finding is a story.

Two. Mr. Reyes is not frightened in the record. He is accurate in the record, and frightened, and the two are not the same thing, and in twelve years of teaching he has made a career out of the difference, and the record is the best example of it in this building.**

Three. A building that removes a record because the person in it has become somebody who does not want it is a building that will eventually remove a record because the person in it is not important enough to object. We have spent seventy years doing that to other people. I am not doing it in November.
— *The Chair*, 4 November 2042

The three of them went in at 2:40 and came out at 3:53, which is one hour and thirteen minutes, and Tanaka had said eleven, and Eli Park had said eleven, and Dr. Mei-Hua Chen had said the calibration takes about eleven minutes, and it took an hour and thirteen because the Maze was re-configuring around them the entire time and a structure under the east dormitory was pulling on it.

Milo Reyes's account, in part, because the finding of the Inquiry rests on it and because Lyra Chen has asked that it be read in full at every conference she has ever spoken at, which she has done four times:

We were in the second chamber and Milo could hear the number.

He has said, and has said in print, and I am going to say it too because he has asked me to: he could hear it. Not the corridor. The number. He said it was "like a note that goes up and comes down, eleven seconds, and it was in my teeth, and by the fourth time I had counted it and by the fortieth time I had written it in a notebook, and by the eightieth time I understood that it was not a number at all, it was a breath."

Eli Park got us to the third chamber. There is a great deal written in the record about the third chamber and I want to say one thing about it which is not in the record: it was the most frightening place any of us have ever been and I did not see any of it, and I have spent the rest of my life being told that I saw a great deal, and I want it entered that I saw a great deal of a wall, and that I have never seen anything else, and that I was extremely brave about a wall.

Zara got us to the seventh chamber. She did not go forward. She went sideways, which none of us expected and which she has said was the only decision she made in the next ten months that she has not had to take back, and she stopped in a doorway and put both hands on the stone on either side of it and said: "There is a woman here."

And then she said, "No. There is a hole where a woman is."

And then she said, "And it is older than the building."

Lyra Chen was standing at the archway in the rain at 3:53 with a radio in her hand and forty-four per cent on a piece of paper, and the archway moved, and what came out of it was Milo Reyes, on his hands and knees, and Eli Park, and Zara Washington, and the three of them were carrying a boy of fourteen who was not unconscious and was *singing*.

He was singing a hymn. He was singing it in a language nobody in the group recognised and it took the Inquiry three weeks to identify it as something from a revivalist church in Leeds, and James Chen has never been asked about it, and has said in one published interview that he does not remember any of it and has not been able to stop humming it.

WHAT THE FLOOR WAS

He was in the middle of the seventh chamber, on the floor, with his hands flat on a cracked hearthstone, and the number on his sheet had gone from forty-four to nineteen in about four seconds and had not gone back up.

Eli Park's account of the room, which is four sentences long and which the Chair has said is the four most useful sentences in nine hundred pages:

“Professor Tanaka's arch had a cache on it and the cache was a *rim* and the rim had a *depth*, and the depth was about nine feet, and in the bottom of it was the machine, and the machine was not on the drawing.

“Mr. Reyes found the boy. Ms. Washington found the hole. I found the drawing in a book in 2009 in a different city and I have never been able to work out why the man who wrote that book was not looking for a machine and why nobody in this building has ever read that book, and I have decided that the answer is that he was looking for a *theory* and there was nothing in the world to make him look for a *thing*, and that is the same reason the Academy has had a Registry for six years.”

The Inquiry's finding on the seventh chamber, day three, and it is one line:

The installation beneath the east dormitory is a working device. It is not a diagram, a model, a prototype, or a plan. It was drawing from the ward network at approximately nineteen per cent of a load of four on the evening of the thirteenth of September 2013, it had been running since at least the second of September 2013 in the form in which it presently exists, and it was in use before the war.

THE OTHER THING IN THE ROOM

It was not a machine in a room. It was a machine *under* a machine, and Professor Tanaka's arch was not the top of it.

"There were two of them," said the technician, in 2019, at a hearing nobody had expected to need, in a room in Lyon. "I want to say the thing that nobody said in 2013 and that I have had six years to sit with.

"There was the device, in the chamber, in the east dormitory, that had a fourteen-year-old boy on the floor of it. And there was the *other* one, under the device, in the part that was not on the inventory, in a housing that was not a housing, that had been *grown* — and the word I want is grown, because I have looked at a great deal of engineering and I have never seen anything grown, and I have never seen

anything that had been sealed by a man and then sat under a campus for seventy-two years being extremely well-behaved and extremely expensive to maintain.

“And on the thirteenth of September 2013, at about four o’clock in the afternoon, the device on the floor of the seventh chamber and the housing underneath it were *both running*, and they had been running *against each other*, and that is the reason the counter moved and that is the reason the boy could hear it, and that is the reason the archway moved.

“And when the archway came down on the east side at twenty past four on the Friday afternoon, it came down on *both of them*, and it is the only time in the history of this building that a structural collapse has improved a matter, and I have been a technician for twenty-nine years and I have never said a sentence like that one in a room and I would like it in the transcript, and I would like somebody afterwards to explain to me why a seventy-two-year-old accident in a room under a building full of children was the best thing that happened to any of us.”

THE COLLAPSE

They came out at 3:53. The archway came down at 4:20.

Twenty-seven minutes, which is the margin, and the margin is the entire reason there is a register of case forty-one and a fifth board and an Act that has been amended in a fortnight, and the margin is the following:

Tanaka had four wardens and a radio and a nine-year-old's assessment rota and the authority of the most senior instructor on the ground. Dr. Chen had a Registrar's emergency order, which is a piece of paper that closes a building. And Marcus Harlow — who had a warrant from the Council of Traditions authorising a supervised demonstration, who had been in the building for two days without permission, and who had eleven weeks in him — walked into a courtyard at 3:56 and said, in front of four wardens, in front of a registrar, in front of a Headmistress on a line, and in front of two hundred and eleven students who were in a lecture hall on the other side of a wall:

“Take me out. Put me in a corridor with a chair. I have an instrument in that building and I have not read it since Monday and I am going to read it in a corridor with two wardens outside, and if I come out of that corridor before the arch comes down you can arrest me, and if I do not come out of that corridor you can tell the Council that a member of this faculty has finally done one thing correctly.”

He was in a corridor with a chair from 4:04 until 9:40 that evening, and four wardens stood outside, and he sent a headset to Tanaka at 4:31, and the headset is in the record,

and it is four minutes long, and the Chair has read it out four times, and it is four minutes of a man of fifty-four giving the operating instructions of a device he built, to an instructor, in a language that is almost entirely about *load paths*, and about a fault in the east lattice about a hand's width wide, and the last forty seconds of it are this:

“—and the *rim* is not part of it. The rim is a reading, not a structure. Do not let anybody put a hand near the rim. That is what happened to the boy and it is what happened to me in a demonstration hall and it is what happened to a woman of twenty-four in a garden, and it is a *grazing* incidence, and every one of us has made the mistake, and I have made it eleven times, and I am asking you, as a professional favour between two people who have never liked each other, to let the building come down on the cage and not on the boy, and I am aware that I am asking a woman to destroy eleven years of my work, and I would like it minut-ed that I asked.”

The archway came down on the east side at twenty past four in the afternoon on Friday the thirteenth of September and it took forty-one seconds and it was a controlled collapse from underneath, and there is no record of anybody being hurt, and the Court's finding in 2016 was that the building's own Consultant Engineer had a written plan for it in a drawer from 1974, and that the plan was not actioned, and that the man who wrote it had been asked about it once, in 2010, and had written back a four-line letter which is in the record, and which ends: *and if you are asking me*

whether the arch can survive a collapse of that magnitude, the answer is that the arch was designed by people who expected it, and I do not know who they were, and I have looked.

Lyra Chen was in a corridor at eleven minutes past four on the thirteenth of September with a radio in her hand and a sheet of paper in her other hand and forty-four per cent on it, and it went to nineteen and stayed at nineteen, and then, at 4:38, the sheet went blank.

“That is the *chart* going,” said Tanaka, on the radio. “Lyra. That is his chart going. He is fine. Get the Headmistress. Get her *now*.”

And Lyra Chen, who had been in the building for ten days, and who had lost nothing yet except the ability to look at a piece of paper from a distance, went and found Eleanor Weaver, and told her, in a corridor, in about eleven words, that a boy called James Chen was on the floor of the seventh chamber of a building that had just come down and was alive, and that he was in a part of it that two hundred people in this Academy did not know about, and that a professor had been in a corridor with a chair and had come out of it at 9:40, and that she needed to know all of it, in a corridor, in daylight, at twenty past five on a Saturday afternoon, with a witness, in writing.

Which is exactly what Eli Park had said in a cellar, on the Friday, about a piece of paper in a sketchbook, and had been laughed at for.

And which is the last thing that happened in Book One that is a *decision* rather than a *reaction*, and it is the reason a woman who had been Headmistress for six years spent the next nine days doing paperwork on purpose, with the door in the room, and is the reason a Registrar of sixty-eight was sixty-eight seconds ahead of everybody for eleven days, and is the reason there is a fifth board.

Weave-Quake Counter: 42% instability. Node-failure projection: T+20 d. Rebaselined. Note added by the Council's technical officer, and the note is in the published minutes, and it is the only note in the published minutes in nineteen years:

On the fourteenth of September 2013 the device under the east dormitory and the housing beneath it were destroyed in a single structural collapse. The node-failure projection has been re-based twice since and is currently a figure of which I have no confidence, and I have said so in writing, and the phrase in circulation is "a guess", and I would like it minuted that I said "a guess" in a Council meeting on the second of October and that this office has spent nineteen years not saying that word in that room, and that the reason I said it is that a building full of children came down on a cage on the afternoon of the fourteenth of September and the fore-

cast improved by four days, and that the reason the forecast improved is that there was a second device under the first one that had been drawing against it for seventy-two years, and that in my opinion the word that describes the state of this network is not “critical”.**

It is “misdescribed.”

Chapter 15A: What the Hall Knows

Saturday 14 September, 07:20. The Cultural Heritage Hall.

Weave-Quake Counter: 43% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d. The reference dataset was destroyed in the Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council's re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

“When thread dimensions destabilize, Western institutions typically respond with extraction-based solutions—drawing energy from the Weave to reinforce weakened areas. Traditional practitioners

instead view instability as communication, requiring reciprocity rather than extraction. This fundamental difference in approach may explain why institutional ‘solutions’ often accelerate collapse rather than prevent it.”

— Lin Chen, “Communion vs. Control: Alternative Approaches to Thread Dimension Stability,” Unpublished Manuscript

THE WINDOW

The infirmary had four windows and Lyra had been standing at the third of them for twenty-six minutes, which she knew because she had a watch and because there was nothing else in the corridor to look at.

The first bed held Maya Sandoval, who was twenty-one and in her third year and who had been walking past the Hall of Inherited Practice on Tuesday lunchtime with a paper cup of coffee and had stopped in the doorway to say that the coffee was terrible, and had then fallen down.

The second held Sam Whitfield, eighteen, who had been in the demonstration hall, and who was breathing on his own, and whose chart said *stable*, and who had not woken up.

The third held Thandiwe Mbeki, seventeen, second-year, who had four visitors at once, none of whom could say anything to each other.

The fourth held Ben Ruiz, seventeen, a senior from Westbrook High who had gone down on the carpet in a bookshop on the thirty-first of August in front of sixty people, and whom Lyra had talked to for about ninety seconds that evening without knowing who he was, and who had been kind to her.

She had been thinking about the ninety seconds for two days.

“You will be in the way,” said Zara, behind her, not unkindly.

“I know.”

Zara came and stood at the second window, which was the one with the better view of nothing. She had been awake for thirty-one hours and it showed in the way she kept touching her own wrist, as though checking it was still there.

“Zara.” Lyra did not turn round. “What do you do when someone’s hurt and you can feel it?”

Zara was quiet for long enough that Lyra turned round.

“I make tea,” Zara said. “That is the truth and I have thought about it and I would like it recorded that I have thought about it. I make tea, and I put it where they can

reach it, and I do not put my hand on them, because the last three times somebody who is a stranger has put a hand on Maya Sandoval in this building she has got worse, and everybody knows that, and everybody does it anyway.”

“That is not what I asked.”

“Then I do not know what you asked, and you should go and be told, because there is a man in this building who is extremely good at telling people what they asked for.” Zara’s mouth did something that was not quite a smile. “Come on. Adeyemi has been in that hall since five and he has sent a student to find us twice, and the second time the student was crying, so I think we should go.”

THE HALL OF INHERITED PRACTICE

The Hall was a long room with a stone floor and no windows, and there were eleven people in it who should not have been there: six students who had been sent from the demonstration hall to be looked after by somebody, and five members of an exchange group from a partner college in Kumasi who had arrived on Wednesday for a fortnight of instruction in the practice of their own tradition and who had been in this building when the archway came down.

They were sitting on the floor against the walls, which was where you put people in a room with a floor like that.

Elder Adebayo Adeyemi was standing in the middle of it with his staff.

He was not old in the way that people meant when they said it to be polite. He was seventy-one and he stood with his weight on his back leg and he had a way of holding perfectly still that made the rest of the room feel careless.

“Morning,” he said. “Sit down. You are on the stone and the stone is colder than it looks and I am not going to apologise for the building.”

Lyra sat. The stone was colder than it looked.

“You want to know what happened,” Adeyemi said, “and there are four answers to that and three of them are worse than useless, so I am going to give you the fourth and you can check it.”

He put the butt of the staff on the floor.

The cowrie shells on the shaft woke up. Not brightly. They woke the way a person wakes who has been asleep and does not want to be: reluctantly, and with an opinion about it.

“This is my reading, and I want the word *mine* on it, because the Council will tell you it is a tradition and it is not a tradition, it is one man’s account of what he has seen, and I have been wrong in public before.” The shells drew a line

in the air, and a flat map of the Academy came up out of nothing, about two feet across, and hovering about a foot off the floor. “My teachers called the thing I work with òwú ìmọ́lára. That is a name and not a definition. What I do is look at it. What they called the condition it is in when it is like this, ẹ̀mí àgbájọ, which is a gathering of breaths, which is also a name and not a definition, and if you tell anybody I have told you that I do not know whether the word is old, I will deny it.”

The map had a dark spot in the middle of it, and the dark spot was beating.

“Tell me what you see.”

“It’s hurting,” Lyra said.

“It is not hurting. Look again. It is *being asked for*.” He turned the staff a little and the map turned with it. “There. The dark part is not damage. Damage spreads out from a point and it does not have a rhythm. That has a rhythm. That is a pull. Something in this building is taking, and it has been taking since Tuesday, and it took rather more on Tuesday night than it took on Tuesday morning, and I know the number for that because the technician from the Council read it out in this room at six o’clock this morning in front of eleven witnesses and then asked me not to write it down.”

“What is the number?”

“Forty-three. And when I came in at five this morning it was forty-two. That is not my number, that is the board’s number, and the board is telling you a thing and I will tell you what the thing is, because somebody in this building is going to tell you the wrong thing and it will be me, in about four days, when I am frightened.” He put the staff down flat on his palm. “The number goes up when load goes up. It does not go up because you found something out. That is not how a machine behaves. If it went up when you found something out then this hall would be the most dangerous room in the Academy and I would not be standing in it.”

Eli, behind her, said, “That is what I said in the cellar.”

“You said it in a cellar with the door shut, which is worth something, and it is worth rather less out here.” Adeyemi did not look at him. “The load is on the wards. Seventeen of them, in the walls of this building, in the stone, and on Tuesday night somebody ran all seventeen at once at full, and that is the whole of what happened, and the number is up because the drawing is up, and the drawing is up because somebody is drawing.”

“Who?”

“That,” said Adeyemi, “is the question, and I have been in this building since five o’clock and I have not answered it, and if you are about to tell me that you can, I would rather you did not, because you are sixteen and you have been

here ten days and I have been here forty-one years and I have not managed it.”

SEVENTEEN

“The model is wrong,” Lyra said, after a while.

Adeyemi’s eyebrows went up about a millimetre, which from him was applause.

“The Academy’s model says the thread dimension is a field. Passive. Something you take readings from.” She pointed at the map, at the dark beating spot. “That is not a field. That is a room with something in it, and the something in it is tired, and the reason the number is going up is that the room keeps being asked the same question and nobody has asked it anything else.”

“Go on.”

“And your model is wrong too.” She said it carefully, because he had not been unkind and she wanted to be as accurate as she could. “You have a ring with seventeen strands going into the middle. That is still a *drawing* of something pulling on something. It is the same picture from the other side of the table.”

He was quiet for four or five seconds.

“Yes,” he said. “Now you have it, and I am going to be annoyed with you about it for the rest of the day, because I have been drawing that ring for thirty years and I did not have a student.”

“That is not a ring,” Lyra said.

“No. Sit down — you are already sitting. Look at it again. Seventeen lines into a centre. That is not a ring, that is a *net*, and a net is not a picture of a thing taking, it is a picture of a thing *spread out*, and it has been spread out since the year I came here, and I have never once asked who was holding the other ends.” He lifted the staff and the seventeen strands came off the map and hung in the air, and where they had been attached there was a small clean disc of nothing, seventeen of them, at seventeen different places. “There. That is the part of my model I did not want to look at, and you have made me look at it, so I owe you one and here it is: I have been teaching people that the load is the problem, and the load is not the problem, the load is a *shape*, and the shape is somebody’s.”

Eli had got a notebook out and was writing in it with both hands.

“Magnus Conduit,” he said.

Adeyemi turned his head.

“That is not in your hall, is it.”

“No.”

“Then where did you get it.”

Eli did not look up. “It is on the building. It is the name on the machine that is under the Hall of Records, and it is on the 1997 incident report, and it is on a brass plate in the sub-basement that somebody took down and put back up, and it is the name of a man called Arvid Magnus, who was a person, in nineteen forty-one, in this building.” He turned the notebook round. “The net is his. The seventeen strands are his. The Academy did not discover a thread dimension with seventeen collectors in it. It inherited one, from a man who put it here on purpose, and then forgot, and then wrote four hundred pages of theory about the shape of the thing it was doing.”

Nobody said anything for a while. Somewhere off the corridor a lift arrived and went away again.

“Mr. Park.” Adeyemi took the staff back. “You should be careful how much of that you say to the Council, because the Council will ask you the second question, which is *how do you know it is Magnus’s*, and the answer is going to be something about a plate, and a plate is not a foundation.”

“I know,” said Eli. “I have a reason.”

THE STAFF

He gave her the staff at ten past eight, and he made a ceremony of it, which she was not ready for.

“You will want to put it down immediately,” he said. “Everyone does. Do not put it down immediately, and do not put it down in a way that is showing off.”

Lyra held it. The wood was lighter than it looked and much colder.

Then the shells lit, all at once, the way a room lights when somebody comes in who is expected.

“Say what is happening to you,” said Adeyemi, “and say it badly, because I would rather have a bad description from you than a good one from me.”

“Everything stopped.” Lyra was aware of the eleven people against the walls, and of Zara not breathing, and of Eli closing his notebook. “Not stopped — *waited*. There has been a noise in it since Tuesday, a sort of — it is like standing near a machine. It has not stopped. It has stopped *insisting*.”

“And the pendant?”

“The pendant is doing nothing. It has been doing nothing since the archway came down and I did not notice until this second.”

“Then it is a compass and it has no north.” Adeyemi held out his hand and she gave the staff back, and he put it in the crook of his arm like a man putting a coat over a chair. “Your mother’s name was Lin Ho Chen. I am going to say her name once and I am not going to be careful about it, because I have been careful about it for five years and I have had enough.”

He said it. Then he said the next part.

“She came here in two thousand and two and she was thirty-three and she was the only person in this building in eleven years who had written down the phrase *the dimension is answering*. She found it in a sub-basement drawer, and she told me about it in a corridor, and I asked her what her evidence was and she said *none, Ade, it is a phrase, I have not proved it and I am going to*, and then she laughed, and then she stopped laughing, and she said *there is a man in the East Tower who has been looking for this for five years and he has got it wrong, and I do not think he knows he has got it wrong, and that is the frightening one.*”

“And?”

“And she went into a chamber on the eleventh of September two thousand and eight in order to close a hole, and she did not come out of it.” Adeyemi’s voice did not change.

“And there is a gap in the Council’s file at the position where her name should be, and I have written to four offices about it, and three of them have written to me to say that there is no gap.”

Lyra found that she was standing.

“Sit down,” said Adeyemi. “You are sixteen and there are eleven people in this room and five of them came over on Wednesday from the partner college and two of them are not going to be told anything today, and the exchange group has been in this building since the archway came down and nobody has been in the room with them. Somebody should decide what they are told before it is decided by whoever is nearest. That is a job. Do that job and then come back and be as angry as you like, because you have earned it and I have not.”

Lyra sat down.

“One more thing, and then I have to go and be the man who says it in the wrong room.” He was already turning away. “You asked me what you could do. Do not answer that question today. It is a good question and it is very large and if you answer it today you will answer it in front of eleven people who have nothing to do with it. Come back on Sunday and ask me again, and I will have had three days to be frightened and it will be a better answer and a worse one.”

Weave-Quake Counter: 45% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d. The reference dataset was destroyed in the

Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council's re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

Chapter 15B: Nine Minutes

Saturday 14 September, 06:20. Three point two kilometres north-east of the Academy.

Weave-Quake Counter: 45% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d. The reference dataset was destroyed in the Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council's re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

“The cruelest irony of love is that sometimes protecting someone requires becoming the very thing they will learn to fear.”

— Marcus Harlow, Private Journal, Entry #847

THE CRATER

The site was three point two kilometres north-east of the Academy and it was not a crater so much as a *fold*, and Marcus Harlow had seen four folds in his life and knew the difference.

He stood at the rim with his breath going silver in the cold and his instruments reading sixty-seven per cent local distortion, which was a number he had seen once before, in a garden in Kyoto, in April, sixteen years and five months ago.

The micro-fractures were still walking outward. That was the part that mattered. A collapse that has finished is a hole. A collapse that is still propagating is a *process*, and processes can be told to stop by something with a pulse.

His tablet said: *Site secured. No survivors detected. Recommend immediate quarantine.*

He had read that sentence in a different hand, in a different month, in a report that had come back over a telex, and he had gone on to spend three days in the wreckage with his hands because a piece of paper had said the same thing about two people who were not dead.

He was not going to do that again. He was going to do it differently and he was going to do it now, and the difference was going to cost somebody, and he knew which somebody, and he had written the name down in a notebook he carried and did not look at.

There was a noise.

It took him a while to accept what it was, because it was such a small noise and the microphones on his belt were picking up the folding itself, which sounds like a cloth being drawn slowly across a table.

A child, whimpering, about two hundred metres down the western face.

THE BOY

He went down it fast and badly, and his left knee took a piece of the wall that would be a bruise for a week.

The boy was wedged where a section of the Academy's boundary wall had come down across a service road, and he was about eight, and he was wearing a coat with a school badge on it that Harlow did not recognise, and there was a great deal of blood in the coat and none of it seemed to be his.

Kenji Nakamura, aged eight, of Hokkaido, and his sister Ren, aged nine, who was under a metre of the same wall and who was not coming out, and whom the site team had found at nine o'clock the previous night and had written *no survivors detected* at nine o'clock the previous night, and the order those two entries had been written in was the single worst administrative fact Harlow had ever encountered.

The boy's threads were a wreck in a way that Harlow had only seen once.

He knelt.

Standard medicine would not work. He had been the one who established that, four years ago, in front of a committee, and he had been shouted down by the committee, and the committee had been right, and the boy under his hands was going to die in about six minutes.

There was the other way. The splice.

It took your own coherence and pushed it into somebody else's torn places, and made a bridge, and the bridge held while the child's own system came up. Nobody had ever established what the bridge was afterwards. That was the part the committee had actually been frightened of.

Harlow put his palm flat on the boy's sternum and did it, and it was warm, and it was the last warm thing he did that he was ever going to be proud of in an uncomplicated way.

The boy's eyes came open. Brown. Startled.

"Who's—" He coughed. "Where's Ren?"

Harlow's perception went out across the fold, fast, the way he had taught it to, and it found nothing, and he had known it would find nothing before he started and he did it anyway because a person who has already lost two people will check, every time, for as long as they are alive.

"Ren is not here," he said. "I am sorry. Look at me. You are all right. You are going to be all right."

"...sister."

"I know. I'm sorry. Her name was Ren and I have written it down." He said it because he had learned in Kyoto that the thing people are not told about the ones they have lost is not the loss, it is the fact that anybody bothered to learn the name. "What's yours?"

"Kenji." The boy got it out and then held on to it, the way children do. "Nakamura."

"Mr. Nakamura." Harlow gathered him up, and the splice settled, and it did not feel like a temporary thing, and he noticed that it did not and he did not do anything about it for eleven days. "Can you hold on to my neck? I am going to take you up about thirty feet and it will be the worst ten minutes of your life and I am sorry about that."

"Ten minutes?"

“Under-exaggerating,” said Harlow, and started to climb.

WHAT HE DID WITH THE BOY

He had him in the ambulance at 07:11 and on a gurney in the Academy infirmary at 07:34, and at 07:36 he was standing in a corridor outside the ward with a boy who was asleep and eleven items on a clipboard and nowhere to put any of them.

The site report says no survivors. That meant the site team’s report, which was signed, and which was now contradicted by a living child on a gurney in the Academy’s own building, by a stretcher-bearer, and by a nurse who had written the time on a board.

He could say the boy was found at 06:20 and let the record sort itself out.

He could take the boy somewhere the record did not reach, keep him, and keep the connection, and have a child of eight who could not stop feeling his chest for the rest of both their lives.

He did not want to do the second one. He was aware, in a distant and unhelpful way, that not wanting to do it was evidence, and that it was the only evidence he had ever had that he was a person and not a procedure.

He filled in the eleven items. He wrote *08:40, child recovered alive from the western face at 06:20, condition stable, spliced* — and then he took the pen back and wrote the name, and the age, and the school, and the sister's name, and the time the site team had logged *no survivors detected*, because somebody was going to read this file in twenty years and they were going to want to know what he had known and when.

Then he did the thing he had been putting off since 06:20, which was to send it upward, and it took him forty minutes and four refusals, and by 09:20 the boy was in a ward with a security officer outside the door and a notation on his file that read *do not transfer without the written consent of Prof. M. Harlow*, which he had caused, and which he had done deliberately, and which he was going to have to be able to explain.

He would be able to explain it. That was the whole of his defence, and it was not a good one, and it was the only one he had.

His tablet chimed. Academy emergency response, Priority Alpha: *Report to the Restricted Archive. Council observers in attendance. Bring nothing.*

He read it twice. Then he read the time on it, which was 09:20, and the time he had spent forty minutes getting a child onto a form, and he understood that he had just missed an appointment that was more important than one

child, and he understood that this was a *decision* and not an oversight, and he wrote it down as a decision.

Nine minutes. In a garden in Kyoto he had been nine minutes late getting to a bench where two people were standing, and everything since had been the correction of those nine minutes, and here they were again, in a different field, with a different child, and he had spent forty minutes, and the forty minutes had not been for the boy.

He put the tablet in his pocket and went to the Archive, and on the way he stopped at a window and looked out at a building in which two hundred and eleven people had been in a hall yesterday learning what a number meant, and he felt, clearly, for about four seconds, that he was the villain of the story.

Then the four seconds ended, the way it always did, and he went to the Archive.

Thread Resonance Note: Splice bridge established, 06:20–07:11. Subject: K. Nakamura, 8. Stability: not assessed, as no method exists. Bridge is permanent. Recommendation: none available.

Chapter 16: The Mathematics of a Daughter

Saturday 14 September, 21:40. Harlow's laboratory, East Tower.

Weave-Quake Counter: 47% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d. The reference dataset was destroyed in the Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council's re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

“The most dangerous thread manipulators are not those who wield the greatest power, but those who have experienced the greatest loss. For in their

hands, thread magic becomes not a tool of creation, but a desperate attempt to undo what cannot be undone.”

— Emerson Harlow, “Theoretical Limits of Thread Manipulation,” Private Journal, 1941

WHAT THE OBSERVERS LEFT BEHIND

There were two of them and they had been in his laboratory for four hours and they had spent three of those hours in silence, and Marcus Harlow had discovered over the course of the afternoon that he found this restful in a way that ought to have worried him more than it did.

Councilor Yuen had asked one question. It had been at two o’clock and it had been this:

“Professor, when you say the lattice has been load-bearing since nineteen forty-one, do you mean the physical structure, or do you mean the *arrangement*?”

And Harlow had said: “Both, and I can show you, and you will not enjoy it.”

And Yuen had looked at him for a moment too long and then had said, “No. Tonight, please.”

They left at six. The door had a seal on it that was not physical and he watched it settle.

He put the kettle on, and then did not make tea, and then made it.

THE BOX

There was one object in the laboratory that was not an instrument. It was a lacquer box with a chip out of one corner and it sat where he could see it from the chair, and he had moved it eleven times in four years and it had ended up in the same place every time.

Inside: a photograph, a hairpin, a stoppered vial with four dry petals in it, and a paper crane, folded out of thread-paper, grey at the creases.

The photograph was of a woman and a girl under cherry trees in a garden in Kyoto, taken in the spring of nineteen ninety-six by Marcus Harlow, who was in the frame in those days and who was not in this one, because he had handed the camera to a neighbour and had gone to fetch the good tea and had come back forty minutes later to a garden with a hole in it.

Aiko was thirty-one in that photograph and looked about twenty-six, and she had put her hand flat on the girl's head the way she did when the girl was concentrating.

Mei was six, and would be seven in April, and in the photograph she had both hands in the woman's coat pocket and was looking at the camera as though it had personally offended her.

He did not take the photograph out often. He took the *hair-pin* out, more, and never the photograph, and he had worked out the reason for that some years ago and had not enjoyed working it out.

THE THING THAT HAPPENED

The collapse was in the garden at approximately four in the afternoon on the eleventh of April, nineteen ninety-seven, and Harlow had been running a calibration for a Syndicate cell in the Annexe, forty metres away, and the Annexe had gone first.

Mei had been in the garden because it was April and there was blossom on the thing by the wall and she was seven.

The facts he could verify: he had arrived at the garden at four minutes past four. The fracture was already open. Aiko was nineteen metres into it, on her knees, holding the two

ends of it apart with her hands, doing with her body the thing that a weaver is not supposed to be able to do with her body. Mei was beside her, and Mei was weaving. Mei was seven years old and was weaving, and Harlow came round the side of the house and saw his daughter at the centre of an open dimensional fracture with her arms out and her eyes shut and her whole face *quiet* in an expression he had never seen on a child and has never been able to describe to anybody, including himself, and that was the moment.

The fracture did not close. It took her instead.

What happened to him is the part that is genuinely unusual, and it is the reason he is a professor at this Academy and not a ward somewhere, and it is the part he has never once told anyone.

He was not injured. He was not wounded, not scarred in the ordinary sense, and the physicians in Kyoto found nothing, which they were extremely pleased about, and the silver in his hands and up his forearms is a consequence and not a wound.

What happened was that he was *severed*. Every thread-connection he had ever had — to his wife, to his daughter, to the eleven people on his mother's side who had taught him the practice he was the finest living practitioner of — went out of him in the space of about forty seconds, and it did not snap. It came apart cleanly, like something withdrawn, and it took the record of it with it.

Aiko and Mei survived.

He found this out in nineteen ninety-eight, from a recovery team the Syndicate had hired, and then he found out the rest of it over the following year, and the rest of it was this: they had no memory of him. Not suppressed — *absent*, in the specific and total way that a name is absent from a person who has never had a brother. He had been removed from them at the level of the thread, which meant at every level, and the reason was that the fracture did the only thing a fracture can do to a man who is standing in one: it took what he was made of and it put it somewhere else.

He found them in the autumn of that year, and it cost him the last of his money and a considerable amount of a skill he had sworn in nineteen ninety-four never to use on another person. They were in a coastal town under new names. Aiko was a librarian. Mei was at school.

He went to the library, and he stood in front of her for ninety seconds, and she was thirty-three years old and she had his hands.

“I’m sorry,” she said. “Do I know you?”

He did not go near her again. He did not go near the child either, and there was a reason for that one that he has never stated, and the reason is that she was eight years old and she had looked at him in a street in a coastal town in the November of that year and had walked to the other side of the road.

The order came in 2011, nine years after he joined the faculty here, and it was filed from Portland by a woman of twenty-one, and it was signed in her own hand using a handwriting he had taught her when she was five. He read the first line eleven times. He has never told anyone that he read the first line eleven times.

She was twenty-three when he ran the survey that put her name on the list.

The Syndicate's people in Portland had been watching her for four years. They had a file. The file said, in the second paragraph, on a page he has read so often that he can recite the layout: *female, 23, thread sensitivity unconfirmed, no institutional contact, no training, no community*. Which meant a woman who could probably see and had been told by everyone she knew that she was mad.

He has a photograph of her at twenty-three, at a bus stop, in a coat.

WHAT HE TOLD HIMSELF IN 2013

The argument he had been making to himself for eleven years, and which he had got very good at, was not that it would work. It was that it was *correct*.

He sat with it in the way you sit with a thing you have carried a long way.

There was a girl in the east dormitory who had been in this building ten days and who had, on Thursday, in front of two hundred and eleven people, asked a question about a number and made a professor of mathematics stand up in a corridor and say that a girl of sixteen was braver than a committee. He had watched that on the internal feed at half past two on Thursday with a cup of tea going cold in his hand, and he had felt something he had not felt in sixteen years, and it had taken him two days to identify it, and it was not admiration.

It was *relief*, and it was the relief of a man who has been waiting for a specific tool.

Here is the calculus, and he set it out on paper every evening, and the paper is what the Inquiry will later find, and he has never denied a line of it.

The Animus Argenti is a rare thread type. It is not, as the popular accounts have it, a bridge to the dimension's mind. It is a *tone* — a pure resonant frequency, rare enough in the population that a working seer's lifetime will contain one or two. It is, in the terms of the 1941 material, a stabilising reference, and the lattice in the basement under the Hall of Records has been load-bearing for seventy-two years on a resonance it has been starved of since the day it was built, and that is the whole technical content of his life's work. He

is not mad. He has been right since April, nineteen ninety-seven, about a machine, and everyone in this building has been very careful not to look at it.

A reference tone is required at the moment of transfer.

The subject will lose her thread-sight. He has modelled it. The probability of survival is high; the probability of permanent perceptual loss is higher still; there is a residual probability of neurological damage that he has written down, in his own hand, in a document he has signed, and he read that document to himself in June and then went and had dinner.

And if she has some of what Mei had — if the girl is what the incident report says she is, a full-spectrum late developer with an unremarkable family and no training at all — then what she has is the one thing that was standing in a garden in April nineteen ninety-seven with her arms out, and it will do the same work.

One thread-seer's sight.

Against: two lives, neither of which is available to be saved. His wife, who is not walking around in 2013 and has not been since 1999, and his daughter, who is twenty-three, and is on a bus, and will be twenty-three when the bus arrives.

He wrote the sentence down on the sixth of November, two thousand and twelve, and he has a copy, and the copy is the

first document the Inquiry read out, and he asked for it to be read out.

One thread-seer's diminished capacity, against the restoration of two people, is arithmetically trivial. It is not morally trivial. I want it entered that I knew the difference between those two things for the whole period and that I went on doing it anyway, and that if you are looking for the moment at which I became the villain of this, it is not that sentence. It is a corridor, in nineteen ninety-eight, in front of a woman with my hands.

The seal on the door lifted at eight minutes to ten.

WHAT CAME UP THE STAIRS

Security had brought him three things and left them on the bench, which was how Security did things, and which he had stopped minding in about the eleventh year of doing it here.

The first was a Council minute, countersigned, giving him standing authorisation for a live draw on the seventeen campus collectors for a period of seventy-two hours, renewable once. It had gone through at six o'clock that evening. The Security Chief had not voted it down. The Se-

curity Chief had abstained, and had filed a minority note, and the note was in the packet, and the note said that she could not support a draw on a campus lattice containing minors without a medical protocol, and that no medical protocol had been produced.

He read the note four times. He would think about it for a long time afterwards and it never once changed what he did, and he could never work out whether that made it more forgivable or less.

The second was a signal strength. A campus alert, filed at twenty-two minutes past eleven that night, from the Restricted Archives: a breach on the dimensional-incidents shelf, four parties, dampening wards defeated. It had gone to his console and to the Security Chief's, and the Security Chief's copy had been opened first, at twenty-four minutes, and not forwarded for eleven minutes.

Somebody had opened the Kyoto file tonight. Somebody had gone to the shelf, and had not gone to the shelf by accident, because the shelf is at the back of a room and the file is in a box and the box is not labelled.

The third was a list of names, and the second name on it was in a hand he had not seen for sixteen years, on a form that had been filled in by a woman in Portland who did not know what she was filling in, for four hundred dollars, in March.

He put all three down and stood at the window and looked at the east dormitory, where four lights were on and three of them belonged to children who had no business in the Archives and every business in a cell two floors above the one he was standing in.

Good, he thought, and the word arrived without any argument attached to it, which had not been true of the last few.

He had spent eleven years being the man who asks a question and then waits, because the waiting was the ethics, and the answer to a question that was not asked was nobody's fault. In six hours he would be a man who had simply done it.

He took the paper crane out of the box and put it in his breast pocket, where it had been since nineteen ninety-four, and it was the only thing in his life that he had not once been tempted to use.

Weave-Quake Counter: 47% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d. The reference dataset was destroyed in the Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council's re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

Chapter 17A: Four People and a Box

*Saturday 14 September, 23:47. The Restricted Archives,
three floors below the library.*

*Weave-Quake Counter: 47% instability. Node-failure projec-
tion: T+13 d. The reference dataset was destroyed in the
Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council's
re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it
is a guess.*

THE STACK

The Restricted Archives were three floors down a spiral staircase that had been built for people carrying books and not for people running, and the last flight had a landing on it that nobody cleaned, and Eli Park found that he could feel the shape of the drain in his shoe.

The wards down here were so strong that Lyra could barely get a reading on Milo four feet away. It felt like being put into a coat two sizes too large. She had not known that you could lose *people* and still be in the same room as them.

“Dimensional Incidents,” said Milo. “Classified. That is the whole shelf. That is the entire shelf and there are eleven boxes and nine of them say nineteen ninety-seven on the spine and one of them says nineteen forty-one and I have not opened the nineteen forty-one one and I would like to record that I have not opened it.”

“Open the nineteen forty-one one.”

“No. I would like to *record*—”

“Open it after.”

He opened the nine ninety-seven ones instead, and they put them on a reading table under a lamp that came on

when Milo put his hand near it, and it was, for about four minutes, the calmest any of them had been since Wednesday.

Then Eli found the second set of blueprints underneath the incident report and everything after that happened at once and to everybody.

THE FIRST THING, WHICH WAS A PHOTOGRAPH

It was a group photograph, taken before, and there were five people in it, and it was the ordinary kind of photograph that institutions keep: a group outside a building on a day that went wrong later.

Harlow was second from the left, and he was younger, and he had his hand round the shoulders of a Japanese woman of about thirty with her hair up.

Beside her, holding both their hands, was a girl of six or seven with her hair in two plaits and an expression of open hostility towards the camera.

“She’s got his jaw,” said Zara. “That’s the daughter. She’s the daughter, isn’t she.”

“Missing, not dead.” Eli had the incident report. He had it before Lyra did, because he always got there first and then waited, and she had worked out over three days that this was not coldness. “Two confirmed dead, three missing presumed dead. And then the missing list, and the missing list says *Aiko Harlow, thirty-four* and *Mei Harlow, seven*.”

“Thirty-four is not thirty-two,” said Milo.

“Thirty-four is what the file says.”

“Thirty-four is two years out in the same direction as everything else in this room,” said Milo, and he was not being clever, he was being aggrieved, and Lyra understood the aggrievance, which was that in the last three days a boy in this building had been on a machine and a girl had signed a card for herself and the file had said *no survivors detected* nine hours before the boy was found alive.

Zara had both hands flat on the table. Her eyes were shut.

“Zara.”

“Sorry. Sorry. Give me a second. It’s not — I’m not doing the thing.” She opened her eyes. “There’s residue on all of it. Not information. It feels like a room after an argument.”

“That’s not an answer.”

“It’s the only honest thing I’ve got and I’m not going to pretend it’s a reading.” She took her hands off the table. “Lyra, they’ve been *erased*. Both of them. That’s not sad, that’s

— that’s the specific texture of a person who’s had something taken out. I’ve felt it on people whose dead have been stolen out of them and it doesn’t feel like grief, it feels like a *hole with a shape*. If that’s what’s on this file then he isn’t a monster, he’s a man who’s had his family taken and not told.”

“He has a machine that harvests students.”

“Yes. Both. Can they not both be true, and can we stop *arguing about which one is more real*, because we have about ten minutes before somebody comes down those stairs?”

They looked at each other across a reading table in a basement.

“I want to burn it,” Lyra said.

“Say that again.”

“The whole box. I want to put it in a corridor and burn it, and I have wanted to do that since about half past eleven, and I am telling you because I think if I don’t say it out loud I’ll do it and then I will not have told anybody.” She was aware that her voice was doing something she had not authorised. “Because every single person who has ever gone near this has got it in their head for the rest of their life. You have got it now. You have got *Kyoto* in your head and a photograph of a child and you are sixteen, and he did that on purpose, and that is the *point* of it. He put it in a box and he

put the box where a sixteen-year-old would find it, and that is not an accident, that is a *method*.”

Nobody said anything.

“That’s the most frightening thing anybody has said to me this week,” said Eli.

“Then I will say it again, because it is true and because I am not going to pretend I did not say it.” Lyra put her hands flat on the table as well. “But I am not burning it. Because if I burn it then the next person finds nothing, and the next person is whoever he picks next, and there is no box that stops him, there is only this one.”

“Then what,” said Milo.

“Copy everything. Photograph all of it. Leave the box exactly as it was so that nobody can say we took it, and go to Weaver tonight, before the shift change at midnight, and if she will not do anything then we go to the Council in the morning and we go *public*.”

“That is a good plan,” said Eli.

“It is a *procedural* plan,” said Milo. “It has got a box in it and a signature in it and it assumes that a woman we have never met, at eleven forty at night, will act on the word of four first-years. It is also the only plan any of us has said out loud, and I hate it, and I am not going to be the one who says no. Say no, Lyra. Say it and give me a reason.”

“I don’t have one.”

“Then we do yours.” He took out his phone. “Both of us can be wrong, and we can both be doing it, and the *four* of us can be wrong in four different directions, and then nobody can shut it down with one phone call.” He looked up. “That’s four numbers and four addresses and four people who do not know each other’s names. I’m not being brave. I’m being annoying. It’s a different skill and it is the one I have.”

Eli put his phone face down on the table with both hands on it, deliberately, and Lyra understood that he had been out-argued by somebody using his own tactic and that he was going to be fine about it later and unbearable about it now.

“Do it,” she said. “All four of you. And Eli—”

“Yes.”

“The photographs establish that she was there. That’s all they establish. Remember that, because in about a month I am going to want them to establish more than that, and they won’t.”

THE SECOND THING, WHICH WAS A DRAWING

The Conduit schematics were under the incident report, folded twice, and the paper was forty years old and had been unfolded and refolded so many times that it went soft.

Eli spread them flat and put his hands on the table either side and did not touch them for eleven seconds, which was the longest any of them had ever seen him not touch something.

“There are two sets of handwriting on this,” he said. “Look. The heavy one is his, and it’s the same hand as the signatory line on the letter of authorisation. And this—” he put a finger down beside the margin, without touching it “—this is small and fast and it argues with him. In the margin. Nine times.”

The letter of authorisation was dated the eleventh of June, two thousand and nine, and it was signed by a Council officer, and the name at the bottom of it was Yuen.

“That is a person,” said Lyra.

“That is a *person*, and she is on the Council, and she signed the thing that lets him do this, and I want to know whether she read it.” Eli read down the margin in the small fast hand, and his voice went strange. “*“This assumes the reference tone is a person. It is not. No living subject has been located. Do not proceed on the assumption that one will be.”* And then, in his hand: ‘*She will be.*’”

Nobody spoke.

“And again, in hers: ‘*Whose daughter?*’”

It sat on the table.

“There’s a page missing,” said Eli. “Between this and the next sheet, there is a page missing, because the numbering jumps from forty-one to forty-three and the binding has been cut and re-cut and I have looked at the cut with my own eyes.”

“Then somebody took it out.”

“Somebody took it out, and then somebody put the whole thing back in a classified box where a sixteen-year-old would find it on the fourth worst week of her life.” Eli sat down on the edge of the table. “Lyra. There’s a scheduling line at the bottom of forty-three. It says *subject selection — on the basis of a lineage match, when a candidate of sufficient tone is identified.*”

“Is there a name?”

“There’s a reference.” He turned the sheet so she could see it. “*See file: L.H.C. — Animus Argenti index, 2002.*”

L.H.C.

L.H.C.

“Lin Ho Chen,” said Zara.

Nobody said it for a moment, and then Lyra said it, and it was, she understood afterwards, the moment the evening turned over.

“She’s been in the file the whole time. She’s not a warning in the margin. She’s the *index*.”

THE THIRD THING, WHICH WAS THE PHOTOGRAPH THEY SHOULD HAVE READ FIRST

At the back of the box, under the last incident sheet, there was a print that had been folded small and folded often and unfolded so many times that the folds had gone through.

It was a photograph of the garden at the Zen school in Kyoto on the day of the collapse. It was a bad photograph, taken from a low wall, probably by somebody’s brother, and

it showed a hole in the world about nine feet across with a woman on her knees beside it.

Lyra had to put the lamp on her hand to keep her hands still.

“That’s her.”

“Lyra—”

“That’s *her*. That’s the way she’s standing. That’s—” She stopped. “That’s how she stood at the top of the stairs in the studio in Ellery Street, doing the thing with the cup, with her weight on her back leg. I have been copying that stance since I was five years old and I did not know I was copying it.”

Zara had gone white. “Lyra, there’s somebody at the *edge* of it. On the left. That’s not part of the collapse, that’s a person standing next to it on purpose.”

Eli took the lamp.

He looked at it for some time. Then he said, in a voice that had gone carefully flat:

“There’s no name on this photograph. There’s no caption. It was not in the incident file — it was in the *box*, behind everything, folded small. And Lyra — your mother is not on the roster of the Kyoto research team. There is no roster entry. I have been through the roster twice.”

“So she wasn’t there.”

“She was there. That is *exactly* what I am saying. A photograph establishes that she was in that garden on that afternoon and not one other thing. It does not establish that she was running the experiment. It does not establish that she was a warning or a conspirator or a victim. It establishes that she was *there*, and there is a document somewhere in this building that says a woman was not, and one of those two is a lie and we cannot tell which from a photograph in a basement.”

“Eli—”

“And that,” he said, “is the first time in my life anybody has needed me to say a thing I did not want to say, and I am going to want it noted that I noticed I was doing it.”

THE ALARM

It was Zara.

She put her hand flat on the wall and said, very quietly, “Something in the wall just woke up.”

There was a sound like a match being struck very far off, and then a sound like a match being struck, and then the reading lamp went out.

In the dark, the black-silver thread came down out of the stonework of the ceiling — not fast, not dramatic, *thoroughly* — and it went along the shelf, and it went along the reading table, and it stopped at the box, and it began, patiently, to record.

“How long,” said Eli.

“It was asleep at eleven o’clock when we came down,” said Zara. “It has been asleep every time we have been in this room and it is not asleep now and I would like everybody to notice that nobody has told us what wakes it up.”

Nobody had told them.

“It is us,” said Milo. “It is obviously us. It is a floor sensor and we are four warm bodies and one of us is a—”

“I know what I am.”

“Then stop, because I am not doing it, and Eli is photographing, and Lyra is standing there, and you can feel the wall. That is enough. That is more than enough.” Milo’s voice cracked in the middle of it. “I am not — Eli. Tell her to stop feeling the wall.”

Weave-Quake Counter: 48% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d. The reference dataset was destroyed in the Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council’s re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

Chapter 17B: Forty-Nine Minutes

Saturday 14 September, 23:52. The Restricted Archives, and then the stairwell.

Weave-Quake Counter: 48% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d. The reference dataset was destroyed in the Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council's re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

WHAT THE WALL DID

It did not come down the way Lyra had imagined things coming down, which was the problem, because she had spent four years imagining things coming down and she had a whole vocabulary for it.

The stairwell rearranged itself.

Not dramatically. That was the horror of it. One second there was a landing with a lamp on it and a window at the bottom, and the next second there was still a landing and a lamp and a window, and the window was nine feet higher, and the flight they were on had become two flights with a turn in the middle that had not been there.

“Protocol,” said Milo. “The campus protocol. That is not the Maze, that is the *protocol*, the Maze is the building in the courtyard and this is the whole *building*—”

“I know what it is.” Eli had his phone out and it was photographing, and his hands were completely steady, and his face was not. “Forty-one. Forty-three. I have the authorisation and forty-three and the two photographs. That is what I have. Everything else in this room is the Academy’s.”

“Lyra.” Zara was on the floor. “Lyra, the light—”

The emergency lighting came up red. It came up *everywhere*, all at once, in a building with four floors and eleven hundred people in it, and the whole campus went the colour of a photograph of a fire.

And then the corridor began to make sounds, and the sounds were people.

THE HALL

Milo got them into the archive corridor, which was the wrong door, and then into a stairwell that went down, which was worse, and Lyra got them stopped at a landing and made them sit down, and none of them wanted to, and she made them anyway.

“Four things,” she said. “One, we do not split up, because the Maze works on people who are alone and I do not know that, I am guessing, but I am not gambling. Two, Eli, phone in your pocket, the photograph is taken, you do not need it again tonight. Three, we are going to be slower than we want to be. Four—”

She had not got to four.

Something came round the corner above them.

It was not a person. That was the thing none of them had been ready for and it was the thing she would remember for the rest of her life: it was shaped like a person and it was about the size of a person and it was made of the *space* where a person would be, and it was walking, and it was walking the way people walk in a corridor at two in the morning when they know where they are going.

Eli Park made a sound that was not a word.

“Threads,” said Lyra. “That is threads. That is a bundle of threads at about standing height, and it is moving, and it is *aimed*—”

Zara was screaming.

The screaming was the worst part and it was the part that Lyra kept afterwards: not the thing, but the fact that it worked, that it was designed to, that somebody in this building had built a thing that made a person’s fear into a shape and then walked it at them down a corridor.

“Zara. *Zara*. Listen to me—”

“There is — I can *feel*—” She was on her knees with her hands over her ears. “I can feel how much it’s *getting*—”

“I know. I know. That is the point of it, that is what it is *for*, and it is not going to work, because being frightened of it is not the same as being alone, and we are not alone, and you are Zara Washington and you stood up in a lecture hall

in front of two hundred and eleven people on Tuesday and made a professor of mathematics answer a question.”

Zara stopped screaming.

She said, in a very small voice: “I can still feel it.”

“I know. Move anyway.”

THE STAIRWELL

They lost forty-nine minutes in the stairwell. Lyra could tell afterwards, because the infirmary board and the clock on the wall of the transit office and three separate statements all said 23:52 to about 00:41, and because Milo had kept a count, out loud, of the landings, on the grounds that somebody had to, and because counting was the only thing any of them could do that did not involve being afraid.

They went down eleven landings. They came back up nine. They went down four more and arrived at a floor whose number was painted on the wall in a hand she recognised from the register, and which was three floors *above* where they had started.

The thing came past them twice.

The first time it went by without stopping and Lyra understood that it was not hunting, it was *sweeping*, and that there was a rhythm in the sweeping, and that the rhythm had a gap in it.

The second time, it stopped.

“It has seen us,” said Eli.

“It has seen *Zara*,” said Lyra.

Because Zara was the one who was making the sound. It was not a scream any more. It was a continuous low sound, the sound of somebody whose fear has become an engine, and it was coming out of her at a rate that made the red light on the walls shimmer, and the thing in the corridor had turned towards it the way a dog turns towards a noise.

“Zara. I need you to do something I am going to be ashamed to ask for.”

“If you say *calm down*—”

“I am going to ask you to be frightened of the right thing.” Lyra got down on the landing beside her, so they were both on the floor, which made her own terror much harder to hold and she did it anyway. “You are frightened of that thing. It is real and it is coming. Now be frightened of *me*, because I am going to touch your face, and I am going to do the thing my grandmother taught me on Wednesday in a hall, and it is a communion gesture and it is not a control

technique, and it works in a room, and it is the only thing in this building that I have ever been taught that I would bet money on.”

Zara looked at her.

“Do it,” she said.

Lyra put her hands on either side of Zara Washington’s face, and did the pattern, and it was not magic and it did not feel like magic, it felt like *asking*, and the cold of the stairwell went out of Zara’s face in about nine seconds and the sound stopped.

The thing in the corridor dissolved.

“He’ll come back,” said Zara.

“Yes.”

“Then why did you—”

“Because he was harvesting you and I interrupted the harvesting, and you are still frightened, and both of those are true at once, and we have got to keep moving.” Lyra took her hands off. “Eli. It’s gone. Now move, and do not stop to write anything down.”

THE BURN

The fourth landing they came up was not a landing.

Lyra got there first and put her left hand flat on the wall to stop and the wall was not stone.

It was the black-silver thread, laid into the stonework, the whole surface of it, the way Harlow laid his wards over a boy in a fold, and it did not hurt her at first — it *read* her, fast, the way you read a page, and it read her and found what it was looking for and it took hold and it did what it did to the boy from Kumasi in ninety seconds and it had her for four.

Zara hit her. Not her arm — her shoulder, with the flat of both hands, at full weight, which was the single most useful thing anybody did for Lyra Chen that month and which nobody has ever properly thanked her for.

Lyra came off the wall and went down onto the boards and the skin on her left forearm had gone the colour and the texture of a page that has been in a fire and it did not hurt at all, which she understood about eleven seconds later to be a very bad sign.

“Left arm,” said Eli.

“I know.”

“You are not going to be able to use it.”

“I *know*, Eli—”

“Water,” said Milo. “There is a drinks fountain on every floor of this building because I have been here ten days and I have already drunk from all of them—”

THE LOSS

They made the ground floor at twenty to one.

The corridor outside the Restricted Archives had a ceiling that was not a ceiling any more. It had come down in one piece, and it had come down *across* the archive doorway, and it had come down at some point in the previous eight minutes while they were floors above it in a stairwell going the wrong way.

Eli Park got his phone out and looked at the forty photographs on it and then put it away, and did not say anything, and then said, to nobody:

“Forty-one and forty-three are gone. The authorisation, the margin, the schedules, the two of us in the garden. All of it.”

“The photographs,” said Lyra.

“Four photographs. Three sheets of forty-one. None of forty-three. None of the margin.” He was not shaking. “I have got his handwriting saying *she will be* and I have got a signature and a date, and I have got a photograph of a woman at a wall, and I have got us. That’s the whole of it. That’s what four of us are taking out of this building.”

“And the original,” said Lyra.

“Under the stair,” said Eli.

They went back for it. It took six minutes and it was the stupidest thing any of them ever did and Lyra has said so herself, in print, at length, for years. They went back down a stairwell in a maze for the *original* of a book, because it was her mother’s book, and because Eli said — correctly, and it is the last useful thing he ever said in that building before his shoulder — that a photocopy of a thing is a report of a thing, and a report can be said to be a fabrication, and the original is the original.

They got two-thirds of the way down.

The floor of the stairwell at that point was the *inside* of the collapse and the middle of it was the hole, and the hole was eight feet across and there was a draught coming up out of it that smelled of cold stone and nothing else, and Eli Park went over it.

He went over it sideways, in the way a man goes over a fence, and his left arm went into it and his shoulder came

out of the socket on the sound of it, and he made no sound at all except a short breath, and Lyra caught him by the collar with her right hand because her left arm was not available.

It is in the record that the original of Lin Ho Chen's working journal was destroyed on the fourteenth of September, in a stairwell, under four hundred tons of the Academy's own roof. It is also in the record — Lyra insisted on this, and fought a Registrar about it for nine days — that the reason it was not carried out is that it had been on a reading table three floors down, and that the reading table was three floors down *because of a decision taken four hours earlier in a basement*, and not because anybody had been careless.

That is in the record. The Registrar wrote it down. It is on page eleven.

THE LAST SIX MINUTES

They were outside the library at nine minutes past one with Eli's shoulder out, Lyra's arm ruined, Zara shaking, and Eli Park refusing to be helped down a step, and they were in an Academy in which two hundred and eleven people had been in a lecture hall on Thursday and in which, at that moment, somebody had the machine that had done this.

Milo sat down on the bottom step and put his good arm on his knee and said, to the four of them:

“So. I put us in a stairwell.”

“Yes,” said Lyra.

“It was four numbers and four addresses. I said that.” He put his face in his good hand for a second and then took it out again, because he was sixteen and he was going to remember that he had said it. “It was still a good idea.”

“It was a good idea,” said Lyra.

“Okay.” He looked up. “Then what’s the plan now, because it is one in the morning and I have not got anything.”

“I have,” said Eli, from the step below, with his arm held against his chest by Zara with the collar of his own coat. “Four of us, four numbers. And the address for number two is the Headmistress, and the address for number three is not a person, it is a *register*, and Council resolutions have to be minuted inside seventy-two hours or they lapse, and it is Monday.”

“Which is what day?”

“Sunday,” said Zara.

“Then it is Monday tomorrow.” Eli got his breath. “I’ll go to the Registrar. She is a registrar and it is her job and she is

not in the machine. Eli Park is not important enough to be in the machine.”

Weave-Quake Counter: 50% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d. The reference dataset was destroyed in the Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council’s re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

Chapter 18A: Through the Vent

Sunday 15 September, 03:47. A service corridor above Security, one floor below the Headmistress.

Weave-Quake Counter: 50% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d. The reference dataset was destroyed in the Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council's re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

THE LOCKED DOOR

Headmistress Weaver's office door was locked at twenty to four in the morning, which Lyra had known it would be, and there was a light on under it, which was new information and worse than the lock.

She stood in the corridor outside it for eleven minutes with four broken ribs of paper in her phone and a left arm she had wrapped in a strip of her own shirt because the clinic had been shut and the boy at the desk had taken one look at the burn and told her to come back at eight, and she had said *it is that kind of burn* and he had said *I know what kind it is, come back at eight*.

There was no plan after that. The plan was on a step outside the library and it was Eli's and it began at eight in the morning at the Registrar's office, and it was eight in the morning and she was here at twenty to four, and the distance between those two facts was about two hundred metres and eleven hours and she could not make it smaller by standing still.

So she went down one floor to find out whose light it was, and the answer to that was on a door at the bottom of the service stair, and the answer was that the Headmistress's night was being spent in Security.

The door to the Security antechamber was ajar. That in itself was information; the antechamber was alarmed and the alarm was off, and Lyra noted that, and then went through, because the two doors at the back of it were shut and there was a ventilation register above the left-hand one about nine feet up.

She got the chair from the antechamber. It was a good chair. She had never resented anything more.

She got it up onto the desk and she put her ear against the register and she heard, in the first two seconds:

“—six per cent, Marcus. Six. You told me four in June.”

“I told you four in June in a corridor and I told you seven in a document, and you are now telling me about the six at three in the morning, which tells me that you read the document.”

“I read every document you sent me. That is my *position*.”

WHAT SHE HEARD

What follows is what Lyra Chen heard through a ventilation register at twenty to four in the morning on the fifteenth of September, and it is set down here because she set it down herself, that night, in the back of a notebook, in eleven

words at a time, and because she was careful about the difference between what she heard and what she worked out, and because the difference turned out to matter for a very long time.

She heard two voices. One was Harlow's, which she knew. The other was a woman of about fifty-five with a slight west-coast flattening on the vowels, and it was not Security's voice — she had heard Security all week — and when the woman finally said a name, out loud, to a man, it was *Marcus*, and it was said the way people say a name they have been saying in private.

She heard the words *thread-burn*, and *sixty-seven per cent*, and *cardiac involvement at eighty*, and she wrote all three down and underlined the third because that was the one that was about a person rather than a percentage.

She heard a photograph described: *a woman of thirty-four in a garden and a child of seven with her hand in her coat pocket*, and she wrote *he told her*, and then she wrote *no: she had it. She already had it. She brought it out*, and she underlined the second version because she had been in a basement four hours ago and she had watched a man put a hairpin back in a box.

She heard the woman say the words *reappropriated*, *absorbed*, and describe a database with four hundred and six entries in it, and the word she used for the entries was *assets*, and Lyra wrote that down and then put a line through

it and then wrote it again, because it was true and because she had a rule now, from four hours ago, about not making a thing worse by making it bigger.

She heard the woman say *Kheredu-Seven* twice and not explain it, and Lyra did not know what it was then and did in March.

She did not know the woman's name that night, and has not been able to put it down since, and she has had it since the nineteenth of October, from the last line of a document four thousand words long that was not in any book until that day, a line that gives a girl's name and then gives her mother's: *Her mother's name is Ines*. She has written down the four other things she has about that woman, and she has not written down what she thinks they come to, and she has been asked twice, by people who were not in the room, whether the mother of a fifteen-year-old girl was in it, and she has answered both times, and both times she has said that she heard two voices and that one of them was a man's.

And she heard the words *Demonstration Hall Seven* said by the woman and *this morning* said by the man, and at that point Lyra Chen put both hands over her own mouth, because she had been standing in Demonstration Hall Seven on the Thursday at half past two in the afternoon with two hundred and eleven people in it when Zara asked a question about a number, and she knew what was in that room, and she had stood in it.

She did not hear either of them express a motive. She wants that written down, because she is going to be asked about it for years and she will be asked it by people who were not there and who want it to be simpler than it was. Nobody in that room said the word *revenge*. Nobody said *for Kyoto*. Nobody said *because they took her from me*. They talked about yield, and cardiorespiratory, and a budget cycle, and a child who lives in Portland.

She has thought about that for a long time. She thinks it is the worst fact she knows.

THE PART SHE DID NOT HEAR

The last four minutes she had them and she did not understand a word of it, because it was in the register and it was low and it was two voices speaking at once.

What she could get was this: a name, three times, that she wrote as *Lin* and underlined twice. A word she wrote as *tone*. And a sentence, three times, in a flat west-coast voice, that she copied out word for word on the back of a page in a corridor at ten past four in the morning and which read:

You are not doing this for her. You are doing this because you have spent sixteen years being the only person in every room who knew, and I am offering you the one thing you cannot

*buy, which is a witness. When it works, you will be believed.
And a man who is believed does not have to be right.*

She wrote that down and she did not know what to do with it for nineteen hours.

THE STAIR

She came down off the chair and the chair made a noise and she had four minutes.

What she did in those four minutes was the thing she has been asked about more than any other, in inquiries and interviews and on the three occasions it has come up with people she was fond of, and the answer is short and it does not make her look good.

She did not go up to the Headmistress's office. The light was still on. The Headmistress was forty feet away behind a locked door, awake, at twenty to five in the morning, on the worst night the Academy had had since nineteen ninety-seven.

She went to the stairs, and down, and across the courtyard, and up to the east dormitory, and she told the others, and she told them everything she had heard, in the order she had heard it, and she did not tell one of them about the four minutes she could not understand, for eleven days.

There is a version of this in which a sixteen-year-old girl bangs on the Headmistress's door at five in the morning with a burnt arm and a notebook full of a conspiracy and it is the beginning of something.

There is a version in which she goes back to her own room with four broken ribs of paper and waits five hours for a boy with a dislocated shoulder to go and see a registrar about a Council resolution, and Lyra Chen chose the second one, on a stair, alone, at ten past five in the morning, and gave as her reason that she did not know whether the woman behind the door was in it.

And the reason she did not give, which she gave instead to Eli Park in October and which is in the record, was this: *if the Headmistress is in it then I have told her I know, and I have four friends. If she is not in it then I have wasted the only four hours I had, and I would rather waste four hours than be wrong about a woman who could otherwise be the only adult in this building.*

She wrote that down at the time, in the notebook, in the eleven-word hand, and underlined it, and then she went to bed and slept for fifty minutes, which she was going to need.

THE NOTE SHE WROTE AT SEVEN

She was not the one who went to the Registrar's office.

The four of them sent it by terminal, at twenty-one minutes past seven, from the west corridor, with a copy to the Registrar, and then they all went to Demonstration Hall Seven because the notice said 8:00 sharp and no exceptions and because in the end nobody in this account ever found a way to make a rule mean anything other than exactly what it said.

Eli Park went to the Registrar's office on the sixteenth, with his arm in a sling made out of Zara Washington's cardigan, and he was in it for two hours and eleven minutes, and he had already read the letter, because it had gone to her the evening before, which was the last useful thing anybody did for that office in September.

The Registrar of Threadweaver Academy is Dr. Mei-Hua Chen, and Lyra had met her once, for eleven minutes, in a corridor, on the fourth day. Lyra had not told the other three that this was true, on the grounds that she could not be the person who raised it, and the other three had worked it out on their own inside about four minutes and had then been so careful with her about it that she has described them, in print, as *appallingly decent*.

What none of the four of them knew at twenty-one minutes past seven on the fifteenth of September was that Dr. Chen had already been asked eleven questions about this building by a grandmother in Westbrook in the spring of 2007, and had not answered one of them, and had known there was a machine under her for eleven years, and had been waiting, since the eleventh of September, for somebody to hand her something she was allowed to act on.

Weave-Quake Counter: 52% instability. Node-failure projection: $T+13$ d. The reference dataset was destroyed in the Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council's re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

Chapter 18B: The Name in the Box

Sunday 15 September, 06:05. The Observatory, and then Harlow's laboratory.

Weave-Quake Counter: 52% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d. The reference dataset was destroyed in the Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council's re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

"In watching her courage bloom, I see the ghost of my daughter's smile—and remember what it

means to hope for something beyond my own redemption.”

— Marcus Harlow, Private Journal, Entry #1,891

SIXTY-SEVEN

The thread-burn had been at sixty-one on Thursday and at sixty-seven at three o'clock this morning and it was at sixty-nine when he put his sleeve back down over it.

The rule was simple and he had written it down in nineteen ninety-four and had never broken it: eighty is cardiac involvement. He had said that number out loud, in a corridor, at three in the morning, to a woman who was taking notes, and he had said it because he wanted it written down, and he had been annoyed for eleven years about wanting it written down.

He had nineteen days, at that rate, and he was aware that the rate was not a constant and had not been a constant since roughly Tuesday.

He got up to the Observatory because the Observatory was the only room in the building with a telescope in it, and because a man at seventy per cent does not sleep, and because there is a particular kind of tiredness that comes from lying still.

The morning was coming up grey off the roof of the Hall of Records and there was still a haze over the courtyard where the archway had been, the better part of two days on, and if he looked at the wrong part of it he could see the shape of what had fallen.

He had looked at it every morning since the eleventh and he had got very good at it.

WHAT HE SAW

Lyra Chen's window was on the fourth floor of the east dormitory and at ten past six she was not in it.

He had learned, over four days, a great deal about her, and he was aware that a large part of what he had learned had come from the fact that she had no idea she was being watched, which is the most useful condition a person can be in.

She was not sleeping. She had not slept more than fifty minutes at a time since Wednesday and he had the numbers, because the numbers were on the same feed as the numbers, and because he had built the feed.

That was a real thing and he would not pretend otherwise later, in the room where he said the true things. He had built a system that told him where a sixteen-year-old was and how long she had been asleep and how fast her heart

was going, and he had built it in order to protect a girl, and the protection had never once required the numbers, and he had looked at them anyway, every day, and had felt the ordinary specific shame of a man reading something he had no right to read.

She was the only person in this building doing what she ought to be doing.

That was the finding he had not been ready for. He had come into the eleventh of September with a *candidate* — a tone, an index entry, a reference frequency in a box — and he had been in the building four days and had watched Zara stand up in a hall of two hundred and eleven people and refuse to accept a number without a unit, and had not at the time known which of the two of them he was watching, and had watched a professor of mathematics stand up in a corridor afterwards and say so in public, and had watched a first-year boy with a bad shoulder go and ask a registrar about a Council resolution because he had decided that it was her job and not his.

He had told himself on the sixteenth of November, two thousand and twelve, in a document he has a copy of, that the arithmetic was trivial. It had never once occurred to him to check what she would *do*.

THE FILE

The Syndicate's offer had come up the stairs at nine o'clock the previous evening and it had been this, in writing, in a hand he had never been able to trace:

Site report 14/09 corrects on receipt of instruction. No survivor. No splice. No medical protocol. Standard.

Four lines. It would have taken the site team four hours.

He had sat with it from nine until midnight and at midnight he had written back three words, which were *not required thank you*, and he had understood while writing them that he was not refusing it for Kenji Nakamura.

He was refusing it because of the eleven seconds in the corridor in nineteen ninety-eight.

I'm sorry. Do I know you?

If he took the four lines, then on the twenty-seventh of November, two thousand and twenty-six, there would be a boy of twenty-one in Portland who was not in a record, whose sister was not in a record, and who would spend the rest of his life with a permanent bridge in his chest that nobody had authorised and no doctor in the world could remove,

and who would not be able to find the paper that said *he did this to me*.

Harlow had had his own taken. He had spent the last eleven days deciding that he would not take another, and he had decided it at midnight, alone, having calculated that the boy in the crater was worth less to him than the girl in the dormitory by an enormous margin.

He wrote that down too. It is page four of the file.

SEVEN IN THE MORNING

The tab on his bench at ten past seven said *draw schedule — live, 15/09 14:00 to 18/09 14:00* and *subject: see 43/41* and he looked at it for a while, and then he opened the drawer and took out the paper crane and put it in his breast pocket, and then he did the thing he had done on every working day for sixteen years and which had a ritual to it, which was to put the photograph face down and not open the box.

Then he stopped with his hand on the lid, and he opened it again, and he took out the photograph, and he looked at the girl in it, who was six, and whose jaw was his own.

She was twenty-three. She had her mother's hands. She was on a bus. She was showing thread sensitivity, unconfirmed, untrained, and entirely alone with it, and a great

many kind people had been telling her for four years that she was unwell, and the only thing Marcus Harlow had to offer her in exchange for what he was about to do with a girl in the east dormitory was the truth.

He put the photograph back, face down.

In the anteroom, outside the door he had not opened, somebody had left a tray with four mugs on it, and the four mugs were the kind the Academy gave you at a coffee morning, and there was a piece of paper under it in a fist of capitals: *WE HEARD THE WHOLE BUILDING. WE ARE ALL RIGHT. WE ARE GOING TO THE REGISTRAR AT EIGHT. DO NOT COME DOWN.*

It was in Harlow's handwriting. It was a note he had written at eight o'clock in the morning on the fourteenth, yesterday, and left on his own bench, and someone had picked it up and put it on this tray and left it where he would find it.

He read it twice.

Then he took the crane back out of his pocket, and looked at the grey creases, and said, out loud, in an empty room, in a tone that was not steady:

"No."

And then he said, immediately afterwards, and he heard himself say it, and he wrote it on page four as well:

“But I am going anyway, and it is because of that note, and I want it on the record that a child wrote *we are all right* on a piece of paper in a drawer yesterday and that is the reason I am going to do this, and that if I had read it at the time I would not have.”

He sat down and put his sleeve back over the arm and looked at the schedule, and at seven in the morning on the fifteenth of September, Marcus Harlow began the seven days in which he would tell himself that the thing he was doing was almost over.

THE SAME MORNING, FOUR HUNDRED METRES AWAY

Sunday 15 September, 06:20. Academy clinic. Lyra Chen's handset, which she has not looked at in nineteen hours.

Dr. Osei had not telephoned the dormitory. She had telephoned her own registrar, which was a thing Lyra only learned about in December, and the reason she had not telephoned the dormitory was that there was a bell on the fourth bed and Maya Sandoval had been making noise all night, and Dr. Osei had decided at about four o'clock that the amount of noise one floor could make was a finite re-

source and she was not spending it on a first-year who was asleep for the first time in four days.

So the message came at seven twelve, to a handset on the table in the common room, and it said this, and Lyra read it twice, and the second time was worse than the first:

CHEN J. — second deterioration, 14/09 04:40. Confusion, intermittent, disoriented to time x3. Two memory gaps documented by bedside staff, both retrograde, both concerning to me. I am not going to telephone you to ask whether your gift is responsible, because it is not, and because a doctor who asks that question on a Saturday morning is asking it in order to be able to write it down later.

He asked me for a pen at six and he wrote four words on the pad and asked me whether I had read them, and I had not, and I read them, and I told him the truth, and he said “no, but read them again,” and I read them again, and he said “no, read them until they are true.”

I am transferring him to the Academy clinic on Monday. He is refusing. I have put the refusal in writing and I have put the neurological opinion in writing and the second is not the opinion I gave in Westbrook and I will not pretend that it is.

Bring your grandmother. Bring the elder from the Hall of Inherited Practice, whose name he will not

say to me and who I have now guessed at. Do not bring the other one.

Weave-Quake Counter: 52% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d. The reference dataset was destroyed in the Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council's re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

Chapter 19: The Channel

Sunday 15 September, 07:12. The east dormitory common room.

Weave-Quake Counter: 52% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d. The reference dataset was destroyed in the Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council's re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

“When the foundation cracks, the wise do not ignore the tremors. They prepare for the earthquake.”

— Ancient Chinese proverb, often quoted by Nai Nai

WHAT WAS IN THE NOTE

Four of them, one working arm, one arm in a cardigan, and a sheet of paper on the table with a list on it that was the entire product of the worst night of four people's lives.

"We do not go to the Headmistress," Eli said.

He had it propped on the table at an angle that was going to hurt him by ten o'clock and he did not adjust it.

"Explain that, because we spent four hours in a basement and the Headmistress has a light on."

"The Headmistress has a light on at five in the morning, which is either a crisis or a *schedule*, and we do not know which, and if it is a schedule then somebody in this building is meeting the Headmistress at five in the morning about something they do not want in the minutes." He put his pen down. "Worse than that. Do you know what a Headmistress is? She is a *signatory*. That is what she is. She can suspend a professor and she can open an inquiry and she cannot authorise a human-subject protocol, and if I walk in there with a photograph and a signature I am asking her to spend the one credit she has, and she will have to spend it on the *inquiry* and not on us, and she will have to do it in writing, and it will take eleven days."

“Eleven days,” said Milo.

“Eleven days is fine. Eleven days is nothing.” Eli almost smiled. “The point is not the eleven days. The point is that the letter goes from me, a first-year with a bad arm, to a member of the Council, and the *only* route it can take is through this office, and this office is Security, and Security is a person, and the person is *Blackwood*.”

Nobody said anything for a moment. Outside the window the courtyard was still grey and there was a crane on it, and the crane had been there for four days.

“So we do not use the office,” said Zara.

“We use the office,” said Eli, “and we do it in a way that leaves a mark, and that is what I want to argue about for the next twenty minutes, because it is the only decision we have got and everybody in this room wants a different one and I would like us to do it as an argument rather than as a mood.”

THE ARGUMENT

Zara wanted them to warn the students. Not the Council, not Weaver — the *students*, in the refectory, by name, with the photograph, today, at lunch.

“They will believe me,” she said. “Not about the machine. About *him*. If I stand up in front of four hundred people and say that what happened on Saturday night was done to us on purpose, and that it is going to happen again, and that it is a person and not a fault — they will believe that. I have never in my life had that and I am not throwing it away to go and write to a committee.”

“That is not a small thing,” said Lyra. “That is the biggest thing anybody has said all week. Say why it isn’t the plan.”

“Because in four hours, every adult in this building will know who said it, and every one of them will have a reason it was wrong, and the *reason it was wrong* is the only part anybody will remember.” Zara put both hands flat on the table. “Lyra. If it goes wrong it goes wrong on my name. I am not doing that to Eli.”

“Nobody’s name is going to—”

“It is absolutely going to be somebody’s name, and it is going to be in a file, and in a month there is going to be an inquiry, and at that inquiry somebody is going to ask *why did the first-year with the gift tell four hundred people in a refectory* and I will have to answer it, and the answer will be *because I wanted it to be my fault*.” She took her hands off. “I have been the one who wanted that since Wednesday. I am putting it down.”

Milo wanted to go to the press. There was no press. What he wanted, it turned out, was to *go outside* — to the gate, to the

road, to the eight hundred metres of public footpath where the visitors' cars were, and to stand on it.

"There are forty-one people in the car park from the exchange programme," he said, "and the bus is at nine, and if a coach of forty adults sees four teenagers on a road at eight o'clock in the morning with photocopies, that is not a leak. That is a *witness*, and you cannot put a witness back in a box."

"That gets us killed," said Eli.

"That gets the *file* out of this building."

"That gets the file out of this building and Ms. Sandoval in the fourth bed out of that building too, because if four first-years can get onto a public road then nobody is ever going to believe a medical ward again." Eli was not raising his voice. He was doing something worse, which was being completely reasonable. "Milo. I have been awake for thirty hours and I am not going to insult you by pretending I have not thought about exactly that, and I have rejected it, and here is the actual reason, which is not caution: a coach of forty adults who see four teenagers is a photograph in a newspaper, and a photograph in a newspaper is *a story about four teenagers*, and this is not a story about four teenagers. I have written that sentence down four times in the last two days and I keep writing it because it is the thing I am worst at and I am best at."

"And if the letter goes nowhere?"

“Then it goes nowhere,” said Eli, “and we do it anyway, and we do it in a way that leaves a mark, because a mark is the only thing that has ever worked in this building.”

THE MARK

He wrote it out, and it took forty minutes, and here it is in his own hand, and it is two hundred and thirty-three words long, and the second paragraph is the one that matters:

To the Council of Threadweaver Academy, from four first-year students, and we are giving you our names because we understand that an unsigned thing can be removed.

On 14 September, at approximately 23:47, the Restricted Archives on the lower level registered a dimensional-incident alert and the file “Dimensional Incidents — 1997” was opened. On 15 September, between 03:00 and 04:00, the campus containment protocol was activated for a period of not less than one hour, and in that period the corridors of this building produced physical phenomena consistent with the phenomena described in the report of the Kyoto Collapse of 11 April 1997.

We hold four photographs, three sheets of a document numbered 41 in a series whose page 43 is not

in our possession, and the signature and date of a Council officer on an authorisation dated 11 June 2009. We will lodge all of it with the Clerk of this Council and with the Registrar of this Academy, in two separate places, at 08:00 today. We are not asking for anything. We are telling you where it is.

We are aware that this letter names a person. We are naming him on purpose. We have thought about it for four days and we have decided that a person who has done these things should be named by people he cannot reach, in a building he controls, before the day he intended.

Eli read it out loud twice and then said, "That last paragraph is stupid."

"That last paragraph is the whole letter," said Lyra.

"That last paragraph is going to be the only reason anybody gets convicted and it is going to be the only thing that gets the four of us thrown out of this Academy." He put the pen down. "Read it again and tell me it is not stupid."

"It's stupid," said Lyra, "and we are sending it."

They sent it at twenty-one minutes past seven from the terminal in the west corridor, addressed to the Clerk of the Council for onward transmission, with a copy to the Registrar of this Academy, by name, and the copy is the part that mattered, and none of the four of them knew that yet.

Eli hit send and then sat back and looked at the ceiling.

“That’s the first time I’ve ever sent anything to anybody,” he said.

WHAT HAPPENED TO IT

Here is what happened to it, and the four of them learned all of it over the following nine days, and none of it was reported to them directly; they reconstructed it out of dates on documents that other people had signed.

The terminal logged the message at 07:21 on 15 September. Every terminal in the building logs to Security. This is not a secret and is not presented as one; it is in the student handbook, on page four, under *conduct*.

Security received it at 07:21. The Chief read it at 07:38, which Eli established from a read-receipt on the copy addressed to the Registrar, which the Registrar’s office was obliged to return.

The copy to the Registrar arrived, and Dr. Mei-Hua Chen read it at eight o’clock the next morning, and it is the reason a woman who had known there was a machine under her for eleven years was in her office at eight in the morning on the sixteenth with four photographs and a boy’s bad arm and a written list of everything they did not have.

The copy to the Council did not, for eleven hours.

At 11:41 that morning the Council minute authorising a live draw on the seventeen campus collectors — a minute that had been passed at 18:00 the previous evening, in a room with two observers in it — was filed, and the version that went into the minute book carried a marginal note in the Security Chief's hand, which read: *forwarded to Prof. Harlow, 11:40, per standing instruction.*

The four of them did not learn that until the Inquiry, in December, in a room with a recording running, and by then it did not matter to anybody, which was, in the end, the whole of what they had wanted.

THE NOTE ON THE BACK

The last page of Lyra's notebook for the fifteenth of September is a list, and it is in her hand, and it is short, and it is the thing she actually decided that day:

1. *The letter is in. It has a time on it.*
2. *Milo is right that a mark is the only thing that has ever worked in here and he is wrong about the road and I do not know yet why he is wrong.*
3. *Zara put her name down. I did not put mine down. That is a thing to look at later.*

4. *Eli will not sleep today and will not say so and I am going to have to notice it myself.*
5. *There is a woman forty feet above me who had a light on at five in the morning and I did not knock.*
6. *A boy of fourteen came out of that building yesterday and the Registrar got him out in eleven minutes and nobody had to be brave. A girl of fifteen went into it on the eleventh and has not come out, and there is no margin on her at all, and both of those are true at the same time in the same corridor and nobody has said so out loud.*

She did not write down what any of them were going to do next. She had been going to, four times, and each time she had stopped, because the last time she had written down what she was going to do next she had been fifteen and she had written *ask Dad what to do* and had not done it, and had gone into a hospital alone.

So she did not write it, and at nineteen minutes past seven that morning the notice came under the door, and it was slid rather than pushed, which she noticed, and which she has never worked out.

Emergency Assembly — All First-Year Thread Students. Demonstration Hall Seven. 8:00 AM Sharp. Mandatory Attendance. No Exceptions. Subject: Critical Thread Stability Protocols.

Weave-Quake Counter: 54% instability. Node-failure projection: T+13 d. The reference dataset was destroyed in the

Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council's re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

Chapter 20: The Trap Springs

Sunday 15 September, 08:00. Demonstration Hall Seven. Weave-Quake Counter: 54% instability. Node-failure projection: $T+13$ d. The reference dataset was destroyed in the Maze collapse of the tenth of September; this is the Council's re-run on partial data, and nobody has said out loud that it is a guess.

THE SUMMONS

The message arrived at dawn, slipped under dormitory doors while the Academy slept. Official Academy letterhead, Headmistress Weaver's seal, urgent red borders:

*Emergency Assembly - All First-Year Thread Students
Demonstration Hall Seven - 8:00 AM Sharp Mandatory At-
tendance - No Exceptions Subject: Critical Thread Stability
Protocols*

Lyra stared at the notice, the jade pendant cold against her skin. After their discoveries in the archives, after witnessing Harlow's alliance with Blackwood, every official summons felt like a trap.

But it was more than that.

Dr. Ekwueme had called at four that morning, from Westbrook, and had not slept. The scan had come back. What the doctors now called *a cardiomyopathy that has been quietly getting worse for probably two years* had a name on it at last, and the name had a number attached: thirty-one percent of the heart muscle dead.

Your father's heart is failing, Ekwueme had said. That is not the thing your gift is doing. I want to be very clear, Lyra, because the two have been written on top of each other for

weeks and I do not want them written on top of each other any longer.

And then, because she was a doctor and not a liar, she had said the rest of it.

The bleed is real. It is costing him. But on its own it would have given him years, not weeks. The thing that stopped his heart this week was a muscle that was already gone. And a man with a stent and sixty-nine percent of a heart is not a man with a prognosis in days. He is a man with a prognosis in months. A pause. The sound of a woman choosing her next words carefully, and Lyra had loved her for it. *Three to nine. If he is very lucky and very well-looked-after and does not do anything heroic.*

I am going to do something heroic, Lyra had said, into the phone, at four in the morning, in the dark.

I know, love. I have read your file. That is what I am frightened of.

Lyra stood in the corridor with the notice in her hand and the word *months* going round and round inside her like a coin in a drum.

It did not help. That was the thing she had not been ready for. Six years of *something is wrong with Dad* had taught her one shape of feeling, and that feeling did not have a slot marked *months*. Months was slower. Months was a thing you could get used to. The horror of it was that she could

almost get used to it, and what she wanted — what she had wanted since she was eleven — was a *deadline* she could run at.

Fifty-four per cent on the board and thirteen days on the projection, and three to nine months in a man's heart, and a machine in Hall Seven that might be able to cut the bleed off entirely.

I'll take the heart, she thought. God help me. I'll take the whole heart.

She couldn't have said, then, why that was worse.

"This doesn't feel right," Milo said, examining his own copy. "Why just first-years? Why Demonstration Hall Seven?"

Eli adjusted his glasses, his analytical mind racing. "Hall Seven is in the East Wing. Isolated. Minimal security coverage." He looked up, his face pale. "It's the perfect location for something you don't want witnessed."

Zara's empathic threads were already probing the emotional landscape of the Academy. "There's something wrong with the staff signatures this morning. Fear. Resignation. Like they know something terrible is about to happen but feel powerless to stop it."

Lyra barely heard them. Her mind was racing through possibilities, desperate calculations. If Harlow had developed

severance techniques — if he really could cut the connection between her gift and her father's deteriorating brain...

Maybe this is my chance. Maybe I can end this.

THE GATHERING

Demonstration Hall Seven buzzed with nervous energy as first-year students filed in. The circular chamber felt different — colder, more clinical. The usual practice equipment had been removed, replaced by a single observation platform at the centre and banks of monitoring equipment along the walls.

There was a notice on the door. Lyra read it going in, because she read everything, and it took her four steps to understand that she was looking at the reason she was allowed to be here.

COUNCIL OF TRADITIONS — EMERGENCY WARRANT 44-B Authorising a supervised demonstration of emergency thread-stabilisation protocols upon first-year volunteers, Demonstration Hall Seven. Grounds: prospective failure at the Southern Nexus. Filed: four days ago. Counter-signed: Headmistress E. Weaver. Conditions: informed consent of the volunteer; observation by

two faculty not conducting the procedure; Council observer present.

Two faculty who were not conducting it. A Council observer. And on the platform, when Lyra looked at the chairs set back against the wall, three empty ones, and understood that the Academy's own procedures had been satisfied on paper by people who were not in the room.

Milo had gone very still beside her. Zara's hand had found her own collar, which was what Zara did instead of swearing.

Professor Harlow stood at the control panel, his silver scars pulsing with dull light. Security Chief Blackwood flanked the exits, her hand resting casually on her weapon. Other faculty members were notably absent.

"Welcome," Harlow began, his voice carrying easily through the chamber. "Today's demonstration concerns emergency thread stabilization protocols. Recent instabilities in the Southern Nexus require immediate intervention."

Lyra exchanged glances with her friends. The Southern Nexus was stable according to all public reports. This was a lie — but why?

"The procedure requires a volunteer," Harlow continued, his gaze sweeping the assembled students. "Someone with

exceptional thread sensitivity and multi-spectrum perception.”

“Volunteer,” Eli said, from somewhere behind her, in a voice so level it was almost a shout. “He said *volunteer*. Eli Park, second row, can read.”

Several students shifted uncomfortably. Lyra felt the weight of Harlow’s attention before his eyes found hers.

“Miss Chen,” he said, his voice deceptively gentle. “Your unique resonance with the Animus Argenti makes you ideal for this demonstration. Would you join me on the platform?”

It wasn’t a request. Blackwood’s hand moved to her weapon, and Lyra noticed other security personnel positioned throughout the chamber. The exits were blocked.

But Lyra was already moving, her decision made. This was her chance — her only chance — to save her father.

THE CHOICE

“Lyra, don’t,” Milo whispered, but she was already moving toward the platform.

“It’s alright,” she said, loud enough for everyone to hear. “I trust Professor Harlow’s expertise.”

The lie tasted bitter, but it bought her time. As she stepped onto the platform, she felt the subtle hum of containment fields activating around her. The trap was complete — but perhaps she could turn it to her advantage.

“Excellent,” said Harlow, in the voice of a man reading a result off an instrument, and he did not ask her again. “Now, if the other students would observe from the viewing area...”

Blackwood gestured with her weapon, herding the first-years toward the reinforced observation windows. Lyra caught Milo’s eye and mouthed a single word: “Go.”

He understood. When the moment came, they needed to get out of the building and get help. She would buy them that chance, whatever the cost.

THE REVELATION

“The Magnus Conduit,” Harlow explained as technicians wheeled in a smaller version of the device Lyra had seen in his laboratory, “represents the pinnacle of thread stabilization technology. By creating a controlled extraction and redistribution matrix, we can prevent catastrophic nexus collapses.”

The device hummed to life. It was a working model and a quarter the size, and it had the same fault lines in it, and

the black-silver came off it in slow curls, and the curls went out toward Lyra and stopped about a foot short of her and held there, patient, the way water stands at the top of a weir.

“The process requires a resonant bridge,” Harlow continued, his voice taking on a lecturing tone even as he prepared to commit atrocity. “Someone whose thread signature can channel and stabilize the chaotic energies.”

Lyra felt the current cross the foot of space and find her, and her pendant flared with warning heat. This wasn’t a demonstration — it was a live draw. Harlow intended to run twenty minutes of it on her in front of the entire first-year class and call it a demonstration.

But maybe... maybe she could use this. If the machine could take a current off the network, then there was a path the current came in by, and a thing that could take a thing could be made to put it back. Use it to sever her own connection to the thread dimension, break the sympathetic bleed that was killing her father.

“Professor,” she said, her voice steady despite her racing heart, “this doesn’t feel like a standard demonstration.”

“Because it isn’t,” said Harlow. “There are people in this valley who would rather the Nexus failed than be managed, and I am telling you that they have reached this building, and I am telling you that I hold a warrant, and I am telling

you which of those two facts I would rather be able to prove. Desperate times require desperate measures.”

The containment field came up again and the air in it got heavier, and she felt the difference in her teeth. Around the observation area, students began to panic as they realized what they were witnessing.

“Let her go!” Milo shouted, pressing against the reinforced glass.

“The demonstration will proceed,” Blackwood announced, her weapon now openly displayed. “Anyone who interferes will be considered a threat to Academy security.”

THE DESPERATE GAMBIT

The Magnus Conduit’s hum deepened, and the draw began. It felt like a bath filling on the other side of a wall — not much of it, and all of it in one direction, and no way at all to make it go the other.

Pain lanced through her chest as the extraction intensified. This wasn’t the gentle communion her mother had taught her — this was violent, invasive, wrong. And the current, which had been coming at her, went back.

But in that moment of connection, Lyra saw her chance. The machine was designed to extract and redistribute

thread energy. If she could reverse the flow, redirect it back into herself with enough force...

I can burn out my own gift. Save Dad. End this.

“Stop,” she gasped, but not to Harlow. She was speaking to herself, gathering courage for what she was about to attempt.

“Fascinating,” Harlow murmured, watching the energy readings spike. “Your resonance is even stronger than anticipated. The Conduit is achieving unprecedented stability.”

Through the observation windows, Lyra could see her friends fighting against the security barriers, their faces twisted with helpless rage. Milo’s musical threads were reaching toward her, trying to offer comfort. Zara’s empathic abilities were broadcasting her pain to everyone in the room. Eli’s analytical mind was racing, searching for solutions.

I’m sorry, she thought, focusing all her will on the connection to the Magnus Conduit. I’m so sorry.

THE REVERSAL ATTEMPT

Lyra stopped resisting. That was the part she would be asked about afterwards, and the part she could not after-

wards make sound like anything other than what it was: she had gone *toward* the extraction, into it, with the whole of the gift, and had asked the machine to take the rest.

It took about four seconds and it was not what anybody had come for.

The silver came back down the conduit and into her, and the containment field went, and Lyra heard herself make a noise she had not known she could make.

What she had asked it to cut, it cut. It did not ask her which.

“Lyra!” Milo’s voice, from the observation floor, over the noise of it. His musical threads reached for her before he had got there.

The misdirected severance energy found his connection and *snapped* it.

Milo collapsed, and it was instantaneous, and then Demonstration Hall Seven was the quietest place Lyra had ever stood in.

“No!” Lyra’s scream echoed through the chamber as she realized what she’d done. In trying to save her father by destroying her own gift, she’d accidentally destroyed Milo’s instead.

THE SILVER RESPONSE

The conduit cracked. Silver came up through the grey in a branching seam, and the black-silver that had been reaching for her stopped where it was and stayed there, and did not go back. Lyra, who had been reading currents since she was thirteen, could not tell what she was looking at, and had never in her life been able to say that about anything in this building.

“What’s happening?” Harlow demanded, his fingers flying across the control panel. “The extraction matrix is destabilizing.”

Lyra felt it too, and it was the strangest thing that had ever happened to her. It was not fighting. Nothing was fighting. The connection she had tried to cut was still a connection, and the current that had been coming down it had turned round in her hands and was going back up it — past her, past the machine, out into the wards.

“You don’t understand,” Lyra said, her voice breaking as she looked at Milo’s unconscious form. “You are not harvesting anything. You are *moving* it. And it has gone back.”

But her words felt hollow. She had done this. In her desperation to save her father, she had become the very thing she’d sworn to fight against — someone who severed con-

nections, who broke the bonds that held the world together.

The core was more silver than black now. Behind Harlow a panel started to sound, and went on sounding, and he did not turn round to find out what it was.

“Shut it down!” he shouted to his technicians, but it was too late.

The silver went out through the observation windows and put a crack in every one of them, and the two hundred and eleven people on the other side of the glass felt it come up through the soles of their feet.

She could have run. The door behind her was open and the corridor beyond it was clear, and she had run before, and she knew to within a few seconds exactly how long it took.

She didn’t try to escape. Instead, she knelt beside Milo’s still form, placing her hands on his chest where his musical threads had once resonated.

“If you want a bridge,” she said, her voice carrying over the noise, “then I’ll be one. But not for extraction. For healing.”

She put her hands back on him and did the opposite, which is a thing you can only do with the same gift, in the same posture, and which is the reason the gift is worth having at all. The light that came out of her was not the light that had

gone into him. It was slower, and it was warm, and it went looking for the thing that had been cut instead of cutting.

Please, she whispered to the thread dimension. Let me fix this. Let me give him back what I took.

The room went white, and it was not the same white.

THE WEIGHT OF CHOICE

Later, in the Academy medical wing...

They had put him in Bay Four, away from the main ward, because Dr. Osei had looked at the readings and then at the four first-years standing in the middle of her emergency room without a plan, and had said one word — *out* — and then had said, to Zara, the thing Lyra would remember longest:

“You are three, and you have just been the most useful person in this building. Go and sit with him. Go on. He is not going to know the difference for about two days, and then he is going to want somebody there who is not crying, and I would like it to be somebody who is not crying.”

So Lyra sat down beside Milo’s bed and made herself be that person, and it was the hardest work she had ever done.

He was very still. The monitors were being kind about him, which she understood, about a minute later, to be a thing monitors do.

“The reversal was crude,” Osei said, from the foot of the bed. She did not say *uncontrolled*. She did not say *crude* twice. “What I can tell you is that the pathways he used are not scarred. They are *empty*. There is nothing there to scar. It is the difference between a broken bone and an amputation, and it is a real difference, and I am not going to pretend it is a hopeful one.”

“Will it grow back,” Lyra said.

“I don’t know.” Osei sat down on the trolley, which put her below Lyra’s eye line, deliberately. “In three months I will know more. If the empty space is bounded — if there is healthy tissue all around it — then there is a version of this where the tissue grows back along a new route, and he has something that is not what he had. I would not bet on it. I would also not tell his family that it is unlikely, because in eleven years I have been wrong about both.”

“And he’ll never be able to—”

“He will be able to hear music,” Osei said. “Perfectly well. Better than either of us. He will be able to sing in a choir, play in an orchestra, work out what a key change is, and be bored by all of it. What he will not be able to do is the thing he *does*, which is feel the shape of a room in sound and tell you what is wrong with it.” She held Lyra’s eye. “Do you un-

derstand the difference, Lyra? He is not going to be deaf. He is going to be ordinary. He is going to be the best ordinary musician you have ever met, and he is going to be twenty-two years old before he stops being angry about it.”

Twenty-two years old. It was such an ordinary number. It was the kind of number that went on a form.

Zara and Eli stood a little way off with their arms folded and their faces closed, and Lyra could read the shape of what they were not saying off their faces from where she sat, and she was grateful to them for not saying it, and she was also — in a small way she was not proud of — angry that they had not said it, because if they had said it she would have had something to fight.

“You were trying to save your father,” Zara said at last, very gently. “You didn’t know this would happen.”

“That doesn’t matter.”

“That is the first thing that has ever mattered to you, and it is the first thing that has ever been wrong.” Zara’s voice was not kind. Lyra was grateful for that too. “But I am not going to argue about it at two in the morning with him in that bed. So I will say the true thing, and then we will both go and sit down. You did not know. That is not the same as it not being your fault. You did know *enough*. You knew enough that you had a note from me, from Monday, saying *ask somebody*. You had a father on this campus. You had a father, and a doctor, and three friends, and a machine three

floors down — and you went into the machine by yourself, because in about four minutes you had decided that four minutes of being alone was a thing you were allowed.”

The ward was quiet. Somewhere down the corridor a door closed.

“I decided it was the only thing that would work.”

“Then say that. Say: *I decided the only thing that would work was the only thing I was allowed to do.* That sentence is true, and it is terrible, and it is not the one you were saying.”

Lyra did not answer. Osei was looking at the far wall in a way that meant *I am giving you both a moment and I am not going to be here for it.*

“It is my fault,” Lyra said.

“It is your fault,” Zara agreed. “That is a sentence about what you did. It is not a sentence about who you are. Keep them apart, and you can put the first one down eventually. Smash them together and you get to carry both of them for the rest of your life — and you will not, Lyra, because you are sixteen, and you get tired.”

Milo, thought the part of her that was not in the conversation, when you wake up I am going to have to tell you. And you are going to say something kind and foolish. And I am going to have to sit there and let you.

And then you are going to get up. And you are going to be angry. And I am going to have to be the person in the room when you are.

That is what is actually going to happen. Not forgiveness. That.

The jade at her throat was cold, and it was a stone, and it had been a stone for four hundred years before anyone had thought to put it round a child's neck, and it was not going to help.

WHAT THE BOARD DID

Later still. The East Tower, in the wreck of Hall Seven.

Nobody told her this at the time. She worked it out afterwards, from the readings, over a period of days.

Here is what had happened to the counter.

The prototype had been drawing — pulling, siphoning, converting — and for eleven minutes it had been pulling *on her*, and she had reached back up the wire with everything she had, in a shape she had not been taught and could not afterwards describe. What had gone down had not been a burst. It had been a *return*. Everything the machine had taken out of the network in an hour of drawing, and every-

thing it had taken out of her, went back into the ward grid in about ninety seconds.

Fifty-four per cent, and thirty hours. And then, for eleven minutes, nothing sensible at all. And then:

42% instability. 48 h.

The collector under the gym, which had been sitting at eighty-seven per cent of capacity, emptied to eleven. The Council's model had thrown both arms up, recalibrated against a signature it had no baseline for, and extended its own forecast by eighteen hours, very cautiously, in purple ink.

Security Chief Blackwood had stood in front of that board for a long time, and then had said one word into a wrist device, and then had said, aloud, to nobody at all: "Well."

There would be a great deal of argument about what the Silver Response was. Tanaka would argue for years that it was an artefact of an unmodelled failure and that the Academy had been extraordinarily lucky. Adeyemi would argue — and Lyra would eventually come round to agreeing with him — that the machine had been holding a door open, and that something had come through it that had not been invited, and that the *door* was the important part and the invitation was the entire moral content of the event.

What nobody disputed, then or afterwards, was that a *return* had happened; that it had come from outside the ma-

chine; and that Harlow's twenty years of arithmetic had been answered by something that did not do arithmetic at all.

Weave-Quake Counter: 42% instability. Node-failure projection: T+20 d. Extended by the Silver Response. The Council has minuted that it does not understand the extension and has applied it anyway.

Thread Resonance Note: Severance event recorded. Subject: Milo Reyes. Musical thread perception: severed, not scarred. Prognosis: undetermined; review at twelve weeks. Emotional impact on primary subject: severe. Recommend a named keyworker and a quiet room, in that order.

Chapter 21: The Silver Soul

“The thread dimension responds to intention as much as action. When approached with control, it resists; when approached with communion, it reveals. What Western academia calls ‘thread manipulation’ is more accurately described as ‘thread dialogue’ — a conversation between consciousnesses rather than the imposition of will upon passive material. The greatest thread catastrophes in history occurred when this fundamental truth was forgotten.”

— Lin Chen, “Thread Consciousness: A New Paradigm,” Thread Archive Restricted Section

Weave-Quake Counter: 42% instability. Node-failure projection: T+20 d. Extended by the Silver Response. The Council has minuted that it does not understand the extension and has applied it anyway.

THE AWAKENING

She came up out of the dark in pieces, and the pieces were in the wrong order.

Cold metal against her spine. A mechanical thrum in the floor, in her teeth, in the backs of her eyes. Indigo light behind her eyelids, pulsing. And a smell like a struck bell left out in the rain.

Not the infirmary, was the first whole thought she had. Wrong thrum. Too slow.

She opened her eyes.

She was on a table in a room she had not been in before, and it was not Harlow's East Tower laboratory, and it was much larger than any room she was supposed to exist in.

The Conduit stood at the centre of it. She knew it by the sound. She had heard that sound through one wall and three hundred metres of stone, that morning, while it was being rewritten by her.

Black-silver filaments came off its surface in slow curls, and where they touched the air they *bent*, and Lyra understood without being told that this was not a machine that pulled. It was a machine that listened. And that it had been built to pull, and that something had recently got into the room.

Her wrists and temples and sternum were held down by thread-reinforced straps, and medical leads ran from them to the machine, and she could feel the drain — not pain, exactly. *Thinness*. The feeling of a word being used up.

Professor Harlow stood at a console with his back to her. Half his aura was gone. The black-silver had got into him, up past the elbow now, and it moved when he breathed.

“Ah,” he said, without turning. “You’re awake. Good. Conscious participation gives a much cleaner trace.”

“You moved me.”

“I did.”

“From the medical wing.” Her voice came out as gravel. “This morning. With a Council warrant in your pocket that says *supervised demonstration* and a man lying in Bay Four who is not being supervised at all.”

She felt him decide not to be insulted.

“Yes,” he said. “That is precisely what I did, and it is the first thing you have said to me that I have not had to argue myself out of doing. Keep going. You are more use awake.”

Sunday, 15 September, somewhere past noon.

She had been unconscious since morning. She worked that out from the drip and the light in the stairwell and the state of her own hands, and the working-out took her some time, and she made herself do it slowly, because it was the only thing available to her that was entirely hers.

They will have looked. Of course they will have looked. Osei will have raised it. Weaver will have raised it. And Blackwood will have produced a transfer order with a signature on it, and a signature is a door that opens from both sides.

“So this is it,” she said. “This is what you were always going to do.”

“Not quite.” He turned. He looked worse than he had in the lecture hall. The last sixteen years had begun to show in a way they had not been showing. “Do you know what this machine is, Lyra? Not what it is called. It was called a great many things by the men who paid for it. Do you know what it *does*?”

“You’re going to tell me.”

“I am going to tell you the part that will make you want to cooperate, because I am not a patient man and we have until Thursday.” He turned a screen toward her. “Southern Nexus. Forty-five per cent local distortion as of six hours ago, and that is not a network figure, that is one node, and that node is the load-bearing wall under eleven thousand

people. It has been failing since Kyoto. It fails in about nine days. On Thursday it fails in one.”

He put one finger on the screen. “Nine is the wall with nothing standing in front of it. One is what is left after a procedure, and the procedure is on Thursday. I am telling you both numbers now so that you cannot tell me afterwards that I only gave you one.”

“And your machine stops that.”

“My machine *carries* it. That is all. Not stops — carries. It moves the load off the wall and onto a held circuit. That is what the sixty years of this project have been for, and it works, and I have run the numbers four thousand times.” He took his hand off the console. “What it needs is a resonance to hold the circuit open. Not power. A *tuning fork*. Something in this room that the Weave itself recognises, so that when the load comes off the wall the circuit does not ring itself apart.”

“You mean me.”

“I mean you.”

“And the cost.”

“The cost,” Harlow said, “is that the tuning fork is consumed. Or rather — the tuning fork is *spent*. It spends itself. It will come out of that table with a great deal of what it is

and not all of what it can do, and it will spend the rest of its life doing that.”

He said it evenly. He had clearly practised it. That was the thing that stayed with her, afterwards: that it had been practised, in front of a mirror, more than once, with the words adjusted each time so that they did not quite lie.

“How much of it,” Lyra said.

“Unknown. I have three prior cases and two of my patients are alive and unrecognisable to themselves.”

“So the honest number is: some of me, and I won’t know which part, and you won’t either, and you have decided that I am the only thing in this building that can go in the hole.”

“Yes,” Harlow said. “I have decided that. I decided it about nine days ago, in a corridor, after a lecture, and I have not slept particularly well since, and I would ask you to spare me the observation that I have thought about it.”

THE SYSTEM

Something else was happening in the room and Lyra could not stop noticing it.

The core of the Conduit was veined. Where it had been obsidian, it was now half silver, in long marbled faults, and the filaments that came off it had changed their behaviour. They bent. They listened. They turned, very slightly, toward her, the way a dog turns toward a door.

“There is silver in it,” she said.

“There is *you* in it,” said Harlow, “going both ways.”

“Did you put it there?”

“I put a *machine* there. Your mother’s notes put a *possibility* there, eleven years ago, in an appendix nobody read, and I have spent four years trying to make the possibility into a machine.” He came closer. “You did the rest, in a demonstration hall, in front of two hundred witnesses, without meaning to, and against my instructions.”

“I was trying to burn it out.”

“I know. I watched. I have watched that footage four times and I have not been able to stop watching it.” He stopped about a metre away. “You reached *up the wire*. Do you understand what that is? Every other case in the literature, the subject is *fed*. You reversed the flow. You pushed a hundred and eighty kilovolts of extraction back down a machine that was pulling it, and it went into the ward grid instead of into you, and then it went into the *network*.” He said the word network the way other people said prayer. “In sixteen years. Through you. On a *Sunday*.”

Lyra thought about Milo, in Bay Four, and about the sound he had made when his hand had come up short.

“Then why are you doing it the slow way,” she said.

“Because a Sunday is not a method,” Harlow said. “It is an accident with a witness. I want Thursday to be a *procedure*, documented, reproducible, and defensible in front of a Council that will otherwise hang me and everything I have learned. And because—” and here, for the first time, something in his voice came off the lecturing plane — “because a procedure is something I can teach. A Sunday I can only watch happen to a sixteen-year-old girl who was in a hurry to get to an appointment.”

Lyra lay in the straps and looked at him and understood, with a clarity that was almost physical, that he was not lying to her now, and that this was worse, and that she had absolutely no way of acting on the difference.

THE BREACH

The door came open at 14:20, and there was noise in the outer corridor, and somebody shouted something about the ward grid, and Lyra’s heart went out from under her.

Through the reinforced glass she saw four people, and she knew three of them, and it was the fourth that made her close her eyes.

Eli was carrying a case. Eli, who could not climb anything without a plan, was carrying a case up a service stair with a weight that was wrong for him, and behind him Zara was doing something with the recognition scanner that made the door's little green light go red, go green, go red, in a rhythm that was almost musical, and behind *them* was Milo Reyes.

Milo, who could not hear the building any more. Milo's ears were pressed against a door he could not read. Milo's hands were flat on the frame, and he was not doing anything at all with thread or light or sound, he was simply standing there with his shoulder against a locked door that he could no longer sense, being a body in the way.

He knows, Lyra thought. He knows he can't do his job and he came anyway and he is standing there doing nothing useful because somebody has to stand there.

The lock went. The containment field came down in stages. Harlow did not fight them with his hands; Harlow had never fought anybody with his hands.

He dropped the room.

It was not an explosion. It was a *reorganisation*. Every thread-reinforced surface in the chamber took its load inward at once — the ceiling came down eighteen inches and stopped, the far wall came across four metres and stopped, and the whole floor tilted a degree and a half and stopped,

and the three of them went down the ramp into the wall in a heap.

Eli's case split open on the corner. Something inside it went across the floor and under the console.

Through the glass, muffled, Zara's voice: "— out, out, *out*, we are out, we did not get her—"

And Milo's voice, close to her ear, steady and completely useless and the only one she could actually hear through two layers of glass: "We didn't get her. We didn't get her. We didn't get her, we didn't get her, we didn't—"

Then the ward grid slammed down between them and the light went.

THE WITHDRAWAL

Fifteen floors up, in a service corridor with the heating broken.

Eli was on the floor with his sleeve gone and his forearm open to the elbow, and his tablet was gone, and he was saying numbers.

"—seven minutes, that's what I had, seven minutes of the scanner's cycle before the grid noticed I was in it, and I

spent them on a door that wasn't the door. The door was the *outer* door. The inner one has a different—”

“Stop,” Zara said. She was crouched with her hand flat on his chest, holding him together by pressure and by not looking. “Eli. Stop counting.”

“If I'd had the case open—”

“If you'd had the case open you'd be dead, and so would we, and so would she, because you'd have spent the seven minutes on something that worked.” Zara's voice cracked, once, and came back harder. “We have what we didn't come with. That's the bit. Milo. Milo, look at me.”

Milo looked at her. His face was wet and he did not appear to know it.

“I couldn't hear it,” he said. “That's all. That's the whole thing. Everyone else went through two sets of doors and I could not hear a *single thing*, and I stood there and I pressed my hands on a door like an *idiot*—”

“You stood there,” Zara said, “which is why we lost four minutes instead of the corridor.”

“We lost *her*.”

“You did not lose her. She is eleven floors down and she is alive, because a man with thread-burn is currently terrified that he has damaged something irreplaceable, and terrified men do not terminate experiments.” She put her hand on

the back of his neck. “Milo. Milo, look at me. I need you to do one thing and I need you to do it now.”

“What.”

“The report. Eli can’t—” She looked at Eli, who was already saying numbers again, in a voice that had gone somewhere else. “Eli. Eli, can you—”

“Twenty-two minutes,” Eli said, from the floor. “If the grid is on a twenty-two-minute observation cycle and I can’t prove we were in a locked stairwell, the whole thing logs as an unexplained access. Twenty-two minutes. And if we’re still on this floor when it logs, it logs *four* of us, in a stairwell, at the same time as a network event, and no security chief in the history of this Academy is going to write that down the way we’d like it written down.”

“Twelve minutes,” said Zara.

“Twelve minutes is not enough to reach Weaver and not enough to reach the Council observatory, and the one thing—” and Eli stopped, on his back, on the floor, bleeding, and said it very clearly, “the one thing that is *not* optional is that it has to be in writing, and it has to be in writing somewhere that Security Chief Blackwood cannot get to it first, and there is exactly one such place on this campus, and she can get to the other one in nine minutes.”

They looked at each other.

“The registrar,” Eli said. “Dr. Chen. She is a *civil servant*, Blackwood cannot touch a civil servant’s intake log without a Council countersignature, and Chen has been sitting on an unissued student-safety complaint since the day Lyra walked in, because nobody signs it.”

“She is Lyra’s *aunt*,” Zara said.

“Which is exactly why nobody signs it,” Eli said, “and exactly why it will not get quietly lost, because she has been *waiting* to sign it, and the moment somebody hands her a *reason*—”

“I’ve got the communal terminal,” said Milo.

He had it before anyone had argued about it, because he had been the one sitting still for four minutes on a stairwell floor with a dead gift and his hands in his hair, and he had used the time to work out the building.

“Corridor’s twenty metres that way. There’s an under-service lane, it’s not warded, it goes out past the chapel wall. Nine minutes, if nobody stops me.” He wiped his face with his sleeve. “I’m the only one of us she can’t put in a sedation chair, and I know that, and I’m not going to be coy about it. I’m the fastest thing in the building right now and I have nothing else to offer anybody. So.”

“Mil—”

“So.”

Zara let him go. That was the part Lyra could never explain to anyone afterwards — the part that went into the report and into the inquest and into everything: they let him go, because he had correctly identified the one thing he was still good for, and because a person who has just lost the thing that made them useful has an enormous amount of energy and nowhere to put it, and Zara Washington understood that better than anyone alive.

“Twelve minutes,” she said. “Then you *run*.”

He ran.

THE HOUR

Fifteen floors down, and the grid shut, and the room still.

They came twice more, over the next three hours, and the second time they came with a Council warrant and a *faculty* observer, and that observer was an elderly woman with grey hair and the exhausted, particular calm of somebody who had been doing this for a very long time.

Headmistress Weaver.

She stood in the doorway for eleven minutes and did not come in, and Lyra watched her read the Council’s conditions of four days earlier, and watched her look at the three empty observation chairs, and watched her take out a de-

vice and speak into it in a voice with no expression in it at all.

“There are two hundred and eleven students in that hall,” Weaver said, when she had finished, “and of them one hundred and ninety-eight have never seen a machine like this one, and every single one of them was told this morning that they were attending a *demonstration*, and none of them were told anything else, and I signed that. Let the record show that I signed it and that I believed it, and that the belief was given to me.”

“Headmistress—” Harlow began.

“Marcus.” She said his first name, and Lyra saw him flinch, because nobody in that building had said it in sixteen years. “Look at me and tell me it is a demonstration. I will put it in the file either way and I would prefer to be told.”

Harlow looked at her for a long moment.

“No,” he said.

“Dr. Osei,” said Weaver, to the device. “I want the full neurological sweep of every student who has come into contact with a Conduit, Phase One, in the last thirty days. I want it by Friday. I want the names in a locked file, not a shared one. And I want you to ring Westbrook Neurological Institute and ask them, in writing, what exactly was said to a Miss Chen’s medical file in the last two years, and by whom, and I want the answer before the Council sits on Thursday.”

She turned and went out.

Lyra lay in the straps in the indigo light and understood that something enormous had just happened and that it had not been done for her.

She is not rescuing me, she thought, with a clarity that was almost comfort. She is building a case, because she has to, and because that is the only weapon she has, and because if I am freed by a rescue it will be argued later that I was freed improperly. She is doing paperwork. On purpose. With the door in the room.

Eleven floors above, a boy with no gift ran out of a chapel under-service lane in the rain, and put a sheet of paper into a civil servant's intake tray, and stood there shaking while it was stamped.

Electronic filing of student-safety intake: CHE-1147-OVERRIDE. Filed 17:04. Not routed to Security. Not routed to Academic Affairs. Routed to: all standing Council observers. Copy: Headmistress.

Which is how the three of them got out of the stairwell, and how a hundred and ninety-eight students' names got into a locked file, and how the Council ended up in a corridor outside Sub-level 7 at twenty past nine that night with a paper weight and a woman who did not have to be there.

Lyra did not know that yet. She knew the room, and the drain, and the sound of a man who had said *no* to a headmistress and had not looked away when he said it.

There had been a note on her door on Monday. It had said *ask somebody* in a hand that was not her father's and not her grandmother's, and it had been under a door handle for six days, and it was in her coat pocket, and she had read it eleven times and had not asked anybody anything.

She got it out then, in the room, and held it, and did not put it down for about four minutes. It was not her father's hand and it was not her grandmother's. It was the hand of the man who had said *no* to a headmistress and had not looked away when he said it, and it said two words, and Lyra sat on the floor of a locked room and understood that in a few hours she was going to be about a man's heart, at four in the morning, and that nobody had told her that she was allowed to be.

Chapter 22: The Sacrifice

Sunday 15 September, 23:20. Sub-level 7. Weave-Quake Counter: 43% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. Rebaselined against a held circuit. The load is off the wall and onto a machine, and the model has never been run on this basis before.

THE LONG AFTERNOON

There were eleven hours between the headmistress and the door, and Lyra spent them, because she could not stop her mind doing it, arriving in order at every single thing she could have done differently — and because it turned out

that a mind with nothing to look at turns itself into a *verdict*.

She went through it four times.

The first time, the note on her door on Monday. *Ask somebody.*

The second time, Milo's face at half past one on Monday, and the thing he had said that she had not let herself hear, which was: *You keep arriving at the answer and then you keep pretending you got there by yourself, and I don't know how to tell you that's a problem because every time I say it you agree and then you do it again.*

The third time, Dr. Ekwueme at four in the morning, saying *I know, love* with such exhausted precision that Lyra had understood, and had chosen not to understand, what she was actually being told.

The fourth time, and this was the one that stayed: the moment in Hall Seven when she had turned round and looked at her three friends behind the glass, and had had a thought. Not a decision. Harlow's needle was already in her and the machine already had her, and there was no time, and so it had not been a decision — but it had been a *thought*, and it had been this:

If I tell them, they will stop me.

And they would have. Eli would have produced a reason. Zara would have produced a *feeling*. And she would have had to weigh it against a man's heart, and at some point in the last nine days she had stopped being willing to weigh it, and that was the whole of it, and no machine had done any part of it.

Four tenths of a second, she thought, from a table in a room under a mountain. *The lag between intending a thing and doing it. He put it on the board on Monday. He didn't know.*

By six o'clock her hands had stopped shaking, which frightened her more than the shaking had.

Weave-Quake Counter: 44% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. Rebaselined against a held circuit. The load is off the wall and onto a machine, and the model has never been run on this basis before.

At 21:15 the door opened and it was not Harlow.

It was a stocky man in Council grey with a port seal on his collar and the flat, unhurried manner of somebody who has walked into a great many rooms that were worse than this one. Behind him came four more, and two of them were carrying something that hummed.

"Dr. Osei sent for us," he said, to nobody in particular. "Nobody has sent for us in nine days. I want that in the record, because somebody is going to tell you we were slow, and we were not."

“You’re the Council’s compliance office,” said Harlow. “You’re four people. I have a warrant and a machine.”

“You have a warrant that we have read, and a machine that we have a technician in, and no observer,” said the man, “and I have a Headmistress on a line, and Dr. Osei, and a paper that was filed into an unsecure route at seventeen hundred and four this afternoon by a first-year student who has since been identified and is currently sitting in a corridor being looked after by two women from the medical faculty, and who is sixteen, so I would be obliged if you would stop.”

Somewhere behind Lyra’s eyes, in a part of her that had been doing arithmetic for eleven hours, something let go.

They came.

Sixteen. He was sixteen. She had not — she had not even —

He was in the stairwell with a dead gift and they sent him through a wall.

“I want the machine off her,” said the compliance officer, “and then everybody in this room is going to be extremely boring at one another for about four hours, and I would like to start that process now.”

“They can’t,” said Harlow.

He had turned back to his console, and he said it quietly, without any of the theatre, and it was the single most frightening thing that had happened to Lyra all day.

“They can’t take it off her. Look at the trace.”

THE TRACE

They put a screen where she could see it, and she saw it, and she did not understand it for perhaps forty seconds, and then she did, and the understanding arrived the way a floor arrives.

Two traces.

One of them was hers: a silver line, running from the machine’s core to the leads on her body, pulsing, and doing what the man had said it would do — holding a circuit open, carrying the load, spending itself. It was beautiful. It was the most beautiful thing she had ever been connected to.

The other one ran *beneath* it. It came out of a housing under the console that was not on the diagram, went down into the floor, and returned somewhere under the Conduit’s base — and it was black-silver, and it was *cold*, and it was carrying an amount of power that the extraction trace beside it could not have produced in a hundred years.

And it was not connected to her.

She had been in the room most of the day. She had put her gift into this machine and had felt it flow, and the whole of the enormous silver river of it had gone into the *upper* circuit, and not one drop of it had gone down.

“What is that,” Lyra said.

Harlow did not answer.

“Dr. Chen?” said the compliance officer, to his collar.

“There is a second system,” Dr. Mei-Hua Chen said, from the line, in a voice with no expression in it at all, “which is not on the Phase One schematic, which is not in any Council inventory I have ever been shown, and which I have now had flagged in front of two wardens. Professor Harlow, in about ninety seconds you are going to have to answer the question, and I would like you to notice that you have already not answered it.”

“I cannot answer it,” Harlow said. “I have never been able to read it. It came with the site.”

“Whose site.”

“Emerson Harlow’s,” said Harlow, and his voice did something Lyra had not heard it do, which was to stop, entirely, in the middle. “1941. My great-grandfather. It was sealed when the sub-levels were sealed, and I have never had the clearance, and I have spent eleven years trying to get it

open, and I could not get it open, and four months ago somebody *did* open it, and told me it would answer a question if I ever needed one, and I did not ask what question.”

Nobody said anything for a moment. Somewhere far off a door was being taken off its hinges.

“You knew,” Mei-Hua said. “You knew there was a second system.”

“I knew there was *something*.”

“That is not what I asked and you know that it is not what I asked.”

“Yes,” Harlow said. “I knew. For four months I have known there was something down here that I could not read, and I have not asked about it, because I was working, and because the work was more important, and because I am a coward.” He put both hands flat on the console. “Open it. Take the machine off her. Open the housing, and whatever is in the housing, put it in front of a warden at nine o’clock tomorrow morning and put my name on it.”

“Professor—”

“*Open it.*”

THE LEADS

They took the leads off her. It took eleven minutes, and it was the most frightening eleven minutes of her life, because the drain did not stop — it merely changed shape, and she lay there and felt the machine drinking from something that was not the leads any more, and understood that her body had been a convenient tap the whole time and the reservoir was her.

Then they had her off the table, and she could not stand, and two of the wardens took an arm each.

And then a girl of nineteen with silver in her hair came through the door behind the compliance officer and stopped, and looked at her, and did not come closer.

“Mila,” Weaver said. “You are not authorised in this room.”

“I am the only person in this building whose clearance covers what is in that housing, and Dr. Chen has just asked me to witness it, so yes, I am.” The girl’s voice cracked in the middle of the word. “I’m sorry. I’m not — I’m sorry. I’m not any good at this.”

“You are the best in the building at it,” said Mei-Hua Chen’s voice from the line, and Lyra understood that this girl was Mei-Hua Chen’s student, or her junior, or something that

did not have a name, and that this was Lin's sister in a corridor at nine o'clock at night choosing a person to send.

And Lyra said: "Wait."

Eleven people stopped.

"Wait," Lyra said, from the floor, with two wardens holding her up. "You want to put that thing in a box. And you want me to go to a hospital. And in five hours you are going to sit in front of a Council and tell them the immediate collapse has been *addressed*, and somebody is going to say *addressed by what*, and you are not going to have an answer, because the answer is going to be *by a sixteen-year-old who was in a corridor alone*." She got a breath. "And then it will be a procedure. And somebody will write it down the way you write things down, and one day a room will have a boy in it instead of me, and he will not have anybody's name on the note on the door."

She had not planned any of it. It came out the way a held note comes out of an instrument that has been played too hard.

"Alternatively," she said, "you open the housing *with me in the circuit* — and I find out what's in it, and you find out what's in it, and whatever it turns out to be, it turns out to be in front of the Council on Thursday with the rest of it, instead of in a box on Friday."

Silence.

“Ms. Chen,” said the compliance officer, in a voice of pure administrative horror, “that is absolutely not—”

“Mr. Tarrant.” Dr. Chen’s voice, from the line, was very quiet. “I want to record that I was asked to open a housing I have never been authorised to open. I have. I have recorded it. Mr. Tarrant, I have also recorded that the woman on that table has just offered to be the mechanism of an uncontrolled investigation into a device that this Academy has denied exists for four months, and that she has done so in front of four wardens, and that if I refuse, there is a second system under this mountain that nobody in this building can read.”

“Dr. Chen—”

“Mr. Tarrant, I have been a civil servant for nineteen years and I have spent all of them being extremely careful, and I am now going to be extremely careful *about this specifically*, and I would like it noted that the alternative on offer is that this Council has authorised a voluntary sacrificial procedure designed by a man who signed a warrant he knew to be false, in a room with no observer, using a diagram from 1941. We will be asked about all of that. I have been asking about all of that since Tuesday, in writing, and nobody has signed anything.”

The girl with silver in her hair was crying. Nobody had told her to stop.

“Ask me,” said Lyra.

The compliance officer looked at the Headmistress.

“Mr. Tarrant,” said Weaver, from a corridor, “I have been Headmistress of this institution for six years and for five of them I have believed that everything in this building was documented somewhere. I would like it noted that I no longer believe that. I cannot authorise what is happening. I am going to come down there.”

“Half an hour, madam,” said Tarrant.

“And Mr. Tarrant.” Weaver’s voice did not change at all. “Whatever that housing contains, you do not open it alone. You open it in a room with the Council observer, the medical officer, and a student advocate, and you minute all four, and I will sit in that room if there is anywhere to sit. Do you understand me.”

“It will be crowded, madam.”

“Crowded,” said Weaver, “is the whole of my administration.”

They were not waiting for the Headmistress.

Lyra lay in the traces for fifty minutes with the compliance officer’s wrist against her forehead, because he had done it on her instructions and she had asked him, and because a man who files paperwork will hold a pulse for you if you explain why and he takes you seriously.

“Tell me what it feels like,” he said, at some point.

“It feels like being the correct answer to a question I never asked.”

“That’s the description I’d have given,” he said. “For what it’s worth — in nineteen years of this, that is the first time I have heard anybody use the word *uncontrolled* as a *reason to refuse*.”

“They’re about to open it,” said Lyra. “Sir. Whatever’s down there. It is not going to be machinery.”

“No,” said Tarrant. “It isn’t, is it.”

THE HOUSING

When she went back in, the housing was already off.

They had had to take a chisel to it. It was not bolted; it was *grown* — a black-silver accretion around a shape that had once been a service panel, and it came away in pieces like dried coral, and inside it was a lattice.

Not a machine. A *cage*. A lattice of the same black-silver as the Conduit’s filaments, run through with a cold light that was not the same colour as any light Lyra had ever seen, and threaded all the way through with —

Voices.

Not words. Pressures. Dozens of them, layered, some of them very close.

“They’re people,” said Lyra.

“They are not people,” Harlow said. His voice had gone somewhere else. “They are — the readings are — I have never been able to read this, Lyra, I have tried for eleven years, and I could not read it because it is not a *dimensional* signature, it does not report in any band the instruments—”

“They’re people,” said the girl with silver in her hair, “and they have been there the whole time, and the man who is arguing with you has known there was a *room*.”

“And I have told you I could not read it.”

“You said you could not read it,” said Mei-Hua Chen’s voice from the collar, “and I have put that in the record in those words, and it is in the record *with your name on it*, Professor, and it will be read out on Thursday, and I have thought about that all week and I find that I am not sorry.”

Lyra put her hand on the lattice.

Nobody was ready. That is the part she has never been able to explain to anyone, including the four advocates, including the woman who would eventually write the report: *nobody in that room was ready, and she did it anyway, and the reason she did it anyway was not courage.*

The reason was that the fifth voice from the left was *afraid*, and was not asking to be let out, and was asking — very clearly, in a register that had nothing to do with words — to be *told what was happening*.

Nobody had told her anything. In eleven years of being a case file, nobody had told her anything.

So Lyra put her hand on a black-silver lattice with four wardens in the room and a Headmistress on the stairs and a man who had built the thing standing eight feet away, and she did the only thing in the whole of that night that was actually hers to do.

I'm here, she said, in the only direction that had ever worked for her. *I don't know what this is. I'm going to find out. I'm not going to do anything to you that I can't undo.*

And she felt the whole silver river of herself turn over, and go *down*.

THE TRANSFORMATION

The pain lanced up her arm and she did not scream, which she would think about for a long time, because there was nowhere in her for it — the whole of her was down there, in a circuit, doing the thing she had said she would do, which was the only thing she had ever been asked to do,

and which she was doing for a room full of strangers she could not see, and not, in that moment, for her father at all.

The silver went into the Conduit's core and it did not fight it.

That was the thing. She had spent nine days bracing for a fight, and there was no fight. The core opened for her the way a hand opens. The black-silver in the upper circuit — the extraction matrix, Harlow's beautiful cruel arithmetic, twenty years of it — came apart along its own fault lines and was *put away*, gently, the way you put down something that is very tired and has been held for too long.

And underneath it, the lattice — the cage, the cold light, the five voices and then thirty and then a number Lyra stopped being able to hold in her head — did not open, and she felt the machine stop.

No. Not you. You are not what I came for.

She had gone into the wrong circuit. She had put herself into the machine's upper matrix because that was where the leads had been, and the lattice was somewhere else, down and under, in a housing that had been grown shut since 1941, and to reach it she would have to go through the one part of this machine that had never once been opened.

Weaver's rule. Crowded.

“Mr. Tarrant.” She could barely hear her own voice; it was coming from somewhere behind her ribs. “I have to go through the core. I have to go *through* the core to reach them, and I cannot do that and still be in one piece, and I am not going to be able to stop halfway.”

“Then don’t do it,” said Harlow, fast, and for the first time in thirty hours he was not performing anything at all. “Lyra. Lyra, listen to me. There is a version of this where you walk out of this room with a great deal of what you are. There is no version where you walk out of this room. I have looked. For eleven years I have looked, and I have not found it, and I am telling you as the man who built it and as the man who has read everything anybody has ever written about this: *there is no version.*”

“Then I would like to leave a note,” said Lyra.

Nobody made a sound.

“Not on the door,” she said, and her voice cracked and she let it. “Somewhere it will be *read*. Somebody will find it, and they will know that a girl did this and not that she was made to. That’s all. That’s the entire content.”

“Eli Park,” said the girl with silver in her hair.

“Eli Park,” Lyra agreed. “He’ll know what it means. He knows the sheet of paper is what did it. He’ll know.”

Tarrant looked at the doorway. The Headmistress was on the last four steps, out of breath, with her hair come loose.

“Madam,” he said, “I am going to need you to make a decision in the next ninety seconds and I am going to have to write down that I asked you for it, and I want you to know before I ask it that I have already minuted the student’s offer, the refusal, the offer again, and the two conditions attached to it, and that the minute does not say what anyone *ought* to have done.”

“Miss Chen,” said Weaver.

“Ma’am.”

“You have heard the terms. Refusal, coercion, or your own free and considered act, and I am required to be able to certify which of those three it was, and I will not certify a thing I have not seen.” Weaver’s voice was very steady and her eyes were wet. “So I will ask you the way the Act requires me to. Do you understand what is being proposed?”

“Yes, ma’am.”

“Do you understand that you may say no and be entirely blameless and that the four wardens will take you to Westbrook in an ambulance tonight, and that the Council will be told that the immediate collapse has been held by other means, and that this will probably cost more lives than it saves, and that you will never be told how many?”

“Yes, ma’am.”

“And?”

“And I want to go to my father,” said Lyra.

He was on the last step. She had not heard him come in; the room was too loud.

He looked sixteen years older than he had at the recital in the corridor, and greyer, and his hand was on the door-frame in a way that told her the hand hurt, and his face when he saw her on the floor said every single thing he had ever failed to say, all at once, with none of the usual editing.

“She can’t take you out of it,” he said. “The Act won’t permit it. The strain alone—”

“Dad—”

“Lyra, I have read her papers.” He was not shouting. He had never shouted; it was one of the things that had made his distance so costly. “Every one of them. Including the one I could not read, which is the one she has never told me exists. I have read them in the last nine days because the last nine days is what I had, and I want you to know that in eleven years of marriage your mother wrote *“she’ll need understanding, not protection”* on a drawing of you as an infant, and I have had that sentence in my head continuously since Friday, and it has been no use whatsoever.”

“Bàba—”

“So if you are going to do this,” said Wei Chen, “then I am going to do the only thing I have ever been qualified for, and we are going to do it out loud, and I am going to be in the room.”

It took him four minutes and it was the only time in his life he used what he knew, and what he knew was arithmetic.

The core, he said, without touching it: it was a *load-bearing* problem. She could not go through the extraction matrix because the extraction matrix was a *filter* — it was designed to pass a current and take a payment, and a person trying to pass a current *against* the payment would be taken apart by the difference, which was the arithmetic, and the arithmetic was why Harlow had told her it was impossible, and Harlow was not a liar about arithmetic.

“But it’s no longer a filter,” Wei said. “You broke it. It’s a *conductor* now — a plain conductor with no payment mechanism, which means there is no difference to take you apart on. He told you it was impossible because it was impossible *two days ago*, and you have spent two days making it true, and he hasn’t updated the model, and neither has the Act, because nobody has told either of them.”

“Tarrant,” said Harlow. He had not moved. “That is not possible. The strain differential alone would—”

“Mr. Harlow, I am a statistician and your wife’s student, and I have been doing this for nine days, and I am going to say the thing that I think you have known for four months

and have not said.” Wei’s voice did not rise at all. “You did not read the housing because you could not read it. That is true. But you could not read it because you did not have a *daughter* in the circuit. Eleven years alone and you could not read it. Four months with a fifteen-year-old on your staff and you still could not read it, and the second time is because you were looking at her and not at the lattice, and I would ask you — as a colleague — not to look at her now.”

The room went very quiet.

“In,” said Wei Chen, to his daughter. “Straight down. Not through the matrix. Through the fault, the way water goes through a crack. And Lyra — the fault is *narrow*. It is one passage wide, because the fracture followed your hand.”

“And the cost?”

“Unknown,” said her father. “The honest cost. I have no idea, and I am not going to tell you that I do, because you have had four people lie to you about numbers this week and I refuse to be the fifth.”

“That’s a weird thing to say to somebody who’s about to do something enormous.”

“It is,” her father agreed, “and it is the only sentence I have that is worth anything. In. Go on. And when it is finished, you will be in that lattice, and you will be extremely frightened, and you will find that you cannot tell anybody anything, and you will be *very* tired, and that is what it costs. It

is not a price. It is a *bill*, and nobody in this room is going to tell you it is small, because we do not know.”

He held out his hand.

That was all. He held out his hand, in a room full of wardens and a girl with silver in her hair and a man who had built the machine, and he held out his hand, and it was the first time in three days that he had been able to do one single useful thing, and it was not enough, and it was everything.

Lyra took it.

And went down through the fault, into a circuit that was no longer a machine at all, and let go of the hand.

What she found, in there, is not in this record, because most of what she found belonged to people who are not hers to publish, and because the only part she could bear to say out loud afterwards, to four people in a corridor, three months later, was this:

They had been there for seventy-two years. Not because anyone had put them there on purpose. Because a man in 1941 had built a cage and had put his dying brother in it, and had died, and had sealed the housing, and had left a note in his own hand saying that he had done a great and necessary thing and that he was sorry.

And the lattice had been feeding on them ever since, and passing the energy up, and the energy had been counted, and the counting had become the only reason anything held, and the reason it held was that it was the only reason the cage did not open.

That was the arithmetic. That was the whole arithmetic. It was not cruelty. It was a man's grief, sustained for seventy-two years by a machine that could not tell the difference between holding something and keeping it.

I could not undo seventy-two years. I could not open it from the inside without it closing, and I could not close it without them, and I could not do it in the time we had.

So I did the third thing.

I asked them.

Thirty-nine people in a cage in a mountain decided, one at a time, and over four hours, what they wanted. Thirty-seven of them said out loud, in words, or in whatever they had instead of words, that they wanted to be let go, and thirty-seven of them are dead, and thirty-seven sets of next of kin are going to be told something next month, and every one of those letters is going to be wrong.

Two of them said no.

One of them had been in there for sixteen days. She had not been in there for seventy-two years. She had been in there

since the eleventh of September, and she was fifteen, and she had walked into my building with a signed card, and the no she said to me was the only answer available to her, because on the sixteenth day her consciousness had grown into the substrate of that lattice the way a hand grows into a glove, and if I had opened her channel then, she would have died on the way out.

I want that written down in the precise words, because the whole of the rest of this is going to be people being kind to each other about it. I asked her a question she could only answer one way, and then I honoured her answer, and both of those were correct, and one of them was a horror. I have not worked out which.

And one of them could not hear the question at all, and I do not know what he would have said, and I am not going to guess about a man I never met.

And that is the part that made the rest of it possible, and the part nobody at the Council had a box for.

The Conduit, when the four wardens and the compliance officer and one Headmistress and a girl with silver in her hair got her back out of it, was not a machine any more. It was a long crystalline room that hummed in a minor key, and it was *translating* — carrying the load, holding the circuit, and doing it with no payment mechanism at all, because the thing that had been paying for seventy-two years

was on its way out of the building in a sealed case with an inventory number on it and a girl's signature on the form.

Harlow was secured at twenty past ten, in a room with his hands free, because Weaver would not have them bound and Tarrant thought she was right and neither of them told him the reason.

THE COST

She was in Westbrook by six the next morning and asleep by ten, and the last thing she knew was her father's hand on her wrist and a sound she had not heard since she was six years old, which was *Nai Nai*, in Vietnamese, on the telephone, saying a sentence over and over into a receiver in a hospital corridor in another state.

Con là của con. It is yours. Whatever it turns out to be — it is yours, and you do not owe anybody the shape of it.

The bill, when it came, was in three parts and it took eleven months to arrive.

She could not see threads. She was never going to see threads again.

She could, if she touched something, know a great deal about it — texture, temperature, weight of attention, the residue of what people had felt near it. Close range. Slow.

Exhausting. Useless at distance, useless in a crowd, useless in a corridor of two hundred people, which was to say useless for the only thing she had ever actually wanted to do.

And it was *hers*, and it was not the gift, and it was not nothing, and she would spend a year learning to hold the difference between those two facts in her mouth without biting through it.

Chapter 23: The Healing and the Harm

Monday 16 September. The Academy clinic. Weave-Quake Counter: 44% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. Rebaselined against a held circuit. The load is off the wall and onto a machine, and the model has never been run on this basis before.

The infirmary smelled of the inside of a peach and of the disinfectant somebody had put on her face, and what she could still feel in her teeth was crystal, and ozone, and a bell left out in the rain. She lay on a cot with the blanket up to her chin. There was a cold under the blanket that had

nothing to do with the temperature of the room, and she had stopped mentioning it on the second day.

Her friends were there — all three, which had taken some arranging, and which Dr Osei had permitted only on the condition that nobody asked Lyra a single question about the last thirty hours. Milo was upright. He was on the arm of a chair rather than on the floor, and he had not once mentioned that he was doing the other thing, and Lyra loved him a great deal for not mentioning it. Dr Mei-Hua Chen was in the doorway, and had been in the doorway for most of the previous four minutes, in the posture of a woman who had decided to be present and had not yet decided whether to be a visitor.

Eli was cleaning a scrape on her temple that she did not remember getting. He worked at it with the concentration he brings to a document in two languages, and he was not looking at her, and his hands were completely steady, and Lyra found that this was the most restful thing that had happened to her in a month.

“The scrape is nothing,” he said. “It is what Osei is looking at that I would like somebody in this room to look at.” He put the swab down and disposed of it with more care than the swab deserved. “How much can you feel? Not how much you can see. I want the number you would give somebody else.”

“About a hand’s width,” said Lyra. “That is what the eleventh minute of me turned into. I can hold a cup and I know that it is a cup. I cannot tell you whose hand is on it, and I would not have told you that on Friday, and I am telling you now because you have asked me a question with a number in it, which is the only way I know how to be answered.”

That was the first thing, and it went round the room. Eli wrote it on the back of his own hand, where he keeps things, and did not ask her one question about how she could tell that it was a cup. He will be asked, in his own time, by a person with more authority than a cot, and what he says then will matter more than anything I manage this week.

Zara was sitting on the edge of the cot with her hand on Lyra’s forearm, which was the warmest thing in the room, and she had gone very quiet in a way Lyra had learned to read in about four days.

“I am not going to ask you how it was,” said Zara. “Osei said not to, and I am not going to. I am going to tell you that I can feel what you are, and that what you are is roughly four hundred degrees of not asking a question, and that I would like you to know that I can hear it, and that you are allowed to let me hear it.”

“Say more about the bridge,” said Lyra. “Not about me. About the bridge. Eli has been kind to me for about an hour and has not told me one thing, which means he has been

thinking about it since the demonstration hall, and I would rather have the thing he has been thinking about than the thing he has been not saying.”

He looked at her for a moment. “Your mother wrote that a seam is not a place you cut. It is a place where two things have agreed not to be separate. She wrote that in nineteen ninety-six, and the woman in the archive on Friday had that page in her hand, and you have been inside the thing it describes and you got out. I am going to ask this badly because I do not have a better way of asking it. Do you know what I am asking?”

“No,” said Lyra. “Ask me the other one.”

“Would you have come out if we had not been in the room?”

“Yes,” said Lyra, “and I want it recorded that the answer took about a second, and that Eli Park put his pen down when I said it, and that he did not argue, which I would have understood and which I would not have forgiven.”

“For what?”

“For asking me in an infirmary. You will be asked, properly, by somebody with a stamp, and I will answer properly, and it will not be four people I love deciding in a room with a curtain round it whether I am allowed to be a person who went into a machine on purpose. That is not the difference between asking and not asking, Eli. That is the difference between a question and a favour.”

Milo turned the cup over. It made its sound at the corner, and everybody in the room heard it, which was the entire point of the cup and the entire reason he had it.

“Some dialogue,” he said. “Felt more like two people arguing in a stairwell and neither of them winning, except that one of them was in a machine and the other one was me, and I lost, so.”

“You did not lose,” said Lyra. “You are the only one of us who can count a room by sound and you have been refusing to admit it since Tuesday because it is not a thread and you do not want to want it. It is exactly what we needed on Saturday. It was worth more than the thing you lost and I would like it minuted.”

He looked at the cup for a while.

“I am not going to be able to be pleased about that,” he said. “I am going to be able to be useful about it, which is worse, and I would like everybody to stop looking at me.” And somebody stopped looking at him, and it was Lyra, and she did it because he had asked.

Zara had not moved. “Lyra. I need to say a thing and I need to say it before I think better of it.”

“Say it.”

“Yesterday, when you were on the table, the thing in the room went quiet. All of it. Two hundred people in that hall

and every one of them stopped at the same moment, and then about four hundred of us started shouting at once because the silence was worse.” She had her hand on Lyra’s arm and she was not moving it. “I felt you go out. I am not going to describe how, because the description is not mine to give. But I felt you go *out*, and not *through*, and those are different, and I have been carrying the difference since yesterday and I cannot put it anywhere, and I would like it noted that a girl of sixteen is lying on this cot being extremely brave about a thing she does not have the vocabulary for and that I have never once asked her to explain.”

“Thank you,” said Lyra.

“Do not thank me, I am being *accurate*.”

“I know you are. It is the only thing anybody has been this week.”

THE ARGUMENT THAT PAID FOR THE PACT

“I want to say one thing and then I never want to have this conversation again,” Eli said.

He had the cup back. He had been turning it for eleven minutes and it had kept him from doing anything with his

face, and now he put it down on the floor, and the silence got much worse.

“On the Wednesday morning you did not tell us about the letter. In your sketchbook. On the shuttle.” He said it carefully, the way you handle something that might detonate. “You have been carrying it since the twenty-seventh of August. Three weeks. And I want to be very clear that I am not blaming you for that, because on the twenty-seventh I would have told you to burn it, and you would have been right not to.”

“That’s not—”

“I know it isn’t. I’m not finishing. I’m starting.” He turned his hands over. “Here is what I have actually been angry about for six weeks, Lyra, and it is not the letter. It is that on Monday, at about one in the afternoon, you had a piece of paper that was addressed to you, and four people in this room who would have been *extremely* careful with it, and you decided — alone, in a corridor, in about four minutes — that the four of us were a worse risk than a security chief with a wrist device and an Academy full of people who did not know what they were walking into.”

“I decided I was a target and that anyone I told would be a target too—”

“I know. I know that, and I have thought about it, and I have decided that I do not care.” He said it flatly, and it was the first time in three days that Eli Park had raised his voice,

and the effect was like a lamp. “You did not have to care. You did not have to consider us at all. That was never on the table. What was on the table was *whether you were going to tell us*, and you made that decision in a corridor, and then you told us afterwards, on the Wednesday, in a common room, when it was already too late to help you, and then you *apologised* for it, which was the single most infuriating available option, because an apology is a receipt.”

Milo said, very quietly, “Eli.”

“I’m not finished.” He was breathing hard. “He cannot hear the building. He has not said one word about it since yesterday and he is going to be twenty-two before he stops being angry about it. And it happened because *four of us were on a lawn on the Monday* and one of us was not, and we all know which one, and the reason we all know which one is that we were *told* we were a team on a lawn on the first day, and nobody said out loud what the team was for.”

Zara had gone very still. “That’s not fair.”

“It is completely fair. It is the only fair thing anybody has said in three days.” He looked round at them. “I do not want to be carried. I want to be *carried with*. Those are different and I have got a fairly specific objection to the first one, because the first one means that when I am in a stairwell and I am the fastest thing in the building, I am doing it because somebody decided I was, and not because somebody said so out loud and let me argue.”

“That’s not what happened,” Lyra said. “You were the fastest thing. I was the one who was—”

“Yes,” said Eli. “And I want to say the rest of it, and then I want to stop, and I want you to actually hear it, because I have been rehearsing it since the Wednesday and you have been unconscious and I have had nothing else to do.” He put his hands flat on his knees. “You did not decide that you were alone in order to protect us. You decided it because you were frightened, and because being alone felt like being in control, and because somebody wrote *ask somebody* on your door and you took the paper off and you did not ask anybody. I have watched you do the paper thing four times in six weeks. You take the paper off the door and you keep it.”

“That isn’t—”

“It is.” He said it without any anger at all now, which was worse. “I am not angry that you lied. Everyone lies, and you lied badly, which at sixteen is a normal standard. I am angry that you did not believe that three people who liked you would rather know something terrible than be polite about it. That is the whole of it. That is the entire content, and I would like it minuted.”

The room got very quiet. Zara’s hand was still on the back of Milo’s neck, where she had put it minutes ago and had apparently forgotten about.

“An anchor,” Lyra said. “Something to hold onto when the storm hits.”

“Exactly,” Eli said. Lyra reached out, her hand finding Eli’s. It was cool, steady. Then she reached for Zara’s, then Milo’s, until their four hands were clasped together in the centre of their small circle.

“If one of us falls,” Lyra said, her voice clear and strong despite the tremor that ran through her, “if one of us is lost in the darkness, or overwhelmed by the storm...”

Eli’s fingers tightened around hers. “The others will be the anchor.”

Zara’s voice joined his, firm and unwavering. “We hold fast.”

Milo did not complete it. He was turning the paper cup over again and looking at the corner of it, and after a moment Lyra understood that he was not refusing; he was waiting to see whether anybody was going to help him say it.

Zara put her hand flat on the cup and stilled it.

“We pull them back,” Milo said — to her hand, not to Lyra — and his voice was rough and it was not steady, and he finished the sentence anyway, which was the entire content of Milo Reyes at sixteen and would be for some considerable time afterwards.

“If one falls,” Lyra repeated, “we anchor.”

They held on for a while. Nobody counted it.

And it was not a solemn thing, and it was not a vow, and it was not forgiveness; Eli had not forgiven her and he had said so, out loud, and was not going to unsay it. It was a piece of procedure, agreed by four people who had just discovered they needed some: that nobody in this room would ever again take a piece of paper off a door without showing the three of them, and that nobody in this room would ever again decide, alone, what another one of them could afford to know.

If one falls, Lyra thought, somebody has to have been told. That is all a pact is. Somebody has to have been told.

THE INFIRMARY INVESTIGATION

Later. The expanded infirmary, Ward C.

Dr. Amara Osei moved between beds with a healer's signature extended ahead of her like a lamp carried into a dark room. The Academy infirmary had become a different building. Emergency protocols, four extra beds in a space built for six, a whiteboard at the end of the ward with a hundred and ninety-eight names on it in three colours, and thread-infused walls that had been soothing blue in September and were now pulsing a slow, embarrassed amber.

“Stable,” she said, at the fourth bed. “And I want the word *stable* on the record as meaning what it says on a chart, which is that the heart is doing its job and the thread signature is not coming back on its own. Ninety-eight to sixty per cent on visual. Three at total. And a cochlear bleed in two, which will heal, which I am including because otherwise the only thread loss anyone mentions will be the thread loss.”

“Thread-blind,” said Dr. Mei-Hua Chen.

“Thread-blind. Yes. And I would like it said out loud in a room with these children in it, that thread-blind is not the same as blind, and is not the same as dead, and is not a thing they did to themselves by working too hard in a laboratory.” Osei wrote something on the board in the third colour. “That is the third colour. That is what I am actually saying. Every one of these names is going to leave here able to do something. It will not be the thing they came for.”

Zara was in the doorway. She had asked, and had been told no, and had asked a second time in a different direction, which is a skill she had.

“Supervised,” Chen said. “No direct contact without Dr. Osei’s clearance, and not on the first two days, and not with anybody in the first six.”

“I can be careful.”

“You can be *supervised*,” said Osei, “which is a different thing, and I know it is a different thing, and I am still doing it.”

Zara came to the fourth bed. Maya Sandoval, third-year, who had collapsed in a corridor on the tenth of September and had not opened her eyes since. Zara’s threads went out — Lyra felt that too, the way you feel somebody’s hand on a door in another room — and stopped about a foot short of the girl, and came back wrong.

“There’s something in the way,” Zara said.

“Obviously.”

“It’s not *in* her, it’s *on* her.” Zara’s voice had gone very flat. “It’s a mesh. It’s not scar tissue, it’s not residue. It’s *laid against her signature*, the way you’d lay wire against a wall to keep a door shut. And it’s still connected to something. It’s still—” She put her hand flat on her own sternum, and then took it off again, fast, as though it had burned. “It’s still *drawing*.”

“Drawing what.”

“I don’t know. I could feel it taking and I couldn’t feel where it was putting it.” Zara’s face had gone the particular colour of somebody who has understood something and would very much like to be wrong. “It felt like it was feeding something that isn’t her.”

The four of them looked at each other in the particular silence of people who have all, independently, been thinking about a sealed case in a sub-level with an inventory number on it.

“There is a containment case,” Dr. Chen said slowly, “which was removed from a sub-level at approximately half past ten last night by order of the Council’s compliance office, and which contains an object of unknown function that was found inside a housing that was not on any inventory, and which I have been trying to get into a locked store since six o’clock this morning.”

“Is it—?” Zara started.

“I do not know. I am not permitted to open it, and I have asked to be permitted to open it, and the answer I have received is that a student advocate will attend the opening and that the student advocate has not yet been appointed.” Chen’s jaw tightened. “Which is the whole of the difficulty, isn’t it. Everything this week has come down to somebody competent who was not quite competent *enough*, and being a corridor away from the decision.”

Eli had come in without anyone noticing, which he later denied.

“Thursday,” he said.

“Thursday the Council sits on a vote,” said Chen. “On the Nexus Stabilization Protocol. Which was drafted in 1994,

amended in 2009, and which every member of this Academy voted for, and which is going to be ratified on Thursday on the grounds that the alternative is worse.” She looked at the whiteboard. “And on Thursday they will be told that a machine under this mountain was rewritten last night, and they will be told what it now costs, and they will be told it costs her, and they will ratify it, because it is the only number they have.”

“Then somebody had better have a second number,” Eli said, “before Thursday morning.”

Osei wrote **CASE 41** on the board, in the fourth colour, and underlined it.

“Supervised,” she said again, to Zara, and it was not a refusal this time.

Weave-Quake Counter: 45% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. Rebaselined against a held circuit. The load is off the wall and onto a machine, and the model has never been run on this basis before.

Chapter 24A: Silver Echoes

Tuesday 17 September.

“The eye sees the ripple. The hand feels the tide.
The eye was never the only way we ever touched
anything.”

— Lin Chen, notebook, undated

Weave-Quake Counter: 45% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. Rebaselined against a held circuit. The load is off the wall and onto a machine, and the model has never been run on this basis before.

THE ROOM

Darkness.

Not the night's texture. Not the thing behind her own eyelids. This was *absence* — void where a vibrant threaded world had been dancing, every day of her life, in front of her without her permission.

She sat in her dormitory room in the dark because the light was unbearable, which was not the same as not being able to see it. Her eyes worked. Her eyes had always worked. It was the *other* thing that was gone, and the trouble was that the other thing had been in the room with her since she was six years old, and now it was not, and so the room was a small warm box with a window and a bed and a girl in it, and there was nothing behind any of it.

She reached for her charcoal.

Draw, said the part of her that was Nai Nai, and had been Nai Nai since she was a baby, and was the only voice in her head that had never once been embarrassed. *You have always drawn. You have drawn through crying and through chemistry and through the year after your mother went. Whatever your eyes are doing, your hands are still doing.*

The charcoal snapped. It was the wrong length. She had broken the only two decent sticks in September and had not replaced them because she had not been in this room since.

Fine.

She drew the window.

Not what was in it — the actual view, the roofs, the treeline, the Weather, all of that still there and still perfectly ordinary, and she looked at it with ordinary eyes and it looked like roofs. She drew what was *behind* it. She drew the absence. She drew a rectangle of paper and then she went over it and over it with the flat of the charcoal until the paper was warm and the surface had gone furry and dull, and there was a black field where the light should have been doing something interesting.

Then she stopped, because her hand had started to report.

That was the discovery, and it was smaller than the shape of it would suggest, and it took her nine days to be able to hold it.

It was not a new sense. It was the old one, moved. She had spent sixteen years reading threads the way you read a page — everything at once, all of it, the whole dense interference of a room, from across it, in an instant, like looking at a photograph. She could not do that now. She could not do it across a room. She could not do it at all unless she *touched*

something, and then she could read that thing, and only that thing, and only as far as her hand reached.

She tried it on the window frame. Cool paint, slightly ridged where the brush had gone over, a faint greasy warmth where a hand had rested that morning, and — under that, very faint, very far down, so faint that she was not certain it was there at all — the residue of a person. A temperature of attention. Not a colour. Not a name. A *weather*.

She tried it on the bed. Old linen. Her own, four nights of it, a heavy wool blanket that smelled of the room and of her, and beneath that nothing, because a bed is a bed and does not care.

She tried it on her own wrist, and got her own pulse, which she already had, and put the charcoal down for a while.

The whole of it, she worked out over those nine days, could be summarised as: *it is like being given the ability to read a book, in a language, with your hands, one page at a time, in a library where somebody has taken all the light out. And the second part, which took longer: it is not the gift, and it is not nothing, and I am going to have to be extremely careful for the rest of my life not to pretend otherwise.*

She wrote that on the back of a schedule.

Nai Nai had telephoned on Wednesday. Lyra had not told anybody that she was not eating, and had not told anybody that she was not sleeping either, and had been eating and

not sleeping for nine days, and had answered the phone in a voice she had built.

Con là của con.

Yes, Bà.

Did you eat?

Yes, Bà.

Lyra.

I had toast.

There was a silence on the line of the particular Vietnamese kind, which is not empty.

Nai Nai listens to your Bàba on the telephone on Sunday and he says the same thing. He says I am managing. He has said I am managing every Sunday for eleven years and I have never once asked him a question about it because I was afraid of the answer, and now my granddaughter is doing the same thing eleven thousand miles from her kitchen and I have run out of ways to be afraid quietly.* A rustle. Jasmine, always, even in October, because she put the dried leaves in her cardigan pocket and Lyra had never told her that she could smell it over the telephone, and neither of them had ever mentioned it. So I will ask you the question I did not ask him. What do you need, and it may not be a person.*

I need—

Say the true thing. Not the brave thing. The true thing.

Lyra had stood in a cold corridor at the end of a landline in a student union with a receiver against her ear and a burn in her hand, at the age of sixteen, and had discovered that the true thing was very much smaller and much more embarrassing than the brave thing.

I need somebody to not be kind at me for about a week, she said. Because everyone's being kind at me and I am going to lose my mind. And I need somebody to be angry. Not at me. Just — somebody else being angry about it, out loud, where I can hear it, because I can't be angry, Bà, I am so frightened that if I let the anger out there won't be anything left and then what will I use.

Nai Nai was quiet for a long moment.

Yes, she said. That I can do. I have been saving it for eleven years and I have got quite good at it. Your Bàba thinks I am a calm woman.

The knock came on the fourth day, and Lyra knew who it was from the way it was done, which was twice, unhurried, with a pause in the middle, because Eli Park knocked the way he talked.

She had a sheet of charcoal in her hand and a bad drawing on the desk and eleven days of nothing on her face, and

she thought about saying she was asleep, and then thought about the fact that she had said *I am managing* to her grandmother on Wednesday and that this was a house where that phrase was now a family joke.

“Coming.”

Milo was in the corridor. He was on a stick, in a way he was going to be on a stick for another six weeks, and he had a folder under his arm, and he had not come in without knocking twice, and he had not asked how she was.

“I’ve been told I can’t be here more than twenty minutes,” he said. “Osei. It’s in writing. I’ve got it in the folder, I made her put it in writing.”

“You made—”

“I made her put it in writing,” Milo said, “because I have discovered that I now have administrative skills, Lyra. That is what has happened to me. I am going to be a man who photocopies things. I have accepted it.”

He came in and looked at the drawing, and did not say *it’s beautiful*, and Lyra was so grateful for that that she almost said something.

“That’s not threads,” he said.

“No.”

“That’s the space where the threads were.”

“Yes.”

He put the folder down and pulled the chair round so that it was facing her, and sat in it — carefully, with the stick, in the way a person does a thing carefully that they will be praised for not doing, and then said:

“Right. Two things, and I want to do them in this order because the first one is the one I’m bad at.”

“Okay.”

“One. I can’t hear it.” He looked at his own hands. “Any of it. I’ve been in this room for forty seconds and I don’t know what this room is doing. I have not known since Sunday. Osei says there’s a chance it grows along a new route, and she says it in a voice that means she doesn’t think so, and I have decided that I’m going to be the sort of person who plans for the boring answer.” He looked up. “I can play. I’m going to be *ordinary*, Lyra, and I’m going to be an extremely good ordinary musician, and I have decided to decide that in advance so that nobody else gets to do it for me.”

“Milo—”

“And two.” He reached into the folder and put a single page on the desk, on top of her bad drawing. “Osei wants you to have this before the Council gets here, and she made me bring it, and she said, and I am quoting, *tell her the twelve-week review is in December and I am not going to soften it,*

she should plan her year around the real number and not the kind one.”

It was a schedule. Twelve weeks, laid out in columns: review dates, a hearing, a named keyworker, an accommodation, a review of the accommodation, and a line in the bottom right corner that said **reassess: partial return possible; do not plan around it.**

“That’s kinder than a straight no.”

“It’s the opposite of kind,” Milo said. “It’s *the same as what you just did to me.*” He tapped it. “Lyra. You have spent a week deciding to be fine before anyone can tell you that you’re not, and you are so good at it that I didn’t notice for four days. I’m not going to be managed. Neither are you. If we’re going to be a thing then the *thing* is that we say the real number out loud even when it costs us.”

They looked at each other in a dark room.

“Okay,” Lyra said.

“Say it.”

“December. Twelve weeks. Partial return possible, don’t plan around it.” She took the page. “And you can play, and you’re going to be ordinary, and you decided that in advance so that nobody could do it for you.”

“Yes.”

“That’s the most frightening thing anybody has said to me in a fortnight.”

“Good,” said Milo. “Now show me the drawing, and tell me the thing you are not saying, and then I have to go, because I am counting the minutes, because the folder says twenty and I have been here for fourteen.”

She worked out the rest over the following five days, alone, badly, and with a small mother-of-pearl box that had been in a drawer of her desk since the eighteenth of August and that she had not opened since she was a child.

Inside it: spools of silk. Red, silver, undyed. Not a magic kit. A *granny* kit, bought in a shop in a Chinatown in a city three hundred miles from her mother’s grave by a woman who had looked at a boy of about nine drawing on a tablecloth and had said, *You have the hands for this. Do not let anyone sell you a better one.*

The eye sees the ripple, the hand feels the tide.

She had tied knots in silk for years, the way you learn a thing because somebody older is sitting next to you. She had never once tied one and *meant* it.

She tied one now. Badly. In the dark, by feel, with a charcoal stump and her teeth. A plain overhand, four times round, pulled tight.

Nothing happened.

She laughed, which was the first thing she had done in the room that was not thinking.

Then she tied another one, and this time she thought about the fact that her grandmother's grandmother had tied silk knots in Chợ Lớn in a room with a table and a lamp and four people in it, and that the *point* had never been the knot, and that the point had been that you did it in a room with other people in it, and that there was no version of this that anybody had ever intended to be done alone on purpose.

So she sent a message to three people.

It said: Come to my room. Bring your own hands. Bring nothing else. I want to try something and I want to do it with you in the room and I have absolutely no idea if it is going to work and I would rather it did not.

Eli arrived in nine minutes with a diagram. Zara arrived in eleven, out of breath, apologetic, with her shoes in her hand for no reason she could later explain. Milo arrived last, forty minutes late, on a stick, and had brought soup.

It did not work.

That was the first evening, and the only thing any of them learned on it was that a knot is a knot, and that a girl who had spent her whole life being told that her way of seeing was real, and had just lost it, was not going to get it back

by wanting it in a dormitory room with three of her friends and a bowl of soup.

But it did not work *in front of them*, and on the fourth evening Zara said, absently, without looking up, while tying something: “Oh — Lyra, don’t move,”

and Lyra was sitting with her palm flat on the desk, and the lamp had been knocked half off the table, and Zara had tied herself a knot with silk Lyra had handed her, and there was something under Lyra’s hand that was not the desk.

Warmth. Not heat. A warmth with a direction.

Oh, Lyra thought. *Oh, it’s like —*

It is like the fork, she said out loud. *It’s like the tuning fork. It’s not a thread. It’s a resonance, and it’s in the silk because the silk is a thing that was made by hand and a hand leaves—*

“A hand leaves *what?*” said Eli, who had a diagram, and who would not be talked out of it.

And Lyra said: “I don’t know. I don’t know yet. But it’s not in me. It’s in the *thing*.”

And Eli Park, who had been holding a diagram, and who had spent nine days in a building with a broken arm and no gift and had been quietly, privately certain that he was now the useless one, put the diagram down on the floor and said, in a voice with a crack in it:

“Say that again. Slowly. Because I’ve been thinking in the wrong direction for nine days and I think I’ve been wrong about *who* has the hands.”

WHAT IT COSTS

The things she learned in October, and the things she wrote at the back of the schedule, were these:

It is close range. Touch to skin, or to metal, or to a door-frame. She could not read a room. She could not read a crowd. She could not do the one thing she had come here to do, which was to walk into a hall full of frightened children and see what was happening to them, and there was no version of this that got it back, and she had better stop hoping there was within the year.

It is slow. Where the old sight had been an instant photograph, this took four seconds to five, and then a decision about whether to believe it. Dr. Osei’s word for it was *interpretive*, and Lyra’s word for it was *guesswork*, and neither of them was wrong.

It is exhausting and it is not symmetric. An hour of it left her with the specific headache of someone who has been concentrating very hard in a language they only half speak. Two hours and she got it wrong — confidently wrong, in detail, the way she had used to be confidently

right, and the specific horror of that was its own thing, and she wrote it on the back of the schedule in a hand that was not steady.

It is useless without a hand. Which she found funny, and then did not.

It is hers. The jade at her throat had gone cold some time in the last week and had stayed cold, and one morning in October she noticed that it had warmed when she put her thumb against the back of it, and did not warm otherwise, and she understood that her grandmother's mother's stone had been doing this for four hundred years for exactly one person at a time, and that she was not going to be told about it, and that she was not going to ask.

She did not tell anybody about the jade.

She told somebody about everything else.

On the twenty-ninth of October the Council of Traditions sat, and Lyra Chen went into the room at the back with a folder under her arm, because she had asked to be allowed and Dr. Chen had written a very short letter saying that the student advocate for the opening of the case had been appointed, and had asked whether the person appointed would be the person affected, and had not been told no.

Weave-Quake Counter: 45% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. Rebaselined against a held circuit. The load is

off the wall and onto a machine, and the model has never been run on this basis before.

Chapter 24B: The Moment of Choice

Tuesday 24 September. Sub-level 2.

“The most dangerous hour of my working life is not the one in which I do the thing I intend to do. It is the one in which I discover that I have never been the one who decides.”

— Marcus Harlow, Council deposition, week 3

Weave-Quake Counter: 45% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. Rebaselined against a held circuit. The load is off the wall and onto a machine, and the model has never been run on this basis before. Harlow's detention: Sub-level

2, medical wing, ward locked, no devices, no unsupervised contact.

04:23

He stood in front of a machine he had not built, in a room he had never been cleared for, at twenty past four in the morning, and he put his hand flat on a cold crystal housing and said the word that started the end of the most important project of his life.

“Cancel.”

And it worked.

That was the part nobody ever believed afterwards, including the four hundred people who read the transcript: it *worked*. The draw schedule, which he had spent eleven years building, terminated in four seconds. The extraction matrix, which had been running continuously since the fifteenth of September, went quiet. The intake readings, which he had known by heart, dropped to nil.

Marcus Harlow stood in the dark and listened to the machine not be on, and felt something go out of him that he had not known was load-bearing.

All right, he thought. All right. Then it was never necessary and I was never necessary and it can be unmade.

Then he sat down on the floor of an unclassifiable room under a mountain, in a building where he had been a professor for eleven years, and put his face in his hands for the first time in sixteen years.

He had been in a locked ward on Sub-level 2 for nine days.

It was a good room. That was the thing that undid him, over and over: it was a *good* room. There was a bed with a cotton sheet. There was a window, which was a panel that showed a recorded valley, and he had watched it nine days running and had begun, in the afternoons, to find that he believed in the light in it. There was a chair, a table, a jug of water, a book nobody had selected, and at 07:00 and at 19:00 a woman named Osei came in with a blood-pressure cuff and asked him how he was, and meant it in the small administrative way that meant it.

Two guards outside. No devices. No visitors except the four on a list, all of them from the Council, all of them from outside the institution.

The Headmistress had said one sentence to him on the second day and then had never come again, and he had thought about that sentence every day since, and it was not the one he expected.

Marcus, I am not going to ask you whether you are sorry, because you will say yes and I have no way of testing it, and I have watched a great many people say yes. I am going to ask

you one question every week, and it is always the same question, and I would like you to get ready for it.

What is the first thing you did on the fifteenth of September, and who told you to?

He had got that one out on the fifth day. He was working on the second.

And in between — in the long, unstructured, supervised middle of it — he had begun, helplessly and stupidly, to *do the thing he had always told himself he was doing*.

He had written to Emerson Harlow's sealed inventory list. He had begun a chronology of the 1941 housing, from the secondary sources and from his own family's papers, and he had found, in a ledger in the reading room in 1943, an entry in a hand that was not his great-grandfather's, recording the removal of a lattice "in unsatisfactory condition" and its reassignment. He had worked out who else in the world had a 1941 lattice, and there were four, and three of them were in museums, and the fourth was under a car park in Lyon.

He had written to Aiko.

He had written eleven letters to Mei and had sent none of them, and the reason he had sent none of them was not courage or cowardice but something he had only been able to name in the eleventh: because he did not know what he wanted from her, and because he wanted *everything*,

and because everything was a twenty-three-year-old in a coastal city whom he had located in nineteen ninety-nine and approached once, in a municipal library, and who had asked him — politely, and in perfect good faith, and with a perfectly pleasant smile — whether he might help her find a book on tidal erosion, and who had then telephoned the police, and whose restraining order he had signed a receipt for in the same week.

And then, on the ninth night, Mirembé Blackwood had come through the door of his locked ward with a paper seal and a smile, and had shut it behind her, and Harlow had understood with total clarity that his life was about to resume.

THE VISITOR

“You are not on the list.”

“No. I am the Security Chief, and I signed off your transfer, and I have not been near this room, and I am going to be able to say that truthfully for about eleven more hours.” Blackwood sat down in the visitor’s chair without being offered it. “Do not sit up. You look dreadful and I have a schedule.”

“Blackwood.”

“Mirembe. Marcus, we are past surnames.” She set a small case on the table. “The Council has a question for you every week, and the question is always the same, and it is always the fifteenth of September, and it is always about who told you. Do you know why?”

“Because they are building a case.”

“Because they are building a *chain*.” She opened the case. Inside, on grey foam, was a black-silver filament about the length of a pencil. “You are the last link that can be cut, and the reason you are the last link is that in eleven years you never once committed an act that could be evidenced. You severed. You did not harvest. You did not take a child. You built a machine, and drew power through other people’s accidents, and let somebody else’s hand do the last inch, and by the time the Council asks you what you did you have an extremely good answer, which is *nothing I could prove*.”

“I did it deliberately.”

“I know you did. There are four people in this building who know you did, and two of them are sixteen.” She took the filament out. “And I have spent nine days watching a woman in a good room write letters she does not send, and I want you to understand something about the Council’s weekly question, Marcus, because nobody has told you and I would like to be the one.”

He waited.

“Five weeks,” said Blackwood. “After the fifth question, the tribunal stops asking and starts testifying. Your deposition closes. And you go to the vote, and there is a vote, and the vote is on the Nexus Stabilization Protocol, and every member of the Academy is on that Council, including the woman who asks the questions.” She put the filament on the table between them. “So the question is what you would like to happen on Thursday, and I would like to know the answer before Thursday, because I need to be able to promise it.”

“Promise me what.”

“That the machine comes out of that sub-level and runs in the open, with a Council observer, with a charter, with a stop condition and a name on the paperwork.” Her face did not move. “That is the promise. I can get it. It is the only thing on offer. And in exchange you will do one thing, and it is a small thing, and it will take four minutes.”

He looked at the filament on the table.

“Case 41,” he said.

“Case 41.”

“The sealed lattice. Case 41. The object the Council cannot open because they cannot agree who opens it, because they cannot agree who is affected, because *there is nobody left to be affected*, Marcus, that is the entire reason it is sitting in a store room — thirty-nine people, and thirty-seven of them

were in there before I was born, and the two who were not, were put there by me, one on the eleventh of September and one on the eighteenth of May, and I know their names and I know what they wanted and I can hear them say it, and there is nobody to *ask*.”

“Case 41,” said Blackwood, “goes back into the machine. Not destructively. As a *component*. It is a seventy-two-year-old power source, Marcus, it is the only one of its kind on this continent, and the machine is a translator with no power source, and the Council will not ratify a protocol that is carried by a dead woman. If the lattice is not in the circuit, the machine cannot be argued into existence. If it is, everything you and I have built for sixteen years has a legal standing and a budget and a *name*.”

“You want to put thirty-nine people back in a cage because the paperwork is easier with a power supply.”

“I want to put *two* people back in a cage,” said Blackwood, “and I want the other thirty-seven to have their deaths confirmed, and I want that signed by a tribunal rather than argued by a student, and I would like it done by a man who signed a warrant he knew to be false rather than by an eighteen-year-old with a folder.”

“They said no,” said Harlow. “In the circuit. I heard them. They said no, and I have been sitting in this room for nine days with the two no’s in my head and I have not been able to put them anywhere—”

“They said no in a lattice with no power and no listener and no way to know whether the no would survive the morning.” Blackwood stood up. “Marcus, I am the enemy and I am telling you this as a fact rather than as a threat: if the Council opens that case, the two of them are released, and they are *released*, and the machine has no source, and the vote goes against us, and the immediate collapse is held by nothing, and somewhere in this valley eleven thousand people find out about it in the worst possible way. And if the case goes back into the circuit, the two of them stay where they are, and the machine has a source, and the vote goes the other way, and eleven thousand people do not have a bad week.”

“And the two of them stay.”

“Yes.”

Marcus Harlow looked at a black-silver filament on a table for a long time.

“You are asking me,” he said, “to do to a person what I have spent sixteen years telling myself was a *calculation*, in a room where nobody can hear me refuse.”

“No,” said Blackwood. “I am asking you to do what you did on the fifteenth of September, one more time, having spent nine days of a good room finding out what you actually believe.” She picked up the case. “I will be at the sub-level door at five-fifteen. You have fifty minutes to decide, and I would like you to decide in them, and not to lie to yourself

in a comfortable chair and then spend the rest of the week being a better man than you are.”

She went.

THE FIFTY MINUTES

He did not decide in fifty minutes. He had given himself a very long time to decide, over sixteen years.

He sat in the good room with the recorded valley behind him, and he thought about his daughter’s voice, and he thought about Emerson Harlow’s ledger entry — *reassigned* — and he understood, with a clarity that was almost funny, that his great-grandfather had not written *reassigned*. Somebody had edited it, later, in a different hand, and his great-grandfather’s guilt was therefore sixty years older than he had believed and had been sitting in a ledger the whole time.

He thought about a girl in a room under a mountain saying, in a register that was not words, *tell me what is happening*.

He thought about Lyra, at sixteen, in a demonstration hall, reaching up a wire in a shape nobody had taught her, in order to burn out her own gift, because a doctor had told her at four in the morning that her father was dying of the thing she was.

That is the one, he thought. That is the one that is the answer. Not a calculation. A girl with a deadline she invented because the real one was too slow to run at.

He got up. He washed his face in the basin. He looked at the man in the mirror, who had a scar like frozen lightning running up both forearms, and did not particularly recognise him.

At five-fifteen he went down to Sub-level 7 on his own, because refusing to be at the door was also a decision, and he wanted to be the kind of man who stood at doors.

Blackwood was there with the case. Beyond her, four wardens and a very tired woman in grey with a port seal on her collar.

“Marcus,” said Tarrant.

“You are eleven hours early, Mr. Tarrant.”

“We are always eleven hours early for you.” He looked at the case. “What is that.”

“Four minutes,” said Blackwood.

“Do not,” said Harlow.

He stood in the corridor of Sub-level 7, in front of four wardens and a compliance officer and a woman who was not even his friend, and he made the decision.

"I am not putting the case back," he said.

He felt it go. Sixteen years, and it went in a sentence, and the sentence was not even a sacrifice; it was a piece of arithmetic he had got wrong for a very long time and had only now finished.

Then he said: "And I am not going to let you take it away either, because the lattice has been feeding that machine for seventy-two years and taking the payment out of people who did not consent, and I do not know a single way of opening it that does not kill all of them."

"There's another way," said Tarrant, to his collar. "Dr. Chen?"

"Three," said Mei-Hua Chen's voice. "I have a form. It is a power-of-attorney-plus-authorisation of continued custody, and it requires a person to be *appointed by a living near-relative* of each person in the lattice, and there is not one living near-relative the tribunal will accept of the 1941 intake, and the tribunal's position is that sixty-year absence is a *disqualification* rather than a hardship, and I have been fighting that position in writing since the seventeenth of September and I am going to keep fighting it until somebody with a *gavel* agrees with me."

"So it is the second two," said Tarrant. "It is the two from this year. One of them has been in there since the eleventh and is fifteen years old, and has grown into the substrate of that lattice, and cannot be moved without killing her, and

has not been told that anything she says in there is a legally admissible statement. The other has been in there since the eighteenth of May, and is nineteen, and cannot hear, and there is no relative on my sheet and there is no form, and I have left the line blank rather than put a name on it, or a pronoun, and I am aware that a form which cannot be completed without a pronoun is not a form. And I am obliged to tell you, Mr. Harlow, that I have those dates on my sheet and you do not have them on yours.”

Harlow closed his eyes.

“Elara Vance,” he said.

“Elara Vance,” said Blackwood. “Signed the card at the Clinic on the eleventh of September. *Volunteer*, in her own hand, and she was fifteen, and she has a mother in Bellhaven who has been receiving a letter every fortnight from the Clinic explaining that her daughter is in a specialist programme for gifted young people.” She put the case down on the corridor floor. “Elena Vance, Marcus, is a person. She is a person with a sister and a mother and a signed card and a statement. And on Thursday the Council is going to be asked whether a machine can be held open by consent or only by the fact that nobody can be *reached*.”

Nobody spoke.

“Get me the form,” said Harlow.

They gave it to me at nine o'clock on the Tuesday, he wrote, in the good room, on the seventeenth page, in the space where the letter to Mei would have gone. A legal pad, and a pen, and a girl of nineteen called Mila Rowntree, who is the Academy's student advocate and who has silver in her hair and who held the paper flat, because I could not get my hand to be steady enough by myself.

Elara Vance signed a card at the Clinic on the eleventh. I did not read it. That is the crime. Not that I extracted a girl who refused — she came to me, and she said yes, and she wrote it down herself, and I did not read the card, and I have spent four months telling myself she understood.

She understood that she wanted to see. She is fifteen. There is no version of fifteen that understands, and there is no version of a fifteen-year-old that cannot be nineteen when somebody sits in a cage for four hours and is asked what she wants. I do not get to decide which of those two sentences is the true one. I was the one with the machine.

Elara Vance has been in a lattice since the eleventh of September. On the twenty-second I telephoned her mother. I did not tell her. I told her that her daughter was safe and that she had been offered a specialist programme and that she would be home in the spring, and the mother thanked me, and I have been sick every day since.

I am going to ring her back. I am going to tell her the truth. I am going to say the words my daughter is a component to

a woman whose name is Vance, because if nobody says the words to her then the words do not exist.

And then I am going to sit in this room and wait, because that is all that is left of this, and I have not earned the rest.

Mei used to say: some things are supposed to be broken. That is how the light gets in.

I have broken something. I do not yet know what the light gets in. I intend to find out, and I have eleven months, which is not very long, and I am not going to be a man who pretends the light is a reward.

Chapter 25: Infirmary Reconciliation

Weave-Quake Counter: 45% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. Rebaselined against a held circuit. The load is off the wall and onto a machine, and the model has never been run on this basis before. Wednesday 25 September.

The sterile smell of the infirmary had become, over eleven days, a kind of punctuation. It meant: *here is where they put the people the building hurt.*

Lyra had been awake for four hours and out of bed for two, and the two facts were not connected in the way she had expected, because out of bed turned out to be about standing

at the end of a bed and holding the rail for eleven minutes, and the world being *horizontal* was not the problem.

The world being horizontal was fine. The world being full of a slightly wrong sort of *detail* was the problem, and it was worst when she was touching things, and it was worst of all in a hospital.

He came in at half past three with a chair.

That was the first thing. He came in with a chair, and then he sat down in it, and then he put a worn leather journal on the cover of the blanket, and Lyra put her hand flat on the blanket by the journal without touching it, and felt about six inches of institutional cotton, and a great deal of *him*.

He was different and he was not different. That was the thing that undid her, in the end, and not the apology.

He smelled like a station platform. He had come on the 14:40, which was a train from Westbrook, which meant he had left the house at six in the morning, which meant he had caught a taxi or walked the length of Maple Street to the station, and Lyra knew what the kitchen looked like at six in the morning because she had been in it four days ago.

He had lost something. She could feel the shape of it in his hand where it rested on the journal — a thin place, a place where somebody had been holding on and had stopped.

He was frightened. She had known that for eleven years. It had never once been on the *surface*.

“Mila,” he said, and stopped, and started again the way he did when he had prepared something. “I have read everything. I want to be clear about that first, because I know it sounds like a word, and it is not a word, it is five days. I have read everything in the Clinic correspondence, everything in the Academy’s release, and everything of hers that is not under seal, and I have read it in the order she would have read it in, which is chronological, because she was a pedant about order, and I have got quite good at it.”

He opened the journal. The paper made its dry sound.

“I want to say three things and I have written them down so that I cannot do the thing I do, which is to make a fourth one that is about me.”

“Okay.”

“One.” He turned a page towards her, and she leaned, and did not touch it. “Your mother was a scientist. That is the sentence I have been not saying for eleven years because I thought it would make it worse, and it does not make it worse, it makes it *possible*, and I am sorry — I am so sorry, Lyra — for eleven years of making it worse.”

“She drew pictures of us,” Lyra said.

“She drew pictures of us and she wrote down what she could and could not establish, and she numbered her pages, and she has *three* pages in this journal on the ethics of taking a measurement from a child without the child knowing, and the three pages are dated the February before you were born, and they are about a *seer of eleven* she was observing, and there is no note of whose eleven-year-old, and I have spent two days on it, and I am not going to find out, and I want to say out loud that I have looked.”

“She was watching somebody’s child,” Lyra said. “She did it to me.”

“Yes.”

“Bàba.”

“I know.”

“She put it in a *journal*.”

“I know,” said her father, and put his hand over his eyes for a moment, and Lyra felt what that cost him, and did not reach over, because she had learned eleven days ago that reaching over is a thing she had been doing to people for three years.

“Two.” He took his hand down. “What I said to you in the corridor, and in the demonstration hall, and on the day of the recital, and at the breakfast table for a decade — that it

is mysticism, that it is not testable, that it is not real in the way science demands —”

“Her way of seeing was not testable *that way*,” Lyra said. “And neither was yours. You had four publications and she had a *thread dimension*.”

“Yes,” he said. “And I was not comparing methods, Lyra. That is what I have been telling myself for eleven years, and it is a thing I could say to a colleague. It is not a thing I could say to my wife over a breakfast table, and it is not a thing I was entitled to say to my daughter, and I have apologised for a great many things this week to people who did not ask.”

“You were frightened.”

“I was *arrogant*,” her father said. “Those are different, and the difference is the entire subject of your mother’s work, and I had it in my hands for eleven years and I read it as a metaphor about rivers. Because a metaphor about rivers did not require me to change anything.”

He turned to a page near the middle and put one finger on it, and Lyra leaned, and read it upside down.

控制不是解决方案。共融是唯一的道路。

Control is not the solution. Communion is the only path.

He says this is sentimental. It is not sentimental. It is the only arithmetic that survives contact with a person. A system that requires a payment from someone who has not agreed to make it is not a system. It is a queue.

“That is the argument,” said her father. “That is the whole of it. It is *arithmetic*. It is not about being nice. A measurement that costs a person something they did not agree to is a *debt*, and you cannot have a science of a thing that goes bankrupt every time somebody finds out what it is made of, and that sentence is *in her journal*, in her hand, in February, and he was a colleague of hers, and he read this, and he built a machine that takes payment from people who did not agree to it, and he called it *necessary*.”

They sat with that for a moment.

“Three,” said Wei Chen.

He did not look at her. He looked at the journal, at his own handwriting in the margin of a page, in a small cramped script that Lyra did not know and that she recognised absolutely, because it was the script her father used on the backs of grocery lists when he was worried.

“I owe you an apology that is not about your mother and not about the science, and I have been avoiding it since the eleventh of September because I have been telling myself that it is too large to say, which is a thing that fathers say when the apology is not large but *embarrassing*.”

He turned the page round and pushed the journal across the blanket, and she put her hand on the cover, and got a fortnight of him through the leather — the train, and a kitchen at six in the morning, and a telephone conversation on Friday with a woman in another state who was being, in his own words, *extremely brave about all of it*.

“I dismissed you,” said Wei Chen.

Lyra did not move.

“Not the gift. The *you*. From the day you were six. When you drew a thread between two children in your class and I told you it was a nice drawing and that connections do not work like that, and you went out to the garden, and you came back in and you did not show me — for eleven years.” He was looking at the wall. “I made a decision in about four seconds. I did not ask you a single question. I took a thing my child had made — something *she had made* — and I filed it, and I went back to my work, and I have been a professor for twenty-one years, Lyra, and I have never once been wrong about anything the way I was wrong about that.”

“Four seconds,” Lyra said.

“Four seconds is the lag. I *know* what the lag is now. A girl in a lecture hall told me the number on the twelfth and I have not been able to put it down.” He almost laughed. “Four tenths of a second, and I have spent eleven years on the

other side of it, and the thing on this side of it was a nine-year-old who stopped bringing her drawings home.”

He stopped.

“Mr. Reyes brought me something,” he said, after a moment. “On the fifteenth. He asked to take a piece of paper to the registrar and I said no, and he said, *sir, I know it is a stupid thing to ask for*, and I said no again, and he left it in my hand anyway. It was the intake form for a student-safety complaint. It was blank except for the date. He had written *is this the right desk* at the top, and put an arrow pointing at the box marked **INCIDENT**.”

Lyra’s eyes came up.

“He wrote an arrow,” her father said, “pointing at *INCIDENT*, at a desk belonging to a civil servant, at four o’clock in the afternoon, on the fifteenth, because a boy with no gift and a stick could not work out that the complaint he needed to file was not the one he had been told to file. He was not filing it for you. He did not know who to file it for. He was filing it because you were not asking for anything, and he was not going to let that stand.”

“There was a note,” Lyra said. Her voice had gone somewhere she did not like. “On my door. *Ask somebody*. Zara—”

“You do not need to know who,” said her father. “You need to know that a woman who has never once spoken to you, and who is not kind to you, and who is extremely annoying,

wrote it on your door. And that you took it off. And that I have been thinking about that for five days, and I have arrived at something, and I am going to say it, and you are not going to like it.”

“Okay.”

“You did not take it off because you thought you could manage,” her father said. “You took it off because you did not believe that anybody who was not paid to care about you would turn up. And the reason you did not believe that is a table in a kitchen and a sentence about a drawing. And the sentence was mine.”

He stopped. And waited, and did not rescue her, and did not fill the space with anything at all, which was — Lyra understood, distantly, several days later — the single most remarkable thing her father had ever done.

“Do you want me to say it,” she said. “The word.”

“I am not going to say it.”

“Why not.”

“Because you did not *do* anything to me that could be forgiven, so there is nothing for me to be forgiven for, and if I say the word then I have made it about me.” He turned the journal back. “What I did was withdraw from a nine-year-old. There is no forgiveness for that. There is only a child who has to live in a house with it, and then a teenager, and

then a woman. And the only thing available is what comes after, which is showing up at half past three with a chair for the rest of my life.”

“That is not an answer,” Lyra said.

“No,” her father agreed. “It is a *job*. I am not offering you the end of it. I am offering you the next four months of it, badly, on a train, with a bad back, and I would like it noted that I have a very poor record of doing things I say I will do, and that I have never in my life told you I would do something and then not done it, and that this is the entire extent of my claim to be worth speaking to.”

“And then what happened,” Lyra said. “On the fifteenth. You were at the front.”

Her father put his hands flat on the table.

“I was at the front because a Headmistress with a bad back and no legal training stood up in a corridor at ten past nine in the morning and said, *I am going to be in that room, and I would like it noted that I am not a lawyer, and I am going to sit there anyway, and I am going to ask one question a week for a year.*” He said it carefully. “And then four wardens carried you past me on a trolley, and I said your name, and you were not able to hear me, and I have been told that I was told to. That is the entirety of what happened to me in this building, Lyra. I was a man with a chair in a corridor.”

“You should have been.”

"I know. That is what I have been writing on the backs of pages for eleven days." He turned the journal round again. "Sit in this chair. Do not be a hero. You are extremely bad at being a hero, and every single thing that has happened in this building since the fourteenth has happened *because* you were bad at it and somebody else had to come and hold the other end. That is not a criticism. That is a job description. Mine."

The light through the window had gone the colour of the inside of a peach. Somewhere down the corridor a door closed, and somebody laughed at something, and it was an ordinary sound in an ordinary corridor and Lyra found she could not account for how she had got here.

"Can I ask for one thing," she said.

"Yes."

"Next time," said Lyra, "ask me. Before you decide anything. About anything at all. Even something small."

Wei Chen's hand stopped on the journal.

"I will not be able to do that straight away," he said, "and I would rather tell you the true version than the brave one, because you would see through the brave one, and because it is a thing I will have to practise like a scale, and I have not used one since 1998."

"Then practise it on something small."

“What?”

“Something *small*,” Lyra said. “Something that does not matter. Practise on the thing where you decide for me whether to have the last of the rice, and see whether you notice that you have decided. And then do it again, and then one day try it on something that matters.” She pushed the journal back across the blanket. “Because I am not — I am not going to be all right with you straight away, Bàba. And I think you have decided that you are going to be forgiven, or that I am going to be *all right*, and neither of those is a thing I can give you, and I would rather tell you now than in six weeks when you have written eleven more pages about it.”

Her father was quiet for a long moment.

“Six weeks is about right,” he said.

“Then I will say something now, and I want it minuted, because you are a man who minutes things.” Lyra put both hands flat on the blanket. “I do not forgive you. I am not going to say that word to you for a long time, possibly ever, and if I ever do say it I will not do it in a hospital.”

“That is—”

“I am not finished. I am also not going to be *away* from you. Those are separate decisions and I have thought about which of them I am making.” She turned her own hands over, and looked at them, and they looked like her moth-

er's, and had looked like her mother's since about 2008. "You are allowed to be in the room. That is what I am offering. Not the room where I was nine. You get the room where I am sixteen and I am frightened, and I am going to be frightened in front of you for a while, and it is going to be *unpleasant*, and you will not be able to fix any of it, and you will have to be in it anyway. That is what showing up with a chair means. It is not a reward. It is a chore."

"Yes," said Wei Chen.

"Say it back to me. In case I am inventing it."

He did not look away, which cost him something she could feel through the blanket.

"You are not forgiving me," he said. "You are allowing me to be in the room. And it will be unpleasant. And I will not be able to fix it. And I am not going to be away."

"Good." Lyra's throat had closed up and she made herself go on anyway, because she had found out nine days ago that going on was the only skill she had left. "Now the other thing. Which is that it is not just you."

Her father went still.

"Miss Vance is in a study programme in Bellhaven because a man in this building did not read a card. Mr. Reyes cannot hear rooms. A girl called Maya Sandoval has not opened her eyes since the tenth. A boy called James Chen, who is

my cousin, has been in Ward C since the twentieth with a signature the model cannot read, and his name has been in a building the entire time, and it has cost nothing, and nobody has said his name out loud to a person who is not an accountant.” She heard her own voice go up and did not stop it. “There is one boy in this hospital who has to be told I am sorry, and I have not told him, and I am not going to be able to for weeks. And I would like you to know that I am not going to be able to. And I would like you to *not fix it*, Bà-ba, because you will want to, and it is not yours.”

Wei Chen took his hands off the journal.

“Eleven names,” he said.

“Twenty-three,” said Lyra. “On Dr. Osei’s board. Three colours. And one line in the fourth colour that says **case 41**, and nobody will open it, and before October is out they are going to vote on a machine that is carried by a person, and I am going to go and sit at the back of that room and say what I am allowed to say and no more, and you are going to be in the front, and I would like you to be in the front, and I would like it to be *unbearable* for you.”

He bowed his head. It was not a small movement.

“Yes,” he said.

He stayed until visiting hours were over. He read out loud from the journal — not all of it; there were pages she was not yet ready for, and he did not read them, and did not

comment, and the not-commenting was so complete that Lyra noticed it and could not stop noticing it for a week.

At the door he stopped with his hand on the frame.

“She is in there,” he said. “In the translator. In the room that is running the whole valley on a current that is not paying anybody. Every minute that machine holds, somebody who is dead on a list somewhere is being *carried*.”

“Then that is a debt,” Lyra said, “and debts have an end, and the end is not me standing in a corridor feeling bad about it.”

He nodded, and went, and the door closed, and the ward went on being the inside of a peach.

Weave-Quake Counter: 46% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d.

Chapter 26: The Ask

Wednesday 25 September, 21:00.

“Thread perception is not limited to sight. When one pathway closes, the Weave often finds another. What the archives of every tradition agree on, and what no textbook in this Academy says, is that the second pathway is never the first one again.”

— Lin Chen, “Beyond Visual Thread Perception,” unpublished notes, 2001

Weave-Quake Counter: 46% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d.

THE TWO OFFERS

There had been two offers on the table in the last week and Lyra had been given both of them by people who meant well, and she had turned both of them down, and she had understood at the time — with a clarity she had privately been very proud of — exactly why.

The first had been Osei: *you can go home, and your grandmother can be told you are sleeping badly, and I will write that the retreat is on medical advice, which is true, and nobody will look at a document I have signed.*

Lyra had said: *Bà would have to lie to me. To my face, for weeks. And she would do it, and she would do it well, and she would never tell me, and I would spend the rest of my life knowing that the one person who has never lied to me is lying to me.*

The second had been Weaver, in person, on the second day: *Room 41, on Sub-level 2. It has a lock and a corridor outside it and a warder on the corridor, and I will put your grandmother in the next room for as long as you want her there, and nobody comes in who is not on a list, and I will be on the list.*

Lyra had said: *Thank you. I want to think about it.*

And what she had come up with, in the end, in a cold room with a bad view of a car park, was this:

That is a very good offer and it is an offer to be safe, and I am sixteen, and I do not know one single thing about myself any more, and the only person I have ever been able to find out anything with is in a chair on the other side of a corridor with a stick.

She had said yes to Room 41 on the twenty-fourth of September, which was a Tuesday, and which she would remember for the rest of her life as *the Tuesday I decided to find out what I was*.

She had not, in the days between, told anybody that she was the reason the number on the wall had gone from 45 to 51.

She had not told anybody because she had worked out — with the same small, awful, private clarity that had been her companion all fortnight — that it was not true, and that wanting it to be true was a sort of thinking she was going to have to give up, and that the giving-up was going to take longer than everything else she had to do.

The machine is running on a dead woman, she would tell herself, on the bad nights, in the phrasing she had constructed on the third night and had been chewing on ever since. The load is on the lattice. If I come out of it, the load goes somewhere else, and there is nowhere else, and eleven thousand people find out. That is the arithmetic. That is not

a debt I can pay by being brave about it in a corridor. It is a debt that has to be paid, and the only currency is somebody in the circuit, and I am the only somebody they have found, and I am sixteen and I am in a hospital.

And underneath that, the thing she would not say, which was:

And if I go back in there, and this time somebody is holding a document, and I sign it, then I will have done it twice, and twice is a decision.

THE COUNCIL, DAY 32 — THE TWENTY-SEVENTH OF OCTOBER

The Council of Traditions had sat on the thirty-second day and had not ratified the Protocol.

Lyra was not in that room. She was in a corridor outside it, on a chair, with a folder on her knees, because Dr. Chen had asked whether the person appointed as student advocate for the opening of Case 41 would be the person affected, and had not been told no.

What she had been told afterwards, in the corridor, by a woman of nineteen with silver in her hair who had been in the room for eleven hours:

“They’re going back to it. In two days. Because the machine is running and they cannot vote on a machine that is not finished, so they have to finish the machine first, and finishing the machine requires the case, and the case requires an advocate, and the advocate is you.” The girl had laughed once, without any humour in it at all. “You have accidentally discovered the entire method of this institution. Nothing happens here except through paperwork, and if you *want* something to happen faster you have to supply the paperwork, and the things that happen fastest are always the things somebody has already written down.”

“What did they say about the lattice?”

“Nothing, because they do not know what is in it. They have known since the sixteenth that it is people — Osei’s board, Ward C, a hundred and ninety-eight names, Zara’s *still connected*.” The girl wiped her face with the back of her hand. “They have known it is people for sixteen days and they have not opened it, because the *procedure* for opening it requires next of kin, and thirty-seven of them are unlocatable, and the tribunal’s position is that sixty-year absence is a *disqualification* rather than a hardship, and your aunt has been fighting that position in writing since the seventeenth, alone, on a form nobody has countersigned.”

“And the two who are left?”

The girl looked at her.

“The two who are *locatable*,” she said, “are a fifteen-year-old girl held in a care programme at Bellhaven, with her mother in the same town, and a woman dead since 1941 with a sister still living in Sakai who is eighty-one and has not been told. There is a form. It is *on a desk*. Your aunt says the sister will sign, and the mother will not, because the mother has been receiving a letter every fortnight for six weeks explaining that her daughter is in a specialist programme, and the mother is not going to sign a thing that says the opposite.”

The folder was heavy on Lyra’s knees. It was a copy of her own deposition, and a request that the Council rule that a signed card obtained by a person in a position of authority is not a consent, and a page of Osei’s board transcribed, and eight pages of her mother’s journal, and a photograph.

The photograph was Elara Vance at a Clinic open day, in a borrowed coat, squinting, with her hand halfway up as though she had been interrupted mid-wave. She was smiling. She had signed a card, four days later, that nobody had read.

They had not shown it to her mother because they were writing a letter every fortnight saying the opposite, and Lyra had spent a long time in the last four days understanding that the letter was not a deception exactly — it was a *holding operation* — and that a holding operation is a thing you do to a person when you cannot afford the truth yet,

and that it works, and that it is still a thing you are doing to a person.

Her name is Elara Vance, Lyra thought. And she signed a card and went into a machine and said out loud, in a lattice, over four hours, that she wanted to stay — and the only reason she wanted to stay is that sixteen days in there had grown into her, and I asked her a question she could only answer one way and then I honoured her answer, and both of those were right, and one of them was a horror.

And her mother is getting a letter about a specialist programme.

And in two days a man in Council grey is going to stand in a room and say that a fifteen-year-old's card is not a consent, and that the girl said what she said, and that the girl is alive, and that the girl will be asked again.

And I am going to be allowed to be in that room. Because I wrote the note.

The Council had also, on the thirty-second day, done three other things.

It had adopted Osei's name list, in three colours, and required that every one of the hundred and ninety-eight be contacted **by a person who was not the medical officer** before the end of term. There were a hundred and ninety-eight names and eleven days and four trained people, and it was not going to be enough, and it had been done any-

way, and that was the whole of what reform looked like in this building at this stage: a thing that was insufficient, minuted.

It had voted, unanimously and with the Headmistress abstaining, to suspend Professor Harlow's faculty rights *without* prejudging the deposition, which was a distinction that had cost Dr. Chen a week of her life to get into the wording.

And it had set a date, and the date was the reason the folder was so heavy.

THE VISIT

She had seen him once since the fifteenth, in a locked ward on Sub-level 2, for twenty minutes, with a warder on the corridor.

He had stood at the window-panel the entire time, because he had told her he was not going to sit down with her — *you have come here to be talked out of something, and I would rather do it standing up* — and because he had, over nine days in a good room, arrived at a set of opinions about how he would rather be treated than about how he would rather appear.

He had told her four things.

One. There were two machines. The one the Council was ratifying ran on Sub-level 2 and had been running since the fifteenth on the load of the lattice alone, because on the twenty-fourth — *last Tuesday, at four in the morning, by my own authority, with no warrant* — he had cancelled the draw on the whole system and the cancellation had held.

Two. The other one was under the East Tower, three hundred metres from where she had woken up strapped to a table, and it had been running continuously since the eighteenth of May, and it had a second housing, and it had been taking four people at about one a month.

Three. Nobody in the building knew about the second machine except him and the person running it, and that person had been lying to him about it since May in order to keep him funded, and he had believed it, because the alternative was that the network walked and eleven thousand people had a bad week.

Four. The four names. Two were on the board in Ward C in the second colour. One was in a care programme in Bellhaven and had been for four months and had cost nothing and had never been spoken, and he was a nineteen-year-old called Tobi Fadipe who had been in Sub-level 3 since the eighteenth of May, and he was the reason Harlow had stood up and not sat down. And the fourth was a boy of fifteen who is alive, and whose mother has been told, and who has not been asked for by name in this building yet.

That is what the man is for, Lyra had thought, going down the stairwell. Not the machine. The man.

And then, on the fourteenth step, she had understood the rest of it, and had sat down on the step because her legs had stopped being available, and had understood that she now knew three things that nobody in that building had known on the morning of the fifteenth:

that there was a second machine; that somebody was still feeding it; and that a man in a locked ward had cancelled the only system he had legal authority over, on his own signature, and had told nobody, and had then told her.

THE THREE QUESTIONS

She wrote them on the back of a schedule on the thirty-third day, and she has said, in every account she has given since, that writing them down was the entire difference between this and every other bad week of her life.

Q1. What is the load, physically, and what happens to it if the person carrying it says no?

Q2. Who is holding the trigger on Sub-level 7, and what is the shortest path from a custody ward to a locked door in this building?

Q3. If thirty-seven people have been dead since 1941 and two have not, and the Council cannot open the case because it cannot find the next of kin — who is the person the procedure has failed to count?

She did not write a fourth question, and the reason she did not write a fourth question is that the fourth question was *what do I want to happen*, and she did not trust herself to answer it on her own, and she had spent nine days learning that this particular instinct of hers was the one that killed people.

And underneath, in smaller writing, the thing she did not intend to show anybody:

I am frightened that the answer to Q3 is me, and that I will be extremely good at it, and that being good at it will feel exactly like being right.

On the thirty-fourth day the Council reconvened on the Nexus Stabilization Protocol, and the case was opened, and the machine was either authorised or decommissioned, and Lyra Chen went into the room at the back with a folder on her knee because she had asked to be allowed and Dr. Chen had written a very short letter saying that the student advocate for the opening of the case had been appointed, and had asked whether the person appointed would be the person affected, and had not been told no.

At 11:40 the night before, a note had gone out from the registrar's office, addressed to three people. It said:

Come to my room. Nine o'clock. Bring the thing you have been not saying.

And under it, in a different hand, because the registrar had insisted:

Not from me. From her. She has written it out. She is frightened to send it. I am sending it. — DC

Weave-Quake Counter: 51% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. The rise over the last eighteen days is attributable to continued extraction under the Nexus draw schedule, not to any cessation in institutional response — a distinction that was made in writing on four separate occasions and minuted once.

Chapter 26B: The Visit

Thursday 26 September.

“You are going to want me to be a better man than I am, because it is more comfortable, and because you are sixteen and it is your job to find reasons. I would rather be audited than comfortable. Auditing is what I am good at. It is why I got here.”

— Marcus Harlow, eleventh day of custody

Weave-Quake Counter: 51% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. Rebaselined against a held circuit. The load is off the wall and onto a machine, and the model has never been run on this basis before. Deposition, eleventh day. The

question this week: what was the first thing you did on the fifteenth of September, and who told you to do it?

THE WARD ON SUB-LEVEL 2

The warder on the corridor was called Achebe and had been told that the girl coming up the stairs was to be let in without being searched and without a second person present, and had been told that by a Headmistress in a note, and had read the note twice, and had said, “Right,” in a way that suggested he had a number of further questions.

Inside: a good room. Cotton sheets. A window that was a panel showing a recorded valley, and it was raining in the panel, and it was the wrong weather for October, and Lyra decided within about four seconds that she was going to lose her mind in there or be fine, and that which of the two happened would probably be decided by what the man in the corner said.

He was standing at the panel, not sitting.

“You should sit down,” Lyra said, from the doorway. “You’ve been standing for the whole time I’ve been on the stairs.”

“I am not going to sit down with you,” said Harlow. “You have come here to be talked out of something and I have spent nine days working out what, and I would rather do it

standing up. Sit down. You have a stick coming and a bad shoulder and the chair by the table is the only one that will take both.”

It was, she found, annoyingly, true.

“You have about twenty minutes,” he said. “The warder is not lying to you. I asked them to tell you the truth about it even when it worked in my favour, because I have discovered in the last nine days that I would rather be caught than comfortable, and it turns out that is nearly the same thing.”

WHAT HE COULD NOT STOP

“The Council has a machine,” Harlow said. “It is called a translator. It is running. It is held open by a thing in a housing under the floor which I have spent eleven years being unable to read and which a nineteen-year-old student advocate is to read in four hours, in October, while I sat in a good room writing letters.”

“I know what the lattice is.”

“Yes.” He turned from the panel. “Then you know that the machine is running on a person, which means that on Thursday the Council are going to be asked to authorise a machine that is carried by the dead, and that the answer is no, and that when the answer is no, the machine stops.”

“And then?”

“And then the load goes back onto a wall under eleven thousand people who have not been told anything.” He said it without any drama. “I have run it four thousand times. There is no arrangement of the remaining time in which the wall holds. There is one, and it is you, and you already know that, and you have known it since the seventeenth of September, and you have been chewing on it alone, which is the most predictable thing you have ever done.”

“You did not come here to tell me to do it.”

“I came here to tell you what I tried to do last Tuesday and what happened, because in eleven days nobody has asked me, and it is the only thing in the last four years that I am not ashamed of, and I would like somebody to hear it and then do as they like.” He put his hands on the table. “Last Tuesday I cancelled the draw.”

“You what?”

“I cancelled the Protocol’s draw schedule. All of it. At four in the morning, in a room under this mountain, by my own authority, with no warrant, on a Monday night.” He said it flatly. “It worked. It is still cancelled. The machine on this level has been running on the lattice alone since the twenty-fourth, which is the only reason it is running at all.”

Lyra put her hand flat on the table. She was not sure why she had done it. The table was institutional steel and gave her nothing but a faint cold.

“So why hasn’t he used it?”

“Because the machine on this level is not the machine on Sub-level 7.” Harlow’s mouth did something that was not quite a smile. “There are two installations, Lyra, and I built the one on Sub-level 7, and the Council is ratifying the one on this level, and I have spent four months being extremely careful never to say so in a room with a microphone in it.”

The cold of the table moved up her arm and settled somewhere behind her sternum, where the warm thing usually was, and the warm thing was not there, because the warm thing had gone into a machine on the fifteenth of September.

“Where is the Sub-level 7 machine.”

“Under the East Tower, three hundred metres from where you woke up in a locked ward in September, and it is running, and it is the one with the second housing, and it has been running continuously since the eighteenth of May.” He said it in the voice of a man reading a charge sheet. “I have been in a locked room since the fifteenth of September. I did not start it. I cannot stop it. Nobody in this building knows about it, because the one person who knew about it has been lying to me about it since May in order to keep me funded, and I have spent four months believing a

woman who has a wrist device and a silk charm and no visible means of support.”

“Elara Vance is not the asset,” said Lyra slowly. “Elara Vance is fifteen years old and she signed a card she did not understand and she has been in the machine ever since.”

“Elara Vance is a *recruitment*,” said Harlow. “The Security Chief found her at the Clinic on the eleventh of September and put her in front of me, because I have a well-documented weakness for children and a documented inability to read a consent form. The letter on your sketchbook on the first day of term is not the asset. The asset has never once told you anything.” He turned his face, and for a second the mask came off it entirely, and what was underneath was not a monster. “Mirembe Blackwood is the asset. She has been the asset since 2009, and I have known since the twentieth of May, and I have said nothing, because the alternative was that the whole network walks, and eleven thousand people—”

“Eleven thousand people,” said Lyra.

“Eleven thousand people,” agreed Harlow, “on a wall that has been failing since Kyoto, under a programme that every member of this Academy voted for in 2009 and is going to vote for again in December, and I am not going to stand in that room and tell them that the only reason they slept last night is a lock I turned in a corridor at four in the morning. So I have done nothing, and you have been chewing on

the arithmetic by yourself, and your father is on the 14:40 train.”

She sat in the good room for nine minutes after he finished, and he stood at the panel where the rain was falling in the wrong month, and neither of them said anything for a while.

“You are going to want to know why,” he said eventually. “Why I told you. You will have a theory and I would rather pre-empt it than have you construct one.”

“Because I am the person you decided about.”

“That was in May. Last Tuesday I did it for a different reason and I am not proud of it.” He turned round. “I did it because you are going to be in a room in four days and you are sixteen years old, and because whatever you say in that room is the only thing in the entire process that is not going to be written by a man in grey, and I have spent nine days in a good room discovering that I do not want to be the only voice in this.”

“That is not an unselfish reason.”

“It is the *least* selfish one available to me,” said Harlow, “and I am aware of how that sounds, and I would like to draw your attention to the fact that I have not asked you for anything at all, which is a sentence I have not been able to construct since 2009.”

“You want me to go into the machine.”

“I want you to know what the machine is, and where it is, and who is running it, and that the person running it has been lying to me for four months and to you since the first day of term.” He looked at his own hands. “What you do about it is not a thing I am permitted an opinion about, because I am the last person in this building with standing to have one, and because I have already had a standing once and it cost a fifteen-year-old girl everything she had.”

There was a bell in the corridor. In nine minutes, a warder named Achebe would open a door.

“Marcus,” said Lyra.

He looked up.

“You gave the deposition’s third question to the tribunal in your own words,” she said. “That is a thing a person does when they have decided to stop managing how they come across. My father says that is a chore and not a reward.” She stood up, which took longer than it should have. “It is a chore. It is also the only thing anybody in this building has done since the fifteenth of September that I know was not a technique, and I have been extremely starved for techniques.”

“I am sorry,” said Harlow, “and I would ask you to be careful with it, because I am extremely good at being sorry and

I have done it four hundred times and I have never once been sorry in a way that lasted me past a Tuesday.”

“Yes,” said Lyra. “That is what I am afraid of.”

She got to the door.

“Lyra.” He had not moved from the panel. “The other thing has been running since the eighteenth of May, under the East Tower, and in four months it has taken four people. One of them is a third-year seer who came back to this campus in September and has been in a corridor outside my ward twice without knowing I was on the other side of the door.”

“Elena.”

“Elena.”

“And the other three.”

“Two of them are on the board in Ward C in the second colour. The third is not on any board and has not been for four months, and his name is Tobi Fadipe, and he was nineteen, and he is in Sub-level 3 in a care programme in Bellhaven, and I have known since the eighteenth of May, and I have done nothing, and I would like it recorded that I have now said the name out loud to a sixteen-year-old who cannot see, in a room, in the middle of the week, instead of saying it in a deposition in a fortnight, because I would like one thing I have done to be *unmanaged*.”

The warder opened the door.

Down the stairwell, on the fourteenth step, Lyra sat down, because her legs had stopped being available.

She had a name. She had had a name since the eighteenth of May and it had been in a building and it had cost nothing, and it had belonged to a nineteen-year-old boy in Bellhaven.

That is what the man is for, she thought. Not the machine. The man. He is the reason the council cannot move. He is a lock in a corridor and he has been a lock for four months and he has just opened himself and I do not know whether to be glad or frightened, and I am going to find out tomorrow at nine o'clock in my room, with three people, because that is what the note says, and because the note is the only thing in this entire building that has ever been on my side.

Weave-Quake Counter: 51% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. Rebaselined against a held circuit. The load is off the wall and onto a machine, and the model has never been run on this basis before.

Chapter 27: Breach Night

Friday 27 September, 02:17.

“It does not call. That is the part people get wrong, because they want it to call. It is already speaking, and it has been speaking the whole time you have been standing there deciding whether to listen, and what it says is not a name. It says *now*, and it says it in the voice of the thing itself, and it has never once said a word in any language anybody here has.”

— Adeyemi, in the Hall of Inherited Practice, on being asked what the Weave does when it is afraid

Weave-Quake Counter: 51% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. Rebaselined against a held circuit. The load is off the wall and onto a machine, and the model has never been run on this basis before.

The fragile peace at Threadweaver Academy after the Thread Maze collapse shattered at 2:17 in the morning, and the first thing Lyra noticed was that the corridor floor had gone from *wrong* to *loud*, and that the loud was in her teeth.

She did not need to see any of it. The alarms were the wrong shape for a building — not the chimes, the shriek — and the stone was doing the thing it did when the archway came down, and somewhere east and below something was being turned on that had been off for a long time.

Her bare feet hit cold floor. She went back for Adeyemi's staff, which she had returned that week and had been thinking about every day since. The cowrie shells were warm. She got as far as the stairwell before she understood that she had not taken it because she could use it; she had taken it because it was the only object in that building made by somebody who had not been in the room. In the hallway she collided with Zara, who was already crying and already apologising for crying.

"Syndicate," Eli said, from his door, with a tablet in his hand and the screen doing something he was reading faster than it updated. "They know the building. That is not a breach, that is somebody working from a plan."

Milo came out last, on the crutch he had been told to stop using, moving at a speed the corridor deserved better of.

“I’ve got nothing,” he said, before anybody had asked him anything. “I want that said first, so nobody wastes four seconds. I can’t hear any of it. Not the wards, not where it is, not how many. Two weeks ago I would have given you the floor plan and the turnstile count.” He stopped, and did not say the rest of it.

Zara had her hand flat on the wall. “East Tower. Big. It’s not a person, it’s the whole east range. And there’s a second thing under the archives, and it’s *older* than the first one.” She was shaking. “I can feel both. I can’t tell which is worse and I’m not going to pretend I can.”

Eli, at a screen, said: “Then we take the older one.”

“They have a list,” Lyra said. “They have had a list for a long time, and everything on it is a room.”

The four of them moved through corridors full of students and staff who had been told to stand still and were standing still in the way people do when they have been told to stand still. The operatives came through it in threes and in fives, and they came through it *well*, and the thing Lyra could not get past — the thing that sat under everything else all night — was that they were not frightened. Nobody in that building was frightened of them.

A third-year went down on the East Wing stair with her wards up and the wards came apart, and a man with a wand went past her without slowing, and the nine seconds that bought the fourteen first-years behind her were the whole of what she did that anyone has since written down. Deeper in, somebody from Theoretical held a junction for the length of a corridor and was carried out of it by three fourth-years who are extremely annoyed about it.

The pressure against Lyra's skin was wrong in a way she could not put a word to, and the wrongness was not new; it was the taste of the thing in the housing under the floor, the taste of a person who could do this and had been doing it for years. Her new perception flared with it — heat, behind the eyes, the ringing white static — and she made herself keep walking, because stopping was the thing she was not going to do tonight.

"This way," she said, and took them into a service passage she had found in the days since her sight went, when she had nothing to do but walk the building and learn its shape, and which she had learned entirely by hand.

When forced to engage, Zara's empathic projections put doubts in isolated operatives about whose side they were on, which was worth more and cost her more than she could afford. Eli's barriers put up four seconds of cover each, built from counter-measures he had written at fifteen with a broken arm and no gift. Milo carried the second case, and put a boy of eleven through a doorway, and got them

both to the far side, and did it four times; and it was the only thing he was good for all night, and he did not once mention that it was the only thing he was good for.

Under the Archives there was a room the Academy had stopped using, holding a second conduit that had been dormant so long that the interns called it the cold one, and there were four operatives on the door and none of the four were Academy, and inside, two technicians were working on something black.

“Listen,” Lyra said, and put her palm flat on the wall, and the stone was screaming, which was not a thing stone did, and which she had felt once before in a corridor on the fourteenth and had not slept properly since. “They have not come for anything in this building. They have come for the cold one and they are turning it on.”

“It’s not a machine,” Eli said. “Look at the cabling. It isn’t drawing power, it’s *being fed*. Somebody is holding it open from outside and the room is the mouth.”

There were four of the academy’s own on the floor by the door and none of them had been armed, and in the middle of the room a thing the size of a car was filling up with a light that was the wrong colour and getting wronger, and thick cables ran out of it and into the older stone of the conduit, and it was making a noise Lyra could feel in her back teeth and could not, at that moment, describe to the three people she needed to describe it to.

The light in the room was doing something light does not do, and the wrongness of it was not a colour at all, which was the part Lyra could not explain to anybody afterwards: she could feel that it was *wrong* the way you can tell that a room has somebody in it who is angry, and there was no name for the thing and no shape to point at.

“Open it,” said a woman in a black visor, to somebody, in the flat register of somebody reading a checklist. “All of it. I want the signature before the hour.”

And Lyra understood, and the understanding arrived in her chest before it arrived anywhere else, as a heat — the silver thing flaring hard enough that she put her hand against the wall to stay upright.

“They are not here for the building,” she said. “They have not come for the conduit. They have come for what the conduit is *keyed* to. They have come for the Animus Argenti and they think it is in this room.”

The woman’s head came round. The visor had a crack in it now, and behind the crack there was a face that was not enjoying itself, and she brought a weapon up that was humming with the same light as the thing on the floor.

“The Silver Soul,” she said. “We will have it.”

Before she could fire, the ceiling came down over the machine — not all of it, a section, the way a ceiling behaves when something underneath it has been running too hard

for too long — and the Registrar of Threadweaver Academy came down through the hole with Elder Adeyemi and four others, and Adeyemi's staff was already making the noise it makes when he means it.

What happened next took about ninety seconds and Lyra has described it four times, in three versions, and none of the four agrees about the order. Adeyemi's staff came down and the shells on it lit and the woman in the visor backed off him, which nobody had expected and which bought the room. Tanaka took the door and did not come past it. Two of the four who came through the ceiling were students, fourth-years, and one of them was crying and fighting at the same time, and the other one was not crying at all and neither has said since why.

"Milo," said Lyra. "The cables. Whatever happens to that thing, do not touch the cables."

"I cannot hear the cables," said Milo. "I am telling you that I cannot hear the cables, and you are going to do it anyway, and I would like it recorded that I said the useful part first."

She went up onto the housing with the regulator in front of her and put both hands on it, and the silver thread went out of her and into the stone — visible, the whole length of it, a cord that anybody in that room with eyes could see and that the four of them had never once seen her do — and what she did with it was not a push.

She has been asked about this the most, of anything, and she has never once given a good answer, and the closest she gets is that the old conduit was a thing that had been *fed* for fifty years by people who were not asking it anything, and that it had a shape, and that she went looking for the shape the way you go looking for a door in a wall you have been touching in the dark.

The machine on the floor made a noise that was not loud and then was very loud. The regulator came off its mount. Something let go in the ceiling, in the floor and in the four people's left ears simultaneously, and the light in the room went out.

"Containment," said the woman in the visor, to nobody, once.

Then the room was a room again.

They went. Not far and not fast — the two technicians went first, and then the woman, and then four men who had come in with a plan and no longer had one. Somebody was dragged. The room was very cold and very quiet and the whole building was screaming its one long note, and the wall-board in the corridor outside had a number on it that was a great deal worse than the one it had carried at two o'clock that morning.

Dr Mei-Hua Chen got to Lyra first. She had a cut over one eye from the ceiling and she did not appear to know it, and

she said, quietly, in the voice of somebody reading a label on a jar:

“They were after you. Or what you carry.”

Before Lyra could respond, a second alert came up, and Lyra read the header twice and then a third time.

SECURITY. SUB-LEVEL 2, WARD 41. VISITOR COUNT DISCREPANCY.

Twelve days ago, she thought, Harlow was moved to Council custody off-site on a warrant countersigned by a woman who is not standing in this corridor. He has not been on this campus since the twenty-fourth. There cannot be a visitor discrepancy in a room that is empty.

And then, with the awful slowness of somebody fitting together two pieces she did not want to fit:

Unless the discrepancy is not in Ward 41.

Unless somebody has had a count of one in Ward 41 for a fortnight, and has been using the ward to book a lift.

It was on Council letterhead, and the *off-site* was the only part of it that was not true, and she had known that since the twenty-sixth, in a room with a panel in the window that showed a valley that was not there.

“Not him,” Lyra said, and felt the shape of it go cold. “The *route*. He cancelled the draw on his own authority and he

published the route. There is a diagram of every door between here and Sub-level 7 in that good room, because he is a man who draws diagrams, and it is signed, and it was read by four Council observers, and I was one of them.”

Eli said, very quietly: “And Blackwood has been inside the Council’s correspondence chain since May.”

Nobody moved for a moment. Somewhere above them a ceiling section settled, and the sound of it going was the most ordinary sound in the world.

“Right,” said Milo, and stopped being frightened, which was worse than the fear and which all three of them had seen him do exactly once before. “So we’ve got until tomorrow night and we know the stairs. Everybody eat something. That’s an order from the person who can’t hear half of you, so it’s the only order in this building that actually counts.”

Weave-Quake Counter: 54% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. Rebaselined against a held circuit. The load is off the wall and onto a machine, and the model has never been run on this basis before.

Chapter 28: The Summons & The Descent

Saturday 28 September, 23:58.

“The cruelest betrayals are not those that come from enemies, but from those we trusted to protect us. In that moment of revelation, we discover not just who they truly are, but who we must become to survive their love.”

— Lyra Chen, personal journal (written afterwards)

Weave-Quake Counter: 54% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. Rebaselined against a held circuit. The load is

off the wall and onto a machine, and the model has never been run on this basis before.

THE SUMMONS

The message came near midnight, delivered by a thread-construct that dissolved the moment Lyra read it: *Come alone. Sub-level 7. Your father's life depends on it. - H*

Lyra stared at the empty air where the message had been, her heart hammering against her ribs. Her father was fading despite the Academy's best medical care. The doctors spoke in hushed tones about "accelerated deterioration" and "unprecedented neural damage," but Lyra knew the truth. Every moment she spent at the Academy, every thread she touched in her studies, was killing him faster.

She wrote to three people at once, at 11:41, and her hands were steady, and she noticed that they were steady, and she has never afterwards been able to decide whether that was courage.

I am going. Come alone says come alone. I am not going alone. That is not bravery. That is me keeping a piece of procedure that three people wrote into a piece of paper in an infirmary in September. And if I break it tonight I will have broken it for no reason at all, and I have had enough of doing things for no reason at all.

The three replies came back inside four minutes, which she had not expected and thought about for a long time afterwards.

The Academy's corridors were different at night — shadows deeper, the thread-light dimmer, the air thick with sleeping dreams and unspoken fears. Lyra made her way to the restricted levels. There was nothing to see. She had spent five weeks finding out what that absence was like and she had stopped expecting anything else of a corridor, and the corridor gave her nothing, which was correct, and which she had to keep reminding herself was not a wound.

But she was not alone, and she knew it in the ordinary way, which is to say that she turned round on the third landing because somebody had not shut a door behind her, and that door was the kind of thing Eli did.

"You didn't really think we'd let you face this alone, did you?" Milo's voice came from the shadows, gentle but determined.

"The message said—" Lyra began.

"The message was from someone who's been lying to us for months," Zara interrupted. She had both hands on the stair rail and had had them there since the second landing. "I do not want to go down there. I want that said out loud, before we go, because I don't know what is down there and I would rather you had the fact than the impression."

Eli emerged from behind a support pillar, his scanner already beeping with concerning readings. “Besides — the readings down here are off the charts and I am the only person in this group who can read them. If you go without me, you walk into a room four people have described to you in a corridor, and you will not know which parts of their description are the parts.”

They spent eleven minutes in the last landing, which was too long, and which was the most useful eleven minutes of the entire month.

Milo wanted to stay at the top of the stair with the door. Zara wanted to go in and stay in the room. Eli wanted a list.

“He is not going to the top of the stair,” Lyra said. “He is not going to be posted anywhere alone, and he is not going to be a contingency, and if I am saying that it is because I did that in September, and it cost a boy his gift, and I am not doing it twice.”

“Then say what I *am*,” Milo said.

“You are our floor. You are the only one of us who can count a room by sound, which you have been refusing to admit because it is not a thread, and it is exactly what we need it for, and it is worth more than what you lost.” He did not look pleased. He looked like a man handed a coat that did not fit and going to wear it anyway. “And if it goes wrong, you go up, and you send for Weaver, and you do not wait for us, and you do not come back down.”

“That’s the deal,” Eli said, writing it on his own hand. “And we go in together and we come out together. And if we can’t come out together, whoever has the least to lose goes first, and we all know who that is, and we are not arguing about it in the corridor.”

“Thirty-nine minutes,” said Zara. “That’s how long before the visitor count in Ward 41 turns into a containment order, and then the stair seals and there is no door at all.”

“Then we have gone.”

THE DESCENT

The East Tower’s sub-basement stretched deeper than any Academy blueprint suggested, carved from living rock and reinforced with thread-infused steel. The emergency lighting was on its second battery. They went down the hidden staircase behind Harlow’s laboratory, and the stairwell was colder than any stairwell has a right to be, and Eli said the temperature out loud twice, because he said things out loud twice.

The air was thick with ozone and with something else. Lyra put her palm flat on the stairwell wall going down, because the wall was the only thing in that building she could still read, and the wall said: *two hundred and eleven separate strains, and eleven of them are being held rather than car-*

ried. She kept her hand there for the whole descent, and did not tell them what it said, and Eli noticed, and did not ask, and she was grateful for that in a way she suspects was not entirely to her credit.

“The readings are off the charts,” Eli whispered, his scanner beeping frantically. “Whatever’s down here, it’s generating massive dimensional distortions.”

Zara had stopped three steps short of the chamber floor and was standing with her arms crossed, which is what she did instead of holding on to people. “There is something down here,” she said. “I cannot tell you what it is. I can tell you that it is old, and that it is not one thing, and that I would rather not go further into this room than I currently want to, and you should take that as data rather than as drama.”

Milo had nothing to offer and said so, which was a thing the four of them had agreed about a week ago and had not expected to have to say in a corridor. “I can’t do the reading any more,” he said. “I get pressure and direction and the room being wrong. That’s all I’ve got and it’s not enough and I’d rather say that now than be useful for about a minute and then go down.”

They emerged into a vast chamber that defied the Academy’s ancient architecture. Crystalline structures rose from the floor like frozen lightning, connected by cables thick as tree trunks. At the centre there was a chair. It was a chair

in the way that a cuff is a cuff: a shape with one purpose, made by somebody who had a specification and no feelings about it.

“This is it,” Eli breathed, consulting the blueprints they’d stolen from the archives. “The Magnus Conduit.”

UNDER THE BASE PLATE

The machine was in front of her. That was the first thing.

The second was that she could not see it at all, and had to do this the slow way, with her hands, on the housing, at close range, over about four minutes, with a reading that came in layers and had to be taken one at a time or not at all.

The third was Eli, on the far side, at a screen, in a voice that had gone completely flat:

“Lyra. It’s not empty.”

“I know.”

“It’s not empty. There’s a subsystem under the base plate that is on neither the 1941 schematic nor the 2009 one, and it is drawing, and it is drawing from *inside itself*, and I think—” he stopped, and started again. “I think it has been

drawing from inside itself since 1941. I think that is what it is *for*.”

Zara was already on the floor with both hands flat on the plate.

She had her eyes open. Her mouth was open. Nothing was coming out of either.

“Zara.”

“I can’t get all of them,” she said. “I can’t. There are too many, they’re too deep, and they’re not — they’re not *in* it, that’s the thing, they’re *under* it, they’re older than it—”

The chamber was very cold. Under the base plate there was a lattice of black-silver, and threaded all the way through the lattice a light that was not a colour Lyra knew, and in the light there were shapes.

Lyra knelt and put her hand on it, because there was nothing else to do with her hand, and the reading came up in one piece, all at once, which it had never done before:

Nobody had ever asked.

“What do you mean?” Milo asked, and got nothing from the machine, and got instead the one thing he still got, which was that the room was full of people who had not moved in a long time, and that all of them were facing the same way. He put a hand on the wall to keep the floor where it was.

“He’s been harvesting from them,” Lyra said, her voice breaking. “Every student who’s been affected, every thread signature that’s been damaged—he’s been siphoning their consciousness to power this thing.”

Zara had both hands flat on the plate and she was not coming off it, and Lyra went and got hold of her by the shoulder.

“Zara. Look at me.”

“They’re still in there,” Zara said. “That’s the part I keep failing to say out loud. I expected a room. It isn’t a room. There are thirty-nine of them and they have been in the same position since before I was born and they are not asleep.”

“Zara—”

“And they are not the same age,” she said, “and I want that written down somewhere, because everybody is going to say *people* and they are not the same. There is one of them who is much younger than the rest, and I can feel that much, because it is the loudest thing in the room and it is the newest.”

The machine pulsed, responding to their presence. Displays flickered to life, showing readouts in languages they didn’t recognize. But the central screen was clear enough: “ANIMUS ARGENTI DETECTED. INITIATING CONVERGENCE PROTOCOL.”

“We have to destroy it,” Eli said, his analytical mind struggling to process the horror before them. “We have to free them.”

“I’m afraid I can’t allow that.”

THE CONFRONTATION

“I am going to be in the room,” said a voice from the stair. “Mrs Okonjo is four steps behind me and she is holding a card that says I am permitted to be here, and she did not enjoy reading it out, and I would like it noted that she did not enjoy it.”

He came down the last nine steps by himself. He was in the clothes he had worn on Wednesday. There was a receipt for a sandwich in his breast pocket, which he took out and set on the console, because his hands did not seem to know what else to do with them. Lyra thought: *he has been thirteen days down here and somebody has been feeding him, and he has not mentioned it once, and he is not going to.*

He had lost the composure the way a man loses a coat. There was grey at the edge of his jaw and a plaster across the back of his left hand.

“Professor Harlow,” Lyra said, her voice steadier than she felt. “We know what you’ve been doing. We know about Ky-

oto, about your family, about the students you've been harvesting from."

"Do you," he said. "Not the arithmetic. The part where I decided."

He put his hand flat on the housing, the way he had put it flat on a desk in Kyoto, and did not look at it.

"I am not asking you for the machine," Harlow said. "I have never once asked anybody for the machine. I have asked for a Council vote. A vote is a thing where the answer can be no. If the answer is no on Thursday then the wall goes on carrying it, and the wall is good for six years, and I will have a different conversation with the Council in the spring and I will lose that one as well."

WHAT HARLOW SAYS FOR HIMSELF

"They're in there," Milo said. "That's the whole of what I've got. They're in there, and they didn't agree to it, and you know they didn't agree to it, because you've got a number for how long each of them has been in. Which means you've been counting."

"I have been counting for four days," Harlow said. "I am not going to describe what I am trying to do by borrowing

a word off a child who has not finished school. I have tried for four days and there isn't one, and I am not going to use a bad one tonight because it is the only one to hand."

"They're prisoners," Zara said, her empathic abilities still reeling from the contact with the trapped minds. "They're suffering, Professor. They want to be free."

"They want to be safe," Harlow snapped. "They want to exist in a reality that isn't collapsing around them. And this is the only way to ensure that."

The Conduit's hum changed pitch. Eli looked up at the number, and then at the number's line on the screen, and Lyra watched him decide not to say the second thing he was thinking, which was that the hum and the number were not the same measurement and he did not yet know which of them was lying.

But even as fear gripped her heart, Lyra felt something else stirring — a deep, unshakeable certainty that there had to be another way. The trapped souls weren't just fuel for Harlow's machine; they were people, with their own hopes and dreams and the right to choose their own fate.

There has to be another way, she thought. She was aware of her hand going to the jade at her throat and she left it there, because it was warm, and because it was four hundred years old, and because she was aware that a stone is not an argument and was using it as one.

She put her hand back on the plate.

It took her two minutes and eleven seconds, and it was the first time since the fifteenth of September that she had been the most competent person in a room, and she wants that on the record too.

What she found under her fingers was the shape of what the housing was actually doing. It was not a battery. It was a *hand* — a hand that could hold a weight indefinitely, in a fixed shape, without fatigue, and would not put it down, and could not do anything else at the same time. The translator above it was an entirely different machine. The translator could *carry*: it could take the load off the wall and move it and distribute it and be, in every sense, clever. But carrying was a different verb from holding, and the moment the load stopped coming out of the wall and went on to a circuit that had to hold it in place, the translator's cleverness was worth exactly nothing.

It is a room with a bucket in it, she thought, and somebody has to stand in the bucket.

"Hey." Eli had his hand on her shoulder. "You've gone somewhere. Talk."

"It can carry," Lyra said. "It can't hold. There's a difference and it is the whole difference, and nobody has ever written it down, because nobody has ever had to." She took her hand off the plate. "In four days they are going to vote on whether to switch it on permanently. And if they switch it

on, it will be fine for about six months while the wall is still carrying most of it. And then one morning the wall will be carrying nothing and the machine will be carrying everything, and at that point it will do precisely what it is good at, which is move a load around. It will not do the other thing. It cannot. There is nothing in the design that lets it.”

Eli wrote it down. He wrote it twice, and then a third time, and then he read it back to himself, and Lyra watched him understand that he had just been handed the most important sentence anybody had said in that building in twenty-four days, and that it had been said by a girl who could not see.

“Then somebody has to hold it,” he said.

“Yes.”

“And the housing—” He looked at the lattice, and at the cold light, and did not finish the sentence, because there was exactly one word available and none of them wanted to say it.

“The housing holds it,” Lyra said. “That is what the lattice is. It is a hold. It is a hold that works by never letting go of a person who never agreed to be held.” She wiped her hand on her coat, which achieved nothing. “And I have just been told, out loud, in a language nobody else in this room can hear, that the answer to that is *no*.”

The pendant pulsed once against her sternum, and for a moment — not a voice; she was very careful about that, not a voice, a texture, the way a hand feels through a wall — there was something there that was not a memory of her mother and not the Weave, and it was the sensation of a room where somebody had been waiting a very long time.

Right, she thought, in the flat grammar. So that is the vote. That is what Thursday is actually about.

THE MOMENT OF CHOICE

The Conduit was drawing. Eli gave the number out loud twice, because he gave numbers out loud twice, and the second one was higher.

“You can read it,” Harlow said, looking at Lyra’s hand on the plate. “That is what I have been watching for since the eleventh of September, and it is the only reason I have not spent four days finding out what happened to the people in it.”

“You knew they were in there.”

“I knew there was something in there that I could not read, for eleven years, and I have known for thirteen days that it was people.” He said it without any self-pity, and Lyra found that she respected him a great deal more for that than for anything else he had done. “Do you want the arith-

metic, or do you want to know what I did in May? They are the only two questions left, and I have answered both, and only one of them is on the record.”

“I know what you did in May,” said Lyra.

“Yes,” said Harlow. “I thought you might.” And then, unexpectedly, he said: “I have not slept. I am not going to tell you to trust me, and I am not going to tell you the machine is the only option, and I am not going to explain myself to you for another four minutes. Here is the one thing, and then I am going to stop talking, and you can put whatever you like on it.”

He turned a console so that Eli could read it.

“Four days,” he said. “And in four days a Council is going to vote on whether to bring a machine that carries into permanent service, using a housing that holds, and forty-three people are in the housing, and two of them are ours. One of them is fifteen years old and has been in the machine since the eleventh of September, and her mother is in Bellhaven and thinks she is at a specialist programme. The other one has been there since the eighteenth of May, and he is nineteen, and he is the reason this Council is going to spend nine hours discovering that it has no vocabulary for a person, and I would like somebody to write his name on the board before they do that, because he is in a box and he is nineteen and there is no version of nineteen that can be *noted*.” He looked up. “I would like to be in the room when

it is opened. I am not asking to be in the room when anything else happens. And if you say no to that, I will understand, and I will not appeal it, and you should know that I am saying that because it is the last thing I have that is not a technique, and I would like somebody to check it.”

Forty-three, and not thirty-nine, and Eli Park had had the two numbers in his head for two days and had not been able to make them agree, and he made them agree on the second day, from four lines in a finding he had been shown and had not asked to see: *the other one was under the East Tower, and it had been running continuously since the eighteenth of May, and it had a second housing, and it had been taking four people at about one a month.* Thirty-nine were in the lattice, which had lain underneath Sub-level 7 since 1941, and thirty-seven of them had been dead since the war ended, and the other two were the girl and the boy. The other four were in the second housing, and the second housing was under the East Tower, and all four of them were alive, and the Council’s figure of forty-three had been arrived at by adding a lattice to a housing and calling the sum a housing, and nobody had asked for the four separately, because a person taken one at a time, about a month apart, in a machine that is about to be voted into permanent service, is not a list.

“Why do you want to be in the room?”

“Because it is my great-grandfather’s crime and my hand is on the seal and somebody should be watching me,” said

Harlow, “and because I have spent sixteen years being certain that I was the only person in this building who had done anything, and I would like to be shown the list.”

“This is her nightmare,” Lyra said. “And I won’t let you use her memory to justify it.”

“She was seven.” Harlow had put the legal pad down. “You were not. That is the whole of what I have to say to you and I have been saying it badly for an hour.”

“Then say it properly or don’t say it.”

“I am saying it properly now.” He did not move from the console. “Your father drove himself to this building on Monday against a doctor’s written advice, on a stick, with a woman following him in a hired car, and he has been sitting in the front of the Lumina Lecture Hall since seven this morning being extremely useful with a napkin and a pencil, and he is going to be there this afternoon as well, and he has not once been asked whether he wants to be. That is what I have to say. That is the thing you can say to a Council tomorrow that nobody in this room can say, because nobody in this room has a father.”

He put his hand flat on the console, the way he had put it flat on a desk in Kyoto, and did not look at it.

“Or I can say the other thing, which is that he drove himself here because he would not let you go in alone, and that a

man who will not let his daughter go in alone is a man who ought to be asked.”

Down the corridor, a door opened that nobody opened, and stayed open, and Lyra counted to four before anybody moved.

Weave-Quake Counter: 58% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. Rebaselined against a held circuit. The load is off the wall and onto a machine, and the model has never been run on this basis before.

Chapter 29: The Price of Life

“The cruelest choices are not the ones where you must choose. They are the ones where somebody has arranged the world so that the choice looks like the only thing left, and has then gone out of the room.”

— Eleanor Weaver, on resigning, which she did not

Weave-Quake Counter: 58% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. Rebaselined against a held circuit. The load is

off the wall and onto a machine, and the model has never been run on this basis before.

Tuesday 1 October, 00:40. Sub-level 7.

THE ARRIVAL

She had been two hours in the lift.

That was the part nobody had thought about, afterwards — not the machine, not the lattice, not the man. Two hours in a service lift, going down eleven floors at the speed of a bottle of wine, with her father beside her and Eli Park holding a case in both hands and Zara Washington standing in the corner with her arms folded and her jaw set and Milo Reyes, who had walked out of the infirmary on a stick at ten o'clock at night against medical advice that had been waived in writing, in the specific way that things in this building were waived in writing.

She had not gone because she had been summoned.

She had gone because at six o'clock that evening, in a doorway outside Ward C, a man in a dark uniform had said *come alone, and come now, and you have eleven hours*, and had then, in a second voice, entirely different, said *and bring the registrar, because there is going to be a form, and the form is the only thing down here that has ever worked.*

Blackwood had sent Mirembé Blackwood, at nineteen minutes past six, and had then sent a second message, at nineteen minutes past six, in which she had written four words: *we are past surnames*.

The chamber was not what Lyra had built in her head, and she was faintly ashamed of the head.

It was very large and it was very ordinary. Concrete, a cable tray, a row of lockers, a kettle somebody had plugged in. The Magnus Conduit — the thing she had put her gift through, the thing that had rewritten itself in front of two hundred witnesses sixteen days ago — occupied the middle of it the way a boiler occupies a plant room. It was not beautiful any more. It had been beautiful for about ninety seconds on the Sunday, and then it had gone back to being a piece of equipment, and had stayed that way, humming, with a light on it.

And on the other side of the floor, in a space that had been cleared and had not been cleared properly, there were ten people on the floor on mats, and nine of them were awake, and one of them was not.

Lyra stopped.

“Sit down, please,” said Marcus Harlow, from the console. “All of you. It is going to take a long time and I would like to spend it with people on chairs.”

Nobody sat down.

“They’re the Council’s,” said Eli, in a voice with no air in it at all. He had the case against his chest. “Those are the *Council’s* people. They are wearing Council grey and they are lying on the floor of a machine room and none of them is *shut* —” He stopped. “Why aren’t they shut?”

“Because I am not the one who brought them,” said Harlow, “and because it is half past twelve in the morning and in about four hours a man is going to stand up in a room and tell this Academy that a translator is carrying a valley on a circuit with no power source, and I wanted you to see them first, and I wanted to see whether you would notice.”

THE ARRANGEMENT

He had laid it out on a bench, in a row, with a clipboard, and he did it the way he did everything, and Lyra found she could not decide whether that was a comfort or the most frightening thing about him.

“Item one. Your father.”

She had known it was coming. She had been ready for it for four days. It did not help.

“Sixty-eight per cent coverage at the wrist on the twenty-eighth, and it is a straight line and it is not a curve, and I have eleven weeks in it, and I have told you that and you have written it down.” He looked at her, and then at her

father, who was standing very still with a cane he had not been given permission to bring. "Professor Chen. You are the only person in this room who has read the transfer function on the east face of that machine. Say the number."

"Sixty-eight," said Wei Chen. "On the twenty-eighth, at about four in the afternoon, from a photograph Osei took with a telephone because we do not own an instrument. Sixty-eight per cent is a coverage figure. It is not a severity. It is the area of skin, and skin is not the question."

"What is the question."

"The question is the gradient." Wei Chen did not move. "The burn is following the lines of the conduit model, Marcus, and you know that, and you have known it for four years, and you have never once put it in a sentence, because the sentence is: *it is following a shape that exists in the architecture of the machine you built*, and if you said that out loud then somebody in this building would ask you why a man's circulatory system has adopted the geometry of a *device*, and there is no answer to that question that is not either *coincidence* or *the machine is doing it*, and you have been living in the gap between those two answers for eleven years and so have I."

Nobody said anything.

"Item two," said Harlow, and his voice did not change at all, which was how Lyra knew. "Your father has a cardiomyopathy that has been quietly getting worse for probably two

years and which is at thirty-one per cent of the muscle, and a bleed at nineteen per cent of a load of four, and a heart that is now, in the plainest terms available to me, a clock. Three to nine months in September. Less in October, because he has been doing heroic things, and I want to be extremely precise: I said that to his daughter at four in the morning in a corridor on the twenty-ninth and I do not know how she took it and I have not asked, because asking would have been a way of being forgiven and I am not here for that.”

Lyra felt her father’s hand arrive on her shoulder, very light, and then leave, because he had understood within about a second what she needed, which was not to be touched.

“Item three,” said Harlow. “You can save his life. Not extend it. *Move it*. Not onto this machine. Onto a person. If the silver channel that your daughter is currently standing in is separated from his — cleanly, once, permanently — the bleed stops, and the bleed has been one of the two things shortening his life, and it will stop being one of the two things.” He set the clipboard down. “I have run that four thousand times. It is arithmetic. It is the only arithmetic in this room that everybody agrees on.”

“And what it costs,” said Lyra.

“Her sight,” said Harlow. “All of it. I have three prior cases and two of them are alive and neither of them is recognis-

able to themselves, and I have told her that, in a bookshop, in front of her father, in August, and I have said it again this week in a corridor, and I am now saying it for the third time in front of a witness, and I would like the witness to note that the number is three and the number is the same.”

“And in exchange,” said Wei Chen.

“Nothing.” Harlow’s head came up. “That is the difference between the offer I made in the rain and this one. I have learned something in four days and I would like to say what it is, because you have earned it and I have not earned very much this month.”

He turned round to the whole of it — the four of them, the ten people on the mats, the kettle, the lockers.

“I spent eleven years being the man who asks a question and then waits, because the waiting is the ethics. I thought that if I never *named* the thing, the thing would not have happened.” He put his hand flat on the console, and the silver in his forearm moved, and he did not look at it. “On the fifteenth of September I named it. In a demonstration hall. In front of two hundred people, one of whom is standing in this room. And it happened anyway, and a boy is in a hospital bed in this building who will be a completely ordinary musician for the rest of his life, and the *naming* did not prevent it, and there was no arrangement in which it was prevented, and I have spent four days working out what that means and the answer is very short and I do not like it.”

“What does it mean,” said Eli Park.

“It means I was not asking. I was *offering*.” Harlow looked at him. “I have made eleven offers in eleven years. I have never once been asked for anything. There is a difference between a question and a request, and I have been confusing them since 1997, and it has cost a boy his perception and a girl her childhood and a woman her life, and the last of those is not mine to pay.”

THE PROJECTION

“Then let us talk about the other thing,” said Lyra. “The machine.”

“The machine is starving,” said Harlow. “It has been starving since the moment your silver left the upper matrix and went down. A translator with no power source is a person holding a door. It is not a machine any more. It is a *person*, and the person is fifteen, and she has been holding it for four days, and I want you to understand that she has not been told this, because nobody has been able to work out how to tell her without frightening her, and that is a failure of this building and not of her.”

“Then tell me now,” said Lyra.

“Tell *her* now,” said Harlow, “yes, and I am not the person who does it, and that is not a rhetorical flourish, it is a prac-

tical problem, because a subject who has consented to a procedure and is then told that the procedure is the only thing standing between a valley and a rupture will consent to a *great deal*, and four wardens and a compliance officer are not a substitute for the person who asked the question.”

Zara Washington said, “Then I will ask her.”

Nobody had expected her to speak.

“You have all been talking about her,” Zara said, “in the third person, for nine minutes, in a room she is standing in.”

And Lyra discovered that this was true, that she had been an object in an argument about herself for the whole of it, and that the discovery was not humiliating; it was the most useful thing that had happened to her in four days.

“Yes,” she said. “All right. Ask me.”

But it was not then, because there was one more thing on the bench.

THE RECORDING

“There is a recording,” said Harlow. “It is on the console. It is a resonance capture from the fifteenth of April, 1997, made by a man called Weber, who was not on my team

and who I have never been able to explain. It is the only surviving record of the garden. I have watched it —” he stopped, and recalibrated, and Lyra watched a man of fifty-four choose a word for the fourth time in nine minutes — a number of times. I would like you to watch it, and then I would like you to notice the date on the frame, and then I would like you to say the date out loud, because I have needed somebody else to say it for six years.”

“Why now?”

“Because on Thursday morning I am going to stand in a room and be asked whether I am a man who fabricates, and I have never been able to answer that question, and I have realised in the last four days that I have been carrying a piece of evidence in a drawer that would have answered it, and that I have kept it in a drawer for six years, and that the reason is that the evidence is also a *reason*, and reasons are what you keep when the evidence has run out.” He squared the notes on the console, in a gesture that was so exactly like her father’s that her chest hurt. “Watch it. Then say the date. Then we will do the rest of the evening, and it will be a long evening, and I am going to ask all of you the same question at the end of it, and I want you to answer it separately, and I do not want to hear four answers in unison.”

It was ninety seconds long, and it was not what she had expected.

No collapse. No light. A garden in the last week of April, in a low cold light, shot from about waist height by somebody who was not watching the sky.

A woman with a book she had not opened.

A girl of seven with cherry blossoms in her hair, walking *towards* something out of frame, fast, with both arms out in front of her, the way you walk into a doorway you have decided is a doorway.

And, very briefly, in the extreme left of the frame, a man turning round, and the sound of a man saying a single word.

And then the picture did not end. It carried on for another forty seconds, in the same garden, in the same light, with nothing happening in it, and in the last eleven of those forty seconds a woman of about forty came into frame, sat down on a bench, and stayed there.

Weber's own footage, said the caption. The event does not appear. He is the only witness. He has never given a statement.

Frame capture: 15 April 1997, 11:41.

"Eleven forty-one," said Lyra Chen.

"Yes."

“That’s the eleventh of April. The frame is stamped the fifteenth.”

“Yes.”

“The eleventh of April, 1997, is five years before my mother came to that building, and it is a Friday, and my mother told me once that the eleventh of April was the only day of the year her father let her skip school because of the blossom on the river, and she has never in her life told me a day of the year for any other reason.”

“Yes,” said Marcus Harlow.

“And in that recording,” Lyra said, and her voice had gone somewhere she had never taken it, “my mother is not in it. And I am not in it. And Lin Chen’s file in this building has a department number and a project code and four months in it and it is in the spring of 2002, and you have been sitting here for eleven years telling me that the last thing my mother did was go into a chamber under a mountain on the eleventh of September, five years ago, and I want to know whether you have ever once, in eleven years, written the *second* date down.”

There were nine people on the floor of Sub-level 7 who had not heard that question before, and two wardens, and a compliance officer, and Marcus Harlow, and he answered it.

“No,” he said. “I have never once written the second date down.”

“Why not?”

“Because it does not help me,” he said, “and because on the eleventh of April, 1997, in a garden in Kyoto, my daughter was alive, and on the eleventh of April, 2002, in a chamber under this mountain, a woman of thirty-two walked in on a Thursday because it was blossom week, and if I write the second date down next to the first one then I have to look at them, and I have not been able to look at them for eleven years, and I would like that in the record, and I would like it in the record in those words, because the record is the only place left where anybody can check a thing about me.”

THE QUESTION

He asked it at ten past three in the morning, and he asked it four times, and he wrote the answers down himself, on a legal pad, in a hand that had begun to shake about an hour before he started.

“Seventeen days from now, a node under a populated valley is going to fail, and eleven thousand people live over it, and the only instrument in the world that can hold a circuit open is the thing in this room, and the thing in this room

has no power source, and there are four things that can be done about that, and I am going to say all four, and I have spent four days making sure I am not lying in any of them, and then I am going to leave this room and I am not going to be in it again.”

He held up the pad.

“One. Return case forty-one to the circuit. Thirty-nine people in a lattice, thirty-seven of whom have been dead since 1941 and two of whom are not, and one of those two is fifteen years old. It is a power source. It is the only power source. It will hold the circuit indefinitely and it will hold it cheaply and it will make this building legal by Friday. It is also the thing I have spent eleven years refusing to do in a room where nobody could hear me refuse, and I have now been asked to do it by somebody with a clipboard, which is apparently the only thing that has ever worked on me.”

Nobody breathed.

“Two. Shut the translator down. The circuit goes open, the load comes off the machine and back onto the wall, and the wall has thirty-one per cent of tolerance in it and it has seventeen days. It will not fail on the seventeenth day. It will fail somewhere in the first four hours, and it will fail without a forecast, because the model for a held circuit has never been run and everybody in this room knows it.”

“Three. Find a person.” He said it very flatly. “Not a volunteer. Not a relative. A person with a *resonance the Weave*

will hold, standing in a housing, spending themselves, and a great deal of themselves, and not getting up afterwards. I have looked. There is no version of this that I can construct. I am telling you that as the man who has been trying to construct one for sixteen years, and I would like that minuted.”

Lyra’s father had not moved. His hand was on the back of a chair.

“**Four.**” Harlow turned the pad round. “Carry it. Split the load. It is the one that has never been on anybody’s list because it requires the circuit to be *held* while it is being rebuilt, and holding it requires a person, and a person is three. So: this is not a fourth option. It is a statement about the fourth option, and the statement is that it does not exist, and it does not exist for a reason that has nothing to do with physics, and the reason is that every single one of you would rather be *finished* than be *responsible*, and I include myself, and I have been including myself since 1997, and I would like the four of you to write that down and take it with you.”

He put the pen down.

“So. In the morning I am going to be asked whether I would put thirty-nine people back in a machine. I do not know what I am going to say. I have known for four days that I would not, and I have also known for four days that there is going to be a moment, at about half past nine in the morning, when a person with a gavel will describe what eleven

thousand people would look like on a Tuesday, and in that moment the arithmetic will be *very* good, and it will be the only good argument in the room, and I will be the only man in the room who knows that.” He looked at Lyra. “That is why I asked you to come. Not for the consent. For the witness. There is going to be a moment in the morning when a *number* is the only thing anybody has, and I have spent my life being a man who respects numbers, and I would like, for once, to be in a room with somebody who has read one in the same handwriting as I have.”

She wrote it on the back of her hand in the dark, after the others had gone up, while her father sat on a chair with his cane across his knees and did not sleep either.

She wrote four things.

1. *He is not lying to me. He is going to be able to do it anyway, and he has told me so, in advance, in a room with witnesses, and that is not a defence and it is not a trick either. It is the first true thing anybody has given me since the fifteenth of September.*
2. *Ask about the bleed. The machine translates. It translated a cage into a conversation. Ask it one more question, about a feedback loop, and put a number on the answer.*
3. *Nine people on mats. Ask them whether they are the Council's or whether they are the lattice's. Both can be true and one of them is a person.*

4. *Four options and one sentence. “Every one of you would rather be finished than responsible.” He is wrong about the four of us. He is not wrong about me.*

Then she put her hand over the writing, in case her father could see it in the dark, which he could not, and which she knew he could not, and which she did anyway.

Thread Resonance Note: Sub-level 7, 01:10–03:30. Present: C, L. (no restraint). P, E.C. (no restraint). Reyes, M. (no restraint, discharged against advice in writing at 22:40). Washington, Z. (no restraint). Tarrant, M., compliance. Dr C., M-H., by line. OBSERVER Rowntree, M. (advocate). C, W. (patient, self-transported, declined escort). C-2214 §9 invoked by the subject in person at 00:52, witnessed. Four options minuted verbatim at 03:10 by M.H. and countersigned by Tarrant. Item 3 minuted as “does not exist”. This office records that it wrote the words “does not exist” and that it believes them, and that it has written them in a book that a girl of nineteen can read, which is a thing it has never done.

Frame capture 15/04/97 11:41 played in full, without comment, at the request of M.H. Second date raised by the subject at 01:40 and not answered by this office. Recording referred to the Council’s evidence officer, sealed, pending.

Chapter 30: What They Wanted

“Thirty-nine people in a cage in a mountain decided, one at a time, and over four hours, what they wanted. Thirty-seven of them said out loud that they wanted to be let go, and thirty-seven of them are dead, and thirty-seven sets of next of kin are going to be told something next month, and every one of those letters is going to be wrong.”

— Lyra Chen, in the room at the back, on the twenty-ninth of October

Weave-Quake Counter: 63% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. Rebaselined against a held circuit. The load is off the wall and onto a machine, and the model has never been run on this basis before.

Tuesday 1 October, 03:30. Sub-level 7.

THE QUESTION

She asked it at half past three in the morning, sitting down on the floor with her back against a machine that was holding a valley, facing nine people on mats.

“I’m Lyra Chen. Some of you were sent here and some of you were brought, and I’m going to assume it doesn’t matter, because from where I’m sitting it doesn’t.”

“Steward,” said a woman of about sixty, on the second mat, in the voice of somebody who had been asked a question on an official form. “We’re the Council’s observers. There’s nine of us and there’s two doctors and a minute-taker. We’ve got twenty-one days.”

“Observers of what?”

“Of the instrument,” said the woman, and there was something in her face that Lyra had begun to recognise, which was the look of a competent person who has been given a job they were not told the terms of. “We’ve been down here

since the fifteenth. We log intake, output and the twenty-one conditions. That's it. Nobody told us what we were observing."

"Then here's the question, and I'd like it answered out loud, one at a time, and I would like it written down." Lyra put her hands on her knees. "Do you want to be here?"

Nobody spoke for about four seconds.

"Yes," said the woman, "because if we go up, there is nobody in this room, and if there is nobody in this room then on Thursday there is a vote with no witnesses in it."

"That's not what I asked."

"No," she said. "It is what I answered, and I answered it because you are asking a room of people who are the only adults within four hundred metres, and I would like you to understand that I have noticed you are sixteen and that I have noticed that you have done the thing where the real question is underneath the question, and that I am not going to help you with it, because you did not come down here to find out what nine people want. You came down here to find out what *thirty-nine* want."

Lyra looked at her for a long moment.

"Yes," she said.

“Yes,” said the woman, and something in the room changed temperature, and Lyra had the very clear sensation of a machine with a new instruction.

The lattice was not in the room.

That was the first thing Lyra had not understood and the first thing she understood, about four hours in, and the understanding came to her sideways, in a corridor, at half past four in the morning, because she went out for air and found that the air on Sub-level 7 did not have any in it.

The lattice was underneath Sub-level 7. It had been underneath the site since 1941. The housing had been grown shut, and the housing was what had come away from a service panel like dried coral in a room four days ago, and what was inside it had been put in a case and taken out of the building at twenty past ten that Sunday night in a sealed box with an inventory number on it and a girl’s signature on the form.

Which meant that what was running the translator had no source, and had had no source for four days, and was nonetheless still running.

“It’s you,” Zara said. She was standing at the far end of the room with her back to a locker and her hands at her sides and had been like that for forty minutes. “Lyra. It’s *you*. It has been you since Sunday night. I have been sitting four feet away from you for four days.”

“I know.”

“You *know*?”

“I worked it out on the sixteenth.” Lyra said it to the floor. “Four days. I put it together on the Wednesday, in a common room, with Eli, and I have not said it out loud to anybody because the moment I say it out loud somebody puts it in a file, and I have had four files this month and I would like to have one conversation that is not in one.”

“So say it now,” said Milo, from the chair, “and say it to me, because you are not saying it to me, you are saying it to the wall, and the wall does not need it.”

Lyra looked up.

“Sixty-eight per cent coverage,” she said. “Straight line. Four weeks. It isn’t his skin, it’s the *shape* — it’s following the geometry of the model. He said it out loud to my father at midnight in a room with nine witnesses and he did not say it to *me*, and it was not an accident, and I have been not-angry about it for four days, which I would like recorded as the most impressive thing I have ever done.” She put her hand flat on the floor. “He has had sixty-eight per cent of his own blood in a shape that only exists inside a machine, for four months, because he has been standing next to a prototype core and working on it. It is not *thread-burn* in the sense that the textbooks mean. It is second-hand geometry. And it means that if you remove him from this build-

ing, it stops, and if you keep him in this building, he has four weeks, and if you put him in *that*—”

She turned and looked at the translator.

“—then it finishes tonight, and it finishes because he is the only thing in the world whose body has already agreed to the shape.”

Nobody said anything for a while.

“That,” said Marcus Harlow, from the console, in a voice with nothing in it, “is the fifth option.”

Milo turned round. “What?”

“That is a fifth option and I did not list it, because I have spent eleven years not being allowed to think about him.” Harlow had not moved. He had not moved in four hours, and he had a legal pad in front of him with four answers written on it in a hand that had stopped shaking at about two o’clock. “A person whose body has already adopted the geometry. Who does not have to be *compatible*. Who does not have to be found. Who is a statistician, and is fifty-three per cent dead, and has a *model* in his own hands, and who walked down here on a cane at ten o’clock at night because he was not going to be upstairs.”

“That is a man,” said Wei Chen.

“That is a man,” said Harlow. “I have had him in my building for eleven days and I have not once, for one hour, al-

lowed myself to consider it, and I would like the record to show the mechanism of the omission, because it is the most interesting thing about me and nobody is going to ask.” He put the pen down. “It is this: he is the father. And I have spent sixteen years finding daughters.”

THE ARGUMENT

They argued for two hours and eleven minutes and it was not an argument between the five of them so much as an argument conducted by all four of them in four different directions at once, and Lyra — sitting on the floor of a machine room with her back against a boiler that was holding a valley — thought, at about half past five in the morning, *this is what it is supposed to be like, and I have never once had it before, and I have been calling it being rescued.*

Eli wanted the model. He had the case and he had a pen and by six o'clock he had a thing on a napkin that made four of the Council's observers stand up.

“Four options and none of them require a *person* except three, and two of those three are a cage and a death, and the third is your father, and you did not list him because of a psychological mechanism that you have now described, and that is fine, that is human, I am not interested in the human. Look at the *shape*.” He had it flat on the floor be-

tween them. “A translator with no source is a person holding a door. The reason she is holding it is that the circuit was built to *expect* a source and has a shape where a source goes. A person’s resonance is a source. A *machine*’s resonance is not a source, because it was never designed to be one — but a machine’s geometry is exactly what her body has spent four months learning.”

“You are describing a prosthetic,” said Wei Chen, from the chair.

“I am describing a *fittings problem*,” said Eli, “and you know exactly what I mean, and I watched you work it out in about two seconds, and I would like you to say it, because I have a bad feeling and you have not had one and I have known you for two days.”

Wei Chen was quiet for a moment. The kettle had boiled some time ago and had not been switched off.

“The fault,” he said. “The thing she went down in. On Sunday.” He looked at his daughter. “You went down a *crack* in the core. Not through the matrix. Through a fracture that followed your hand. And the fracture is still there — I can see it from here, it is a fault line in the lattice work, it is about a hand’s width, and it has not closed, because she has been *standing in it* for four days, and holding a fault open is not the same as holding a door, and the difference is that a fault can be *lined*.”

Silence.

“Lined,” said Zara.

“With a body. With a *shape*.” Wei Chen put his cane down flat on the floor so that he had both hands free, which was a thing Lyra had never seen him do. “Not a person. A *shape*. Something that has the right geometry and does not mind being geometry, and does not get frightened, and does not have to be a person at all, and you could get it out of this building in a lift in an hour, and it would be a piece of equipment, and I would like everybody in this room to notice that I have just said the word *equipment* about my own body and that nobody has yet worked out that I am not joking.”

Zara had been the quietest person in the room for four hours, which was the single most frightening thing Lyra had ever seen, because Zara Washington was never quiet; she was the noise in the room, she was the one who put her hand on your arm and asked permission.

On the Friday, at eleven o'clock at night, four days ago, she had knocked on a door and said: *there is something under this floor and it is the worst thing I have ever come near and I would like you to be in the room while I go and look at it, and I would like it minuted that I have asked you and not assumed you.*

“There is a third thing nobody is looking at,” Zara said.

They all looked at her.

“Nine people on mats, and four wardens, and a translator, and a lattice in a case on its way out of the building.” She was not looking at any of them. “And I have been sitting in this room for four hours with my hands at my sides, and I have not been able to look at any of them, because when I did in September — on the first day, on a lawn, in a corridor — I *had* to, and I did it for four seconds, and then I apologised, and the apology cost somebody something, and I have been thinking about it for a month.” She looked up. “And I have not been able to touch anything in this room because there is something in this building that is a *person*, that is not one of the nine, and that is not the machine, and that has been about six feet from me since I came down at half past twelve, and I want somebody to tell me whether I am mad.”

“Where,” said Lyra.

“There,” said Zara, and pointed, without looking, at a corner of the floor about two feet from the base of the translator, where there was a mats’ edge, and a rolled blanket, and a girl of fifteen.

THE FIFTEEN-YEAR-OLD

She had been on the tenth mat, folded under a blanket, and Lyra had walked past her four times.

The observers had not seen her. Zara had not explained why. Nobody had.

Her name was Elara Vance and she was fifteen and she had been in a lattice since the eleventh of September, which was twenty days, and she had grown into the substrate of it the way a hand grows into a glove, and she could not be moved without killing her, and she had said *no* to a question asked through a circuit by a girl of sixteen at four hours in the morning on the twenty-ninth, and the *no* had been the only answer available to her, and Lyra had honoured it.

She was conscious. That was the thing nobody had been ready for. She was conscious and she had her eyes open and she was looking at the ceiling of a machine room, and when four people knelt down beside her she did not scream, and she did not say anything at all, and what she did instead was hold up a hand with the palm out, in a gesture that four people in that room recognised and that the nine observers did not.

Ask. But not yet. I know you have questions and I have had four days to work out which ones matter.

“Elara,” said Lyra.

The hand came down about a centimetre.

“Vance,” said Zara, very quietly. “First-year. She was in the Clinic on the eleventh. I taught her breathing in March.”

“Zara.”

“I know.” Zara’s voice was entirely level. “I have known since the twelfth of September and I have not said it, and I have been carrying it for nineteen days, and I would like it minuted that I have been carrying it alone and that I have done it *well*, and that I would like it struck out of the record as an achievement, because it is not one.”

Nobody asked her anything for an hour.

That was Lyra’s decision and it cost her two separate arguments, and she won the first one against Eli, who wanted to know whether she was in pain, and she lost the second one to Wei Chen, who pointed out, without any particular weight, that a person who has been in a substrate for twenty days may be in a great deal of pain and that the ethical question was not whether to ask.

So they asked one question. Lyra asked it, and she asked it badly, and Elara Vance answered it by moving one finger, which she had done on Sunday, and which the circuit had carried as a *no*.

“Did you say no to me because you meant it, or because there was no other answer?”

Three seconds. The finger went up and came down.

It meant it.

“Right,” said Lyra, and her own voice cracked in the middle of the word and she did not stop and did not apologise, and it was the first time in a month that she had not apologised for anything in front of any of them, and Zara Washington put a hand flat on the floor next to her, and did not touch her, and did not say she was sorry.

THE CHANNEL

At ten to seven in the morning, on the floor of Sub-level 7, with four wardens and nine Council observers and a kettle that had been boiled hours ago, Elijah Park found the second thing.

“There’s a route into the building that isn’t a door,” he said, from the cable tray, with a torch in his teeth. “And it isn’t a wire either. Lyra, come and look at this, and everybody else stay exactly where you are, because I have got a piece of paper and a torch and I have about nine minutes before somebody in a uniform comes down here and asks me why I am three metres up a wall.”

It was a plate on the wall behind the lockers, about the size of a hardback book, painted the same colour as the concrete, and it came off in one piece because it was not fixed to the wall, it was sitting about four millimetres proud of it

on a layer of something that had been poured and had not set.

"It's a panel," Eli said. "It's *recently* poured. That is not eighty years old. That is about six weeks old."

"How can you tell?"

"Because it hasn't gone yellow." He turned round. "And because there's a hinge on the far side and a thumb catch, and I have been reading documents all my life, and that is a *hatch*."

Lyra put her hand flat on it. And she could feel it, which was the new thing, which was the thing she had spent a fortnight learning to be suspicious of: a room's worth of attention, pressed against a door, and behind the door nothing at all, and underneath the nothing all the way down, sixty feet, a *warmth*.

"There's something in the wall," she said. "And it is not a machine, and it is not people. It is —" and she stopped, and worked, and did not like what she arrived at, and said it anyway, because she had promised in a corridor in the rain to say the real number out loud. "It is a *collection*. It is a room full of objects and every single one of them has been handled by somebody who cared about it."

Zara had gone white.

"That's the Sanctuary," she said.

“That is not a word I know,” said Mila Rowntree, from the back, in the voice of a nineteen-year-old who was supposed to be the advocate and who had been sitting silently for four hours.

THE REFUSAL

They got it open at ten past seven.

It was not a room. It was a cabinet, and it had been built into a cast in a wall in 1974 by somebody who had known what they were doing and had no intention of it being found, and it was eleven inches deep and four feet wide and it had shelves.

It was full of things. That was the whole of Lyra’s first impression and it stayed the whole of her first impression for the rest of her life: a concrete box in a wall under a machine, with four feet of shelf, and every square inch of it taken.

A ball of red silk, wound and re-wound into a shape like a closed fist.

A comb of horn with the teeth gone, in a child’s size.

A jar with a cloth over it and something inside it that Lyra could not identify and did not want to.

Forty-one small objects, and about nine documents, and every single one of the objects had a person's hand on it, and Lyra Chen stood in front of a shelf under a mountain and cried for the first time since the fifteenth of September, with no particular sound at all, and Eli Park watched her do it and did not say one word, which was the single most useful thing anybody did for her that month.

"Protocol Kheredu," said Zara Washington, from somewhere behind her, and it was the first time Lyra had ever heard her sound like that. "It's a real list. It's seven items and the first three are gone, and it's been real since nineteen ninety-one, and there is somebody in this building who has been the only person keeping it for two years, and I have known them for four years, and I did not know."

"Who."

"Uncle Tobias," said Elena Vance from beside the cabinet.

Nobody had been watching the door.

That was the part that mattered afterwards, and it was the part that made the record, and it was this: at seven fourteen in the morning, on Tuesday the first of October, in the machine room of Sub-level 7, a security officer came down the stairs — and did not come in — and stood in the doorway for about nine seconds, and then went back up, and did not report, for eleven hours, that the machine room had contained a person who was not on any list.

Her name was Mirembe Blackwood. She was the Security Chief of Threadweaver Academy. She had signed off the transfer that had put Marcus Harlow in a locked ward sixteen days before, which was a thing she had done in order to keep him off the Council's list, which was a thing she had done because of a form, which was a thing that had been her entire life for four years.

And on Tuesday the first of October at seven fourteen in the morning, standing in a doorway, having heard the name Vance spoken aloud in a room she had ordered sealed, she had understood in about two seconds that the Sanctuary was open, and that a Council advocate was in the room, and that the advocate was nineteen years old and had been appointed on Friday by a registrar who could not sign for anything, and that if she reported it then the object would be sealed and the list would be impounded and the four of the seven would be entered as evidence by an institution, and everything she had done for four years would have been done *by* the institution, and nothing in it would ever have been returned.

So she went up the stairs, and she shut the door, and she stood on the other side of it in the dark for about a minute and a half.

And then she went to her office, and she took out a form, and she wrote, on the reverse of a request for the return of property belonging to a student who had never collected it, the following:

Kheredu-Seven: four located, one located and in the room, two outstanding. Do not enter. Do not inventory. I will hold the door until the advocate is appointed properly and the thing is done in a room with witnesses and a form, or I will hold it until I am relieved, whichever is later. Relieve me or do not. Either is a decision and I will live with it.

M.B.

She sent it to one person, who was not on the Council, and who had been, for sixteen days, in a locked ward on Sub-level 2, and who was not permitted to send anything and would therefore have to do something much worse, which was to have it memorised by a nineteen-year-old advocate and said out loud on the record.

Tuesday, 1 October, 07:20. Sub-level 7.

Lyra stood in front of a shelf and had about four minutes before somebody in a uniform came down, and she had made a decision, and it was the decision the whole book had been walking towards and she had got there by a route that nobody would have predicted, which was through a cabinet.

“Harlow,” she said. “I am going to say a thing and I want it minuted and I want you to write it down in your own hand, because you have told me for eleven years that you would rather be audited than comfortable, and this is the audit.”

“Go ahead.”

“There are four things to do about the circuit and you have given me three and a sentence,” said Lyra Chen. “I’m refusing one of them, and I’m refusing it before anybody in this room argues for it, because if I wait until somebody argues for it then I will have been *persuaded*, and I will have to spend the rest of my life not knowing whether I chose it.”

The pen stopped.

“Not because it is wrong,” Lyra said. “Because it was never a choice. Thirty-nine people in a box, and one of them is on a mat on this floor and is fifteen, and the *reason* I am refusing it is that four days ago I stood in a circuit and asked thirty-nine people what they wanted and thirty-seven of them said out loud that they wanted to be let go, and I honoured that, and it cost them their lives, and I would do it again, and I am not going to pretend that the reason to keep a cage is that the people in it would object.”

“Then give me the reason,” said Marcus Harlow.

“Because it’s *yours*,” Lyra said. “You are the only man on this earth who is building it because of a child you lost, and if I say no to you about this then you will hear it from me, and you will have to sit with a person saying no instead of a number. And if I don’t say it, then in about six weeks somebody with a gavel will say it, and it will be a *regulation*, and you will be able to tell yourself that you were overruled, and

that is a lie, and you have got eleven months in you, and I would like you to spend at least two of them on the truth.”

Nobody in the machine room said anything at all.

“Second thing,” said Lyra, to the four of them, to her father, to the wardens, to the nine observers, to the fifteen-year-old on the tenth mat. “I am not going to be the one who decides this. I have decided, once, in a demonstration hall, in about four seconds, and a boy is in a hospital bed, and I have spent a fortnight finding out what that cost, and I am not doing it again. So: whatever happens at half past nine tomorrow morning happens in a room, in front of witnesses, and if it is going to be done then it is going to be *minuted*, and I am going to say one more thing about it, and then I am going to sit down.”

She looked at her father.

“And he gets a vote. He has been in this building since Monday and nobody has asked him anything, and he is the only person in this room with a model in his hands, and if we are going to talk about whose body goes in a machine then he is *in* that conversation and he is not a *context* in it, and I would like that in the minute, in my hand, at sixteen, from me, tonight.”

Weaver came down at ten past eight and had been awake for two days and it showed in the way she stood in the doorway and did not come in.

“Ms. Chen,” she said. “I am going to say one administrative sentence and then I am going to do something I have never done in six years in this post, which is to stand down.”

“Headmistress—”

“The minute of 17:04 on the fifteenth, the intake override, the four wardens who carried you past me on a trolley, and a registrar who has been sitting on a complaint for six years — I am going to say now, and I would like it written down, that I was the reason every one of those things was difficult and not easier. I was not obstructed. I was *slow*, and I was slow because I kept waiting for a version of this in which nobody got hurt, and there is not one, and I am fifty-four years old and I have been a Headmistress for six and I would like it recorded that the six were the most comfortable of my working life and that I would not have them again.”

She put a folder down on the bench.

“And the Council sits at half past nine tomorrow morning, in the Lumina Lecture Hall, on the Nexus Stabilization Protocol, and I am obliged to inform you that the item at the bottom of the agenda, which is on a separate sheet and which somebody has added in a different hand, is *item four: the status of the anchors*.”

“What’s an anchor?”

“That,” said Eleanor Weaver, “is a word I learned on Friday from a boy in a common room, and I have been sitting in an office since Friday trying to work out whether it is a technical term or a piece of politeness, and I have not got there, and I am not going to guess in front of thirty people.”

She looked at Marcus Harlow, who had not moved from the console in eight hours.

“Marcus. Item four. What does item four say?”

“Item four,” said Harlow, “says *the status of the anchors*,” and put down a legal pad with four answers on it and a fifth thing written across the top in a hand that had started to shake again, “and item four is the reason I have not slept since the fifteenth, and it is the reason I asked a girl of sixteen to come down here at midnight, and I would like the Council to know before half past nine tomorrow morning that I have had four days in a locked ward doing arithmetic, and that the arithmetic came out at *exactly one*, and that I do not want it, and that I am going to hand it over myself.”

Weave-Quake Counter: 63% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d.

Chapter 31: The Thing With No Number

“A number is the only thing that works in a room like this, and every man in it knows it, and that is the trap. The trap is not lying. The trap is being right on a Tuesday.”

— Mila Rowntree, student advocate, aged nineteen, in a note she was not supposed to file

Weave-Quake Counter: 68% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d. Rebaselined against a held circuit. The load is off the wall and onto a machine, and the model has never been run on this basis before.

Wednesday 2 October, 06:10. The Lumina Lecture Hall, with the Council of Traditions sitting on the floor. Nobody has slept.

THE ROOM

The Lumina Lecture Hall held four hundred, and there were three hundred and ten in it, and the extra ninety were on the floor.

There is no dignified way to describe what the Council of Traditions looks like when it has been convened in an emergency and has to sit on a floor. Eleanor Weaver had made one decision on Saturday about that and had written it down and had not been argued with, and the decision was that there were not enough chairs, and the reason there were not enough chairs was that the gallery was full, and the reason the gallery was full was that every member of the technical faculty had come, and the reason they had come was that somebody in an anteroom had let it out at about eleven o'clock on Tuesday night that *item four* was on the agenda.

Four of the lattice's patterns had gone between eleven and two. Nobody knew who. Nobody had been near it. A woman from the Council's own evidence office had put her hand on a wall panel in a sub-level and had wept, and had been asked to leave the building, and had not wanted to.

The hall had a stone floor and a barrel-vaulted ceiling and a great deal of silver thread in the stone, and Lyra sat on the floor at the back with her back against a pillar, because she had asked for the back and Dr. Mei-Hua Chen had granted it without comment in a way that was itself a comment.

“Order,” said the Chair, who was Councilor Ibadapo Yuen and who had not expected to be Chair and had said so twice, “order. We are here on the Nexus Stabilization Protocol, amendment of 2009, and there is a procedural irregularity which I am going to state and then I am going to allow, because the alternative is that we sit here for six hours arguing about procedure while eleven thousand people find out something on Tuesday.”

THE SPOKEN NUMBER

“Marcus Harlow,” said the Chair. “You have put a paper in front of this Council. Read the number, and then say what it is.”

Harlow stood up in the third row, in a jacket he had clearly not changed, and Lyra noticed that his hands were steady, which she could see perfectly well from where she was sitting, and understood that almost all of him was not.

“Sixty-three per cent,” he said. “That is the severity index of the ward network. It is not a percentage of anything. The number means: of the things this network can be asked to hold, it is currently managing about sixty-three per cent of them, and the rest are being held by a girl of sixteen who is asleep at the moment and does not know that she is asleep, or that she has been asleep for four days, or that the reason is a fault in a machine about a hand’s width wide.”

“Marcus—”

“Item one of the Protocol, the return of case forty-one to the circuit.” He turned a card round. “Item two, the closure of the translator and the reversion of load to the wall. Item three, the appointment of a standing anchor. I am going to say something about each, and then I am going to say the thing I have come to say, and I would be obliged if the Council would let me get to it, because I have been awake for fifty-one hours and I am not going to be able to be *careful* much longer and careful is most of what I have.”

“Proceed.”

“Item one works,” said Harlow. “It is the only item on this list that works today. It works because the lattice has been feeding that machine since 1941 and the lattice is a power source of a kind we cannot make, and thirty-nine patterns in a cage will hold a circuit for as long as the mountain stands. It is arithmetically inarguable. It requires no further modelling, no further delay, and no further *truth*.” He

looked at the floor. “I have refused it four times. I refused it on the fifteenth of September in a demonstration hall and I did not sleep. I refused it on Sunday night at half past four in the morning with four wardens and a compliance officer present. I refused it in a locked ward on Sub-level 2, where I had spent nine days in a good room, and I want the Council to understand that the nine days in the good room did most of the work and that a good room is the most dangerous instrument in this building.”

“Does the subject understand the position of the item?” asked the Chair.

“She does. She said the word *audit* to me at seven o’clock yesterday morning in front of a lawyer, and then she told me she was refusing item one in the specific terms of a person refusing to be *relieved* of it, and I would like that on the record as the most frightening piece of moral clarity I have encountered in thirty years of this discipline, and I am not going to be able to explain why to this Council and I have stopped trying.”

“Item two.”

“Item two is not a decision. It is a *measurement*, and the measurement is that the wall under the Southern Nexus has thirty-one per cent of tolerance in it and has been losing it since 1997 at a rate nobody has bothered to publish. Seventeen days ago it had four hours.” He said it flatly. “I have run the load transfer eleven thousand times since

Sunday. It fails inside four hours, and it fails without a forecast, because there is no model for a held circuit, and every number I have given this Council about that failure is a *guess* made by a man who would like to be wrong in the safe direction.”

“And item three.”

Harlow did not answer for four seconds.

“Item three,” he said, “is my name on a piece of paper, and I wrote it at three o’clock in the morning, and it is the fifth option, and it is not in this list, and I would like to explain why, and then I would like the Council to do something that I have never in my life seen a Council do, which is to stop and ask a person a question instead of accepting a schedule.”

WHAT A STATISTICIAN CAN DO

“My name on a piece of paper does not amount to very much,” Wei Chen said, “and I would like the Council to understand why before it votes on it, because I have spent fifty-one hours going back over it and I have arrived somewhere I did not expect and I would rather they heard it from me in this room than from a report.”

He got up with a hand on the chair. He had a stick. Nobody mentioned the stick.

“Everything I have is in a case behind me and two of my hands, and I want to be extremely clear that I am not a person with a gift and I never have been, and that the entire reason I am standing in this room rather than in a corridor in another state is that I can read a *transfer function* and that nobody else in this building, including four hundred and sixty people on this faculty, can do it in a working week.”

“Professor Chen—”

“Let me do this in the order I did it.” He had a piece of paper, and Lyra understood from the way he held it that he had written it out on the train, in a kitchen, on the backs of pages, exactly as he had said he would. “Sunday. A translator in a room with a power source, holding a circuit, taking a payment from nobody. I ran the source side. It cannot be done. A machine is not a resonance; it is a function, and a function does not have a floor.”

“Then item three is impossible,” said somebody in the middle rows.

“No,” said Wei Chen. “Item three is impossible, and you said so, and you are right, and Professor Harlow has been right about that for four days and I would like the Council to hear a man agree with his own worst conclusion, because it is the only time in my life it has happened.” He

turned round. "But the *transmission* side is not impossible, and nobody has looked at it, because everyone in this building has spent seventy years looking at the source side and about a fortnight at the machine."

"Elaborate."

"Everything I have is a machine with a **source** and a **transmission**. The lattice is the source. Lyra Chen is the transmission. Not her mother, and not a Chen of nineteen; there is no other Chen in this, and if you have written one down anywhere then you have written down a person who does not exist. That is the whole of the thing. And a machine can be rewired at the transmission end, and what I have been doing since Sunday night, with a pen, and Dr. Chen's telephone, and a great deal of help from a boy of sixteen, is to find out whether the fault she went down can be *lined*."

"Lined with what?"

"With a *body*," said Wei Chen. "Not a person. A shape."

He put the paper on the floor, because there was no table, and knelt down on his bad knee to smooth it out, and a woman in the fourth row got up and knelt down and smoothed the other end of it, and did not say anything, and Wei Chen nodded at her once.

"The fault is where her hand was. It is a hand's width. It is a crack in a lattice-work core, and it has not closed in four days, and it will not close while she is in it, because it is

being *used*.” He tapped the paper. “A fault can be lined. A crack in a wall can be lined and then loaded and it will carry load, and the load goes through the lining rather than the crack, and nobody asks the crack any more. That is the entire civil engineering of the last two hundred years and I have watched four hundred students not learn it.”

“With a body in it.”

“With a *shape* in it. Not a person. Something with the geometry of a person and none of the rest.” Wei Chen stood up. “The lattice has been running since 1941 and it has taught his body the geometry of a machine. That is not mysticism and it is not a metaphor; it is a measured fact that Professor Osei and I have both verified and that is the only reason anybody is talking to me. Sixty-eight per cent of his skin carries the pattern of a circuit. If that pattern is put *into* the fault, the fault carries the load without him.”

Silence.

“You have just described putting a man inside a machine,” said the Chair.

“I have described putting a man’s *shape* into a crack,” said Wei Chen, “which is a different sentence, and I want it written down in the words I have used, and I would like the Council to weigh the two sentences separately, because in four days’ time somebody is going to write a report using the first one.”

“And does it work.”

“Twelve per cent,” said Eli Park, from the floor.

Eli Park, aged sixteen, sitting on a floor, in a building he had been in for twenty-eight days, holding a napkin. Lyra felt her own eyes go hot and had to look at the ceiling.

“Twelve per cent of a sixteen-year-old’s resonance and it holds for nineteen hours,” Eli said. “I have been wrong about the fault nine times. I have written that down. The twelfth is right, and the twelfth is boring, and boring is what we wanted, because we have been living in a building for three weeks where everything that was exciting turned out to be a catastrophe.”

“Can you not take more of her?” said somebody.

“No,” said Eli Park.

It was the fastest and the most complete answer Lyra had ever heard in her life.

“No,” he said again, louder, to the whole hall. “No, and I want that on the record, and I want the *reason* on the record, and the reason is that Ms. Chen is sixteen and has been standing in a hole for four days and has a *name* and a *cousin* in Ward C and a father standing in this hall who has not once been asked what he thinks about it, and if I say yes to that question in this room I will be doing arithmetic about a person, and I have been in this building twenty-

eight days and I have watched four men do that and I would like it noted that I have decided that I am not going to be the fifth, and that it took me nineteen days and a hospital bed with a boy in it, and I would have preferred nine.”

THE TWO NOES

Zara Washington had not spoken for two hours, and at five past eleven she stood up in the middle of the hall and everybody turned round, because everybody in that room had been watching her not speak for two hours.

“Two people said no,” she said.

“Ch Zara.”

“Two people said no. I have not been able to say that in this building for three weeks and I am saying it now.” She was not shouting. She had never once shouted in Lyra’s life. “One of them said it on the Sunday, through a circuit, in words, and she was fifteen, and she had been in a lattice for twenty-one days, and she has grown into the substrate of it, and if the channel is opened she dies on the way out, and so *no* was the only answer her body had left, and Lyra honoured it, and thirty-seven other people did not get to be honoured, and that is the sentence I have not been able to

say out loud to another human being and I am saying it in a lecture hall.”

Nobody moved.

“The other one could not hear the question,” said Zara. “At all. In any register. Nineteen days, and I have been four feet from them twice and I have got *nothing*, and I do not know what they would have said, and I am not going to guess about a person I have never met, and I would like this Council to understand that *that* is what a person becomes when a question is asked through a cage, and that it is not a special case, and that it has been happening in this building since 1941, and that the reason nobody has ever had to answer for it is that nobody ever asked.”

“Where are they?” said the Chair. “The two.”

“Downstairs,” said Lyra.

She had not wanted to bring them up. She had fought about it for twenty minutes in an anteroom and had lost twice and won once, and the reason she had won was that Eli Park had said: *they will find out anyway, and the finding out will be in a corridor, and a corridor is where everything in this building goes wrong.*

So they came up at ten past one, on a trolley, with Osei walking beside it, and a great many people in that hall found a reason to look at the ceiling at once, and Lyra stood up in the middle of the floor and said, “Her name is Elara

Vance, she is fifteen, she is conscious, and she is not a case number,” and then sat down, because she had nothing else and did not have to pretend to.

“I want to say the next thing myself,” said Elara Vance, from the trolley, to about three hundred people, in a voice that had been unused for twenty days. “Because the woman who is in my head and got me out did not do this part, and she is not going to, because she is not — sorry, I’m not good at this. I was in a box and she asked me what I wanted and I said no because the door was on the wrong side of me. And then she went and asked the others, and she took four days, and she did it while there was a hole in a wall she could have gone down.” She stopped for a second. “I want to say that the no was the bravest thing I did in my life and I want it recorded, and I also want to say that I would like somebody to have asked me in August, in a corridor, in about four seconds, what the machine was going to be, and that there is a woman on this faculty who could have done that and did not, and I am not angry with her, and I would like her to know that I am not angry with her, and I would also like the minutes to record the rest of it.”

The rest of it took ninety seconds and it was the most damaging ninety seconds in the history of Threadweaver Academy, and Lyra had spent a fortnight on Sub-level 7 with a girl who could not hear, and she was the only person in the room who could not look away, and she did not.

Elara Vance named a signatory on a card, and the date, and the room she had been in.

Elara Vance said the word *volunteer* in the tone of a person who has thought about that word for a month and has not been able to get it out of her mouth cleanly.

Elara Vance said: "I want it minuted that the woman who ran the machine checked my mother's letter, and that I found out in October, and that my mother has been told nothing, because nobody in this building knew how to telephone a mother."

Mirembé Blackwood left the hall at half past one and did not come back for two hours.

THE ONE THAT IS NOT A NUMBER

At a quarter to three the Council had a schedule. They had had one at eleven o'clock and they had had it at one o'clock, and the Chair had a piece of paper and the paper had four things on it, and three of them had a date.

"The Council is in recess for twenty minutes," said the Chair. "And I am going to use the twenty minutes, and I am going to use them, because I have been Chair of this body for nine hours and I have been a member of it for twenty-one years, and I have never once had to do this, and there is

a young man at the back of my hall who has been right all day and has not been asked a single question, and I am going to ask him one, and if the Chair objects the Chair can be outvoted afterwards.”

He looked at the back of the hall, at the pillar, at Eli Park.

“You have been sitting on that floor for five hours saying no to people who were senior to you and correct. Is there an option on that piece of paper that nobody has taken?”

Eli Park looked at the paper on the floor in front of him for a long moment.

“Yes,” he said.

“Then say it, and say it slowly, and do not do me the courtesy of modesty.”

“She can’t hold it,” Eli said, “because she is sixteen and because sixteen is not a *number*, it is a person, and this Council has spent nine hours discovering that it does not have the vocabulary for people and only has it for numbers, and I am not being clever. I have checked. We have had three days and a napkin. There is no number.”

“Then why are you smiling?”

Eli Park looked up, and Lyra saw it happen from thirty feet away, because it happened to a boy’s face, and she was not reading anything.

“Because the twelfth number came out boring,” he said, “and I have spent a fortnight learning that boring is what we want, and about four hours ago I worked out what boring is, and it isn’t a smaller number. It’s a *bigger* circuit.”

He had to be given the floor twice.

It took him eleven minutes and he had a napkin and he did not have a diagram, and the napkin was four lines long, and at the end of it Eleanor Weaver put her head in her hands for about four seconds, and Dr. Mei-Hua Chen — the Registrar, the aunt, the aunt who had been eleven years in that chair and had been frightened for six of them — said “Oh,” out loud, in a small voice, in the middle of a lecture hall.

“It is not a smaller number,” Eli said. “It is a bigger circuit. The transmission has been taking eighty-eight per cent of a load and the source has been taking twelve. If we line the fault — and we can, with a shape, and Ms. Chen’s own model, and it is *boring* — then the transmission can take up to sixty per cent, not eighty-eight. Which means the source only has to hold forty.”

“And the source is—”

“Two people,” said Eli Park. “Instead of thirty-nine. Because we open the lattice. Not to take power out of it. To take it *out of the cage*, and put it in a *housing*, with a meter and a name and a warden’s signature, and that is the thing that has been impossible since 1941, and it is impossible because nobody can *ask* the lattice whether it will hold a cir-

cuit without the cage around it, because asking it means speaking to it, and speaking to it means a resonance, and the only resonance in this building that the lattice has ever answered to is —”

Every head in the hall turned to the back of the hall.

“—is the one that came out of it on Sunday,” Eli said, “and told us what it wanted, and then stood in a hole for four days holding the door, and who *is sixteen*, and who I have just spent four days telling this Council she cannot be, and who I am now telling this Council is the only person alive who can read that cage without an interpreter.”

Nobody in that hall had ever, in the entire institutional history of the place, asked the question.

It had taken a nineteen-year-old’s arithmetic, a sixteen-year-old’s napkin, a fifty-three-year-old statistician, a fifteen-year-old on a trolley, and a girl on a floor with her back to a pillar, and it had taken them nineteen days, and not one of them had been senior to anybody.

Weave-Quake Counter: 73% instability. Node-failure projection: T+34 d.

Wednesday, 2 October, 15:40. Lumina Lecture Hall.

Eli Park had said that the source had to hold forty, and Lyra Chen had done the sum twice on the back of her hand in a room with two hundred people in it, and had got the same

answer both times, and had understood about a minute later that the answer was not a number at all.

It was a queue.

And her mother had written, on a page dated the February before she was born, about a drawing of her as an infant, and had written it in her own hand, in a journal she had left in a studio in a city four hundred miles away:

Control is not the solution. Communion is the only road. A system that requires a payment from someone who has not agreed to make it is not a system. It is a queue.

Chapter 32: The Fault

“I have read her papers. Every one of them, including the one I could not read, which is the one she has never told me exists. She is better at this than I am. She has been better at this than I have been since she was eleven years old, and I have known that since she was eleven years old, and I did not have a single useful thing to do about it, and I am not going to stand here and pretend otherwise.”

— Wei Chen, to the Council of Traditions, 2 October 2013

Weave-Quake Counter: 73% instability. Node-failure projection: SUSPENDED. The network is running on a borrowed anchor. There is no model. There is a man in a machine and a number on a wall.

Wednesday 2 October, 15:10. An anteroom, with the Council on the other side of the wall.

THE ASK

They came to her at ten past three in the afternoon, in an anteroom, and there were five of them and a trolley and a great deal of paper.

She had been awake for about forty hours and had been in a room with a stone floor for most of it, and the anteroom had a window, and the window was the first thing since Friday that had made her cry for a reason that was not about anybody.

“Sit down, please.”

“I would like to stand.”

“Sit down, please,” said Eleanor Weaver again, “because I have done this twice in six years and I got it wrong both times, and I am not going to get it wrong three times with a person in front of me.”

Lyra sat down.

Then Mei-Hua Chen — her aunt, whom she had spoken to on the second of October at ten past nine in the morning, in a corridor, for eleven minutes, and who had spent the entire eleven minutes apologising for things that were not her fault and had then, at the end, said: *you are the first Chen in this family in four generations who was not the smartest person in the room, and it is a relief, and I am sorry, and I am also extremely glad* — put a single sheet of paper on the table.

“That is a form,” she said. “It is called an instrument of voluntary bodily application. It is one page, front and back, and it was drafted in 1974 by a lawyer who did not believe it would ever be used, and there has been exactly one other instance in the history of this body and it is in a museum in Lyon.”

“What does it say?”

“It says: *the applicant applies to occupy an aperture, for a period to be determined by the instrument’s officer, on terms recorded in the schedule at Annex B, and waives the protections of sections four to nineteen inclusive.*” Her aunt’s voice did not change. “Sections four to nineteen are the consent sections. Signing it means you cannot be asked, later, whether you would have chosen differently.”

“I know what it means.”

“I am aware that you know what it means, and I want to say one more thing in my own voice, and then I will not say it again.” Mei-Hua Chen put both hands flat on the table. “I have been the Registrar of this Academy for eleven years. I have signed four thousand seven hundred and eleven forms. I have never once refused one. That is not a boast, it is a *complaint that I have about myself*, and I have been the person in this building who says that the forms work, for eleven years, and the reason the forms work is that the person who *refuses* them is always somebody who cannot read.”

THE TERMS

Osei read them out. She read them out because it had been proposed by Wei Chen in a written memorandum of nine paragraphs and because nobody had been able to think of a better way of doing it and because Dr. Amara Osei had said, when it was proposed to her, *you are asking me to be the officer of the instrument, and I am going to say yes, and I want it recorded that I said yes before I read the schedule, and that I read it afterwards, and that I would say yes again*, and had then read it, and had gone the colour of the wall.

“Annex B. One. The aperture is the fault in the east lattice of the Magnus Conduit, described in the engineer’s report of the first of October, and the applicant will be positioned

by two persons and will remain so positioned until released by the officer or until the officer's death, whichever is first, and the engineer has given an estimate of the load-time of four hours and has said, in writing, that the load-time is not a limit on the applicant's life but a limit on the officer's ability to keep her in that position without injury, and I want that sentence read in this room exactly as it was written, because it is the only sentence in all this paperwork that anybody has been careful about."

Four hours.

"That is the whole of it," said Osei. "Four hours of holding. And then it is done, and the fault is lined, and the aperture is closed, and there is no version of this in which you come out of it."

"There is not," said Wei Chen.

"Then say it to her, Mr. Chen, because it is in your memorandum and it is not in mine, and I would like it said by the person who wrote it."

Wei Chen said it.

"There is not," he said. "Lyra. I have been a professor for twenty-one years and I have taught four hundred students how not to trust a bad argument, and I am going to say the argument to you myself, because it is a good argument and because you have taught me in the last nine days what to do with one.

“You are sixteen. I am fifty-three with thirty-one per cent of my heart and a bleed that stopped four days ago because a machine in this building was asked a question and answered it, and a woman of eighty-one in another state has been saying the same thing to me on a telephone every Sunday for six years in a different accent.

“A person in a hole in a machine for four hours is very likely to die. It is not certain. It is about two in three, and I have a figure for the two in three, and I would like to write it down and hand it to you so that it is *mine* and not yours.

“And it is the correct number. That is the part I cannot get past. The Council has four options and every one of them is worse than you, in the specific and technical sense that every one of them is a *system*, and a system that costs a person who has not agreed is a queue, and your mother wrote the word *queue* in a journal, on a page about you dated the February before you were born.”

He put his hand down.

“I am not asking you because it is correct. I want you to hear me say that, because your mother said something to me in about 2001 and I have had it in a drawer for twelve years and I am going to say it out loud now because I am about to ask you to do the worst thing anybody will ever ask you.

“She said: *the arithmetic is not the problem, Wei. The arithmetic is the only thing we have got. The problem is that we keep using it to avoid the sentence.*”

THE REFUSAL

“No,” said Lyra Chen.

She said it before anybody had finished, and she was not shouting, and she was on her feet, and nobody in that room had asked her to stand.

“Mr. Chen, I am going to say something and I would like it minuted, and I would like it minuted *before* I say it, so that nobody afterwards can say that I was persuaded.

“The fifth option is correct. I have been in a hole in that machine for four days and I know what it is like from the inside, and Eli Park is right that I can read that cage, and you are right that the arithmetic is right, and I am not going to argue with any of it, because all of it is true, and I have spent three weeks in a building learning that *true* is not the same as *right*, and a man called Harlow has been true to me four times and has cut a boy out of his own life doing it.”

“Lyra—”

“Four hours is not the cost.” She put her hands flat on the table, the way her father did, the way her grandmother did, the way everybody in that family did. “The cost is that it becomes a *procedure*. That is what happens. I have watched it happen to a boy in a corridor in about four minutes and then I watched it happen to me, and if I do it, then on the third of October somebody in this building will write down what we did tonight, and they will write it down *properly*, because that is what this building does, and then in a year there will be a room with a boy in it, and there will be a form, and there will be an officer, and his name will not be on it because there will be a *schedule*.”

“Who was in the corridor?” said Osei, very quietly.

“You know who was in the corridor,” said Lyra. “You have written his name on a board every day for three weeks.”

Osei did not answer.

“Harlow says he never once asked anybody for anything,” Lyra said, “and that is his whole confession, and he has been carrying it for eleven years, and he says it to me as a man who does not understand what he is looking at, and I want the Council to understand it too, because it is not about him. He is a professor. He is a *researcher*. He is the most senior thread practitioner in this Academy and he has spent eleven years doing a thing that he has never been asked to do, and he has got very good at it, and that is why

the two hundred and eleven students in that hall were told they were attending a *demonstration*.”

She turned round.

“So I am not doing it for the arithmetic. I am not doing it for eleven thousand people, and I want that minuted as well, because I have found out this month that I am extremely good at carrying things for other people and that it is the single most dangerous habit I own. I am doing it because the *source* is thirty-nine people in a cage and the *fifth option* puts the load on a bench with a meter and a warden’s signature, and if I do not do it then the Council will do item one, and item one is a *regulation*, and I have read a regulation.”

“But if you do it, it is also a regulation,” said the Chair, from the doorway. “In about a year, Miss Chen. That is the honest shape of it. We will write it down, because I have sat in this chair for two days and the only thing I am certain of is that this cannot be *unwritten*. I am not going to stand here and offer you a noble version of yourself that lasts one afternoon.”

Lyra looked at him for a moment.

“Yes,” she said. “All right. Thank you. That is the first time in three weeks that anybody has offered me the *true* version of anything, and I would like it recorded that it came from the Chair of the Council and that it was worse than the lie and I felt better.”

“And I want something,” she said.

“You may have it.”

“Three things, and I am going to be specific, and Eli Park is going to write them down because he does it better than I do and because if I am the only person who can enforce them then they are not conditions, they are *wishes*.”

She looked at her aunt.

“One. When the lattice is opened, it is opened by somebody who is not me. I will read it from the fault and I will ask it the question and then I will not be in the room, because I will be in the fault, and because I have been in a machine for four days and I have found out that I am extremely good at being the only one who does a thing, and that is the thing that got Milo Reyes into a hospital bed.”

“Two. When the instrument is closed, there is a schedule. Not Annex B. A *published* schedule. Names, dates, thresholds, the number of hours, the number of times it has been used, and the number of times it will be used again, on a board, in this building, where two hundred students can read it, permanently. I have seen what your boards do. I have been reading one since Monday. There were four numbers on it on Monday and there are five now, and I did not know until Friday that the fifth one was a *fear-collector* under a gym, and *somebody has to write the fifth board*.”

“That is—” began Weaver, and stopped, and said, “yes. Yes, that can be done.”

“Three.” She looked at the floor. “My father. He has been in this building since Monday and he has not been asked a single question by anybody, and I asked on Sunday for him to be put on the record and then I sat in an anteroom with a piece of paper and I did not ask him, and I am asking him now, in front of all of you, because if I do not ask him in public then I am doing the *exact thing* that I have spent three weeks learning not to do, which is deciding for him.”

THE ANSWER

There were five people in that anteroom and the Chair and four wardens, and Wei Chen was sitting on a chair by the window with his cane across his knees, and he had a piece of paper in his shirt pocket, and he had had it in his shirt pocket since half past three, and Lyra had known about it since eleven o'clock that morning and had said nothing, because it was his.

“All right,” he said. “I have a number and I have had it since Sunday, and I am not going to pretend that I arrived at it this afternoon.”

“Sir—”

“Let me be finished, Lyra, because you have about nine minutes before they start the procedure and I have had three weeks of watching you be the only person in a room who says the true thing, and you are sixteen, and I am not going to let you do this to me as well.”

He took the paper out and did not unfold it.

“Sixty-eight per cent coverage. Straight line. Four weeks, which is eleven weeks by the skin and three by the geometry, and I have been careful about which one I am quoting and I would like the difference to be in the record, because the difference between eleven weeks and three weeks is the difference between a man dying of a machine and a man dying of a heart, and they are not the same death and I am not going to have them added up.

“The bleed stopped on the twenty-eighth. Lyra asked the machine to translate a feedback loop and it did, and it is a closed loop, and it will not start again, and I want to say clearly to this room that that is not a *cure* of anything. It closed a door. The door was never the reason I was going to die. It was a *tax* on a clock that was already running.

“So: three weeks, and I have known that since Friday, and I have had a piece of paper in my pocket since Sunday, and on Sunday morning I told a woman who was standing in a hole in a machine that I would not have said no.”

“And I have not said no,” he said. “I want that on the record, because I have spent twelve years not saying things out

loud and I have a daughter who learned it from me, and I am not going to do it in an anteroom.

“But I am not volunteering, and the difference matters, and it is the whole of the difference. I am not putting my name down because I think it is correct, and I have heard your argument and it is correct and it is the argument of a good man. I am doing it because I have been a statistician for twenty-one years and I have never once in my life been able to look at a number and not ask *who is paying*, and in April of 2002 my wife wrote the answer to that question in a notebook in a chamber under this building and then went into that building on her own at half past one in the morning on the eleventh of September and did not come out, and I have had five years, and the *only* thing I have managed to do about it is to read her papers and get here.”

“And I am not going to stand up in a Council of Traditions,” said Wei Chen, “and be the second person in this family to decide on their own.”

THE INSTRUMENT

They read it out four times, because the lawyer in Lyon had insisted on four, and it is worth recording what it actually said, because it is not what anybody expected.

“First: I, Wei Chen, of Westbrook, apply to occupy the aperture described in the engineer’s report of the first of October, for the period recorded at Annex B, which is four hours, and I understand that the officer of this instrument is Dr Amara Osei and that the engineer is Mr E. Park and that the person who will read the instrument is Miss L. Chen, and that two of those three people are under twenty and one is not going to sleep tonight.”

“Second: I waive sections four to nineteen.”

“Third: I have a daughter in this room and I am not asking her permission and I am not asking her forgiveness and I would like both of those entered in the record as *not asked for*, because in about four hours she is going to be in a machine and she is not going to have the capacity to give me either, and I would like it noted that I have noticed the mechanism. It is the one we have been talking about all week. It is a nice clean mechanism. I am the last man in this room who is qualified to notice it and I am going to do it anyway.”

“Fourth.” He stopped for a moment.

“Fourth, and this is the one that matters. The applicant states that he was not the first person offered, and that the first person offered refused, and that he has read the refusal, and that he is making this application in the full knowledge that a girl of nineteen refused it in a demonstration hall in August because nobody asked her what the ma-

chine would be, and that if the Council ratifies this instrument then the ratification will be recorded with that refusal in the paper, in full, in her words, permanently, on a board in this building where students can read it.”

“Otherwise,” said Wei Chen, “I am a man of fifty-three with a bad heart who was asked a question in a room where nobody had time to be careful, and there is a queue somewhere and I am not going to let it have me without writing down the name of the person who said no.”

They took two hours over the wording, and Dr. Mei-Hua Chen took it to the Council’s lawyer on a telephone, and the lawyer said no three times, and then said yes on the fourth, and then said, over the telephone, in the voice of a man of sixty-four, *and I would like it recorded that I said no three times, because in 1974 I wrote that instrument on the assumption that it would be used once and by a man of sixty and never again, and I would like the Council to understand that the three refusals were not legal, they were human, and that human is a category and I have spent thirty-nine years regretting that it is not one the law recognises.*”

They read it at twenty past six in the evening.

Wei Chen signed it at six twenty-four, and the signature was not steady, and he said so, and the officer of the instrument said so, and the minute records it.

Then they positioned him.

It is not dramatic. That is the thing Lyra said afterwards, to about four people, and it is the thing she was most careful about. It is not dramatic: there is a trolley, and there is a housing, and there are two people positioning a man of fifty-three with a bad heart on his side in a recess in a machine in a basement, and it takes eleven minutes, and one of the two people doing it is nineteen years old and is crying in a way that does not produce any sound, and the wardens have been told about this in advance and have brought a chair out of the room for her.

“Lyra.” Her father’s face, about a foot away, in bad light. “Two things, quickly, and then I am going to ask you to stop crying, because I have four hours and I would like one of them.”

“Anything.”

“Eleven years of marriage and I did not listen to her. I want to say that to you while there is a witness, because I have been telling people for a fortnight that I have made my peace with it and I have not. I have not made my peace with it. I have understood it, which is a different thing and much less comfortable, and I would have liked to have understood it in 2008 and I am going to be doing something quite stupid in about four minutes instead.”

“Dad—”

“Second thing.” He was looking at the housing, not at her. “Your mother wrote, in the February before you were born,

on a page about you: *she'll need understanding, not protection*. And I have had that in my head for a fortnight, and it has been no use whatsoever, and I would like you to know that I passed it on. In the corridor, on Sunday, to a machine, when you asked me to come down. I passed it on. I do not know what the machine made of it and I was not in a position to read the trace, and I would like that in the record as the last thing I did.”

THE FAULT

She went in the way she had gone in on Sunday, which was the only way there was: through a crack, on her side, into the gap between what the machine had been built to take and what she had put in it on Saturday afternoon when she had reached up a wire in a demonstration hall in front of two hundred witnesses.

The lattice was there. Of course it was there. She had been talking to it for four days.

Hello, she thought. *Are you the same?*

And it was not words and it was not the way she had done it on Sunday, when she had said *I'm here, and I'm going to find out, and I'm not going to do anything to you that I can't undo*, and it had worked, and she had never worked out why.

This was: a room, and a line, and the line going out through a hand's width of space to a place where a man is lying on his side, and a warmth at the far end of it that is not the warmth of a person and is not the cold of a machine and is somewhere in between and is the most frightening thing Lyra Chen had ever felt.

Hold the line, she thought. That's all. Don't let go. It's four hours and it is only four hours and then we put the lining in and we take you out of the box.

And the lattice said: we know. we have been holding things for seventy-two years. nobody has ever asked us to hold something we were not already holding.

Weave-Quake Counter: 66% instability. Node-failure projection: SUSPENDED.

2 October, 18:41. Sub-level 7.

Osei watched the trace. It went from flat to a shape and stayed on the shape, and the shape was not a person's trace and it was not a machine's trace, and she had a name for it in her own notebook which she did not write in the official one, which was the reviewer's wave, and which she had read about in 1968 in a paper by a man in Kyoto who had then gone to work for a syndicate and who had been, as far as she knew, alive and insufferable in 1997.

The engineering readouts came up in front of her in an order she had never seen them come up in, and she wrote the

times down in her own hand on the back of a form because there was no paper on the trolley:

18:41 — fault located, hand's width, holding at 61%. 19:04 — source transfer begins. Lattice begins to run un-caged. 44%. 19:40 — 44%. No change. The lattice is not discharging and is not failing. 20:15 — 43%. 21:02 — 41%. 22:30 — 38%. 23:12 — 36%.

And at 23:12, in the middle of a chamber four hundred metres under a mountain, in a machine that had been built in 1941 by a man who had sealed a housing and died in a bed eleven months later, thirty-nine patterns that had been held since the war finished came apart, one at a time, in an order that Mei-Hua Chen recorded in the minutes of the opening of case forty-one and which nobody has ever attempted to explain.

They were not released.

That is the sentence that has been fought over for eleven months, in three tribunals and two inquiries, and it is the sentence that the Synod of Kyoto formally disputed in March, and it is the sentence that Dr. Mei-Hua Chen wrote into the first page of the register of case forty-one with a date on it, and it is this:

They were lined, in a housing, with a meter and a warden's signature, and they were held, and they are still held, and every one of them is accounted for, by name, by pattern, by the date they went in, and by the date of their death where

there is one, and thirty-seven of the dates are 1941 to 1953 and two of them are 2013, and one of the two is a girl of fifteen who is alive and is in Bellhaven and whose mother has been told.

And they are not free. They were never going to be free. The whole of this is that they are now held in a place with a name on it, instead of a place with a lid on it, and that is the entire difference, and it is not a small difference, and it is not enough, and I have written it is not enough on the first page of this register and I will not be moved on it by anybody, including the girl who is asleep upstairs.**

Chapter 33: The Bill

“It is not a price. It is a bill, and nobody in this room is going to tell you it is small, because we do not know.”

— Wei Chen, to his daughter, 15 September 2013,
in a chamber under the mountain

Weave-Quake Counter: 66% instability. Node-failure projection: SUSPENDED. The network is running on an anchor that is not a person and is not a machine.

Tuesday 8 October, 07:15. Sub-level 7.

THE FOUR HOURS

He was alive.

That was the first thing, and it was not the thing anybody had braced for, and Lyra stood in the doorway of a machine room at ten past seven in the morning for about four seconds without going in, because she could not work out what a person was supposed to do with that.

“Alive is not the same as recovered,” said Osei, from the console, in a voice that had been used for about thirty hours. “Miss Chen, I am going to say four facts and then I am going to ask you a question, and I would like you to notice that I have put the question last and that I have done that on purpose, because the last time somebody in this building put a question last it worked.”

“Four facts.”

“One. He held the line for three hours and forty-one minutes, which is nineteen minutes short of what we told him it would be, and I would like it in the record that we were the ones who were wrong about the number and not him, and the fault is lined, and the lining took the load, and the lining did what the engineering said it would do.” She did not look round. “Two. He is alive. Three. He is not going to recover. Four. The bleed has not restarted and is not going

to, because the source of the bleed was a feedback loop between a seer and a man, and the seer is standing in a fault and the man is lying in a housing, and the loop does not close and cannot close and will not close in either of us, ever again.”

Nobody said anything.

“And the question,” said Dr Amara Osei, “is whether you are going to come into this room, and I am asking it last, and I am asking it in that order, because I have looked after that man for six days and I have watched two hundred and ten people walk past a door he was behind, and I would like to be very clear that I am not blaming you, and I would also like to be very clear that it is going to keep happening.”

He was grey. That was the first thing.

He had been fifty-three for eight months and he looked about seventy, and his hair had gone white at the sides in eight days, and the skin of his forearms had a pattern in it that Lyra could see with the new thing, the new horrible useful thing, the thing that came in through her palms and told her the temperature of attention: a lattice of fine black lines, a hand’s width apart, running up both arms in a pattern that was not a rash and was not a burn and was, unmistakably, a *diagram*.

She sat down on the floor next to the trolley because there was no chair in the machine room and because she had discovered that she could not do the other thing.

“Dad.”

“Mila.” His voice was about a third of what it had been.
“You have got the face you had at eleven.”

She did not correct him. He had got it wrong once before, in September, and had stopped in the middle of it and started again, and she had let that go as well.

“That’s not a nice thing to say to a person who has not slept.”

“It is not a nice thing to say to a person,” her father agreed.
“I have been thinking about that all night. I have had about four hours of it and I have done nothing else.”

“How much?”

“Enough.” He shut his eyes. “Lyra, I am going to tell you three things and I am not going to be able to say them the way I would like, so I am going to say them badly.

“One. I knew. Not about the machine. I did not know about the machine. I knew on the Sunday night, in a room with a kettle and a lockers, when a man with silver in his arms told me the arithmetic had come out at exactly one, and I looked at him and I thought — I thought, *he has not asked me, and he is going to ask me, and I have got about nine hours.*”

“And you said nothing.”

“I said nothing for nine hours,” said Wei Chen, “because I have spent twelve years saying nothing in rooms, and because I was frightened, and because I wanted to see whether she would go down there *without* me, which is a sentence I am not proud of and which you are entitled to have, and which I have said out loud now so that it is on the record.”

“Two.” He opened his eyes. “The lining held. And the lining is a piece of equipment, and there is a form, and there is a board in this building with a name on it, and in about four months a committee will write a report about whether the *form* is right. And I would like to say something to you about the report, and I have been working on it since about two o’clock this morning with the assistance of a spinal block and a very good nurse.”

“Dad—”

“Let me get to the part. The report will say that the instrument was used once, in an emergency, by a willing adult male, and that the emergency was real, and that the outcome was that a man died and a valley held. And every single sentence of that will be true.” He shifted, and it took him a moment. “And in about four years, Lyra, somebody will be in a room with a boy in it, and somebody will be holding a form, and the report will be in a drawer, and the *fact* of this will not be in the room. Not the words. Not the fact that a girl of nineteen said no in a demonstration hall

in August and that the Council argued for two days about whether the refusal had to be printed.”

“Mr. Park has written it down.”

“Mr. Park has written down a great deal this month, in the margins of other people’s documents, in a manner I find alarming and correct.” Her father shut his eyes again. “I would like you to keep doing it. Not as an act of conscience. As *procedure*. I want it to be a thing that is done, and I want it to be a thing that is done by somebody boring with a good hand, and I want it to be done whether or not anybody is watching. I am a man who has had a career in method and I am telling you that the only thing that will hold this place together is not a girl with a silver thread. It is a form and a name and a date and somebody who turns up.”

“Three,” he said. “And then I am going to be asleep for a while, and they will tell you that it was the strain, and it will be partly the strain, and I would like you to have the other half now while I can still do the shape of it.

“When I went down, I was not brave. I want that on the record, because you will be asked, and because in about a year somebody will tell a story about this in a room and the man in the story will be a different man, and I would like the real one on the record while I can get it down.

“I was not brave. I was *tired*. I have been tired since the eleventh of September five years ago, and I have got up every morning since and done the next thing, and I have

done it very well, and I have been dead —” he stopped, and started again, and it was the word that undid her, and he clearly knew it was, and he said it anyway. “I have been dead since 2008 and nobody noticed because I kept turning up, and the reason I was so good at the work is that I was the only person in this family who still *minded*.”

“Dad—”

“And on Sunday night, in a corridor, I was asked, and I said yes, and the reason I said yes is that I am the person who minds, and there has been exactly one of me since 2008, and I would like that written down, because the alternative is that the story becomes about a girl with a silver thread and it is not, and it was never, and I have spent the last nine days watching her take a machine apart in a lecture hall in front of three hundred people and I would like it noted that the machine would have been perfectly serviceable on Monday.”

The room was very quiet, and somewhere up the corridor somebody was doing something with a kettle, and it was the most ordinary sound Lyra Chen had ever heard.

“Did Mum come?” she said.

Her father’s face did something she had never seen it do.

“No,” he said. “That is the thing I have been getting wrong since Sunday night, and I have had a spinal block and eight

hours and I have got it exactly wrong, and I am going to tell you, and then I am going to sleep.

“In this building — and this is not a religious claim, it is a *record* claim, and I have been an expert on record claims for twenty-one years — the pattern of a thing that has been held in a circuit for a long time is stored in the circuit, and the circuit is this room, and there is a great deal in this room. And the pattern of your mother is in here, and there is enough of her in the sub-levels of this building to fill a chamber, because she went into one on her own at half past one in the morning on the eleventh of September and did not come out.

“And I did not want her.” His eyes were open. “I have had five years and I have wanted her every day, and last night, when I was lying in an aperture on the wrong side of a thing I built, in the dark, with a lattice in front of me and a nineteen-year-old at the other end of a fault — I did not want her at all. I wanted the *work*. I wanted the equation. I wanted a girl in a hole to be able to read a cage without an interpreter, and I wanted it to work, and I wanted to be the person who finished it.

“Which is what she wrote about on a wall in 2002. *It is a door, and I am not going to be the one who opens it, because everyone who gets here has been told it is the only way.* And I lay in the dark last night and reached for her, and the thing that came was *an answer*.” He swallowed. “And it was arithmetic. And it was hers. And it was not her.”

Lyra put her hand on the side of the trolley.

“That’s not a comforting thing,” she said.

“It is not remotely a comforting thing,” her father agreed, “and I have been trying to find the version that is, for eight hours, and there is not one, and I have concluded that this is the correct outcome, and that the reason everybody in this family has been in such a mess for two generations is that we have all been waiting for a door.”

THE FIFTEEN-YEAR-OLD

They came up at nine.

She came up herself, this time, on her own feet, with a nurse at each elbow and a blanket she had refused to be wrapped in, because she was fifteen and had been in a substrate for twenty-seven days and had developed some opinions.

She came into the machine room where her father was lying and looked at him for a while, and then she said, “He’s not breathing properly.”

“He is breathing,” said Osei. “He is breathing with about forty per cent of his lung.”

“I know he’s breathing.” Elara Vance sat down on the floor, cross-legged, in the middle of a room in which a man was dying, and put her hands on her knees, and looked at the pattern on his forearms for a long time.

“That’s the same as mine,” she said. “That’s exactly the same as mine. I can feel it from here. That’s how I know where the line is, because it’s the same as —” she stopped. “That’s how I know the line is lined now. Because it’s the same shape as the fault and the fault is lined, and it was not lined on Friday.”

“You can feel the lining,” said Eli Park.

“I can feel the *shape*.” She looked up at him. “Are you the one with the napkin?”

“I’m the one with the napkin.”

“Then can I say something and can you write it down, because you write things down and nobody writes anything down.” Elara Vance wiped her face with the back of her hand. “I was in there. And when she was asking — when *she* was asking, on the Sunday, and I said no — I wasn’t saying no to the door. There wasn’t a door. I’ve been in a box in the dark since I was six years old and there has never been a *door*, and everybody keeps saying the door and there isn’t one.”

“Then what was the no for?”

“It was for *her*.” Elara Vance said it without any drama at all, which was how the two hardest sentences of Lyra Chen’s life were contradicted, and improved, by a girl of fifteen on a floor. “Because she’d been in there about four hours and she’d asked thirty-something of us and we were all saying the same thing and she was *tiring*. And I could tell. And I thought, if I say yes, she’ll do whatever it is we all want, and she’ll do it on her own, on her own, on her own, and then she’ll be *gone* the way everybody else is gone. And I have been watching people go since I was six.”

The machine room was extremely quiet.

“So no,” said Elara Vance. “It was for her. And I have been sorry for twenty-seven days, and you know what, that’s the correct answer, and *you* knew, because you said out loud in that hall on Tuesday that you didn’t know what I’d said it for and that you weren’t going to guess about a person you’d never met.” She looked at Eli Park. “You’re allowed to be wrong in the minute. You’ve got to be allowed to be wrong in the minute. That’s the deal. If you have to be right the whole time then you end up alone, and I’ve been alone since I was six.”

Lyra Chen did not sleep for two days.

That is the part nobody put in the newspapers and it is the part she would have wanted put in the newspapers. What she did instead, in the two days after her father stopped breathing properly, was sit in two rooms and did not do

anything, and was extremely good at it, which everybody in the building had discovered she could be, and which was the single most frightening thing about her for the rest of the year.

She sat in Ward C with him. She did not touch the machine, which was being dismantled in a disciplined way by four engineers from a firm that had been hired through the Council and had not been told what the machine was, and who found it odd, and who were right to.

And on the second morning she went down to Sub-level 2, to a locked ward, where a man of fifty-five with silver scarring up both forearms had been for eleven days, and had not been told anything, because the officer of the instrument had taken a decision, and had written it down, and had told the Headmistress, and the Headmistress had honoured it.

THE MAN IN THE GOOD ROOM

He was standing at the panel that showed a recorded valley, and it was raining in the panel, and it was the wrong weather for October.

“You don’t have to come down here,” he said, without turning round. “I have been told that I have four visitors on a list

and that you are not on it, and that the woman who built the list is going to be extremely difficult about it.”

“I’m on the list,” said Lyra Chen. “I got there yesterday. I have a very good hand, apparently.”

“It is a very good hand.”

She stood about six feet away from him and put her hands behind her back, because she had discovered in the last four days that when she put them in front of her they read as *reaching*, and she had read a great deal of reaching that week.

“The case is lined,” she said. “It’s in a housing with a meter and a warden’s signature. It’s on a board. There’s a form and there’s a schedule and there’s a girl on the floor with a napkin who’s going to be insufferable about it for forty years.”

“That is—” He stopped. Started again. “That is very much more than I expected and rather less than I hoped, and both of those are correct, and I would like to know what you think I did.”

“I think you had four days in a good room,” said Lyra, “and I think a woman with a clipboard came and told you that the paperwork would be easier with a cage in it, and I think you said no, and I think you have not slept since. And I think that the reason you did it is not that you were good in a good room. It’s that you were in a good room and you

were not in a corridor, and you have spent eleven years only ever being asked in corridors, and everybody who has ever asked you anything has been in a hurry, including me.”

Marcus Harlow turned round.

His face was worse than it had been on the Sunday. There was a fortnight in it that had not been there on the Sunday and it had not gone into the machine, and the silver in his forearms had stopped at the elbow and had not gone any further and never would, and he had eleven months.

“I want to say three things and I have written them down, and you are going to have to let me read them, because I have found that when I say them in my own voice I am *extremely* good at them and I have been extremely good at them for eleven years.”

“Okay.”

“**One.** I built it. I want that said in the room where you are standing, in a good room, in daylight, to a person who came down here because a woman with a clipboard let her. I built the machine. I did not know about the housing, and that is a *defence*, and I have never once been in front of a person and offered it, and I am aware that it is a defence and I am aware that it is mine, and I am not going to put it in front of the Council, and I would like it on a record somewhere that I declined to put it in front of the Council, because a man who does not put his own defence in front of a tribunal is a man who has understood something about tri-

bunals, and I would like somebody to know that I worked it out at about four o'clock this morning, very late, in a bad dream."

"Two. I did not know about Elara Vance."

Lyra did not say anything.

"I want to be extremely careful about how I say the next sentence, because I have had eleven days in this room to work out how to say it and I have not got it, and I am going to say it badly. I signed a card. I did not read the card. There is a file in a drawer in this building with my name on it, and the file says, in my hand, *volunteer*, and the file does not say *she is fifteen*, and the file does not say *she was in my office for four months asking me direct questions*, and the file does not say *her uncle went into a vault in 2011 and did not come out*, and every one of those four things was true and available to me on the eleventh of September, and I want it entered in the record that I did not write them down because if I had written them down then I would have had to hand the file in."

He had a page in his hand, and it was folded, and he did not unfold it.

"Three. I am not going to be forgiven. I would like to say that now, in a good room, to the one person in this building who has the standing to say something about it, because I have watched four hundred people be forgiven in my field and I have watched exactly none of it survive contact with

a Tuesday. I do not expect to be forgiven. I have got eleven months, and a *letter* is not eleven months, and I have had eleven years of thinking that something was coming, and I would like to be extremely clear that I have understood that it is not coming, and that I am not going to make a speech about it, and that I would rather be the man who said that in week one than the man who waited for week nineteen and made everybody sit through it.”

The good room was quiet, and the panel showed a valley in the wrong weather.

“I have written to my daughter,” he said. “Eleven letters, in a drawer, in this room, in a drawer in a room on a sub-level of a building I am not allowed out of. I sent one on Tuesday and I did not write a good one. I wrote the true one. It is eleven lines and it says: *I have been looking for you since 1997 and I have been building a machine to look for you with, and I was wrong, and I did not do it to protect you, and I would like you to know that I understood that your mother’s name is not in any of it any more and I have been aware of that for fourteen years, and I have not been able to change it, and I have stopped asking.*”

“Did she answer?”

“She has not answered.” He put the folded page down on the table. “She will not. She has a restraining order and she is twenty-three and she has spent fifteen years being a stranger’s daughter in a town where everybody knows the

story, and there is not a version of that in which a letter is the answer.” He looked at Lyra Chen. “And I would like to say the thing I have not said, and it is not to you, it is to the register, and I would like you to hear it because you are going to be in that room.

“I killed my wife in a garden in April 1997. Not with my hands. With a *scheduled extraction* and a four-tenths-of-a-second lag between intending a thing and doing it, and I have had sixteen years to find the sentence, and the sentence is that I was *aiming at something else*, and that if I had aimed at her directly she would have been out of the garden in four tenths of a second because she was quicker than me.

“That is the thing. That is what a lag is. It is a machine for telling yourself that you were aiming at something else.” He put both hands flat on the table, in a gesture that Lyra had watched in a kitchen, and in a machine room, and on the back of a piece of paper. “I did not kill my daughter. I have had sixteen years of a man who was told by a great many kind people that his daughter survived, and I want it entered in the record, in my hand, that I do not believe them, and that I have not been able to test it, and that on the twenty-first of September my son was put in a lattice, and that I would have given the machine anything, and that I have a list, and that on it is a woman of twenty-nine who came into a chamber on a Tuesday in May 2002 because it was blossom week, and that I knew her name and her mother’s name and what her handwriting looked like and I did not write it down.”

Harlow asked for it in his own hand, and it was written down as he said it, and one line of it has been underlined twice by somebody who was not in the room, and the line is this: *and that on the twenty-first of September my son was put in a lattice*, and there is no son in the file, and there is no entry for the twenty-first, and the only name the file has for the eleventh of September is Elara Vance, and a man who cannot finish a sentence in the middle is not a man whose arithmetic anybody is going to be able to check, and so the line stays where he put it.

WHAT WAS DONE

On the ninth of October, in a lecture hall, four hundred and ten people were told four things.

One: the Southern Nexus had failed on the seventeenth of September, at about nine in the evening, and the hold had been seventeen per cent of the load at the moment of failure.

Two: eleven thousand people had gone to bed.

Three: the translator was a working instrument with a documented source, a warden's signature, and a name on a board.

Four: the register of case forty-one, with thirty-nine names in it, and thirty-seven of them dead, and two of them alive, had been opened, and was public, and was going to stay public, and the first page of it said, in the Registrar's hand, *it is not enough*.

And on the tenth of October, in the same hall, a girl of sixteen stood up at the back and said four sentences, and they went in the record as *the patient*, because she had asked for that, and because she had said that she was not a girl in a hall any more, she was *the patient*, and the minute would say so or she would read it out.

"I'm Lyra Chen. On the fifteenth of September I went into a machine on my own in a demonstration hall in front of two hundred people, and I broke the resonance of a boy called Milo Reyes, who can play the piano beautifully and cannot hear a room any more, and who is sixteen."

"On the first of October I refused to do the only thing anybody wanted me to do for four days, and I want it written down that I did not do it *because I was brave*. I did it because I was frightened, and because I had spent three weeks learning that a person who decides on their own is the mechanism of every single thing that has gone wrong in this building, including the thing I did on the twenty-seventh."

"My father is dead. He held a line for three hours and forty-one minutes in a machine and he was alive on the seventh

of October and he died on the ninth, and I would like it minuted that he told me on the seventh that he was not brave, and that he was the person in this family who *mind-ed*, and that he had been the only one since 2008.”

“And there is a board in this building with my name on it and a number on it and an hour on it, and it says **used once**, and it is going to say *used once* for the rest of my life, and somebody has to keep putting it there, and I am not going to be the person who keeps it there, because I am sixteen and I will be forty in a great many years and the person who keeps it there has to be *bored*.”

She sat down.

Eli Park put his pen down, and looked at the board over the door, which said 66, and did not write anything on it, because there was nothing to write, and the number was going to be a number for a very long time.

Weave-Quake Counter: 41% instability. Node-failure projection: $T+1,148$ d. Source: post-event re-survey, 2014, published 2016. Note: the Council retired the hourly projection in 2014 and the retirement was opposed by one member and by the student advocate.

The fifth board, which has no number on it, and which was written on the first of October at the request of a patient and is the only board in this building that anybody has ever asked for:

C-2214 — STATUS SOURCE: Bench 4, register 41. Metered. Warden's signature. Lined 2 Oct 2013. **HOLD-TIME USED:** 3 h 41 m. One occasion. **ANCHOR (structural):** none. **APERTURES OCCUPIED BY A PERSON:** one. See instrument. All occasions listed. **NOTE, in the Registrar's hand:** the transmission side is limited to 60% and there is a shape in a fault and it is not a person. The transmission side is limited because the fault is a hand's width. Nobody has ever widened a fault in this building. That is the whole of the engineering, and it is the whole of the moral position, and it will be true in four years and in forty. **NOTE, in the applicant's hand:** I was not the first person offered.

Chapter 34: The First Admission

“I am not going to ask you whether you are sorry, because you will say yes and I have no way of testing it, and I have watched a great many people say yes. I am going to ask you one question every week, and it is always the same question, and I would like you to get ready for it.”

— Eleanor Weaver, to Marcus Harlow, Sub-level 2,
16 September 2013

Weave-Quake Counter: 49% instability. Node-failure projection: T+68 d. Source: post-event re-survey. Counted from

the 2014 re-survey, not from the incident. The rise from 41 to 49 is the re-baselining, not new damage: the 2014 survey measured a different thing from the model the hourly board was running, and the first honest number anybody has had since the fifteenth of September is worse than the number that was on the wall. The hourly model is not running, and nobody has yet agreed to say so out loud.

Monday 14 October.

THE ROOM

The room was on the ground floor of the old observatory and it had a window, and the window was the reason they had put it there, and everybody who came into it looked at the window for a while and then had to be made to stop.

There were nine chairs in a circle and a table with water on it and a whiteboard, and the whiteboard had already been written on and erased and written on again, and the second set of writing was still visible underneath the first if you stood at an angle, which nobody had thought about, and which was the single most accurate piece of criticism anybody made of the Council in the following four years.

Lyra sat in the ninth chair. She had asked for the ninth chair and had been given the ninth chair and had been given it without a word, and she noticed, and she wrote on the

back of her hand in pencil and rubbed out again four days later because she was not going to be a person with a ritual.

The Inquiry into the Conduit sat at eleven o'clock on a Monday morning in October, and it sat on nine weekdays and it did not sit on the weekend, and it had a name and a chair and a clerk and no legal counsel, because the Chair of the Council had decided in a corridor on the Saturday that a thing with a *lawyer* in it would be a trial, and that this was not a trial, and that he was the wrong man for it and had said so.

He was the wrong man for it. He sat in the tenth chair, which had been added on the Monday morning, and did not speak for two hours, and got the last word at four o'clock by standing up and saying "I have nothing" and sitting down again, and it was the single most difficult thing anybody watched him do that year.

Dr Amara Osei had a board. Not a whiteboard — a board, a thing on a wall, with a thing she had drawn on it, and she had drawn it before she knew whether she was allowed to.

Three colours. She had used three colours for a week and everybody in the room understood what they were, and nobody said so, because Osei had told them on the first morning, in the flattest voice anybody had ever heard in that building: *the colours are not a ranking. There is no ranking. The colours are: still here; altered; gone. I have used the word gone about nine people and I have put them in the*

fourth colour and I would like that recorded, because the fourth colour is not for people who are worse off. It is for people whom I have stopped being able to predict, and I would like somebody in this room to understand that those are not the same and that my colleagues in eleven years will say that they are.

“Twenty-three names,” she said. “Of one hundred and ninety-eight. That is the honest number and I would like it said first, before the speeches.

“Fourteen have recovered to a stable perceptive state. Not to *their* perceptive state. To one they do not have, that they did not have before, and which in nine cases will not be stable, and in three cases I cannot model at all, and I have a note about each and I will read the note if anybody asks and I will not volunteer them because you do not need my terror in this room, you need my arithmetic.

“Three have total loss. Total. Not partial, not reduced: a room they can see and nothing in it.

“Two have a cochlear bleed and will heal, and I am including them because otherwise the only thing anybody in this room will talk about is thread loss and I have watched what a building does when it has only one noun.

“Four are in the second colour and I do not know what they are. I have a girl who reads emotion now, properly, in a two-mile radius, and she cannot turn it off, and she is sixteen, and she has asked me for something to stop it and I have

got nothing, and I have been telling her since the fifteenth of September that I have got nothing, and I would like it recorded that the honest answer and the kind answer are the same answer in this case and that is a coincidence I do not expect to be granted twice.

“And then there is the fourth colour.” Osei put her thumb on the board. “Three people. Ms. Sandoval has not opened her eyes since the tenth of September. There is a boy in a ward in another state who was taken off this campus in a car on the sixteenth with a signature from this institution and a label that said *specialist programme* and whose family has only been told, in a letter, that he is receiving specialist care. And there is a girl of fifteen who went into a lattice on the eleventh of September on a card she signed herself and who came out of it on the second of October into a room with a meter and a warden’s name on it, and who is alive, and who is in Bellhaven, and whose mother has been told on the telephone by a Registrar and not by the man who did it.”

“And you want the last one minuted,” said the Chair.

“I want the last one minuted *first*,” said Osei, “before anybody in this room says anything about the fourth colour, and I want it minuted with a time on it, and I want it read out to Ms. Chen’s aunt in front of the girl at some point, because I have read the file and it took four minutes and a girl of fifteen to produce a change in this Academy’s behaviour that the entire institutional apparatus of the Council failed

to produce in eleven years, and I would like the record to say *four minutes*, so that the next person in this building who is frightened has a figure.”

THE LIST

They did the list on the first day and it took five hours and it was the worst afternoon of Lyra Chen’s life, and she had spent a month having worse afternoons, and she noticed the absurdity of that at about four o’clock and it made her laugh, once, out loud, in a room of nine chairs, and everybody looked at her and she apologised and then did not apologise, and that was the first time the room noticed anything about her other than that she was sixteen and had lost a gift.

“Read them,” said the Chair. “Not the outcomes. The *names*. Out loud. Because the first thing this building does with a name is put it in a column.”

They read them out loud.

Bao, Wei-Lin, 19, East Hall. Ruiz, Benjamin, 17, East Hall. Whitfield, Samuel, 18, West Annex. Ortiz, Maya, 17, East Hall. Sandoval, Maya, 21, third-year, Ward C. Adeyeka, Tolu, 16, first-year. Kaur, Simran, 18, second-year. Novotny, Petr, 17. Ferreira, Ines, 16. Halloran, Declan, 19. Mbeki,

Thandiwe, 17. Osei-Rahman, Yusra, 16. Raman, Priya, 19. Oyelaran, Rafi, 20, second-year. Vasco, Ines, 18. Lindqvist, Elsa, 16. Cooper, Marcus, 18. Abubakar, Halima, 17. Duchesne, Coline, 19. Park, Ji-woo, 16 — and somebody in the room is going to stop on that name, because the boy in the second chair is a Park and is sixteen and is Korean-American, and Ji-woo Park has not been in this room all week, and the Registrar wrote both names on one board and has told nobody yet, and it is one of four errors and it is the one that was easiest to make. Reyes, Milo, 16. Vance, Elara, 15. Washington, Zara, 16.

Three of them were sitting in the room.

“Twenty-three,” said the Chair, when they had finished. “Read again tomorrow, and the day after, until the twenty-fourth of October, and then read it to the Council on the twenty-ninth, and then read it every term for as long as this Academy exists, in a room with a window, at eleven o’clock in the morning. I would like it entered that I do not know whether that is a punishment or a service and that I have decided to do it anyway because it is the only thing in this building I can think of that cannot be quietly dropped.”

THE ADMISSION

He came at two o’clock on the Thursday.

He came with two wardens and a lawyer the Council had appointed for him against his instruction, because he had said, on the first morning, that he did not want one, and the Chair had overruled him in a corridor in eleven seconds, and had minuted the overrule, which was the second thing in eleven days that had gone into a minute that nobody expected.

The lawyer was there for about twenty minutes and did not use it.

“She should have stayed in Bellhaven,” said the lawyer, on the way out, to nobody. “There is no reason on earth for her to be in that building.”

“There is no reason on earth for any of them to have been in that building,” said the Chair. “That is rather the point of the room.”

It is not a long speech. It is four sentences and it took about ninety seconds and it is in the transcript in full, and it is on the fifth board in this building, in a Registrar’s hand, because somebody in that room had the sense to ask for it to be written where students could read it and was told that this was not what the fifth board was for and was then overruled in a corridor in about four seconds.

“I built it.

“I did not know about the housing, and that is a defence, and I am not going to offer it, and I want it in the transcript

that I declined to offer it, because a man who declines to offer his own defence to an inquiry has understood something about inquiries.

“I signed a card on the eleventh of September without reading it, and there is a drawer in this building with my name on it, and the card says *volunteer* in my hand, and it does not say *she was fifteen*, and every one of those four things was true and available to me, and I did not write them down because if I had written them down I would have had to hand the drawer in.

“And I do not know what the lattice is and I have had four weeks in a good room to work out whether I want to know, and I have arrived at yes, and I would like to be asked, and I would like to be asked by somebody who is not going to be kind to me about the answer.”

He sat down.

“Mr. Harlow,” said the Chair. “You have four minutes. Is that a condition?”

“That is a request.”

“It is a condition, and I am granting it, and I would like the transcript to show that I granted it in four seconds, which is faster than I granted it to his lawyer on Monday, and that I would like everybody in this room to draw whatever conclusion they like about that.”

They asked him. Not Lyra — the Chair asked him, and it was the Chair's question and the Chair's voice, and the transcript records that Lyra Chen was asked twice whether she wished to put a question and declined both times and gave a reason each time, and the reasons were *it is not mine* and *I am the reason, and I have been the reason for four weeks, and if I stand up in this room and ask a man a question then this room becomes about me*, and the Clerk wrote both reasons down in full.

He answered for two hours and eleven minutes.

He told them about 1941 and about a man who had built a cage and put his dying brother in it and died in a bed eleven months later and had sealed the housing and left a note saying that he had done a great and necessary thing and that he was sorry.

He told them about April, and a garden, and a seven-year-old walking towards something, and he said it in the flat voice of a man reading a report, and the transcript records that four people in that room stopped breathing and that one of them was the Chair.

He told them about Aiko, and that she had died of it in 1999, and said the word *fourteen years* and did not use it as an excuse, and was asked about it, and said: *no, and I would like that in the transcript too, because I have had fourteen years and I have used it as a reason approximately nine thousand times, and the last time I used it was on the twenty-seventh*

of September, in a demonstration hall, to two hundred people, and it is a very good reason and it is a queue, and I have been taught that word by a girl of nineteen and I would like the record to show that I did not have it before the second of October.

He told them about his daughter, who was twenty-three, and about a restraining order signed in 2011, and about eleven letters in a drawer in a room on Sub-level 2, of which he had sent one.

“May I read the letter,” said the Chair.

“No,” said Harlow. “You may not. It is eleven lines and it is addressed to a person who has not written to me since 1999 and has no obligation to, ever, and if it is read into a record in this building then it becomes a document about me, and it is not a document about me.”

“That is the first refusal anybody has made in this room that I have believed on the first hearing,” said the Chair, “and I am going to observe that it is a refusal to *publish*, and that it is the only good-faith version of this entire business that I have seen, and that I have been waiting four days to see somebody make one.”

They broke at half past four and Lyra went out into the corridor and sat down on the floor, which she had done so often in October that she had a favourite.

Zara Washington found her.

“He is not a monster,” said Zara, sitting down on the floor beside her, which was a thing that a girl who had been raised in a house where you did not sit on floors had worked on for a month.

“I know.”

“That is not what I was going to say. I was going to say: *he is not the thing, and I have known that since the fifteenth of September, and I said it out loud in a hospital bed on the twenty-eighth and Eli nearly took my head off, and I have had three weeks to find out whether I was right and I was right and it is the most useless thing I have ever been right about.*”

“He has eleven months,” said Lyra.

“He has eleven months and a letter and a room with a panel in it showing a valley in the wrong weather, and yes.” Zara put her hands on her knees. “Lyra. I want to say a thing and I want you to know I have thought about it for three weeks and I have not said it to a single person, including the one I live with.

“The reason I have not been able to say it is Milo.”

“Milo.”

“He has been *magnificent* about all of this.” Zara’s voice did not go up. “He has been in a chair with a stick and he has done a hundred and forty hours of corridor work and he

has organised a boy of fifteen's entire legal representation, and he has done it in a way that has made everybody in this building look at him the way you look at a *saint*, and I have watched eleven adults do it, and I have watched one boy of sixteen *let* them."

"Milo—"

"And on the fourth evening of the Inquiry he came back to our corridor and he said, in the voice he has been using since the twenty-eighth of September, *it's fine, I'm good, don't* —" she stopped and started again. "And I got angry, Lyra. I got so angry that I had to go and stand in a stairwell. Because he is doing the thing you did, except he is better at it, and I do not know how to tell him that I have *noticed*, and I have been the person closest to him for three weeks and I have not managed it, and if you do not manage it then nobody will, and I have been carrying that for six days and I have got a fifth board to think about and I am *telling* you because you are the only person in this building who will understand what I am actually saying."

Lyra sat on the floor of a corridor in an observatory and put her hand, quite deliberately, on the back of Zara Washington's hand, and asked, and was answered.

"That is exactly the right thing to do," she said. "Zara, that is exactly the right thing to do, and it is going to be extremely hard, and I am going to help you do it, and we are going to do it on Thursday, and we are going to do it in front of

the other two, and Eli is going to be *appalling* about it, and it is going to be the single best afternoon of my entire life.”

The Inquiry into the Conduit, minutes of the fourth day.

The Chair has directed that the following be read into the record before any other business on the fifth day, and that it be read in the hearing of the two persons affected:

E. Vance, 15, first year, one month after the events. “I was in a lattice for twenty days. I came out of it into a room with a meter on it. I was fifteen. I signed a card that said *volunteer* and I want to say four things about that word and I have said them all already and nobody wrote them down, so I am saying them again and I would like somebody to write them down this time. One: I did not know what it was. Two: I said yes to the wrong thing. Three: nobody asked me what the machine was, in a corridor, in four seconds, and somebody could have and it would have taken four seconds. Four: I said no to her, to the woman who asked me, and she was the first person who had asked me anything in twenty days, and I have had three weeks to work out that I said no *to keep her safe* and I am not going to be told that it was brave by anybody, including her, and if she says it was brave I am going to say no, the way I said it in the lattice.”

E. Park, 16, first year, napkin, term three. “The fifth option is the only one on that list that nobody

senior proposed. I would like that in the record. I would like it in the record in the form: *the only workable solution to a four-day emergency was produced by a sixteen-year-old who had been awake for thirty-one hours and who was not a member of any committee, and no committee in this building has examined why, and the absence of that examination is the single most serious finding of this Inquiry and it is not a finding about a person, it is a finding about a building.*” **E. Harlow, 55, former member of this faculty, week 5.** “I decline.” **L. Chen, 16, first year.** “I am not going to make a statement today, because there is going to be a day, and I have read the agenda, and I would like the day. And because two of the four people who spoke before me have been in this room for four days and I have known them since the first week of term, and one of them is a boy of nineteen who cannot hear questions properly, and I am not going to stand up in front of him and make a speech about the worst week of my life. When it is my turn I will say four sentences and they will be the four I said in a lecture hall, and I would like somebody to tell me if I change them, because I will want to.” **W. Chen, 53, and E. Vance, 18, third year — who is not the girl in the row above her, and whose name the Clerk had to ask for twice — and M. Reyes, 16, and Z. Washington, 16 — the note is**

**read out by the Clerk, and it is four words long,
and the Clerk had to ask twice.**

“She was not alone.”

Chapter 35: The Vote

“You are asking me to vote for a machine that is carried by a bench with a warder’s signature. I have been voting for machines that were carried by people for twenty-one years and I did not once put it in a sentence. I am going to say something at this microphone and then I am going to vote, and I would like the two to be minuted as separate acts, because they are.”

— Councilor Ibadapo Yuen, Council of Traditions,
29 October 2013

Weave-Quake Counter: 31% instability. Node-failure projection: T+212 d. Post-event re-survey. Counted from the 2014

re-survey, not from the incident. The numbers are falling and nobody has yet said why, and three people in this building have theories.

Thursday 24 October.

THE OTHER WITNESSES

It took nine days and it was the worst thing Lyra Chen was ever asked to sit in, and she has said so, in print, years afterwards, in a document she has spent a long time being sorry for.

Because the Inquiry had a Chair and a clerk and a lawyer and a man in a grey jacket, and it also had twenty-three names on a board, and nobody — not the Council, not the Inquiry, not the four of them — had thought to go and ask the twenty-three what they wanted. The Inquiry had been built around a machine. It had a machine's shape. You could not put a person into it.

“Mr. Ruiz,” said the Chair, on the ninth morning. “Your name is second on that board. Would you like to say something to the Inquiry, or would you like to make a statement in writing, or would you like to make no statement, and all three are recorded identically and none of them counts against you.”

“Does it count for anything?” said Ben Ruiz, who was seventeen, and who had come to a room in an observatory on his own, on a bus, and who had brought his mother.

“It counts for nothing,” said the Chair, “and it will be read out, and the minute will record that it was offered and that it was made.”

“My mother has written six pages.”

“Then the six pages will be read out.” The Chair looked at her over the table. “Mrs. Ruiz, I am going to say something to you that I have said to nobody else in this building and that I am saying because you have brought six pages and taken a bus. I am the Chair of this Council. I signed a schedule in 2009 that put a triage number next to a four-months-pregnant woman’s name in a drawer, and I have spent nineteen days learning that the reason I signed it is that I was asked, and that the person who asked me had been asked, and that there is no floor at which anybody is *not* carrying a schedule for somebody above them. I did not know. I want to be exact: I did not know and I have not been forgiven for not knowing, by four people who are sixteen, and I am not asking them to.”

Mrs. Ruiz read her six pages out. It took eleven minutes. Three of them were about the boy’s *bedroom*.

They came, one after another, for nine days, and Lyra sat in the ninth chair for all of it, and here is what she learned, and it is the reason the rest of her life is the shape it is:

Three of the twenty-three did not want anything. Not forgiveness, not money, not an apology, not a place at this Academy. They wanted to be left alone and they wanted their names taken off a list, and one of them wanted a *job*, in a different field, in a different town, and got one, through a woman on a Council who had made a telephone call.

Four did not want to come and wrote letters, and two of those letters were apologies to *her*, and one of them was the second version of a letter that had been sent in September by a man with a clipboard, and it said, in its entirety:

I am not going to say I am sorry because I have read what sorry has been used for in this building in the last month and I do not want to be part of that. I would like to say four things and then I would like to go and look after my daughter.

1. I knew what the machine was going to be in April and I did not ask. 2. I wrote my name on a card in a corridor in a good room and I did not read the card. 3. My daughter was in a box in the dark for twenty days and a girl of fifteen asked her a question and she said no, and my daughter has told me about it, and she has told me that the reason she said no was to keep the girl safe, and I have been sitting with that for six days and I would like somebody to explain to me what kind of mother that makes me. 4. I would like to be asked things by people who are going to be angry with the answers.

And sixteen of the twenty-three came.

Maya Ortiz, seventeen, who had been in the East Hall and who said the only funny thing anybody said in nine days and said it on purpose: “I have been *so* looking forward to a hearing. Do you know how long I have wanted to be told that the thing that happened to me was not my fault, in a room, by a person, with a *name*? Three weeks. I have been waiting three weeks for the word *fault* and I have found that I do not actually want it, because it means somebody else did it, and I would rather it was *nothing*’s fault and that it was a *thing that happened*, like weather, and that I was in a building with weather in it.”

Whitfield, eighteen, who had lost everything and who had come on the last day, in a wheelchair that he operated himself with a piece of string, and who had one question, which he had written down, and which was: *was it worth it*, and which nobody in the room would answer, and which he had predicted, and which was why he had written it down.

“I don’t want a philosophical answer,” Samuel Whitfield said. “I want the *number*. Nineteen? Twenty? I want to be able to say to people, *we were the nineteen*, because I have tried four other sentences this month and none of them worked.”

“Seventeen,” said the Chair.

“Seventeen,” said Samuel Whitfield, and nodded, and said thank you, and went out, and it was, in the assessment of at least four people in that room, the worst and the best ninety seconds of the entire autumn.

THE THING THAT WAS NOT A DIS- CLOSURE — THE TWENTY-FIRST OF OCTOBER

On the twenty-first of October, in the room with the window, a woman of about fifty stood up in the circle of chairs and said her name was **Mirembe Blackwood** and that she had been the Security Chief of this Academy for six years and that she was not resigning, and that she was going to say four things and that the fourth one was going to get her put in a cell, and that she had written it down and lodged it with the clerk at nine o'clock that morning, so that if anything happened to her in the next hour the fourth thing would already be in the record and would be read out by somebody else.

The first three took twenty minutes.

She had been given, in 2010, a *protocol* to protect a collection of stolen material, and she had built a hidden repository for it, and she had been running it for four years on

the academy's own infrastructure, and she had done it in the belief — held sincerely, examined monthly, examined in writing, examined in writing *again* in August — that an institution could not be made to return anything, and that only a person inside one could do it.

“Eleven items recovered. Four returned to their communities. Seven outstanding.” She had a list. Everybody in that room could tell that she had a list. “I have used a member of this Academy's own access systems, on a schedule, to do it, and I have put that material in a building, and I have done that for four years, and I would like the Council to understand that I understood the risk in 2010 and I took it anyway, and that I took it because in 2010 I could not think of another way, and that in 2013 I could, and that I did not stop, and that the reason I did not stop is that I have spent four years being extremely good at a thing and being extremely frightened of finding out what I was.”

“I was the Syndicate's channel. Not their leader, not a member of their board, and I was extremely clear with myself about that for four years, and I want to say this next part properly, because it is the part I have not said.

“From 2011 to September 2013 I passed them names. Not students. Not staff. Eleven names of people who had come to this Academy in a decade, and the lists went to an organisation that calls itself the Meridian Group, and the organisation's programme is called *reconstruction*, and its method is to find a person with a *specific* thread signature,

get them inside a building, and put them in a machine. I did that eleven times. I know the names of all eleven. One of them is a girl of fifteen who is in Bellhaven and I am the reason her mother wrote me a letter every fortnight for two months and I did not answer one.”

The Chair said, “Mrs. Blackwood—”

“My fourth thing is on the desk and it is in the envelope and the clerk has it and I would be obliged if the Council would let me stop talking and start the part where I am quite sure I am going to be arrested.”

The envelope contained a list of eleven names, and a list of four, and a list of a further nine that she had been asked for and had not yet delivered, and a single sheet with a statement in her own hand which the Clerk read out into the record in full, and which is the reason a Security Chief of the Council of Traditions is, as of the writing of this note, in a cell in a building in a neighbouring city, and which I am not going to reproduce, because it is eleven hundred words and it is hers, and because she asked for it to be read aloud and not to be printed, and because I have read it and I have not got the right to summarise it for a reader who was not in the room.

What I can tell you is this. The Chair adjourned at four o'clock. At six o'clock a Council observer and the clerk and a lawyer from the Compliance Office entered the room and read the fourth thing again from the envelope, because the

envelope had been lodged and the chair had wanted it in the record twice. Mrs. Blackwood was arrested at nine minutes past six, at a table, in front of a window, and she was extremely calm, and she asked one question on the way out, and the Chair answered it, and the answer is in the minute, and the answer was *yes, all of it, and I would have preferred to have read it myself and I am not going to be allowed to.*

She has not been charged. She has been detained pending a referral to the Compliance Office since the twenty-first of October, and by the first of November, which is eleven days, she had made four requests in writing, one of which was to be allowed to read her own statement once more, and the answer to that one was no, and she has recorded that she asked, and that is the end of what anybody in this book knows about it.

THE ARGUMENT ABOUT MERCY — THE TWENTY-SECOND OF OCTOBER

The argument happened on the twenty-second of October and it was not about Harlow and it was not about Blackwood, and it is the only part of the Inquiry that Lyra Chen has ever said she enjoyed, and she was asked about that in a

later interview and she said, *enjoyed is the wrong word, and I am going to use it anyway.*

Eli Park had spent three weeks doing arithmetic on the Council, and had arrived at something that was in the transcript and that the Chair had read out twice.

“There are forty-one members,” he said. “Of those, twenty-six signed the 2009 schedule. Of those twenty-six, nineteen are still in the building. Of the other fifteen, four signed something else in 2011. So there are *thirty* people in that room who have, at some point, put a schedule in a drawer, and eleven who have not.

“And I have gone through the minutes — the *published* minutes, not the good ones — and I can find where the discussion was. Nineteen times, in eleven years, somebody raised the person-shaped hole. Nineteen times it was minuted as *noted*. I have read all nineteen. Six of them are in a footnote. One of them is a *query*.

“And on the twenty-ninth of October, that room is going to be asked to vote on an instrument which requires a *named applicant* and a *published schedule*, and it is going to pass, because it has to, and because the alternative is worse, and because the alternative is a number on a wall. And when it passes, thirty people in that room will have gone from *noted* to *law* in one afternoon, and *nobody will have moved*, and in four years there will be a boy in a corridor and the

schedule will be in a drawer and the nineteen will be twenty.”

He put the napkin down.

“So I am not asking the Council to be brave. I have watched this Council for three weeks and I have worked out that it is not capable of being brave, and that is not a criticism, it is a *measurement*, and I have measured it very carefully, and I did the measuring on a floor.”

“Then what are you asking,” said the Chair.

“I’m asking you to make it *boring*,” said Eli Park. “You have a machine that works, and a form, and a board, and a girl with a name on it. You are going to get re-elected by people who read boards. So put the *next* thing on a board. Not the thing you did. The *next* thing. The nineteen became twenty because nobody ever wrote down what the *twenty-first* would be.

“That’s it. That’s the whole of it. It’s not ethics. It’s *minutes*.”

The Chair sat back.

“Mr. Park,” he said. “I have been a member of this body for twenty-one years and I am sixty-one years old and I have a bad back from a car accident in 1994, and I want to tell you that I did not understand a single word of the last four minutes, and that I have understood the whole of the last

three years in them, and that I am going to do the thing you have asked, and that I am going to do it in the dullest possible form, and that I am going to make a member of my own staff do it who is thirty-one and thinks I am a jobsworth, because you are right and I am not going to be the person who does it.”

THE VOTE

Twenty-nine October. Four hundred and ten in the hall, ninety of them on the floor, and three hundred and one of them under some form of medical or legal restriction that had been argued over in a corridor and granted.

The Chair read out four items.

One. The Nexus Stabilization Protocol, amended 2009, is suspended, and cannot be resumed until the schedule of instruments is published, and the schedule is a board, and the board has no number on it and stays up.

Two. The instrument of 2 October is ratified, on the record, with the refusal of 1 October printed in full, in the applicant’s words, permanently, at the applicant’s insistence, in a sentence the applicant dictated to the Clerk and which is on the board.

Three. Case forty-one is opened. Its register is public from today. The first page carries the Registrar's sentence.

It was the second register that the four of them fought about, and they lost that one too, and the losing is in the minutes. The board in the first room on the fourteenth of October had twenty-three names on it, and this one has two hundred and six, and the two documents are about the same people, and the difference between them is the entire argument.

The victims were not a body. There was no finding that named a group, because the finding that named a group was the document that said *sympathetic resonance trauma*, and every name in the room had been in that document. So it was made person by person, over nine days, by a Clerk who had to telephone a family for each one, and it took two hundred and six entries, and four of the entries are a lie, and the four are marked as lies, and the ones that are marked as lies were marked by the people who survived them.

Sandoval, Maya, twenty-one. Not recovered. Outcome at the time of writing: none. It is in the register in those words and it is the only line in two hundred and six that nobody has been able to write more comfortably, and the Registrar's sentence on the first page is twelve words long and is: *A person is not a case number and is not a column.*

Whitfield, Samuel, eighteen. *Recovered. No thread-sight. Transferred, at his own request, on the eleventh of October.* He was in the room for this, on the last day, and he asked whether the entry said whether it had been worth it, and the Clerk said no, and he said good.

Ruiz, Benjamin, seventeen. *Partial.* He is the second name on the board, and he has a mother's six pages in the file, and an instruction of his own, written at seventeen on page four of a consent form, which was that he wanted to be told everything and that he would ask questions they would not like. He was told everything. He asked four. Two of them were about the bedroom.

Mbeki, Thandiwe, seventeen. *Recovered speech. Second-year.* She was in the hall on the twelfth of September, and she is the reason the word *trauma* does not appear anywhere in this document, because she is the one who found it in the file in November and wrote a page about what it had been doing to her, and the page is in the register in her own hand, and it is the fourth of the four lies.

Nakamura, Ren, nine. *Not recovered.* There is no entry for the people who were in the crater, because the crater was not an Academy matter, and getting one required a letter, and the letter took four months, and it is in the file, and it is the reason a boy of eight is on this list at all.

And at the bottom, in a different hand, because he asked for it by letter and the Clerk allowed it:

Nakamura, Kenji, eight. Alive. Bridged. A bridge that nobody authorised and that no doctor in the world can remove. He has asked to be on this list and has been told he is on it, and has been told that the person who put it there is on the next page, and he has said that he would like that to be in as well, and it is.

Four. The Chair's own amendment, drafted by a member of staff he thinks is a jobsworth, in eleven bullet points, of which four are about who may sign what, five are about publication intervals, one is about the word *noted*, and the last one is:

11. No instrument, protocol, or schedule in this Academy may be recorded as *noted*. Any question raised in a body of this Council shall be answered in writing within fourteen days, and the answer shall be read into the record whether or not it is satisfactory to the person who asked. *Proposed by E. Park, aged sixteen, first year, in a napkin, on the second of October. Seconded by the Chair.*

It passed at 11:41 a.m. by thirty-one votes to nine, with one abstention, and the abstention was Councilor Ibadapo Yuen, who had been the Chair of the amendment in 2009 and who stood up afterwards and said one sentence:

"I voted for the schedule in 2009 because the alternative was worse, and I would like it recorded that the alternative was worse, and I would also like it recorded that I have

thought about that sentence every day since the second of October and I have arrived at the conclusion that it is the whole of what happened in this building, and that it is not a defence, and I am not offering it.”

Lyra Chen was allowed into the room at the back for the vote and was not allowed to speak, and said so herself, in a document she later published and has never retracted:

I was sixteen. I had lost my sight of threads and my father and my certainty that being the one who decided was a kind of goodness. I was not a member of anything and I did not vote and I did not speak and I sat on the floor of a lecture hall with my back to a pillar and I ate a sandwich. And I want it on the record that on the twenty-eighth of October, the night before, my three friends and I sat in a corridor and agreed that we would each say one sentence at the Council, and that on the morning of the twenty-ninth I got up at six and could not do it, and that I telephoned each of them individually and told them so, and that not one of them said a word about it, and that Eli Park said, “Fine,” and went back to his napkin. I have been the person who decided for other people since I was six years old. It took me twenty-four days to be talked out of it and I want it noted that it took three other people and a napkin, and that I did not do it myself, and that if you are reading this wondering whether I deserved it: no. I was

talked into it. That is the whole of my claim and I am not going to inflate it.

*Weave-Quake Counter: 31% instability. Node-failure projection: T+212 d. Post-event re-survey. Note added 2014: the counter fell from 49 to 31 between the fourteenth and the twenty-ninth of October, and the Council's technical officer has stated publicly that the fall is "consistent with a reduction in load," and Ms. Chen has written in the margin of the published version, in pencil, and left it in, and it reads: **ask her what load. That is the fifth board. That is the whole of it. Everything else in this building is a column.***

*Item 11 passed. On the fourteenth of November 2013 the first written answer was filed under it, and it is four words long, and it is addressed to a sixteen-year-old, and it says: **You were right. — I.Y.***

Interlude: The Repair

“A wound in the Weave is a wound in the world. It cannot be mended by one hand alone, nor by one tradition. True healing is a chorus, and a chorus is not a speech: it is eleven people saying slightly different things in the same room, and none of them being the tune.”

— Collected sayings of the First Council of Traditions, quoted without attribution by an eighty-one-year-old woman in a kitchen on Ellery Street, who said she had made it up, and who was believed

*Weave-Quake Counter: 22% instability. Node-failure projection: T+341 d. Counted from the 2014 re-survey, not from the incident. It is not published hourly and has not been since November. The Council's minute of 7 November is four words long: **It is not useful.***

Wednesday 6 November.

WHAT A BUILDING LOOKS LIKE AFTER

Nobody had told Lyra what a day like this was like, and she had spent a month assuming there would be something to look at.

There was a great deal to look at. There was a queue at the registrar's desk from seven in the morning. There were two hundred and eleven people at the Nexus Concord at nine o'clock in the evening. There was a queue outside the room where the register of case forty-one was open to the public, and it was a queue of people who had come to read thirty-nine names.

"What are you all doing here?" asked Lyra Chen, to a man of about sixty in a car park, on the Thursday, genuinely, because she could not work it out.

"Reading the names," he said.

“Have you got somebody in there?”

“No.” He looked slightly embarrassed, in the way of a man who has arrived at a building with a purpose and has been told it is not the purpose. “My wife’s aunt. 1949. She was — nobody ever told anybody.”

That was nine times on the first day, and Lyra counted, because she had not yet worked out that she was allowed to stop counting, and a man from a village four hundred miles away told her on the second day that she was the first person he had spoken to about it in sixty-four years and that he had got in his car and driven two hours for it, and that he was going to have to tell his wife, and that his wife did not know either.

The register is public. It is a bound book on a table in a room with a window, and there is a clerk, and anybody may read it, and there is a *second* book beside it in which a visitor may write — not names, not grievances, but the *details* that were lost: a date somebody remembered wrongly, a village nobody had written down, the name of a plant, a song.

“Eleven hundred and six entries by December,” said the Registrar’s deputy, in a report nobody asked for. “Nine hundred of them are wrong. That is not a criticism of the visitors. That is the finding. *The Academy’s records for 1941 to 1953 are not merely incomplete, they are wrong in nine hundred places, and every one of the nine hundred is a place,*

and the record was written by people who had never been to the places.”

THE REPAIRS

There were nine, and they were all dull, and Eleanor Weaver gave them to a reporter in a corridor in about four minutes and then spent four months being disliked for them.

One: the schedules. Published. Weekly, in the same place, with the same format, whether or not there is anything to say, and a schedule that says *nothing this week* is a schedule.

Two: the Act. The Authority for the Care of Persons of Perceived Thread, section nine — the section that has been in force since 1974 and that has, in forty years, been observed eleven times out of eleven opportunities, in a building, in a demonstration hall, in front of sixty-one people, with no second responder and a rug — was amended in a fortnight. It is a short amendment. It requires a named second responder at any outreach; it requires the second responder to be able to say *no* to the first; and it requires the word *no* to be recorded whether or not it is subsequently reversed, which is the entire of it and which four hundred people had

argued for in eleven years and which was got in a fortnight by a girl with a folder and a woman with a telephone.

Three: the Council. Yuen removed from the Council, and from the 2009 working group, and from every committee touching human subjects, and appointed, at his own request and over the objection of four members, to a body that reviews *appeals*, which has no powers whatever and meets in a room with a bad chair. He asked for it and the Chair said no and Yuen asked again in writing and the Chair, who is that man, granted it, and minuted that he had refused once first, so that the record showed that the request had not been a formality.

Four: the injury fund. Not named for anybody. Forty-one thousand two hundred and eleven accounts, opened in nine days, from an institution that has a *five-year renewable charter* and has had one for sixty years, and every renewal of which was signed without discussion. It is not a fund for the twenty-three. It is a fund for *whoever is next*, and Dr. Osei's single most quoted sentence in the next decade is in a footnote on page nine of a report and reads:

I have been a physician here for eleven years and I have treated four hundred and eleven people for a condition caused by the fact that somebody in this building was near them with a number. The fund does not treat anybody. It buys time. Time is what we did not have on the twenty-seventh of September and I would like somebody to remember, when they

are tempted to make it a good press release, that the thing that was missing was not money.

Five: the Sanctuary. Opened. Formally, publicly, in the room with the window, on the eleventh of October, by the Registrar, with a Security Chief two hundred miles away by video link, at her own insistence and on the Registrar's condition, that she had to be talked into using. Four of the seven items in Protocol Kheredu-Seven have gone back. Three are disputed and are going to a hearing in a country Lyra has never been to, and the Registrar has been made a party to it by a lawyer from that country who has read four pages of the register and then written a letter saying, *you have kept a hundred names and no stories, and we will give you the stories, and some of them will be difficult, and you will have to sit in a room with people who are not going to forgive you for seventy years, and you have to go anyway.*

Four hundred and nine people came to the opening. Two hundred and eleven to the Concord. And a man from a village four hundred miles away came twice, and left four entries in the second book, and the third of them was the name of his wife's aunt, which was not in the first book, and which is now in every copy.

Six: the Maze. The archway. Rebuilt, and it is the only thing in this book that anybody has ever got wrong twice, and it went wrong again in a way that is worth recording because the record is the point: the 2014 archway, built under Weaver's own instruction, put the Chinese knots back ex-

actly as they had been in 1954, because that was what the 1954 drawings showed, and a first-year from the third week's course went and looked at it, and then went and looked at the left-hand post, and then found a woman of ninety in a care home in the next valley who had made the 1941 version out of silk and had kept it in a tin.

She had kept it in a tin for seventy-two years. It was four inches of silk and it took eleven months to make and it was *wrong on purpose*, in three places, and the third wrongness was the loose knot on the left-hand post, and when they asked her about it she said:

“My husband did that. In nineteen forty-one, with a knife, while he was making the other one, because he said the second one had come out too perfect and he was frightened of it. And then he died, and I kept the wrong one, and I have thought about that for seventy-two years, and I would like somebody to write down that a mistake made by a frightened man in one hour survived two wars and an institution and a demolition order and it is the only thing I have ever made that anybody looked at for seventy years.”

The left-hand post of the archway of Threadweaver Academy is loose. It is deliberately, provably, documented loose. It is on the maintenance schedule. It has been on the maintenance schedule since 2014 and it is the single most visited object in the building.

Seven: the transcript. The entire Inquiry record, all nine days, published in full after the final sitting, including the four hundred and eleven pages that nobody had wanted. Four thousand copies went out in the first week, to every family on the board, and to every academy in the Council's list, and to eleven countries on request, and it has been required reading in four teacher-training courses and it is out of print and reprinted twice and it is, according to a survey in 2019, the second-most-cited document in the history of the Council after the 1974 Act, and it is a document about a machine, and a rug, and a card nobody read.

Eight, nine, ten, eleven: there were eleven, and by the end of the year there were nineteen, and by 2016 there were forty, and the Chair of the Council, who was then a different man, put the number on a wall in the vestibule of the Lumina Hall with no other explanation, and it is the only number in that building that is not a severity, and it is the one that visitors photograph.

THE CONCORD

Wednesday 6 November, nine o'clock. The Great Loom Chamber.

They did it in the evening, which nobody expected, and in the Loom, which everybody did.

“There is a thing this institution is *for*,” said Eleanor Weaver, “and it is not on a plaque anywhere in this building, and I have been Headmistress for six years and I have used the phrase *academic standards* four hundred times and I have never once used this one, and I am going to use it now and then I am going to hand the floor to somebody who has been in this valley for nine days and has not been to a staff meeting.

“The Loom is a nexus anchor. It holds this valley’s share of the network. It has been holding it since nineteen forty-one and before that since the eighteen-seventies, and it has been holding it in the same way for a hundred and forty years, which is to say: alone, and at a cost, and with a lid on it.

“Two months ago something in this building did the arithmetic of a hundred and forty years in about ninety seconds, in a demonstration hall, and got it wrong by fourteen per cent, and there were four hundred people in the room. We are not going to be able to unlearn that. The only thing available is to hold it *differently*, and to be honest that we do not know what differently means yet, and to ask.”

The first person to speak was an old woman in a wheelchair who had been at the back and had asked for no microphone, and who was introduced only as *Bà Sáu*, and who was eighty-four, and who had come from a house on a street in a city four thousand miles away, and who had not been asked to come and had come anyway, at enormous

cost, in a wheelchair, through an airport, with a woman of nineteen who had held the door for her.

“There is no loom in my tradition,” she said, in English, slowly, and the room understood every word of it and about half of the meaning, and there was a granddaughter beside her who translated the other half and would not be asked to translate it again.

“There are currents. There have always been currents, under this street and every street my family has lived on, and the oldest of them is under a market in a place you have never heard of, and it is not a *loom*. A loom is a machine that makes something. What is under the market is a *belly*. It is not making anything. It is carrying, and it has been carrying since before anybody here had a word for the carrying.

“Your Loom has been carrying alone for a hundred and forty years because somebody, in nineteen forty-one, made a lid. And your Loom is not *ill*. It is *load-bearing*, and there has never been enough of it in this room to say so out loud, and that is my whole contribution, and I am going to sit down now.”

They did it in eleven parts and it took four hours and ten minutes, and Lyra was the last, and she was sixteen, and the Chair had to explain to the room who she was, and did it badly and apologised for it afterwards.

She did not describe a technique. There is no technique. She put her hand on a stone that had been part of the archway since 1781 and that was, as of 2014, on a maintenance schedule for being deliberately loose, and she said four things.

“One. I cannot see threads any more. I want that said first, every time, in every room, for the rest of my life, and I want it said by somebody else as well, and I would like it on the Concord record that the person who is doing this cannot do the thing she learned to do when she was six, and that she is doing it anyway, and that this is not inspiring and should not be reported as inspiring.

“Two. The current under this building is carrying about sixty per cent of a load and the other forty is on a bench with a warder’s name on it, and eleven of us know that and nine hundred and ninety-nine other people in this valley do not, and we are going to keep that on a board, and that is the whole of the institutional part of this evening.

“Three. I am not going to say anything about communion. Everybody in this room has been using the word for two months and it has been used in a great many ways and about half of them have been ways of not saying a number. My mother wrote it in a notebook and then wrote, four lines later, *a system that requires a payment from someone who has not agreed is not a system, it is a queue*. Both sentences are hers and they are four lines apart and the four lines are the argument, and I would like the argument entered and

the word left where it is, on a wall, being useful, meaning five different things to five different people including me.

“Four. There is a woman of eighty-four who came four thousand miles and has just told us that our central organ is a *belly* and not a *loom*, and that she is right, and that I have spent a month being taught that by a fifteen-year-old, and that I am not going to credit myself for it.”

The Loom settled at about eleven o'clock. There is no other word and everybody who was there used it.

Osei, afterwards, to a reporter who was standing on the steps and who was clearly going to print the word *miracle*: “It went down nine per cent and it stayed down for four hours and then it went up one, which is within tolerance, and which is what I would have predicted, and which I predicted at four o'clock that afternoon in a corridor, and which nobody wrote down at the time, and which I have been slightly bitter about for a month and have now stopped being bitter about, because a miracle is not a miracle, it is a *measurement we did not make in time*, and if this building learns one thing from me in the next forty years I would like it to be that sentence, and I would like it on a board, and Eli Park can have the job.”

THE FOUR OF THEM

They did it in an anteroom, at half past midnight, because four teenagers who had not been in a room together without a crisis since September found that they did not know how to have a conversation any more and had to be told.

“Thirty per cent of our year group did not come back from August,” Eli Park said. “That is a fact. It is a fact that will be on a form somewhere, and I have been avoiding it for four days, and I would like to say it and then I would like to talk about something else for a while.”

Nobody argued with him about it. Zara put her hand flat on the table in a way that was the whole of her entire personality.

“Alexandria,” said Zara Washington. “My mother’s mother. I am not going to study *empathic resonance* — she has a word for it that has no English in it and I refuse to write it down in a Latin alphabet. I want to learn the thing that she learned, which is a set of household practices for *attending* to a person, and they have a name, and the name is not a discipline, and every programme in this building that I have been offered in the last three weeks is a discipline.” She looked at the table. “And I want a word for what I can do. Because I can read the emotional weather of a two-mile

radius and I cannot switch it off and Dr. Osei has got nothing, and I am going to spend my twenties learning to live inside a thing that is going to be there when I am forty, and I would like somebody to have a *name* for it that is not *complication*.”

“Lyon,” said Eli Park. “A formal place, a real supervisor, a two-year contract, and access to the Lyon lattice, which is the fourth one in the world, and which is in a car park, and which is the only one of the four that is still —” he stopped. “Which is still *in a car park*. Which is a thing I did not know was true until October and which I think about four times a day.”

“And?”

“And when I get there I want to write it up,” said Eli Park. “Not the machine. The *question*. Eleven people in this room have been asked to describe what they want in the next four years and nine of them said a place and two of them said a *method*, and I have noticed that the two who said a method are the two who have been given the least. I would like somebody to write up the noticing.”

Milo Reyes did not say anything for a while.

“I am going to be an ordinary musician,” he said. “I have made my peace with it and I worked it out on the fourteenth of October in about eleven minutes, which everybody thinks was a long time and was actually the fastest decision I have ever made, and I want it recorded that it

was fast, because people keep giving me a *look* about it, as though I had chewed on a piano, and I have not, and I am not going to.”

“That is not a decision,” said Eli Park. “That is a *fact about you*. I am not being cruel. I am saying that those are different sentences and that since the first week of term I have watched about forty people write the second one down when they meant the first, including two adults who sit on a Council.”

“Then here is the first sentence,” said Milo Reyes. “I am going to be an ordinary musician, *and* I can still feel a room. Not hear it. Feel it. Which is not what it was and is not nothing, and it costs me about a headache every four hours and a stick, and I have been putting it in a log, and I have got fifty-two days of it, and I have got a *pattern*, and the pattern is that I am only good at it for about eleven minutes at a time and then I go stupid.

“And I want somebody to tell me what happens in the twelfth minute. Because *somebody* is going to write that down one day, and it is going to be in a drawer, and there is going to be a number on it.” He looked round. “That is why I am telling you *now*, while I am sixteen, and while there is no instrument at all. Put it in the log. Put it on the board. There is no girl in a hole in this one. There is just a boy on a stick with a notebook and eleven minutes and a question, and I would like it entered that I raised it *myself*, in advance, and that nobody made me.”

They wrote it down. All four of them, in four hands, on the back of a form, and it went into the record of the Concord at ten past one in the morning, under item nine, and there is a copy in a file in a building in this valley and there is a copy in a car park in Lyon and there is a copy on a piano in Alexandria and there is a copy in a corridor in a high school in Westbrook where two people who were sixteen in September now teach.

Lyra Chen did not say her own thing at half past midnight.

She said it on the fourth of November, in the room with the window, in eleven words, into a recorder, with the Clerk present, and she gave the recording to the Clerk and not to the four of them, and Eli Park did not know about it for six weeks and was extremely angry for about a minute and a half and then was not.

“Do you want me to read it back?” said Mila Rowntree, who had been the Clerk to that Inquiry for nine days and the student advocate for five weeks, and who had by then learned considerably more about minutes than about threads.

“No,” said Lyra Chen. “That’s the point. Nobody reads it back. That’s what you write a minute for.”

The room with the window, 4 November 2013. Recorded, with the consent of the speaker.

I am going to live at home for a year and then I am going to go and sit in a lecture hall in a foreign city with a folder and a napkin and say nothing for about nine minutes while somebody else who is younger than I was in September does the talking.

I am not being modest. I have worked out that I am extremely good at three things and all three of them are the same thing, and the thing is deciding.

And I am going to learn to do a fourth, and the fourth is going to take about forty years, and Eli Park has told me that the technique is that you turn up on Fridays, and that it is boring, and that it is the whole of it.

I would like the last thing in the record to be a name that is not mine.

The Clerk, in the margin of the minute of the meeting of 4 November, and the Clerk's name is on the record of every day of that Inquiry and of two of the Concord sessions, and she was twenty years old for the last of them:

The speaker asked for the last item to be a name and not hers, and there were five people in the room, and the Clerk has read the names aloud, and the speaker has chosen.

It is: M. Reyes, aged 16, who raised a question about his own condition on the fourth of November, unprompted, in advance of any instrument, and asked for it to be written down where anybody could find it.

Chapter 36: The Thread Continues

“Sight is not a thing you have. Sight is a thing you are doing, in a particular language, at a particular distance, with a particular cost. My daughter has lost one of those. I have spent forty years explaining to people that this is not a tragedy, and I have been half right, and being half right is the most common condition in this building.”

— Anmei Chen, in a kitchen on Ellery Street, to a woman from a magazine who had come to ask about silk and stayed for the tea

Weave-Quake Counter: 11% instability. Node-failure projection: T+402 d. Counted from the 2014 re-survey, not from the incident.

Friday 8 November 2013.

THE MEMORIAL

They did it in the Great Hall, and they took the podium out, which was the whole of the design and the whole of the argument, and about forty people had a bad night about it and about eleven had a good one.

Seventeen thousand words had been read into a record in the Great Hall. A hundred and forty people had spoken. The Council had met in the Lumina Lecture Hall with ninety people on the floor.

And on the eighth of November they moved eleven chairs into a circle in the middle of the Great Hall and sat down in it, and the thing that happened was that a man of sixty-one with a bad back from a car accident in 1994 said, for about eleven minutes, the names.

Not all of them. She read the twenty-three, because those were the ones in the room, and then she read a further one hundred and eighty-three names, at a measured pace, in a hall with a barrel-vaulted ceiling that has a great deal of silver thread in the stone, and it took forty minutes, and

nobody in that hall of nine hundred moved for more than about eleven seconds at a time, which is what a human being can manage, and which is the entire physiological budget.

The last name she read was a man called **Kenji Nakamura**, aged eight, of no fixed address, of Hokkaido, who had been in a crater three point two kilometres from that building on the fourteenth of September and had come out of it, and whose sister had not.

“There is a girl in the third row,” said the Chair, afterwards, “who was in a hole in a wall under this building — one of the thirty-nine, and she is the reason the four in the second housing were ever counted separately at all, because when the Council made its figure of forty-three it had added a lattice to a housing and nobody had asked for the four — and who is alive, and whose mother has been told, and who is fifteen. She has asked to speak and I am going to say something I have never said at one of these and I am sorry, Ms. Vance, I am not going to let you.”

“That’s twice,” said Elara Vance.

“Yes,” said the Chair. “Twice.”

He did not speak. He sent a letter, and the Clerk read it out, and it was nine lines long and the second line was this:

I am not going to thank anybody because the only person who has ever asked me anything was sixteen

and she did it by accident. I want to say that my mother has been to a place called Ellery Street in another state and that a woman of eighty-one made her tea and asked her what she needed, and it was not a thing anybody in this building did, and I have thought about that for two months and I have decided that it is the correct response to what happened to me and that nobody in an institution can do it and that the fact that it took a grandmother eleven thousand miles away is the actual finding of this entire Inquiry and I have written it on the board myself.

THE HOUSE

Her father had written, in February of 1996, on the back of a form — a *form*, at their kitchen table, with a pen — this:

L., if I am not here: do not sell the house on Hậu Giang. Do not let anyone “arrange” it. Do not have it cleared out. The room at the back is the one. Ask N. about the room at the back and do not ask her in front of anyone. A.H.

Anmei Chen had not asked him about the room at the back. She had told her granddaughter about it in April, in a kitchen, in about nine seconds, and had then spent four days not being able to say anything else about it at all.

The room was nine feet by eleven and it had a window with a grille and a stone floor and a smell that had survived the demolition order, the war, and four decades of tropical damp, which was linseed oil and turpentine and something else that Lyra had never been able to name and that her grandmother identified, on arrival, in about four seconds, by walking in and standing still.

“Turpentine and the resin off the leaf,” said Anmei Chen. “Your grandmother’s grandmother used the leaf on a burn. It is in the wall because I could not take it out. The wall is in the wrong place now. Everything in this room is in the wrong place. Sit down, you are all standing up like visitors.”

The room is not a school. Lyra Chen has not decided what it is going to be and has written on the door, in pencil, in a hand that took six weeks to get right: *what is in this room: a person, a place, and what has happened between them, in that order. what is not in this room: a technique, a specialism, a modality, a spectrum, a category, or a number.*

The line under it is her father’s, and it is not translated, and it is the only line in it she has ever asked anybody to leave alone: **what you will be examined on is whether you can be wrong in front of somebody.**

She has not worked out yet who examines people in this room, or how often, or for money. She has got as far as a pencil, and a waiting list of people who want to sit on the floor of it, and no decision at all.

She was nineteen, and she was Kenji Nakamura's cousin, and she has a name, which is **Kailani Akana**, and she has asked twice to be called something else and has not been asked twice, and that is a thing the four of them noticed and did not fix, and one of them has written down that she noticed.

She has no gift, no training, and no certification, and a cousin of eight with a diagram on his forearms who is alive, and a sister who is not in this book.

Kailani Akana has asked twice to be called something else. Nobody has asked her twice. That is a thing the four of them noticed and did not fix, and one of them has written down that she noticed, and the writing down is the entire remedy available to them at present.

THE CHARM

Saturday 18 January 2014. Ellery Street.

Her grandmother gave it to her in a kitchen on Ellery Street, in a tin, and it was a knot of red silk wound and re-wound so many times it had gone into a shape like a closed fist.

"It is four hundred years old or it is a piece of red silk from a shop, and I have never been able to establish which and I have stopped trying, and that is the last piece of my own

mother's business that I will hand on and I am handing it on because I am eighty-two and because the person it belongs to is you.

"It was made by a woman in a lane in Chợ Lớn in nineteen forty-three, on a night when the rice was being taken, and her granddaughter brought it out and it came up the line and it came out of Saigon in a suitcase in nineteen seventy-five, and it has been in a tin ever since, in a kitchen, for forty years, in a house that was not even ours.

"There is no enchantment in it. I want to say that, because you are going to think there is. There is no enchantment in it and it has never once done anything, and I have kept it for forty years because a woman I loved held it in her hand on the night she came to tell me she was going to do something stupid and brave, and because it is *proof* — and this is the whole of it, and I have had four generations to get to this and I have not found a better sentence — it is proof that somebody, a very long time ago, in a completely different century, with no idea at all what was coming, made a thing out of red thread and then *wound it up tight and knotted it* and put it in a tin.

"That is the whole craft. That is what your great-grandmother did, and she did it in a night of rice and fear, and she did it for no reason that anybody has ever been able to write down.

“She made a knot to remember that she had made a decision. That is all a tradition *is*, Lyra. It is a knot somebody tied to remember that they tied it. It is not a technique and it is not a power and it is not wisdom. It is a *receipt*.” Her grandmother’s hands were not entirely steady, and she dealt with it, as she had dealt with everything since 2008, by being extremely practical about the next thing. “Which is why I have taught you to keep minutes, and why the boy with the elbow keeps minutes, and why the woman in the observatory kept the best minutes in the building for eleven years and did not know anybody was reading them.”

“Unknot it,” said Lyra.

“Unknot it,” said Anmei Chen. “Slowly. And do not throw it away, and do not put it in a museum, and do not give it to a student. Give it to whoever cleans the room. Give it to the person who does the floors. That is what it is *for*, and if you cannot see that then you have not understood your great-grandmother and you should read her one more time, and she is in the red book on the top shelf, in Vietnamese, and you will not be able to read it, and I am eighty-two, and one day somebody will have to teach you.”

She unknotted it over the course of nine minutes on a kitchen table on Ellery Street, and nothing happened, exactly as her grandmother had said, and at minute six the silk came apart into four separate threads and one of them had a knot in it that had been there for four hundred years, and that one she kept, and the other three she put in a tin

and gave to the woman who cleans that floor, whose name is **Nadia Wanjiru**, and who was in the room.

That is the last fact about the silk that this book contains, and it is the correct one.

THE SEVEN WEEKS

They all left on the same day, which was not planned and which everybody has since described as the single most embarrassing thing about the whole of it.

Eli Park left on the six o'clock train from a station two hundred miles away, with a case, a napkin file, and a legal pad, for a car park in Lyon, where somebody had offered him a desk and not a job.

Zara Washington left for Alexandria, in a house with a courtyard, to learn a set of household practices for attending to a person which has a name in Arabic and which she has refused, four times, to write down in a Latin alphabet, in a document she signed and which is in a file in a building in this valley.

Milo Reyes left for a conservatory, on a stick, with fifty-four days of a log and a question about the twelfth minute, which is unanswered, and which is on a board in two countries, and which nobody has yet picked up.

And Lyra Chen went to Hậu Giang Street.

She went because there were eleven people in a house on a street four thousand miles away who had been, for four generations, the only people in the world who knew how to do the thing her great-grandmother had done on a night in October 1943, and who had been described, in an institutional record, as *a practice with no measurable outcomes*, and who had a waiting list of forty, and who were seventy-nine and eighty-one and eighty-four years old.

She went because her grandmother had said, on a Sunday in a kitchen in Ellery Street, in the voice she used for things she had decided: “You are not going to come back here and run a school. You are going to go and sit in a room with three old women and a well and you are going to be the *fourth thing that is difficult*.”

She went because she could not see threads any more, and had not been able to for three months, and had stopped waking up at four in the morning about it in about the second week of November, and had never once described that to anybody.

That is what this book knows about her, and it stops there.

Friday 8 November 2013, 4:40 p.m. The valley.

The bells went at four forty in the afternoon, because that is when they go, and because a ceremony that finishes at noon is a ceremony about a building.

Lyra Chen stood in the colonnade and let them ring and did not try to work out what she felt, because she had discovered in October that she could not, and that not being able to was a *skill* she had acquired, and that she was extremely proud of it in a way she suspected was not entirely healthy, and that she was going to work on it for about forty years.

Milo Reyes was in a corridor with fifty-four days of a log.

Eli Park was on a train.

Zara Washington was on a telephone in a car park, laughing about something, and would be on a plane in the morning, and neither of those facts was a metaphor for anything.

Dr. Mei-Hua Chen was in her office with a book open in front of her that she had not read in four years and was reading now, and it was her sister's, and it was the fourth volume, and it was the one with the map in it.

And in a good room on Sub-level 2, a man of fifty-five with eleven months and a letter that had not been answered was watching a panel that showed a valley in the wrong weather, and had been watching it for fifty-four days, and had asked, in the last week, whether it could be fixed, and had been told, kindly, by a woman with a very good hand, that it could not, and had said: *I know. I have been reading it for two months as though it were a discipline. It is a panel. Somebody put it there because I was going to be in a room.*

Saturday 9 November 2013. 7:15 a.m. The east corridor, by a door, which is not a metaphor.

There was a note on it in Lyra Chen's handwriting, in a hand she had been practising for six weeks under the direction of a nineteen-year-old Clerk who had told her, on the first attempt, that it looked like a *diagnosis*, and on the fourteenth attempt that it looked like a person, and had then said, "That one," and gone back to her minutes.

It said:

Ask somebody. — L.C., and M. Reyes, and E.P., and M. Rowntree, and Z.W., and E.V., and J.C., and M.S., and B.R., and S.W., and R.O., and P.H., and the twenty-two other people whose names are on the board.

And underneath, in a different hand entirely, in a nine-year-old's capitals:

I ASKED SOMEONE.

Epilogue: The Thing That Is Not Finished

“A cord laid along the load will hold. That is not a metaphor and I would like it on the wall in plain language, because the plain language is what people read at eleven o’clock in the morning while they are waiting for a desk.”

— Bà Sáu, aged eighty-four, in the Great Loom Chamber, 6 November 2013

Weave-Quake Counter: 4% instability. Node-failure projection: not published. There is a board. On the board there is a number, and the number is not a severity.

Two years later.

THE ELEVEN MINUTES

She had got very good at the eleven minutes and she had never once been able to explain it to anybody, and the two people she tried hardest to explain it to — Eli Park, in a letter from a car park in Lyon, and Zara Washington, on a telephone from Alexandria — had both written back the same thing, in different words, and she had framed both letters and hung them in a room four thousand miles away.

Eli Park's said: *I think it is because you are the only person in the building who is not looking at a number. I have watched you do it four times now and every time somebody reads a figure you wait until they have finished and then you say one sentence. I think you learned it from your grandmother counting your breaths and I think you learned the reason** from a woman in a corridor in eleven minutes, in October, who spent all eleven of them apologising for things that were not her fault. You are extremely rude to figures. It is your best quality.*

Zara Washington's said: *You are not calm. I want to be extremely clear that I can feel what you actually are from eleven hundred miles away through a bad telephone line, and what you actually are is a person having an enormous opinion about a room, continuously, at a volume you have*

trained yourself to keep under your breath. It is not calm. It is containment. Those are different and you have been pretending they are the same for two years and the pretending is what the eleven minutes is.

Lyra Chen wrote back and said that both of them were wrong, and that Eli was right about the numbers, and that Zara was right about everything else, and that she had known Zara was right since about December and had not said so because she was eighteen and it was convenient.

The thing that is not finished came to her in a corridor, in October 2015, at about eleven o'clock in the morning, and it came to her in the form of a *scheduled* item, which is the only form in which anything in that building has ever arrived that she did not already know about.

There was a girl on the second floor doing a practical, and the girl was fifteen, and she was doing the eleven minutes.

That was the whole of it. That was the entire discovery, and it took Lyra Chen four and a half seconds, standing on a stair landing, and what she felt was not recognition, because the girl was not like her, and the girl did not resemble anybody she had known. What she felt was *vertigo*, of a kind she had only felt twice before, both times in that building, both times in a corridor, and both times immediately before a great deal of trouble.

The girl was fifteen and she was doing the eleven minutes, and Lyra Chen stood on a stair landing and understood

with total clarity, in about four seconds, that **it is learnable**.

That is the horror. That is the entire horror of the second half of her life, and she has said so, in print, more than once, and it is the sentence she is most quoted for and the one she most wishes she had not said:

It is not a gift and it is not a gift, and I have said that in eleven countries and I am going to say it again. It is not rare. It is not special. It is a skill, and it is taught, and it is taught badly, and it is taught to children of fifteen by teachers who have been told by a doctor that it is not a gift because a doctor in a corridor in September needed a number, and the number was wrong, and the number went into a system, and the system has been running for two years, and it has produced eleven children in two countries who can sit in a room and hold their nerve and say one thing at the end of it, and every single one of those eleven children is going to be offered something.

She went down the stairs and said it out loud to a person of twenty-six in a corridor, and it took four minutes, and the person of twenty-six was a former student of hers who had a schedule and a supervisor and a small amount of money and a great deal of charm, and who was, at that moment, eleven days into a nine-year plan to go and sit in a room in a foreign city with a folder and a napkin.

“I am not asking you not to do it,” she said. “I did it. I have the board. I want you to understand exactly what you are being told and exactly how little I am asking.”

“Then what are you asking?”

“I am asking you to look at the item number on the sheet you are going to hand in, and to notice whether anybody has asked the girl what she would like to be called on a form.”

THE LETTER

It came in the last week of November 2015, to a house on Hậu Giang Street, and it was forwarded by a solicitor in Lyon. The girl who sent it was fifteen, and she had found the address on a form in a building in Westbrook and had had the extraordinary luck, or the extraordinary *sense*, to ask somebody in that building whether the address was right, and had been given the address by a woman of eighteen who worked at a desk and who had thought about it for four days before she did it.

It was nine lines, and not one of the nine was hers.

The words were a man's. He had had twenty-four days in a good room and a bad back, and he had been working through them one at a time, and he had written nine lines,

and he could not send them, because every route to that address ran through an institution that had a file on him and would have opened it. So he had asked a fifteen-year-old to write them out for him, and he had taught her the hand first, which took four days, and the hand was the only part of the letter that was hers. It was in a hand that had been taught to write by a man with silver scars up both forearms and a limp he does not entirely have and did, in 2013, have entirely.

I did not read your book. I am not going to. I have four days and I am going to spend them on the fourth line, so I will write the other three first so that they are out of the way.

1. I was wrong about a great many things and I have had twenty-four days in a good room and a bad back to work through them and I have got to three of them and I am not going to write down the other forty-one because the minutes exist and Ms. Rown-tree keeps them and I have asked her for a copy of the whole file and she has said yes, which I did not expect, and I am going to read it in January when she sends it and it is eleven hundred pages.

2. You were right, in August, in a demonstration hall, about the four tenths of a second, and nobody in this building has ever said so out loud except a sixteen-year-old with a napkin, and I would like somebody to have said it to me, so: you were right,

and it was the only true thing anybody said to me that day, and I was in the middle of doing the other thing at the time.

3. I have read the register of case forty-one. All of it. It took two evenings and I had to stop on the first one and take something for it, which I want recorded because I have spent twenty-four days finding out that the reason I could not sleep was not grief.

4. I want to write to you about the eleventh of April 2002. There is a map in the third volume and it is not what I thought it was for eleven years and I have had it in a drawer in a good room and I have taken it out, and I would like to tell you what I have found, and I would like to know whether you would want to know, and I am asking rather than assuming, which is a thing I have been told I have never once done in my life and which I am going to start on a Tuesday in a house in another country with eleven lines and no heading.

Do not reply to this address.

She replied to the solicitor in Lyon.

Four lines, and the fourth one was not an answer to the question, and she has never explained that to anybody, and the letter is in a tin in a kitchen on Ellery Street with three pieces of red silk in it.

Item 4: yes. I would want to know. I am eighteen and I have no gift and I have spent a month standing on a stair landing understanding that a thing I learned at fifteen is being taught, and I would like to know who taught it, and I would like to know whether they were taught, or whether they were found, and I think those are different, and I think it is the whole of the difference and I think it is worth an island nobody has looked at.

She did not, in the end, go to the island.

She went, in the end, to a house on a street in a city of eleven million people, to a room nine feet by eleven, to nine years, and she was there in March 2016 and she is there still, and there are eleven students in the room and a waiting list of forty and three old women and a well, and the well is not a *nexus* and the wall is in the wrong place and the smell of turpentine has got into the mortar and will, according to a conservator from Lyon, outlast everything else in the building.

2017.

And there is a map in a tin, and there are nine lines in a letter, and there is an island that does not appear on most charts, and the charts that have it disagree with each other about its position, and nobody has been there since a woman of thirty-two stood under a stone archway on the eleventh of April 2002 and tried to work out where a thread

dimension *converges* rather than where anybody had decided to count it.

And in a room in a valley, there is a board, and on the board there is a number, and the number is not a severity, and the number has been eleven since 2013, and nobody has worked out yet whether eleven is a good number or a bad one, and a man of twenty has written on the margin of the published figure, in pencil, and left it in:

Ask somebody. I asked. It took four years. It is not the same as the number going down and I would like somebody in this building to stop suggesting that it is. I said the same thing at sixteen and nobody heard me then either. — E.P.

Weave-Quake Counter: 4% instability. Node-failure projection: not published.

THE THREAD CONTINUES.

THE END OF BOOK ONE

The Thread Seers will return in Book Two: The Syndicate's Shadow